

A *House of Kirovsky* novel

CRAVE ME

She *came* for the story.
She *stayed* for the sinner.

MEGAN WILLIAMS

TABLE OF CONTENTS

[Crave Me \(House of Kirovsky, #1\)](#)

[Chapter One](#)

[Chapter Two](#)

[Chapter Three](#)

[Chapter Four](#)

[Chapter Five](#)

[Chapter Six](#)

[Chapter Seven](#)

[Chapter Eight](#)

[Chapter Nine](#)

[Chapter Ten](#)

[Chapter Eleven](#)

[Chapter Twelve](#)

[Chapter Thirteen](#)

[Chapter Fourteen](#)

[Chapter Fifteen](#)

[Chapter Sixteen](#)

[Chapter Seventeen](#)

[Chapter Eighteen](#)

[Chapter Nineteen](#)

[Chapter Twenty](#)

[Chapter Twenty-One](#)

[Chapter Twenty-Two](#)

[Chapter Twenty-Three](#)

[Chapter Twenty-Four](#)

[Chapter Twenty-Five](#)

[Chapter Twenty-Six](#)

[Chapter Twenty-Seven](#)

[Chapter Twenty-Eight](#)

[Chapter Twenty-Nine](#)

[Chapter Thirty](#)

[Chapter Thirty-One](#)

[Chapter Thirty-Two](#)

[Chapter Thirty-Three](#)

[Chapter Thirty-Four](#)

[Chapter Thirty-Five](#)

[Chapter Thirty-Six](#)

[Chapter Thirty-Seven](#)

[Chapter Thirty-Eight](#)

[Chapter Thirty-Nine](#)

[Chapter Forty](#)

[Chapter Forty-One](#)

[Epilogue](#)

[Acknowledgements](#)

[About the author](#)

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CRAVE ME

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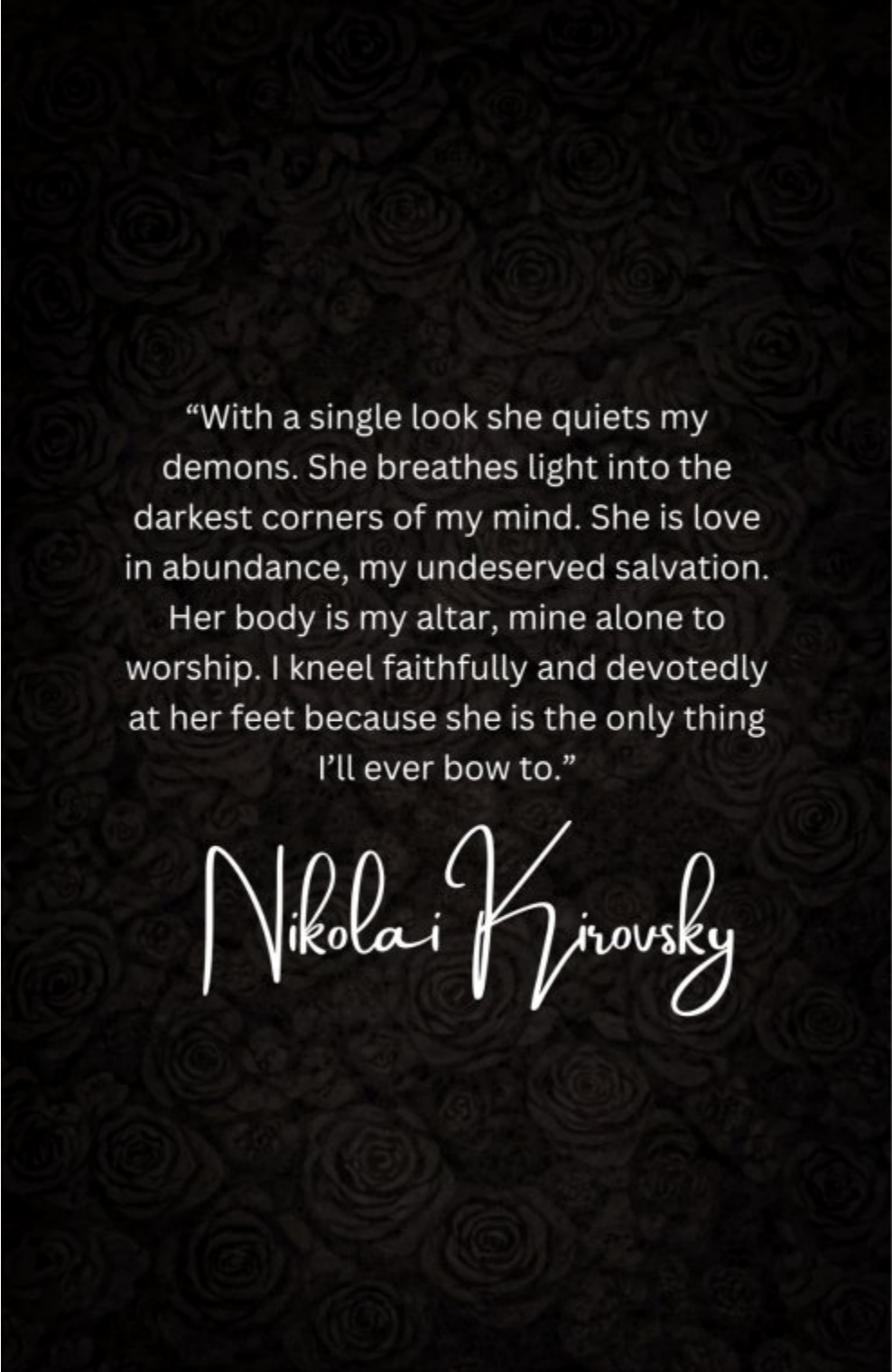
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Content Warning

This book contains mature content.

It includes graphic violence, explicit sexual material, and themes intended for adult audiences only.



“With a single look she quiets my
demons. She breathes light into the
darkest corners of my mind. She is love
in abundance, my undeserved salvation.
Her body is my altar, mine alone to
worship. I kneel faithfully and devotedly
at her feet because she is the only thing
I’ll ever bow to.”

Nikolai Kirovsky

Chapters

[Chapter One](#)

[Chapter Two](#)

[Chapter Three](#)

[Chapter Four](#)

[Chapter Five](#)

[Chapter Six](#)

[Chapter Seven](#)

[Chapter Eight](#)

[Chapter Nine](#)

[Chapter Ten](#)

[Chapter Eleven](#)

[Chapter Twelve](#)

[Chapter Thirteen](#)

[Chapter Fourteen](#)

[Chapter Fifteen](#)

[Chapter Sixteen](#)

[Chapter Seventeen](#)

[Chapter Eighteen](#)

[Chapter Nineteen](#)

[Chapter Twenty.](#)

[Chapter Twenty-One](#)

[Chapter Twenty-Two](#)

[Chapter Twenty-Three](#)

[Chapter Twenty-Four](#)

[Chapter Twenty-Five](#)

[Chapter Twenty-Six](#)

[Chapter Twenty-Seven](#)

[Chapter Twenty-Eight](#)

[Chapter Twenty-Nine](#)

[Chapter Thirty](#)

[Chapter Thirty-One](#)

[Chapter Thirty-Two](#)

[Chapter Thirty-Three](#)

[Chapter Thirty-Four](#)

[Chapter Thirty-Five](#)

[Chapter Thirty-Six](#)

[Chapter Thirty-Seven](#)

[Chapter Thirty-Eight](#)

[Chapter Thirty-Nine](#)

[Chapter Forty](#)

[Chapter Forty-One](#)

[Epilogue](#)

[Acknowledgements](#)

[About the author](#)





CHAPTER ONE



EMELIA

I'm cursed.

Not the storybook kind, with spells and spinning wheels, but I've always felt a sense of dread lingering around me, just waiting for the moment I let my guard down.

I've imagined countless scenarios of what that moment would look like. None of them pretty. Most of them bloody and visceral. Imagine walking down the street, headphones on enjoying the day and then *splat*, an unsecured air vent falls on my head.

I have my parents to thank for my wild imagination. A trait I have somehow managed to use to my advantage by becoming a top 100 romance author. A role that has taken me to many corners of the world. And now that same imagination has landed me here, in front of the grandest building in the city,

The Mercer, for an evening of glitz and glam hosted by my publisher, Orion. Because nothing bad ever happens at black-tie events, right?

“Promise me you won’t leave my side,” I beg as I squeeze James’s thigh while he expertly quaffs his perfect sandy-brown hair in the car’s mirror. His hunter green eyes sparkle even under subtle amber lighting.

Jittering nerves frayed and raw, blind me to the fact that my nails are biting straight into muscle.

“I promise,” he chuckles as he removes my hand. “That is one tight grip, Em. I feel sorry for the poor bastard who gets his balls stuck in that vise.”

My eyes roll in playful amusement. “I mean it James, you’re here to support me. Not chase some hot, rich executive looking to explore their sexuality.”

He clears his throat, the sound low and flirtatious. “I’m just living my best life, babe.” A smirk pulls at his lips as he winks at me, “I can’t help being desirable.”

James Fields has always been a man who knew who he is. Intelligent, resourceful, confident and undeniably gorgeous. I haven’t met a person that he hasn’t successfully charmed. My freshman semester at college might have been my last if it weren’t for him. He not only made first-year composition enjoyable, but he, very easily, tore down my cinderblock walls and solidified his place as my best friend. My partner in crime, the Clyde to my Bonnie, and our friendship only grew stronger over late-night essaying and 03:00 caffeine runs.

We’re kindred spirits, interconnected souls, destined to pen our passion and our trauma. While I chose the fictional world, James felt that his talents

were more suited for a serious role. Trust me, the irony was not lost on him.

He became a journalist for one of the leading news sites in the world, The Chronicle. He worked his way from junior contributor to investigative journalist in only four years. Unfortunately, drawing the ire of many senior colleagues.

James sits in rooms that most would never know existed. He's covered many high-profile cases with prominent businesspeople, and politicians. But he revels in the danger. He thrills in the chase. James is doing what he loves, and no threat, no demand could ever make him change who he is.

The passenger mirror clicks open as the urge to check my hair and makeup becomes overwhelming. I'm pleased to see that Alicia has done an amazing job transforming me into a goddess. My dark brown hair bounces in soft waves down my back, a feat I could never accomplish with my own tools and countless tutorials.

My makeup is subtle but striking. A sharp winged liner drawn with artistic precision sits on top of my eyelids, behind thickened eyelashes, a contrast to the beautiful flecks of gold shimmer behind it. My eyebrows look like sisters, not the distant cousins they were just hours ago. This might be the best I've ever looked. God, that's a sad thought.

"Earth to Emmy," James snaps his fingers with a grin as he stares at me. "It's time to go inside."

I take a deep breath, trying to steady my nerves.

One.

Inhale.

Two.

Hold it.

Three.

Exhale.

The valet opens the car door with a polite smile, offering me his hand as I gently lift from the seat. My dress hugs every curve of my body. A one-shoulder, soft satin, rouged dress in the most exquisite shade of phthalo green. James's eyes nearly popped out of his head when I pulled my face trying it on, still undecided before eventually succumbing to peer pressure and purchasing it. Thank God I listened to him.

The warm evening air wraps around us, accompanied by a subtle, cooling breeze. The sound of clicking cameras and chattering photographers fill the atmosphere. Drowning out the noise of the bustling city around us.

It's a grand entrance to the annual Orion Writers Ball. An extravagant event hosted by publishing giant, Orion, to celebrate its writers. Non-fiction, memoirists, biographers, short story writers and novelists all celebrated for their contributions to the literacy world.

It's a night of celebration. A night I should be looking forward to, but instead my stomach turns with unshakable nerves.

After a very successful, and totally unexpected year, my young adult series 'Undying Love' has become a best seller, with over two million copies purchased world-wide.

At twenty-eight years old, I understand how much of a blessing it is to have my passion not only recognised but praised and rewarded when there are writers twice my age waiting for their chance to break-through. I still don't feel like I deserve it.

I doubt I ever will.

James grabs my wrist and guides me onto the red carpet with a bright smile as he speaks through his teeth. “Get it together, we’re here to have fun.”

My body finally begins to relax at his touch. He’s right. All my life, anxiety has followed me like an invisible, demonic shadow. A therapist would probably tell me that it was due to losing my parents at a young age and being shipped off to a different city to live with my workaholic aunt who let the TV and gadgets babysit me.

Writing was the only outlet I needed. Immersing myself in a world created by my own imagination helped me forget about the gaping hole in my chest. But I won’t let it get the best of me tonight. Nerves begone. This will be a night for celebration; I’ve worked my ass off to be here. *This is where I belong.*

“Emelia Morelli, look this way,” a photographer shouts as their arm waves in the air.

James and I pause on the crushed velvet red carpet as lights flash, and lenses point our way.

“I’m totally uploading these pics to my dating profile. This lighting is amazing.”

“Lucky for you, they’re getting your good side,” I laugh and shoot him a teasing grin.

A young woman dressed in all-black, with a tablet and an earpiece then approaches us. She gestures for us to follow through the entrance doors towards the event hall.

Posters and life-size cardboard cut-outs line the foyer through the hallway towards the banqueting hall. Character artwork from different authors under Orion's management.

"Oh my God," I gasp as my eyes land on it. My own characters, Lily and Ryan, a cutout taken directly from the book cover placed in a premium position, centre of the room. I don't have a moment to take it all in before James is handing me his phone. "Take a pic," he smirks, already posing.

I chuckle as I angle the camera and take the image. Checking to make sure he looks perfect knowing he would ask me to retake it if he doesn't.

"Now you," he insists, his hands already on my waist positioning me in place before stepping back and taking a picture.

"Gorgeous!" He beams.

"Emelia, ah you look stunning babe," Sam exclaims as she walks our way. I'm immediately enchanted by her pleasantly sweet, spicy perfume as she wraps her arms around me and kisses my cheek. It's an elegant scent and something so uniquely her.

Samantha Elliot, literary agent to lucky authors who secured her before she rose to the top of her field. I just so happened to be one of them and it didn't hurt that she was also my college roommate and one of my best friends.

Sam looks striking in a halter neck, floor-length black dress. The fabric delicately synchs at her waist, showing off her voluptuous curves. Her strawberry blonde hair flows in loose waves against her creamy alabaster skin. She rolls her big blue eyes playfully as James walks towards her with wide, open arms before squeezing her into a tight hug.

“Don’t you look handsome,” she smirks. “You know Mr. Jones doesn’t attend these events anymore. Not after...,” she scrunches her nose. “...you know.”

“I heard,” James grins wickedly. “Quite the scandal, sleeping with his wife’s gay assistant. I didn’t know he was so...easily corruptible.”

I shake my head with a chuckle. “You’re impossible.”

“Impossibly irresistible,” Sam adds with a cheeky smile.

James grins as he offers us each an arm. “Shall we, ladies?”

As we enter the grand banquet hall, my eyes widen as I finally take it all in.

All the glamour.

All the decadence.

For nearly four years I have been publishing my work under Orion, but this is the first year that I have not only received an invite but also a nomination for the most prestigious award of the night, ‘Author of the year.’ Securing that award would not only open doors for me as a writer, but it will solidify my place in the romance literacy world. My name would be featured amongst giants of the industry, literacy architects who revolutionised the romance genre.

Sam walks ahead and spots our names on a table. “We’re here,” she smiles as she waves us over.

The banquet hall is elegantly decorated in shades of white and cobalt blue. Crisp white linen tablecloths cover the nearly three dozen round tables, all aligned perfectly, each with a beautifully delicate assortment of blue lilies

in a crystal vase sitting in the centre. The wait staff pull out our chairs as we finally make our way to our table.

“Gretchen really went all out this year,” Sam marvels as she picks up the silver cutlery, checking her teeth in its reflection.

“Well Orion did just declare a 43% increase in revenue,” James smirks. “They should be treating their writers very well.”

I catch a glimpse of Gretchen Jones in my periphery as she moves elegantly across the room. My head turns automatically to watch her. I’ve only seen pictures of her in news articles and magazines; she’s even more beautiful in person.

Gretchen is in her early to mid-fifties. Petite with shoulder length dark hair and soft blue eyes. She purchased Orion when it was operating under a different name, she saw the potential, and she didn’t hesitate to offer the owners a buyout. She then spent the last thirty years turning Orion into a global publishing giant.

Writers dream of having Orion’s crest printed on their books. It's a badge of honour in our world. I nearly stop breathing when I realise that Gretchen has caught my gaze. Oh my God, how long have I been staring at her? She smiles and nods politely before returning to the guests around her. Each one more desperate for her attention.

“We should do Hawaii again for my birthday this year, get the gang back together,” James smiles as he takes a glass of champagne from the waiter.

I cringe internally. “Okay but don’t let me drink as much as I did last time.”

“Are you kidding, you’re so much fun when you’re drunk!” Sam teases.

“I mean it,” I laugh as I lift my hands emphatically. “Three is my limit then I’m done.”

In an instant, my face drops as all the joy disappears from the room when *he* walks in. The one person I prayed I wouldn’t see tonight. Salt smears deep in the wound as I realise that he isn’t alone.

“Oh my God, what a fucking asshole,” Sam sneers as Thomas waltzes into the banquet hall. Dressed in an all-black suit, his dark blonde hair styled neatly, golden silky strands glint in the light as he makes his way through the room with a charming smile. He looks every bit the gentleman he pretends to be.

Tom and I dated for nearly two years, we met at a writing conference and instantly hit off. Little did I know, he was hitting it off with multiple women behind my back. His date wears a low-cut gold dress with slits so long she’ll be flashing the room with one wrong move.

Tom catches my gaze, and Sam’s glare. He winks and pulls his date closer, whispering something in her ear that makes her giggle. *Arrogant jerk.*

“I’ll kick his ass if you want me to Em, just say the word,” James offers, already annoyed at the scene unfolding before us.

I return my attention to the table and neaten my dress. Tom doesn’t deserve any emotion from me. I won’t give him the satisfaction.

“No,” I smile. “He’s a dick, it’s not worth it.”

Sam leans forward, her voice dropping to a whisper. “I could have laxatives put in their drinks before the night is over.”

I laugh at the ridiculous thought. “No, really. I’m okay.” I place my hands on theirs and squeeze affectionately. Grateful that I never have to suffer

through anything alone with my best friends by my side.

Drinks and conversation flow easily as the night progresses, successfully keeping my nerves at bay. That changes the minute the crowd begins to still as Gretchen walks onto the stage and concludes the award ceremony portion of the evening.

James turns to me with a wink as they announce the final category of the night, 'Author of the year'.

Gretchen stands behind the clear podium as she speaks into the microphone. Her voice strong, confident and commanding.

"This award recognises an author who has not only showcased their incredible talent through their work but also brought innovation to Orion's own social and digital marketing strategies. Previous winners include Ted Lancaster, Ruby Diamond and Jenna Humphreys." She pauses as the crowd applauds. "I would like to congratulate each of the nominees in this category. You have all owned your space as authors and that, in itself, is commendable." She takes another pause. "Tonight, the award for author of the year goes to..."

My pulse is racing. My heart thumps loudly in my ears, drowning out the sound around me as Gretchen opens the crisp white envelope in her hands.

Time slows. Sam leans forward and holds my hand as James take the other. Damn it, breathe Emelia!

One.

Inhale.

Two.

Hold it.

Three.

Exhale.

“...Emelia Morelli,” Gretchen smiles as the crowd applauds, and sound begins to return to me.

“Holy shit, you did it, Em!” James exclaims as he hugs me tightly.

What the...? Did she just say my name?

“I knew you would win!” Sam laughs as she pulls me into a hug.

I lift from my seat before my mind can catch up, I begin making the terrifying walk towards the stage as the bright overhead lights focus on me.

My life suddenly flashes before my eyes with each step. All the years I had spent left home alone, finally finding my voice in my stories. Being shipped off to boarding school when Aunt Nina decided she wanted to travel the world with her latest boyfriend. The relentless bullying, orphan jokes, taunts and pranks meant to break me. My first kiss with a boy at sixteen in a dark movie theatre while Gravity played on the big screen. Meeting James and Sam and all of our unforgettable adventures together. Then, my parents. My first loves and my first heartbreak. Flashbacks to them telling the most imaginative stories before tucking me in at night. Their hugs, their kisses, the absolute safety I felt in their embrace. So much love and laughter filled our home.

Then with another step remembering how cruel life can be when you're only eight years old and the sole survivor of a car crash that would leave you all alone in the world for the rest of your life.

I catch the tears forming in the corner of my eyes.

Don't think about that now Em. Tonight is a night of celebration. I exhale sharply and force a smile as I finally reach the stage.

Gretchen gracefully hands me the award as the crowd cheers loudly. "Congratulations Emelia," she smiles before offering me a hug.

"Thank you, I manage," my voice coarser than I intend it to be.

Gretchen steps back and gestures for me to move towards the microphone.

Shit, I hadn't prepared anything. I didn't think I would win!

I take a deep breath and nod as I try to at least sound prepared. "This award means the world to me." I pause, trying to steady my voice. "Some of you may not know this, but my parents were authors, published under Orion," I say as I turn to Gretchen with a smile. "My mother was Alyssa Morelli, a renowned children's author and my father, Jonathan Morelli wrote some of the most thrilling spy novels of his and our generation." I pause again, swallowing hard as I feel my throat dry. "I am truly grateful and overjoyed to see their work still being circulated today. I've always dreamed of following in their footsteps and carving out a world of my own, a world that brought joy and love and escapism to readers."

A tear falls down my cheek before I can stop it. I turn to Gretchen. "Thank you, for trusting me with this title, I promise that I will do my best to not let you down."

The crowd applauds as Gretchen moves towards me and hugs me again. "You deserve it, Emelia," she whispers.

James and I sit at the bar as we wait for our drinks. He's been eyeing a waiter all night, thinking I hadn't notice. He isn't nearly as slick as he thinks

he is.

“Just go talk to him,” I chuckle, rolling my eyes.

A coy smile grows on his face. “Who?”

“The waiter you’ve been eye-fucking all night,” I tease. “Go, I’ll be fine.”

“Are you sure?” He feigns protest.

“Yes, I’ll be okay,” I smile.

James kisses my cheek before dashing off. “You’re the best.”

“Here you go ma’am,” the barman smiles, handing me a martini.

“Em, there you are!” Sam exclaims as she nears me. I freeze as my eyes lift; Gretchen is walking beside her. Both heading straight towards me.

“Emelia, I would like to officially introduce you to Gretchen Jones,” Sam smiles as she winks at me.

“It’s an honour Mrs. Jones and thank you again for the award, it means everything to me.” I smile, forcing down the flutter in my stomach.

“I meant every word Emelia. The way you connect with your fans on social media has evolved the way we advertise at Orion. We’ve allocated more resources to our digital advertising and that move has already paid off.” She smiles.

I turn to Sam. “Samantha manages all of my accounts; she’s a marketing genius.”

“Emmy is so modest,” she laughs. “She’s amazing and people love her.”

“I can see that, which is why I would like to propose an offer to you Emelia, if you’re open,” Gretchen grins.

Sam shoots me a look to tell me to go with it. Like I would ever turn down anything that Gretchen Jones has to offer me.

“Our research shows that the romance genre has become incredibly popular amongst readers in our target audience, with an especially high peak in spicy and darker romance.” She pauses. “Something about a flawed, brooding man falling for a delicately good woman just knocks their socks off, and I’m sure some other garments we won’t mention,” she chuckles.

Hearing Gretchen laugh instantly quiets my nerves and eases the tension in my chest.

“We’ve decided to launch a new division, Orion After Dark to provide more specialised care for our romance authors, like yourself.” She smiles.

A small breath escapes my throat. “That sounds, incredible.”

“I’m glad you think so Emelia, which brings me to my proposition. To coincide the launch, we would like to feature a new book from a select few of our beloved romance authors. We would like to offer this opportunity to you and for your book to focus on a darker romance love story.” She pauses, letting the idea sink in.

My mouth goes dry again. I write soft, light romance novels. Would my audience even want this?

“I uhm...” I begin.

“We’re not asking you to completely depart from your current work, we just feel that you’re already a very likable public figure, you could reach an older, more mature audience with the right marketing,” Gretchen grins. “If you’re open to it.”

“She’ll do it,” Sam cuts in, already sensing my apprehension.

“I’d like to hear it from Emelia,” she focuses her gaze on me.

I take a deep breath and nod. “It’s certainly an intriguing offer,” I manage. “If you have confidence in me Gretchen then, I won’t let you down.”

“Brilliant,” she smiles. “I’d like to see an outline and ten chapters in eight weeks, could you manage that?”

“Uhm...”

“Yes, she can! That’s no problem.” Sam cuts in again.

Gretchen smiles as she nods before walking away. I wait until she’s out of earshot.

“Sam what the hell? Eight weeks? I have other projects that I’m working on. And what do I know about BDSM?” I raise my hands in frustration.

“Oh God Em, dark romance isn’t just whips and chains, it’s way more nuanced than that. There’s so much fun morally grey area for you to play with.” She chuckles. “All you need is a dark, dangerous male lead with past trauma and a beautiful woman who he becomes obsessed with. Easy. Damn, I should be a writer.”

I shove her arm playfully. “I think I need to go home and lay down. This has all been a lot to digest in one night.” I admit as I look around the room for James when speak of the devil, he comes waltzing towards us with a wicked grin.

“Let me guess, you got his number?” I raise my brow with a teasing smile.

“Even better, we’re meeting at a club later,” he winks.

“Does that mean I can’t get a ride with you?” I ask, already pouting.

James laughs, wrapping his arm around my shoulder. “Of course you can, besides I need to charge my phone at your apartment before I meet with Domino later.”

“Domino?” Sam repeats, scrunching her brows.

“Yeah, I didn’t give him my real name either Judge Judy,” he retorts.

Sam rolls her eyes. “Oh my God, well you kids be safe, I still have some schmoozing to do,” she winks before hugging James and I then returning to the party. Her hips sashaying with seductive ease as she walks away, drawing the lingering eyes of several men at tables nearby.



“My feet are killing me,” I complain as I finally reach the front door of my apartment. I toss my heels aside and sink into the cool wooden floor with a satisfied sigh.

“I don’t know how you girls walk on those things,” James scoffs playfully as he plops himself on my cool grey couch and plugs his phone into the charger.

My stomach announces itself with a low but unmissable growl. As amazing as those extravagant events are, they never serve real food. It’s all canapés and booze.

“Pizza?” I ask, holding up the box.

“Hell yeah,” he grins. “I’ll be working off those carbs later, if you know what I mean.”

“I always know what you mean.” I laugh as I turn on the oven and pop the pizza inside.

“Can I ask you something?” I start as I walk to my bedroom and pull the dress from my body watching it fall to the floor like a satin waterfall.

“Anything babe, what’s up?” James asks, eyes already glued to his phone as he texts with a boyish smile.

I pull a long hoodie over my head and slip my legs through a pair of grey sweatpants. Comfort at last.

“How do you hook up with strangers so easily?” I pause as I pull my hair into a loose bun. “Doesn’t it ever feel, awkward?”

James laughs, finally turning his attention to me. “Not at all, sex should be fun. And for me, it always is,” he shrugs with a sly grin. I exhale as I sit on the floor in front of him, pulling a cushion between my legs as I rest against the couch.

“Orion wants me to write a dark romance,” I pout, “but I don’t even know where to start. I need to be inspired; I need a muse, someone dark and dangerous.”

James chuckles, eyes back on his phone. “Like the Russian mafia.”

I stare at him with a raised brow. “You know someone in the Russian mafia?”

“Not just someone, *thee* someone.” He grins. “Nikolai Kirovsky,” he chuckles with a forced Russian accent. “We became close when I provided some vital intel on a business rival a few years ago. That man is all kinds of sin and sexy.”

I lift to my knees as my eyes burn into him. Hello? Is he not connecting the dots? I continue to stare at him, hands on my hips until he finally notices.

“Hell no,” he shakes his head. “I’m not putting you in touch with the Kirovsky’s, that’s fucking insane.”

“Please,” I beg, moving closer to him on my knees with my hands clasped together.

“Em, these are very dangerous people,” his voice stern. “The kill you and wipe your existence from humanity kind of dangerous. And besides, Nikolai would never agree to it. Not in a million fucking years.”

“But you could ask?” I suggest, giving him my sweetest smile. “If he says no then okay, I’ll take the no and I won’t ask you for anything again, I promise. But I’m really wracking my brain on how I’ll be able to submit ten chapters in eight weeks without your help,” I admit. “Please James. Please. Pleeeeeeeease.”

He runs a hand through his hair as he closes his eyes.

“Uh, fuck okay, I’ll ask,” he concedes before pointing a finger at me. “But if he says no...”

“I won’t ask again, I promise!” I smile.

He shakes his head with a sigh. “The things I do for you.”



CHAPTER TWO



NIKOLAI

In Russia we have a saying.

‘Волка ноги кормят’ [the wolf is fed by its legs]. It loses some of its poetry in English, but the meaning is clear: to survive in this world, perseverance isn’t optional. Failure is unacceptable.

This world demands blood. Power. Unbreakable loyalty and unshakable resilience. It’s obedience, respect and most of all, fear. Once you’re in it, you don’t ever get to walk away from it. It’s tattooed onto your fucking soul. You kill for your name; you bleed for your brothers. You protect what belongs to you, no matter the cost.

“Nikolai?” Father Vitaly’s soft voice cuts through the quiet of the empty chapel. Sunlight stabs the high arched windows, creating coloured shadow on the red carpet beneath my feet. He makes his way towards me as I sit in front, quiet and contemplative.

“I didn’t expect you today,” he continues as he sits down beside me. His small, limp frame hides behind a loose black robe. He straightens his glasses as he stares at me.

“I need to see her,” I manage. My eyes remain fixed on the table of flickering candles at the altar. Staring into the flames as I see my sisters face staring back at me. Vitaly nods his head in understanding as he pats my shoulder.

“Time doesn’t lessen the pain,” his head tilts sympathetically, “I’m praying for your healing, Nikolai.”

I lean forward. Eyes still fixed on the altar. “I don’t deserve healing.” Not for everything I’ve done. Not after all the lives I’ve taken. And in the end, *she* paid for my sins.

I lift from the bench and pick up the bouquet of white flowers seated neatly beside me. Lilies, her favourite. I walk before Vitaly can respond. I don’t need to hear that I’m worth saving. What a fucking joke.

The Kirovsky name is a symbol of power drenched in a legacy of blood and vengeance. The empire became mine at only seventeen when my parents were murdered on their way home from an associate’s event. Fucking cowards. They couldn’t even give them the decency of a fair fight. Just gunned them down like animals on the side of the road. I’ll never forget the way that my father held onto my mother, even in death.

Protective.

Devoted.

An image that will forever be burned into my mind.

After I buried my parents, my cousin Roman became my right-hand man, and together we took our vengeance against the men who dared to touch our family. I had my parents' initials engraved on each and every bullet we ploughed into their filthy fucking bodies. I wiped their family names from existence and took control of their business. Their men reported to me. If they fought, they would feel the raging heat from the barrel of my gun on their forehead.

Click. Gone.

I push through the chapel doors and slowly walk towards the cemetery just outside. The quint town in the Italian countryside has become my home for the last year.

Victoria loved vacationing here with her fiancé Erik, she loved it more than our home in Russia. The people. The air. It always brought her so much joy.

My feet stop instinctively as I reach her headstone. There were times when I couldn't even force myself to look. Seeing her name on cold, hard stone like that made me sick by its permanence.

Vengeance keeps my fire burning. I wait for the day her murderer will bleed, when I can watch him take his last breath with my hands gripped around his throat. Dmitri Baranov. I need to hear him scream for mercy while I twist the knife deeper and deeper. I will make him feel every second of anguish that I've had to endure since he took my sister from me. Since he stole the very essence of my soul from me. The only person who truly understood me. Truly loved me. I force myself to look down.

Victoria Kirovsky.

Beloved fiancé, sister and friend.

I would give anything to trade places with her. I rest the bouquet in front of the tombstone as a tear falls down my cheek. “You will have vengeance soon V. I swear it.”



The flight to Paris is quick. Efficient. I find peace in the air. No questions. No demands. Just quiet between the clouds.

I step out of the private plane and take in the scent and sight of the city. I’ve been many times before, but my visits were never for pleasure. I pause at the top of the stairs as the hum of the engine slowly fades behind me. I adjust my cuff as I check the time on my watch, the gold and emerald face catching the late afternoon light. Below, an unmarked, sleek, black SUV idles on the tarmac.

The driver leans patiently against the door, eyes forward as I make my way down the stairs. I reach for my phone and instruct Roman to keep the plane waiting for me.

Я хочу вырваться отсюда как можно быстрее [I want to get out of here as soon as I can]. I type.

“Good afternoon, Mr Kirovsky,” the driver opens the door with a polite smile.

I nod in reply and slide into the backseat.

I arrive at the estate in Rambouillet. About 40 minutes southwest of Paris. Katherine Alexander, Head of Nocturne, has an annoying flair for dramatics. Childish, for a woman pushing fifty-five. She called an emergency meeting

with the high-ranking members. No details, just an instruction to come, immediately. No excuses.

Nocturne is a secret organisation for elite businesspeople who deal in non-legal activities. It provides protection and resources. Access to law enforcement, judges, politicians and even a few presidents. At a price, of course.

Katherine's father, Ronald Alexander held the title of head for many years before his sudden passing two years ago. I, and other members voted for Katherine to take his place because we trusted in Ronald's leadership, we shared in his vision. We believed that his daughter, his only heir, would uphold the same strength and unwavering loyalty that defined his legacy. We were mistaken.

The Alexanders specialised in telecommunications for almost sixty years, Ronald singlehandedly turned his small-time operation into a multi-billion-dollar corporation. Katherine has never had to work a hard day in her fucking life.

And it shows.

Despite that, she has created quite a reputation for herself. She made very powerful connections within our circles, so no-one dares to question her.

If you do, you're out. Or worse.

"Wait for me," I instruct the driver before leaving the car. I straighten my jacket as I walk towards the front door. Two large men stand guard.

"Mr Kirovsky," one nods. The other man places a silver tray in front of me. I exhale sharply as I remove my gun from the holster and reluctantly place it on the tray.

“Thank you, sir,” he turns and holds the large wooden doors open for me to enter.

The chatter of conversation travels through the air as soon as I cross the threshold. Staff guide me down the long, dull hallway to a banqueting room which has been setup with a large, rectangular dark wood, almost black, table at its centre. The energy in the room exudes quiet but unmistakable power. Soft light filters across the polished wooden floors. The members are already seated in the high back, leather bound chairs. A council fit for kings.

Katherine’s grin widens as I finally enter the room.

“Nikolai, thank you for joining us,” she eyes me up and down as I take the empty seat directly opposite her. I scan the room and nod as I make eye contact with the others. One seat is still empty. Hmm. Frederick is absent.

In attendance is:

Katherine Alexander (*London*)

Head of Nocturne and CEO of Alexander Telecommunications.

Damian Willoughby (*New York*)

Eldest heir to Willoughby Jewellers. His family mines gold and precious jewels.

Hera Alvino (*Switzerland*)

CEO of Alvino Properties.

Suoh Murata (*Japan*)

Specialist in black market weaponry and military defence.

Spencer Lee (*New Zealand*)

CEO of Leechee AI.

Abdullah Sayad (*Dubai*)

Eldest heir to the Sayad oil dynasty.

Zeek Siphokazi (*South Africa*)

CEO of Inkazimulo Mining. They mine gold and precious metals.

Meena Olsa (*Germany*)

Heiress to the Olsa diamond empire. Her family owns and operates mines around the world.

Romero Nichols (*Brazil*)

Heir to the Nichols banking and investments empire

Briella Aspen (*Italy*)

Heir to Aspen Automotives

And me, Nikolai Kirovsky (*Russia*)

Specialist in black market weaponry and CEO of Kirovsky Cyber Security.

Over a trillion dollars of net worth sit in this room. Katherine booted out many of the older members after she took control. She thought it would be best for their ‘heirs’ to take their seat, justifying the move by placing importance on building their generational wealth.

These are the wealthiest fucking families in the world. I knew that was bullshit. She prefers the members to be younger, mouldable, acquiescent to her requests.

“Thank you all for coming at such short notice,” she grins as she scans the table.

“Why are we here Katherine?” Meena turns to her unimpressed as she brushes her long blonde hair behind her shoulder.

Katherine stares at her for a moment. Letting her sit awkwardly in her tone of disrespect before she answers.

“You’ll notice that we have an empty seat,” she announces, gesturing towards the chair beside Suoh. She reaches forward and picks up a remote as she turns on the large screen on the wall before us.

“Oh my God,” Hera exclaims as she places her hand over her mouth. Her face contorts in horror as a series of grotesque images come to life. She retches before deciding to look away. A shared look of disgust fills the room.

“Frederick Ross was murdered in his home a few days ago,” Katherine starts as she clicks through images of his bloodied, decapitated body.

“Who the fuck did this?” Zeek presses, his eyes darting between the screen and to Katherine.

Her face is stone cold as she moves through more images of the scene, Frederick’s wife. His child. His dog. All butchered.

“That’s enough Katherine,” I interject as I glare at her.

She leans back as she takes in the faces of the members.

“I think we all know who was responsible for this...” she nods. “Dmitri Baranov.”

My fists clench at the mention of his name.

“Why would Dmitri-” Briella’s head shakes in disbelief.

Katherine turns sharply. “We think he’s going after the people who voted him out.”

Romero stands. “Woah, none of us voted him out,” he pounds his fists on the table. “That vote was meant to equally split the China project with Spencer. We did not want him removed.”

“He gave me no choice!” Katherine’s voice raises in contempt. “He refused to work with Spencer, and he had become increasingly hostile. Just look at what he did to Nikolai.” She turns to me, voice softening, “poor Victoria, gunned down like that...”

I push my chair back. “Dmitri has not been seen for nearly a year,” I say, my voice low and rough. “If he dared to show his face, I would know.”

Suoh nods. “Why are we just assuming that this was Dmitri?”

A scowl forms on Katherine’s face. “Because if it wasn’t him, that means it was one of you...”

Briella gasps, appalled at the accusation. “We have an oath...”

“None of us would do this,” I agree, looking around the room.

“Someone did this,” Katherine bites out, “and if I find out it was one of you then I’m afraid that I will have to act accordingly,” she warns.

Hera reaches for her bag and stands, still covering her mouth. “I have to leave,” she manages before rushing out of the room. Concerned, Meena follows after her.

Zeek stands next, he eyes the rest of the members warily before following Meena.

Abdullah stares at Katherine. “What do we do now?”

She exhales sharply. “We each need to prepare for the inevitable. Dmitri will be coming after us, so I suggest we all lay low, temporarily.”

I shake my head. That's fucking stupid. I've known Dmitri for a long time. Since we were boys. A time long before he turned into the fucking traitor he is. Dmitri was always good at hunting.

I'm better. If he wants to find the members. He will.

This doesn't feel like him.

Abdullah nods at Katherine then briskly leaves the room. Suoh and Spencer stand simultaneously and make their way to the door with the rest of the members following closely behind in hushed conversations.

I stand and begin to walk as well.

"Nikolai, you're leaving too?" Katherine asks with a pout, as she walks towards me, glancing around the empty room. One thing about Nocturne - being a member is a privilege, unfortunately to retain that privilege also means having to endure harassment by a woman who grossly overestimates her appeal.

Katherine's thrown herself at me countless times. Each time I would lose more respect for her and now, I have none left. There are rumours that she's slept with each of the men, all except for three. Suoh, Zeek and I which I believe, she's taken as a challenge.

"I have business to attend to, Katherine," I reply coolly as I check my watch.

"Hmm," she grins. "I thought you might like to stay for dinner. It's a beautiful estate," she pauses, running her hand across my chest and dropping her voice to a seductive whisper. "I would love to show you around."

"I appreciate the offer," I remove her hand. "But I'm afraid I have to go."

“You know I just love that area you found in the countryside, so charming. I bought a little estate nearby,” she grins. “I’m thinking of having a gala soon, it would be fantastic to see you there, Nikolai.”

I exhale sharply. “I’ll try my best, Katherine. I have to go.”

I don’t give her a chance to respond before I walk out of the room. I eagerly proceed down the hall to the car waiting outside. I need to get the fuck out of here.



My estate always feels quiet. Dead fucking quiet. No number of lavish parties or business meetings could ever revive it. It’s a husk. A beautiful shadow of what it once was. I bought it for Victoria as a gift for her birthday. Now the walls whisper broken promises and shattered dreams. But this was the only place I knew Dmitri wouldn’t look. I needed solitude while I hunt him down.

My phone buzzes as I walk through the front door.

“Good afternoon, sir,” Lev greets politely as he holds the door open.

“Afternoon Lev,” I reply with a nod before checking my phone.

James Fields. He needs to talk.

I turn to Roman. “My office,” I say curtly before I walk ahead of him, leading the way.

I remove my jacket and drape it on the leather couch in the corner before sitting at my desk and turning on the large monitor positioned on the wall.

Roman leans against the window behind me, crossing his arms as I dial James.

He answers after two rings. "Nikolai, thank you for returning my call." Immediately, I notice a measure of anxiety in his usually confident voice.

"I've been waiting for this," I admit, leaning back in my chair.

"Did you find any valuable information from your source?"

James nods. "I did."

I lean forward as James shares his screen. "Dmitri was last seen in New York, just two days ago." He begins. "My source spotted him meeting with Spencer Lee..."

Spencer fucking Lee? "Are you sure it was him?" I press. That's not possible. I was just seated in a fucking room with him hours ago.

"I'm sure," James replies with a nod. He then pulls up an image of Dmitri and Spencer at a high-end restaurant having dinner together. It was unmistakably him. That smug fucking bastard.

I turn to Roman. "We need to let Katherine know."

He nods in response, already making preparations on his phone.

"This information is very useful, thank you James," I say.

He clears his throat. "Actually Nikolai, there's something I need to ask of you..."

My brow lifts at I stare at him. He's uncomfortable. Why?

"Ask," I reply with a nod, intrigued.

"This is completely ridiculous, but I promised I would,"

he starts. "My best friend, Emelia Morelli is an author, fictional

author, and she's been asked to write, darker material for her next book..."

My brows furrow. "What the fuck does that have to do with me?"

James chuckles nervously. "Well, I was wondering, and I know this is a big ask, but I would truly appreciate it if she could interview you for her book."

What the fuck? I turn to Roman who's equally confused. He looks to me and shrugs.

"Why would she want to interview me?" I press.

James swallows. "Emelia needs inspiration to write."

Roman stares at his phone as he quickly searches her up on the internet. "Oh, I've heard of her, my sister loves her books."

I glare at him. "Raquel is barely twenty, all she reads are those trashy romance novels..." I sneer.

James's eyes widen. "Uh..."

My gaze returns to him, seeing the discomfort on his face is almost laughable. "That's what your friend writes? And you want her to interview me?" I scoff, insulted.

"I know it's a big ask Nikolai and I will understand if you say no," he pauses. "Emelia hasn't exactly had an easy life, I promised her that I would ask, and I did. I'll tell her that it's not happening."

I take a deep breath. What a strange proposition. I don't need a stranger in my fucking home, especially when I'm so close to getting to Dmitri. But I can't dismiss the fact that James has been a very loyal associate. He's never once asked for a favour. Monetary or otherwise. Damn it.

“Fine, she can interview me but, she’ll need to come here, and she’ll take the time I give her.”

James’s eyes widen in surprise. “Wait, seriously?”

“Should I change my mind?” I ask with a pointed look.

“No, no,” he chuckles. “Thank you, Nikolai, I truly appreciate this.”

I lean forward. “I’m only saying yes as a favour to you James, you’ve been invaluable. But, if she steps out of line or does anything I don’t like, she’s gone. Do you understand?”

“Yes, trust me, she’ll be invisible. I promise.” He smiles.

“Don’t make me regret this,” I reply before ending the call.

Christ, what the fuck am I doing.

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CHAPTER THREE



EMELIA

I take a deep breath as I walk through the airport.

The air in this small, coastal Italian town smells fresher, cleaner, untouched by the decay of the modern age.

My eyes lift as I near the glass doors heading towards the exit, carry on and luggage already in tow. I stop and look at the cars parked neatly in formation. Not many. Understandable for a small town. Then I see him, a large muscular man wearing a fitted black shirt, black slacks and black aviator sunglasses.

He stands, holding a sign with my name on it. Such a small sign in such large hands looks ridiculous but I don't dare to laugh.

"Hi, I'm Emelia," I smile as I walk towards him, dragging my suitcase awkwardly behind me. He dips his sunglasses and eyes me up and down before opening the door and gesturing for me to get in.

"Uh, my luggage," I start, already turning around.

“I’ll take care of that,” he finally speaks. His voice is low and deep. His Russian accent unmistakable although not as thick as I was expecting it to be.

“Thank you,” I smile with a nod before sitting in the back seat of the large black SUV. He closes the door behind me and places my luggage in the trunk. I feel my nerves begin to swirl in my stomach. Am I really doing this? I’m in a foreign country with a group of very dangerous people, people I don’t know. Oh God, what the fuck am I doing?

The sound of the closing driver door snaps me out of my thought. He takes off his glasses and looks at me in the rear-view mirror.

“My name is Roman, I’m Mr. Kirovsky right-hand man.” He offers with a smile. His voice smoother now, more polite.

“It’s nice to meet you Roman,” I smile back. “How long is the drive?”

He starts the car. “About an hour, we’re on the countryside, far from the noise and eyes of the town,” he smirks as he holds my gaze in the mirror.

Oh God, are they planning to kill me?

“What kind of music do you listen to?” he asks, his tone brighter as he fiddles with the radio.

“Anything is fine,” I reply cautiously.

“My sister is a huge fan of your books,” he adds as we finally hit the road.

“That’s sweet,” I chuckle. “I’d be happy to sign anything for her while I’m here.”

“That’s very kind of you Miss Morelli,” he nods, shooting me a look in the mirror.

“Please call me Emelia,” I insist.

His phone rings and an image of a beautiful woman with long, thick, dark curly hair appears on the screen.

“Excuse me, I have to take this,” he says before answering the call.

“Дорогой, во сколько ты придёшь домой? Моя мама присоединится к нам на ужин в шесть [*dorogoy, vo skolko te sobiraesh domoi? moya mamma prisoedinitnya ke nam na uzhin vieu sixty* - Babe what time are you coming home? My mother's joining us for dinner at six].”

“Мне просто нужно сделать остановку в поместье, а затем я буду в пути [*mne nuzno lish zayekhat na pomestier, a potom ya otpravljus vieu put* - I just need to make a stop at the estate then I'll be on my way].”

“Ребёнок сегодня много шевелится, давя на мой мочевой пузырь [*rebyonok segodnya mnogo shevelitsya, davia na moi mochevoy puzyr* - The baby has been moving around a lot today, pressing on my bladder].”

He laughs.

“Он мой растущий мальчик [*moi rastushchiy malchik* - My growing boy].”

“Не опаздывай [*ne opazdyvay* - Don't be late].”

“Увидимся скоро. Я тебя люблю [*uvidimsya scoru. ya tebya lublu* - I'll see you soon. I love you].”

He ends the call with a smile and a shrug. “My wife.”

“How long have you been married?” I move in my seat, trying to get comfortable.

“Three years,” he chuckles proudly. “We’re having our first baby soon.”

“Congratulations,” I smile. “You must be thrilled.”

He shoots me nod and a wide smile in the mirror, “couldn’t be happier.”



The rest of the drive is scenic and serene. It doesn’t take long before we hit the open gravel road near the estate neighboured only by sweeping views of rolling vineyards that stretch as far as the eye can see. Right ahead, nestled on the sun-drenched hilltop is a grand villa. It’s a masterpiece of old-world charm and modern-day luxury.

Large black iron gates open for us before we make our way down a long, paved driveway with cypress-lined rows which leads to a grand courtyard with a water fountain at its centre. The villa is stunning. More than stunning. It’s perfect. Stone walls are weathered to a warm-honey brown. Terracotta tiles line the roof, bathing in the Mediterranean sun. Cicadas hum in the distance, which only adds to its romantic charm. It’s a place of beauty and elegance, untouched by the haste of time.

The car rolls to a stop in front of the main archway leading to the double front doors. He exits the vehicle first then opens the door for me. I take a moment to breathe it all in.

Roman walks by me with my luggage. “These will be waiting for you in your room.” His smile widens as he nods.

“Thank you Roman,” I smile back.

I walk towards the entrance where another man dressed identically to Roman stands, eyeing me cautiously as he scrolls through a tablet in his hands.

“Emelia Morelli,” he tilts his head with a smile. “My name is Viktor.”

“Nice to meet you Viktor,” I nod and straighten the bag on my shoulder. He turns the tablet screen to face me then asks me to place my fingertips on the handprint. I hesitate for a moment but comply to his request.

“You’re not going to steal my identity, are you?” I joke, trying to lighten the tension.

He stares at me intently then grins. “We already have your identity. Emelia Morelli, born April 18th to Alyssa and Jonathan Morelli. You graduated from college in 2018, with honours. You have a three-bedroom apartment on 6th avenue, and you drive a 2023 silver Audi A5.” He smiled. “Which reminds me, your car is overdue for a service, you should probably have that taken care of.”

My mouth falls open.

“I’m more of a Volvo guy, but this is a beautiful car,” he smirks as he swipes through images of my car parked outside my apartment.

My mouth goes dry. “You’re very thorough Viktor.”

He smiles as he swipes through images I’ve posted on my social media feeds then; he plays a video that I thought had been scrubbed from the internet.

The Hawaii trip last year.

Oh. My. God.

They have a video of me drunkenly lap dancing on Sam and being a total nuisance while dancing and singing on the bar tables. I want to die.

“Why do you have that?” I ask in horror.

Viktor chuckles. “We need to know what kind of person you are before allowing you to sleep under the same roof as the boss.”

I shake my head. “Please delete it.”

“I can’t do that,” Viktor smirks with a shrug. “It’s part of your file.”

No. Fucking. Way.

“Please Viktor, I don’t want Mr. Kirovsky seeing that and thinking that I’m not a serious writer.” I beg.

An older man dressed in all-black walks towards us with a smile.

“Miss Morelli, my name is Lev. I’ll show you to your room.” He smiles politely, gesturing for me to follow him.

Viktor grins as Lev ushers me towards the stairs. Reluctantly, I follow him. Damn it. I am going to kill whoever didn’t delete that video.

Lev and I climb the cascading staircase which leads to a long and majestic hallway. The cool wooden floor is softened by a long Parisian runner in hues of gold, red and olive green. Several oak doors line the corridor, each with beautiful golden hinges and handles. The walls are adorned with a curated collection of artwork in gilded frames. One that catches my eye is an oil painting of yellow and lilac wildflowers bathing under the Tuscan sun.

Lev pauses at the end of the hallway and opens the door with a smile. “This is your bedroom, Miss Morelli.”

My eyes widen as I take it in. The bedroom is a sanctuary of timeless Italian elegance. Natural light filters through the large arched glass doors leading to the balcony. The walls are a muted ivory, with similar artwork as the hallway. Exposed wooden beams stretch across the ceiling.

At the centre of the room, stands a king sized, four poster bed, dressed in rich white linens. An oak desk rests beneath the window, facing the sun as a plush grey chair sits tucked neatly into it.

The ensuite is just as elegant, white tiled floors, a rainfall shower and a marbled bathtub. A large mirror sits above the vanity with an ivory white sink.

“Wow,” I manage.

“If you’re hungry Miss Morelli, the staff would be happy to prepare something for you,” he offers.

“I’m okay for now, thank you Lev and please call me Emelia,” I smile.

Lev nods. “I’ll be right downstairs if you need anything.” He says before making his way to the door.

“Lev, will I be meeting Mr Kirovsky soon?” I ask, turning to him.

He shakes his head. “He’s unavailable this evening, but he will meet with you tomorrow.”

I nod and watch him leave.

I pull out my phone and sigh as I sit on the bed. Six missed calls from James. Uh-oh. I promised I would call him when I landed.

I return his call and prepare myself for a scolding.

“You were supposed to call me when you landed Emelia,” his voice stern and impatient as he answers.

“I’m so sorry, I just got caught up with everything here. But I’m safe, I’m at the estate now,” I reply, putting the call on speaker as I unpack my bag.

“Have you met Nikolai yet?” he asks, his tone beginning to soften.

“No not yet, I’m supposed to meet him tomorrow,” I answer, packing my clothes into the dresser. “This place is beautiful James! You should see this bedroom.”

“Yeah, it’s a fucking dream. Just keep your head down, get your notes and come home, okay? My anxiety is through the roof with you being there.” He admits.

I laugh. “Everyone’s been really nice to me so far, I think you’re worrying for nothing.”

“Oh Emmy, you have no idea who the Kirovsky’s are. Trust me, that’s not a world you’d want to be caught up in,” his voice low and firm.

I pick up my phone and turn off the speaker as I hold it to my ear again. “James, I love you and I’m so grateful that you’ve arranged this for me. I promise, I’ll be safe, okay?” I smile.

James sighs. “I want a text from you every day.”

I laugh. “Fine, jeez, I gotta go, I’ll check in with you tomorrow, sir,” I joke.

“You better,” he chuckles. “Bye babe.”

“Bye,” I smile.

My gaze lifts to the window as I watch two black SUV's drive out of the iron gates. Suddenly, my stomach growls. I guess I am hungry after all.



I walk through the hallway, down the staircase, looking around until I finally find the kitchen. The setting sunlight pours in through the arched windows. A large wooden island with a thick white and grey marbled slab countertop sits in its centre. Copper pots hang overhead from an iron rack suspended by the wooden ceiling beams.

Two women stand in the kitchen, an older woman, early-sixties, petite with black framed-glasses and greying hair tied in a neat bun stands in front of the stove stirring what smells to be a rich, creamy butternut soup while a younger woman, mid-twenties, with black hair tied in a ponytail stands at the counter chopping vegetables. They share similar facial features.

“Hi, I’m Emelia Morelli,” I say as I catch their attention.

The older woman smiles warmly, her eyes squinting as she stares at me. “We heard that we have a guest, it’s lovely to meet you Emelia, I’m Maria and this is my daughter Zora.”

“Hi, it’s nice to meet you,” Zora smiles sweetly.

“Whatever you’re making it smells amazing,” I say as I walk towards them. “Can I help?”

Zora smiles, “No that’s okay, mama has a very particular way of running the kitchen.” She laughs. “Trust me, you don’t want to get yelled at for cutting the carrots unevenly.”

Maria laughs as she turns around. “I’m not that bad.”

Zora turns to me and mouths ‘She is’.

“How long will you be staying, Emelia?” Maria stirs the soup with a soft gentle hum.

I shrug. “A few weeks, Mr. Kirovsky was gracious enough to let me stay until I submit my draft to my publisher.”

“You’re a writer?” Zora’s eyes sparkle.

I nod with a smile.

“What do you write?” she asks as she continues to chop vegetables. Eyes darting between the chopping board and me.

“Romance, mostly,” I reply.

“That’s so exciting!” she smiles.

“Did you say your last name was Morelli?” Maria asks as she adds a sprinkle of pepper.

I nod my head with a smile. “Yes.”

“My husband was obsessed with a spy novel series by Jonathan Morelli, is he a relative of yours?” Maria asks.

I nod. “He was my father.”

Zora tilts her head with a soft smile. “Nikolai won’t be back for dinner but you’re welcome to join

us, if you’d like,” she offers.

“I would love that, thank you.”



Mornings at the estate are like waking up in a dream. Sunlight filters through the large arched windows and balcony doors. Drawing in warmth and a sense of ease I'm trying to get used to.

After breakfast, I wander into the flower garden, where every root carries the memory of careful hands. Lilies, roses, daffodils, and sunflowers stand in rows like a chorus, their colours weaving a melody across the earth. I lift the hem of my dress as I bend, my fingers graze the golden faces of the sunflowers. Petals as soft as whispers as they stare up at the sky.

"Miss Morelli," Lev's voice cuts through the quiet.

I lift my head and turn to him with a smile.

"Mr Kirvosky can meet with you now," he says, gesturing towards the pathway.

I nod and follow him.

Lev leads me back into the villa through the foyer, down the hallway towards a large oak door which stands slightly ajar. He enters first, scanning the room then turns to me. "He'll just be a moment; you can wait here."

I nod. "Thank you, Lev."

I watch him leave and quietly close the door behind him. My gaze lingers around the room—its dark wood desk positioned near the tall, arched windows; walls dressed in artwork and sleek LED screens. My steps carry me to a bookshelf lined with philosophical works and treasured collectors' editions. My fingers pause on a rare prize: a 1922 first edition of *Ulysses* by James Joyce, its slightly worn blue wrapper still bearing the ghost of its original painting.

Then my eyes drift to a large painting, its style echoing those I'd seen in the hallway near my room. I step closer, drawn into the vivid wildflowers blooming across the canvas. Each stroke feels like a tender kiss, painted with reverence and quiet longing. Against the brooding weight of a pre-storm sky, the explosion of colour seems to reach for me, stirring something deep within my soul.

I take a closer look at the artist's signature, 'V. Kirovsky.'

Hmm, a relative. I would very much like to meet them.

"Who the fuck are you?" A low, rough voice cuts through the quiet to immediately demand my attention.

I turn; a soft gasp escapes my throat as my eyes meet the most attractive man I've ever seen now standing just a few feet from me.

Tall, broad-shouldered, impossibly handsome. A loose strand of dark hair tumbles across his forehead, framing strong, dark brows, while deep forest green eyes hold me captive.

My breath catches in my throat as a smirk pulls at his lips. A sight so devilish that it's sending my pulse into overdrive.



CHAPTER FOUR



NIKOLAI

Roman is early.

Muffled sounds outside the bathroom door of my office pulls my attention. I wash my hands and splash water on my face as I stare into the mirror. Soon I will have Dmitri right where I want him, I will make him pay for everything he's taken from me.

I dry my face and toss the towel in the hamper before I open the door.

My feet stop immediately. A woman stands in my office with her back towards me as she stares at the painting hanging on the far wall. Her long dark brown hair cascades in thick waves down her back. Her dress, a sweet shade of lilac hugs at her waist delicately before flowing down, teasing the curve of her ass and hips before settling below her knees.

"Who the fuck are you?" I ask, confused.

Then she turns. The moment my eyes meet her face, the freshest air fills the entirety of my lungs. As if I've just learned to breathe for the first time.

Her eyes are a beautifully bright shade of honey brown. They sparkle with magical clarity. Her lips are full, coated in a shade of mauve lipstick that suits her perfectly. Her hair moves with her, like a silk waterfall. Her skin glows, as if she's perfected the art of tanning. Although her dark brows suggest that is all natural.

The thin delicate straps of her dress are unmissable, no bra. Her breasts sit firm and full, with the curve of cleavage teasing behind her neckline. God, she's fucking incredible.

Mallory has always managed to find the most beautiful women for me, granted I pay her agency a fortune to do so, but she really fucking outdid herself this time.

"I wasn't expecting anyone today," I smirk as I hold her gaze.

"You didn't know I was coming?" She asks, confused.

I shrug. "I'm not displeased by it, not at all."

Her eyes widen as I move towards her. Such a beautiful woman should be on the cover of magazines, not subjected to the life of an escort. Staring at her, the innocence in her face, the thought of another man having access to her makes my blood boil. I make a mental note to discuss her contract with Mallory.

"You're supposed to be shown to my bedroom upon arrival, that's the rule."

She frowns. "What?"

I chuckle. "You must be new." Good, she's a rookie, just what I need.

“I’m not sure how to respond to that,” she says.

I lean against the desk as I take in every inch of her. “Take your dress off.”

“Excuse me?” she snaps, crossing her arms against her chest.

“As lovely as that dress is, I’m not paying you to model it for me. Take it off, leave the heels on and sit on the couch.” I command.

“You’re not paying me at all!” She exclaims. “Who do you think I am?”

My brows furrow. “You’re from the agency.”

Her mouth falls open. “You think I’m an escort?”

My head tilts. “What-”

“I’m Emelia Morelli, James’s friend,” her nose scrunches as she stares at me incredulously.

Fuck me.

“Why the hell are you dressed like that?” I ask, annoyed.

Her mouth falls open wider. “Oh, now you don’t like my dress?” She snaps. “A minute ago, you were telling me to take it off.”

A grin pulls at my lips as I cross my arms against my chest. “Well Emelia, my offer still stands.”

“No thank you,” she rolls her eyes.

I gesture to the seat in front of my desk for her to sit before moving to my chair. “Let’s not make a big deal out of this. I just didn’t expect you to look, the way that you do.”

“Is that supposed to be a compliment?” Her tone drips with sarcasm as she takes a seat.

“They’re not all escorts, you know.” I grin, leaning comfortably against the back of my chair.

“How romantic,” she tilts her head and scrunches her nose. “Could we just, start over?”

“Sure,” I nod.

She extends her hand over the desk to me.

“Mr Kirovsky, I’m Emelia Morelli,” she forces a smile. “Author, *not* escort.”

“Call me Nikolai,” I reply coolly as I shake her hand. Her skin feels warm and soft. My hand instantly feels colder when she pulls away.

She smiles as she settles back into the seat opposite me. Her bright eyes tearing into me from across the desk.

“Thank you for letting me interview you and allowing me to stay in your home, I know you’re a man with limited free time, so I just wanted to let you know how much I appreciate this.” Her voice is warmer now, sweeter.

I nod as I try to organise my thoughts. I didn’t expect her to be this fucking gorgeous.

“If you have an assistant, I could schedule time in your diary with them directly, if that works better for you?” She suggests.

“No,” I shake my head. “I’ll have one of the staff get you whenever I have a free moment, that’s the only way this will work.”

Her brows knit. “You want me to just hang around all day until you’re free?”

I nod with a growing grin. The thought of keeping her waiting for me

shouldn't excite me as much as it does.

"No," her lips tighten.

"Excuse me?" I must have misheard her.

She shakes her head. "I still have work to do; I can't disrupt my writing anytime you have a few minutes to spare."

I lean back, taking her in. No-one says no to me. "Those are the terms, Emelia." My voice is low and challenging; my eyes burn into hers just waiting for her response.

She makes me wait, locking eyes for long moment before she nods once. "As long as I'm not being called at odd hours of the night, I suppose I could make that work."

There's fire behind those big brown eyes. A fire that threatens to burn both of us the longer she stays here.

"I believe you write romance novels, is that right?" I ask, my tone sounding more mocking than I intend it to be.

"I do," she nods, straightening her face.

"You write about romance like a woman in love. Are you in love Emelia?" I press, curious.

She hesitates for a moment. Her eyes drop to the floor then back up to me. "I don't know if I've ever really been in love to be honest... My stories are fiction, to me too," she murmurs.

Her gaze drops again for just a second. I would love to know what thoughts are running through that pretty little head of hers.

"What is it that you're trying to accomplish with your time here?" I ask.

She leans forward, brushing her hair from her shoulder. “Inspiration,” she smiles, “my publisher’s asked me to write darker material for my next series to coincide with the launch of their new business division. This might be ridiculous, but I think that being in the space of someone like yourself, would spark some ideas.”

Someone like me? She has no fucking idea what I’m capable of.

She lifts from the chair as her eyes suddenly widen. She walks towards the window and stands beside me as she looks out onto the lawn. She is inches away from me, so close that I can breathe in her florally vanilla perfume. If I reach my hand out just a few inches, I can run my fingers all along the perfect arch of her back.

“You have a helipad?” She asks with a laugh.

I nod with a smile, watching her sit down again.

“Can I be honest,” she starts. “I expected you to be older.”

I lean back; eyes narrowed on her. “How old do you think I am?”

She shrugs. “Mid-thirties.”

I laugh. “You think that’s too young to have all of this?”

“No,” she chuckles. “I just mean that, it’s impressive.”

Fuck, she needs to stop looking at me like that. You need to set boundaries Nik. Asap.

“You’ll have full access to the estate and all the amenities,” I reply coolly.

“Thank you,” she smiles with a nod.

“Any communication in or out goes through our network so no pictures, videos or sharing this location, do you understand?” I ask, raising a brow.

She nods her head with a polite smile. "I understand."

Good girl.

She lifts from her seat and makes her way to the door. She pauses with her hand on the knob and slowly turns to me.

"You didn't happen to see the folder that Viktor put together of me, right?" she asks awkwardly.

I lean back, unable to stop the smirk as I shake my head.

She exhales. "Okay," she smiles before leaving the room.

I open Viktors email with Emelia's file as soon as the door closes. Standard protocol for all guests. If only I had checked before that little mix-up. Although seeing Emelia's face flush with embarrassment was interesting. There's a fire inside of her that I would just love to stoke.

But I won't touch her.

I can't.

I open a video file and enlarge it on the monitor. Music plays in the background as Emelia saunters towards the camera in a bikini with a bottle of vodka. Cheers echo around her as she straddles a friend and grinds on her lap. Her head rolls back as laughter rings like an enchanting melody from her throat.

Watching her hips roll is making my heartbeat drum and my cock ache. She's goddamn breathtaking. Her friend slaps her ass playfully as she pours the bottle of vodka over her chest.

Fuck me, she's going to be trouble.



CHAPTER FIVE



EMELIA

The estate grounds unfold like a dream.

It's expansive and lush with a sense of quiet grandeur in every single detail.

I lean against the terrace as I take in the panoramic views of the vineyards in the distance, tucked beneath the undulating hills beyond. I finally feel like I can breathe. Like my anxiety demon has been gagged and hog tied. Good fucking riddance.

I close my eyes as I feel the soft gentle breeze kiss my face. The constant noise of the outside world can't find me here.

When I step into the hallway, my footsteps echo faintly against the wooden floor. Nikolai's bedroom sits at the very end of the corridor, next to mine. Two other guest rooms line the hall, empty but immaculate, each a reminder of the kind of wealth that can afford unused space.

There's a large guest bathroom with marble counters, and a quiet sitting room with tall glass doors leading out to a wide balcony. The ground floor is a labyrinth of elegance. A grand foyer with polished stone, a formal dining room with a crystal chandelier hanging above a large oak table, a study lined with leather-bound books, and a private gym just down the hall from Nikolai's office.

In the living room, sunlight streams through patio doors that open to the terrace. Beyond, the pool glitters like glass, framed by manicured grass. Then, a stone walkway leads to the adjacent guest houses, lived in by the staff. Past that, a small forest whispers in the breeze, wild and untamed compared to the precision of the villa.

"Miss Morelli, Mr Kirovsky is ready to meet with you for your first interview. He's in the garage." Lev says with a polite smile.

I nod. "Thank you, I'll be right there."

I grab my journal and a pen before heading down to the garage. The mingling scents of leather polish and motor oil lead me straight to him. He's bent over the open hood of a 1967 Ford Shelby GT500, dressed in navy sweatpants and a once white T-shirt now stained with black smudges. I pause, caught in the moment. His hands darkened with grease, his brow gleaming faintly with sweat.

"What are you doing?" I manage through a shaky breath.

His gaze roams my body until he finally meets my eyes. "Hand me that towel," he gestures to the table.

I swallow hard then walk by him, to the worktable against the wall. It looks more like a showroom than a garage.

Every shiny thing has its place. Rows of wrenches in different lengths like polished silverware, screwdrivers with coloured handles fanned out in neat order, and a little dish holding screws and bolts as if they were pieces of jewellery.

There's a heavy silver stick with a dial at one end, something that looks important, though I couldn't guess what for. Boxes of cloths are stacked neatly beside bottles of sprays, their labels sharp and clinical. Even the hammers seem too clean, their heads unscarred.

I lift the soft grey towel and hand it to him. My breath hitches as his fingers touch mine. Warm, rough hands. The pads of his fingers caressing my skin. It's just a second but it's long enough for him to burn himself into me. To make me long for the feeling of those large, rough hands all over my body.

God how am I going to make it through the next weeks when he's looking at me like that? Like he can read all my dark, dirty thoughts and it pleases him.

"How do you want to do this?" He asks with a smirk as he wipes his hands and gestures for me to sit on the bench beside him.

"I-"

"You have questions prepared for me, I'm assuming?" He continues, turning his attention back to motor.

Of course. Questions. Get it together, Emelia.

"Yes, just general questions to start. To understand your mindset a little more," I begin, flipping open my journal and taking a seat on the bench.

"What would you like to know?" His grin darkens.

I lick my lips. “Have you ever killed anyone?” I stare down at my journal for a moment as heat begins to course through my body.

“That’s your first question?” He chuckles, the sound low and sexy. “I’ve killed lots of people, Emelia.” He begins to wipe down the glistening black surface then picks up a torque wrench.

My eyes lift to him. “How did you kill them?”

“Bullets, knives, some with my hands.” He turns to face me. “It all depends on what they did to provoke my anger.”

“What did the last person do?” I ask, intrigued.

I should be terrified, running for the fucking hills. And yet, I can’t tear my eyes away from him. My body will not move even at my own command.

He exhales sharply before turning to me. “Broke my trust.”

I squeeze my thighs together as I watch a bead of sweat drip from his forehead, drifting slowly to his neck. Nikolai lifts his shirt, exposing the beads of sweat dripping along the strong, chiselled lines of his stomach and torso as he wipes his forehead and neck.

“I don’t trust easily, if at all, and when I do, I don’t like to be made a fool of,” his tone firmer, harsher while he pulls out the oil dip stick, wiping it clean, reinserting then pulling out again to check the level.

“Do you ever regret it?” I pause. “Taking a life...?”

He exhales sharply as his eyes focus on me. “Not once.”

I swallow hard. I need to get this interview back on track before I melt all over this bench.

“What was it like growing up as the son of business mogul, Aleksei Kirovsky?” I manage.

Nikolai stills as his eyes drop. “Tough. My father was difficult man to please. He demanded perfection. At all times.”

“What did that mean?” My brow raises as I watch him, completely entranced.

“While my friends were playing soccer and hockey after school, I was thrown in a cage and forced to fight for my life.” He says coldly.

“Krovavy Krug,” he sounds out, “The blood circle.”

I drop my journal and stare at him.

“You either kill or you die. I had to fight until there were no opponents left. When my body was strong, my mind had to be too. I had to learn to command a room, to lead men, to instil absolute fear in the eyes of an enemy just by the mention of my name.”

He hides his pain, disguising it as anger and apathy. He’s clearly become an expert at it, but there’s a sadness in his tone that stills my heart.

My gaze softens. “And your mother?”

His eyes return to the motor as he gives a bolt a quick twist. “My mother was the only person my father would listen to, she was the only person who ever truly understood him.

Alina Kirovsky put men two, three times her size in their place,” a soft smile graces his lips.

“Do you have any siblings?” I lean forward.

He pauses then nods. “I have a younger brother, Dominik, but he’s not interested in the business. Only spending our parents fortune on parties and

orgies with strangers.”

“Who’s V?” I ask, curious.

His head snaps to me as his eyes narrow. Fuck.

“The paintings in the house, they’re beautiful. I just wondered-”

He exhales sharply, averting his eyes. “Victoria... She was my sister.”

Was? Shit.

“I’m sorry,” I breathe.

“For what?” His lips straighten.

I swallow hard. “I didn’t know...I’m sorry, for bringing it up. The paintings are so beautiful, I was just curious.”

He pauses then returns his attention to the motor.

“Which one do you like?” he asks, his voice softer now.

A breath escapes my throat as my gaze falls to my feet. “I like them all, but my favourite is the one in your office. The wildflowers before a storm. There’s something hauntingly beautiful about it, to capture a moment of life and vibrance, knowing that in an instant, it’ll be ripped away as though it never existed. It’s poetic.”

When I look up, Nikolai’s staring at me.

“Victoria was a very gifted artist...” he starts. “She would make me sit for what felt like hours when she practiced her portraits. I hated it at first but, it always seemed to make her happy. If our father were alive, he would have never let her step foot in an art school. She would have been married off at eighteen to secure a business deal,” he pauses. “When I took over, I was more than happy to watch her fulfil her passion. She thrived in art school. Her

dream was to live out here on the countryside and paint the world.” Nikolai pauses again as his gaze burns into me. A slip of the mask as he allows me to see his grief.

The urge to comfort him is strong. So strong that my fingers grip the bench to stay tethered to it. I have to remind myself that to him, I’m a stranger.

A guest in his home.

A passerby in his world.

A temporary distraction from a life that I have no business inserting myself into.

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CHAPTER SIX



NIKOLAI

Daniel Smith is as an architect on several projects.

We've worked together for many years. He is one of the best. If not the best. Which is why I retained his services for the weapons armoury in Prague.

I need perfection.

This project demands it.

Daniel lays a blueprint case on my desk with a proud smile. "My team is finalising some structural details. The venting system was challenging but not impossible," he says, adjusting his thick-framed glasses. "You should have the final plans from my team within a few weeks, Nikolai."

I lean forward and raise a brow. "The permits?"

"They're being taken care of, your people were very, persuasive," he grins with a nod.

“Good.” I smirk. “This site is very valuable to me and my business associate. I don’t want any surprises.”

“You won’t get any, we’re making sure of that,” he nods.

I lean back, exhaling slowly. “When could we begin construction?”

“Most likely by the end of August,” he replies. “September, more realistically.”

“Fantastic,” I say, turning to Roman.

“Suoh will be glad to hear it,” he adds.

“Thank you, Daniel,” I nod.

Daniel nods back as he begins to leave with Viktor showing him out.

Roman exhales sharply. “Katherine won’t like that you’re moving ahead with this. She would want to know,” he warns.

“She needs to mind her fucking business and stay out of mine,”

I retort. “She has bigger issues to worry about.”

“Frederick?” Roman shifts uncomfortably.

I nod slowly. “Это плохо пахнет [*pachnet gadko* - it smells foul].”

“Maksim is following up on the lead, if Dmitri is in New York, he will be found soon,” he insists.

I exhale sharply. “Why has he resurfaced after all this time? And why meet with Spencer when he was so against working with him before?”

Roman stares at me intently. “It doesn’t make sense.”

I lean back. “I told Katherine I wouldn’t interfere, for now.”

Roman raises a brow. “And you intend on keeping that promise?”

I chuckle. “Нет, черт возьми [*chert vozmi, nett* - Fuck no].”



I usually eat lunch on the veranda of the estate, when I have time. I can organise my thoughts in the quiet.

I pause as I see her. There goes my plan to limit my contact with her. She’s already managed to make me open up far more than I should have. That cannot happen again.

Perhaps I can use this as a way to finally get her out of my head. Get to know her, the real her. I’ll let her babble on and on about nothing until she’s just a faceless body. As they all become when they try to get too close.

Emelia’s thick, long hair glows in beautiful bronze hues as she bathes in Tuscan afternoon sunlight. Her crisp white sundress hugs her breasts and waist before flowing down, settling just below her knees. There’s no denying that she’s a fucking beauty. She sits with a half-eaten bowl of fruit in front of her as she stares into her book.

“Do you mind if I join you?” I ask with a grin as she finally meets my gaze.

Her smile widens. “Please do.”

“Your home is beautiful,” she murmurs as her eyes sparkle with delight. “I feel like I’m in a dream.”

“Thank you.” I smile as I sit opposite her. Lev places a salad bowl in front of me with a nod before leaving us.

“What are you reading?” I ask, curious.

“Cursed Light, you wouldn’t know it,” she chuckles. “It was written by a friend of mine; it’s in the genre my publisher’s trying to push me in.”

“I thought you write romance?” I ask before taking a bite of my salad.

She smiles. “I do, but this is a little different. It’s a darker romance.”

My brows furrow. “What’s dark romance?”

Emelia bites her bottom lip as she stifles a small laugh.

Her cheeks begin to slowly redden. “It’s kind of...” she trails as she tries to find her words.

Why is she getting so flustered? And why do I find it so fucking cute?

“It’s romance but darker, more dangerous, higher stakes,” she manages.

“What’s dangerous about it?” I ask, taking another bite.

She tucks her hair behind her ear as she smiles. “Well, there are elements of danger...”

“Like what?” I press, amused at how nervous she’s becoming.

“Like... a woman being chased through dark woods by a handsome, shirtless, masked man and when he catches her, they...” she pauses.

“They what, Emelia?” I ask, intrigued.

“They uhm...” she laughs nervously, trying to find her words.

“They fuck?” I grin.

Her breath hitches as she stares at me. “Yeah,” she manages with a nod.

I lean back and raise a brow. “And women enjoy that?”

“Some do,” she nods with a shrug.

“Do you like that?” I ask, voice dropping to a near whisper. My eyes drifting to her lips.

She holds my gaze as her mouth falls open slightly. “I guess, I don’t... not, like that.”

Hmm, interesting.

“Do you have plans for your afternoon, Emelia?” I ask as I finish my salad.

She shakes her head as a sweet smile remains fixed on her full lips.

I tilt my head. “Would you like to accompany me on a drive?”

“Okay,” she nods.

I begin to stand. “Meet me in the courtyard in five minutes.”

Her eyes widen. “Should I change?”

I shake my head with a widening smirk. “You’re perfect.”



I stand in the courtyard, leaning against my black Aston Martin Valhalla as I wait for her. The black gloss finish soaks up the sunlight. I admire the design, running my hand across the curve of the hood, my fingers brushing against the carbon finish. I’ve always had a deep love for cars. The precision, the control, the sheer fucking power of it. There’s nothing like dropping your foot on the accelerator and it giving you everything it’s got. I could only bring a few of my favourites with me to the estate, the rest wait for me back in Russia like loyal dogs.

The clicking of sandalled heels pulls my gaze to her. Emelia, walking towards me in that white dress, like she belongs in a dream. That long,

luscious hair of hers framing her angelic face. My head is telling me to stay the fuck away from her but every other part of me screams to know more about this beautiful stranger in my house.

She smiles at me, a smile so bright and effortless it could bring a grown man to his knees. I feel a grin pull at my mouth before I can stop it. I step aside and hold the passenger door open for her.

“Thank you, Nikolai,” she says before slipping into the seat effortlessly. I close the door behind her then make my way around to the driver’s side and slide in beside her.

I start the car; it responds in a low and guttural roar to life. I smirk as I notice Emelia’s eyes widen at the sound. Her perfume enchants me immediately, vanilla and floral, sweet and tempting. I feel her eyes on me as I shift into gear and pull out of the gates.

Emelia’s quietly marvelling at the views of the green hills rolling into distant vineyards. The Italian countryside looks as though it has been painted just for her, and she’s soaking it all in with wide, wonderous eyes. Soon the scent of the ocean begins to drift through the windows. Announcing itself.

She turns to me, her smile warm and curious. “Where are we going?”

I grin as my eyes remain fixed on the narrow coastal road. I ease the car off the asphalt and onto a private, gravel road. A few moments later we roll to a stop on an empty beachfront plot.

“You’ll see,” I grin.

She lets out a soft laugh as she reaches for the door handle and cracks it open.

“What are you doing?” I ask, staring at her.

She turns back, eyebrow raised. “I thought-”

I lean in before she can finish, slow and close, reaching across her. “A gentleman opens the door,” I murmur as my face hovers close to hers.

She pauses, just for a moment as her eyes pour into mine. Then slowly, and reverently, she nods as I gently pull the door closed again. I step out then move around to her side. Her eyes are fixed on me as I open the door and hold out my hand to her. She takes it with a smile.

“Take your shoes off,” I murmur.

She tilts her head slightly as she looks at me, but then complies, pulling her heels off one by one and holding them in her hands. I remove my shoes and socks too.

I take Emelia’s shoes and place them on the floor of the passenger seat, beside mine.

She looks up at me curiously as I close the door. I gesture towards the sandy path beside the car.

The breeze rolls in from the ocean, brushing strands of Emelia’s hair as we make our way down to the beach. It’s quiet. A few small families dot the shoreline, kids jumping into the waves, building sandcastles. Couples hand in hand on romantic strolls and dogs chasing after bright green balls.

Peaceful.

“This is where I come to think sometimes, when I want to be alone,” I say, finally breaking the silence.

“I can see why,” she nods. “It’s beautiful here, Nikolai.”

I look over at her. “I thought it would be a good place to get to you know you better.”

“What would you like to know?” She smiles, a playful glint in her eyes. “Besides what Viktor has meticulously researched in his file.”

I chuckle. “Tell me about your family.”

She pauses as her smile fades slightly. “My parents passed when I was young, really young,” she says softly. “A drunk driver hit us head-on. I left the hospital with twenty-six stitches, a broken arm... and no parents.”

I stop walking as my eyes stay locked on her. “I’m sorry...”

She offers a small smile. “It’s life, I guess.”

She stares at the sand as we start walking again. “I was sent to live with my aunt Nina, my mom’s sister. She did what she could, but she wasn’t exactly the nurturing type. She sent me off to boarding school as soon as I turned ten. I stayed there until I graduated high school.”

Her voice dims as she continues. “Kids can be cruel. I was bullied for being an orphan. Like I chose it. Like it was my fault...” she pauses. “Graduations, family days ... I spent them all alone, shying away in the shadows. I didn’t have anyone to show up for me. After a while I just got used to it. I stopped inviting my aunt to be a part of my life, there wasn’t any point in trying.”

I stare at her, wondering how someone so beautiful could suffer so much pain and still carry herself with such grace and strength.

“I didn’t have any real friends until college,” she continues, her voice slowly lifting as her smile returns. “That’s where I met James. And Samantha. James’s family sort of... adopted me, in their own way. Birthdays, holidays, I always spent it with them, an honorary Fields.”

She smiles again, softer this time. "James is my best friend. He's incredibly kind. Loyal. Like the brother I never had."

I nod. "James is a good man. I haven't known him as long as you have, but... he's solid. Trustworthy. That much I know."

"He's had my back through everything," she says, her gaze fixed on the water now. "Honestly, I don't know where I'd be without him."

In the corner of my eye, I notice two men staring at Emelia as we begin to pass. She doesn't even notice their hungry, filthy gazes on her body. But I fucking do. And I don't fucking like it.

"Bellissimo bambino [Beautiful baby]," one of them whistles as they finally pass us.

I turn, my smile just as wide as theirs as I move towards them.

"Continua a fissarla e ti taglierò i fottuti occhi [Keep staring at her and I'll cut your fucking eyes out]."

The fuckers turn and quickly walk away, smiles vanished.

"What was that?" Emelia chuckles as she scrunches her nose.

"They asked for the time," I grin.

"It didn't-"

A sudden burst of laughter interrupts us. A little girl no more than two or three, comes bounding toward us on chubby legs, her cheeks sticky and her face smeared with chocolate ice cream. Blonde curls bounce around her shoulders, and wide blue eyes sparkle with pure, uninhibited joy. She runs straight to Emelia, giggling as she throws her arms around her legs and looks up, expectantly raising her hands to be picked up.

"Hi, honey," she laughs, crouching to scoop the child into her arms. "Are you lost?" The little girl babbles something incomprehensible between giggles, her tiny fingers reaching up and tangling themselves into Emelia's long, perfect hair. She laughs again, completely caught up in the moment, trying and failing to decipher the toddler's words. I stand, silent, watching.

The little girl nestles her head against her shoulder, content and calm now.

"You are just the sweetest little thing," she murmurs, brushing a curl from the girl's face. Then, without warning, the child looks at me and stretches out her small hand. I don't think. I just move.

I step forward and extend my hand; I feel the impossibly soft grip of her tiny fingers wrapping around my index finger.

The world narrows. Time stalls.

Emelia looks up at me then, holding the girl with one arm, the other gently rubbing her back. Her eyes soften the moment they meet mine. And then, voices.

"Oh mio Dio, ci dispiace tanto [Oh my God, we're so sorry]!" a woman rushes up, slightly breathless. The little girl's mother.

"È appena scappata, grazie mille [She just ran off, thank you so much]."

The father steps forward, eyes widening as he takes in the white dress now smeared with chocolate handprints.

"She ruined your dress. Can we cover the dry cleaning?"

Emelia looks down, then laughs. "No, really, it's fine. It was worth it."

The couple offer grateful smiles as they gently pull their daughter from her arms and walk off, still apologizing.

"We should get back," I manage, voice lower than I intended. Emelia nods slowly, offering me a small, understanding smile. We walk side by side, returning to the car.



We arrive back at the estate after a comfortably silent drive, the kind of quiet that didn't need to be filled. The engine purrs to a stop, and I catch a glimpse of Emelia's hand reaching for the door handle, only for her to pause halfway, remembering.

I smirk as I slide out of the car and move around to her side and open the door. She looks up at me with a smile that makes something stir in my chest.

She steps out gracefully; the folds of her white dress still marked with faint smudges of chocolate and sand. As she walks a few steps ahead, she pauses, then turns to face me.

"Thank you for today," she says sweetly.

I lean back against the car, hands tucked into my pockets, eyes running down the mess on her dress.

"Maria can get that out," I say with a grin.

She glances down, then laughs. "I think it adds character."

I smile; my eyes linger on her as the last rays of light catch the sparkle in hers. She smiles, softer, then turns and makes her way toward the front door.

I stay a little longer, watching her, wondering how on earth this beautiful fucking creature found her way to me. And more importantly, how the fuck am I going to stay away from her...

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CHAPTER SEVEN



EMELIA

It's been five days since the beach.

Nikolai's been in and out of the estate. I can't shake this feeling like he's avoiding me. The thought gnaws at my chest, festering like an infection.

Did I do something to upset him? Did I say something? It hurts when he doesn't so much as look my way when we pass in the foyer. He just rushes off, out the door or to his office with Roman or Viktor close behind. No interviews, not even a good morning. Just stone-cold silence.

I shouldn't have been so open about my life, about my family. Vulnerability isn't a currency Nikolai trades in. He probably sees it as a weakness. The undeniable truth is, he and I come from two very different worlds.

His life is forged in danger, sharpened by violence. He walks a tightrope between life and death. Every choice he makes feels like it could end in bloodshed.

I've only ever flirted with danger from the safety of my computer. I write about thrills, about shadows in the dark and the rush of risk, but I've never lived it. My hands aren't scarred; my breath has never caught from the weight of real fear. I imagine storms; Nikolai creates them. And maybe that's why I should have kept my world tucked away, locked up tight.

I decide to focus my attention on where it should be, writing. My outline is done. I just need to start my first chapter. But the blank document stares at me mockingly. I look out the study window into the garden. As if I can find the words there. My fingers brush the keyboard, slow but purposeful. I know my story's in here; I just need to find it. Just one sentence Emelia. That's it. Just one. So, I begin.

Home was meant to be my sanctuary. My peace.

Instead, it was my prison.

Then, the surge begins.

For seven years I've been running. Running from the life they scripted for me, from a story etched into my skin before I even took my first breath.

Running from the chains of their sanctified ordinary.

The day I turned eighteen was the last time I saw my parents. The last night I slept behind a locked door, trapped with my own shame. The last time I was forced onto my knees for three hours, begging God to scrub me clean of a sin I willingly chose.

I head to the kitchen to make a cup of tea. I still, my feet are frozen in place as I see Nikolai at the fridge grabbing a bottle of water.

“Hi,” I breathe. The only word I can muster after days of mere glimpses of him.

He nods then grips the bottle before heading past me.

“Are you-”

My words fall the ground; he’s already making his way out of the door. What the fuck did I do? I must have done something; he can barely look at me. I don’t understand. He was so nice to me, maybe naïve to think, but I thought he enjoyed my company. I can’t shake that look on his face. Like he wasn’t even looking at me, but past me.

I move to the stove and pour hot water from the kettle into a clear mug. I steep the earl grey teabag, watching the colour change to a warm amber. I drizzle just a drop of honey and milk.

My phone rings. James. Just the person I need.

“Hello handsome,” I smile.

“Hello gorgeous, quick question.” He pauses. “Would you mind if I crash at your place for a few days. I’m having my bathroom retiled, I hate that fucking blue now.”

I laugh. “Maybe don’t let your next boyfriend redecorate your home after only three months.”

I can practically hear him rolling his eyes. “I know, but he was so hot Em.”

I stir my tea with a smile. “Of course you can stay at my place. Although, we might have to be roomies soon.” I sigh. “I think Nikolai hates me; it’s

only a matter of time before he asks me to leave.”

“Why? What happened?” He asks, concerned.

I perch on the kitchen stool. I wrap my fingers around the mug as steam curls into the air. “I honestly don’t know. He was really nice to me, sweet actually, then silence. It’s like I don’t even exist.”

He sighs. “Nikolai has a lot going on-”

“You didn’t see the way he just looked at me James...”

“Em, listen, I can’t go into detail about this, but Nikolai lost someone close to him and he’s on a mission to find the person responsible.”

“Do you mean Victoria?” I ask.

“How do you know about Victoria?” he presses, surprise etched in his tone.

“Nikolai told me, she was his sister, right?”

James pauses. “He told you? Fuck okay, yeah, she was his sister, and she was murdered by a man he called his best friend.”

I still. “Why would his friend do that?”

“That I can’t tell you babe, but, if Nikolai wants you to know then he’ll tell you himself.” His voice calmer, soothing now.

“James,” I sigh, “what do I do?”

“Try talking to him Em, if he wants you to leave then don’t argue, you leave and come home.” He replies, his tone firm.

I exhale sharply with a nod. “Okay.”



CHAPTER EIGHT



NIKOLAI

I watch her on the security cameras around the estate.

Unable to stop my eyes from their need to see her. I've been rude, distant. Filling my days with meeting after meeting to avoid her. To fight the fucking pull towards her. But that's exactly the problem. The reason my mind has been fractured, why I can't fucking focus on what I came here to do. Dmitri. He needs to be found. He seems to slip out of my fucking fingers every time.

The image of Victoria appears in my mind. Her face haunts my dreams as she cries. She doesn't understand why I haven't avenged her death. Why I've let her murderer roam free. Why I've allowed him so much time to live, to breathe.

Guilt weighs on my chest like I've swallowed lead... I don't have answers for her.

I sit in my office, phone in hand as I accept an invitation to meet Vince Murdock at his latest business venture. A casino in Sanremo. Vince has always been somewhat of a mystery to me. He's a self-made man but the company he keeps is appalling.

Drug smugglers, skin traders, anyone who pushes the bounds of degradation. There is no place in the world for people like that, their death would be fucking sealed after they meet me. A little hobby. Vince has never suspected. Why would he? Death is the only certainty in the world. And I've made sure that many bad men have met a very bloodied end.

My eyes lift as a soft knock sounds at my door. Then, *her*.

"Nikolai, could I speak to you for a moment?" Emelia asks, voice soft and sweet as she stands in the doorway. She wears blue jeans, sneakers and a black button up. Her hair falling down her back with gentle ease. Fucking beautiful, as always.

"I need to leave for a business trip," I say, already standing.

She moves forward, fingers clasped together as she stares at me, "Have I done something to upset you?" The fucking sadness in her eyes stills me.

"This has nothing to do with you," I lie.

"Then why are you avoiding me?" She presses.

"Emelia-

"Do you want me to leave?" She asks with a quiver in her voice.

I exhale sharply. No, I don't fucking want her to leave.

I stare at her, hating myself but it needs to be done. "I don't have time to answer your silly little questions."

Her face drops.

I move closer. “You think you see something inside of me Emelia, you want to see something that just isn’t here.” My feet reach her. I stand inches away as my eyes pour into her. “I’m not a good man, I kill, and I fucking like it. There’s nothing but darkness inside of me.”

She stares up at me, brows furrowing. “I didn’t-”

“When I agreed to this, it was on the condition that you take the time I give you.” I lean down, voice low. “I don’t have time for you, Emelia.”

Her eyes begin to glisten. I walk away before she lets a tear fall.

I can’t fucking see that.



Roman and I take the plane to Sanremo. Emelia’s already in my fucking head and we’ve barely left the tarmac. The way she looked fucking killed me, it’s like I watched myself hurt her and now I want to punish myself for it.

The thought of coming home and not seeing her there fucking eats at me. I reach for my phone and text Luka. My eyes and ears, and one of the best hackers in the world. Now, he’s my trusted head of cyber security.

Keep an eye out if Emelia tries to book a flight.

Any flight.

Make sure it’s cancelled or full.

His reply comes back almost immediately.

Understood. I’m on it.

I can’t let her leave. Not like this.



We hit Sanremo just as night falls. The city glows like a jewel against the Riviera. The Rava casino appears to rise from the water, surrounded by glittering and gold lights. Every inch of it screams old-world elegance. But that's just the mask. The action is happening underground. That's where the real fucking money moves.

Roman and I are escorted down by one of Vince's assistants, a slick little man with a permanent sneer who reeks of expensive cologne.

Wide double doors swing open, revealing a room humming with power and money. Cigar smoke curls toward chandeliers as chips clink and laughter rumbles. This is a hole carved out for the rich, the crooked, the untouchable.

"Nikolai!" Vince's voice booms from the poker table. He's red-faced, laughing, one hand buried in the hip of a girl balancing awkwardly on his lap, trying not to topple over his swollen stomach.

I give Roman a subtle nod to fade into the background, then step forward.

"Quite a place you've got here, Vince," I say, my voice smooth but edged.

He slaps the girl's ass hard enough to make her squeal, then waves her away. "Money makes money," he grins.

I adjust my black jacket before lowering myself onto the chair beside him. A cocktail waitress appears, eyes lingering a little too long. "Can I get you something to drink, handsome?"

Vince leans in, smirking. "She can give you more than that, if you want."

I shake my head. "No." My eyes flick to the dealer. "Deal me in."

Cards slide across the table as I glance at Vince. “I didn’t know Alfonso was willing to sell. He practically lived here.”

Vince’s grin turns into something darker. “It took some convincing.”

“From you?” I arch a brow, genuinely curious. Vince is rich and greedy, but intimidation is not his in his playbook.

“Let’s just say I made a new friend who was more than happy to do the legwork for me.” He laughs, low and smug.

I play the full house in my hand. Vince groans, tossing his cards down with a chuckle. “Damnit.”

That’s when a voice cuts across the table, smooth, accented.

“Now this looks like fun.”

My head lifts. A tall man steps forward, sharp suit, short dark hair, eyes like burnished steel. A small scar cuts across his right cheek. The Russian accent is unmistakable.

Vince lights up. “I was just talking about you!” He waves him over. The man takes the seat opposite me, his gaze locking on mine like a predator testing its prey.

“Nikolai, I’d like you to meet Aleksandr Woznyuk.” Vince gestures grandly.

I nod, keeping my expression unreadable. His stare doesn’t break.

“You don’t recognize me?” he asks, head tilting slightly, voice quiet but needling.

My brows knit. “Should I?”

A slow smirk spreads across his lips. “I’ve been told I look just like him.”

The dealer slides cards his way. I study his face. There's something there, a flicker of familiarity that I can't quite pin down.

"Funny how some memories mean more to some than others,"

he says with a grin that makes my teeth itch. I don't like his fucking face. Or the way he's staring at me like I'm already a target.

"Do you enjoy speaking in riddles, Aleksandr," I press, my voice flat, "or are you going to tell me how I'm supposed to know you?"

I fold, my hand meaningless now.

He lays down a simple two pair, wins the pot, and leans back with a smirk. "Where's the fun in that?" He gives Vince a nod, then rises smoothly to his feet. Three men appear from the shadows to fall in behind him as he walks away.

"I'll be seeing you around, Nikolai," he tosses over his shoulder.

Not if I see you first, fucker.

I watch him disappear into the crowd, unease gnawing at the back of my mind. Who the fuck is he?



I give the instruction to Lev to ask Emelia to meet me in the gym. I'll give her an interview today. Something to appease her. To keep her from trying to leave.

I punch my fists into the leather boxing bag as I wait. Five minutes go by.

Then ten.

Then twenty.

I unspool the tape on my knuckles and pick up my phone, checking the security cameras. She's sitting in the study in a pretty, little pink dress as she reads peacefully. What the fuck?

I leave the gym and make my way to the study; Emelia exits and nearly crashes into me in the hallway. She gasps then steadies herself.

"Didn't Lev pass on the message for you to meet me?" I ask, annoyed.

She stares at me. "He did. I just didn't want to bother you with my silly little questions," she shoots me a sarcastic smile then tries to move past me, but I block her.

"You wanted time, and I've just given that to you. So, you decide to waste it?"

She rolls her eyes. "I'm so sorry for wasting your precious time, Nikolai."

My jaw ticks. "Are you always this fucking childish?"

"Are you always such a fucking asshole?" She snaps, trying to move past me again but I stop her, caging her in against the wall. "One day you're nice to me, the next I don't exist. What do you want from me, Nikolai?"

"What the fuck do you want from me, Emelia?" I yell.

"To start, how about you look at me when I walk into a room or acknowledge that I actually exist." She yells back. "It's not hard."

I exhale sharply. "I told you; I'm not a good-"

She scoffs. "Oh, boo fucking hoo, you're so dark and angsty because you've lost people. Well so have I! I've had people I love ripped from me too, but I don't treat anyone like shit because of it."

“God damn it Emelia,” I punch my fist against the wall. “You have no fucking idea what a pain in the ass you are.”

She raises her voice, unflinching as she stares up at me, pressing a finger against my chest. “Likewise, asshole! Do you think I enjoy being ignored? Or waiting around for you to grace me with your ‘precious’ time?”

I exhale sharply and grab her wrist. Her touch is like gasoline on the fire raging inside of me. “Emelia...”

She pulls her arm away. “I’ll leave as soon as I can get a damn flight out of here.”

I grab her waist and force her against the wall. “You’re not going anywhere.”

“You don’t tell me what I can or can’t do!” She shouts as she pushes against my chest.

I stare at her, eyes darkening as my restraint continues to weaken. I lean forward, dropping my head until my lips ghost dangerously close to hers. “You better reign in this little attitude of yours Emelia or I’m going to bend you over my fucking knee.”

Her full lips fall open as her eyes widen in surprise. Clearly lost for words, now that surprises *me*.

I tighten my grip on her waist, letting my fingers slowly hike her dress. “I will lift this little dress,” I pause as I gradually pull the hem higher, exposing her thighs but she doesn’t stop me. “Then, I’ll tear off your underwear before warming the curve of your ass with the palm of my fucking hand.”

Silence lingers in the air between us. Mixed with the sound of

heavy breathing and hearts racing as we stare into each other. God, she smells so fucking good. My eyes drop to her chest, drawn to her nipples hardening behind the thin pink fabric.

I'm hard as fuck.

I can't stop myself; my lips crash into hers and before I can think straight, I'm wrapping my arms around her as I begin to lose myself. Her soft, warm, pillowy lips welcome me as I breathe in her enchanting scent. Tasting the lingering sweetness of strawberries on her tongue.

She pushes against my chest. I release her then a warm hand slaps across my cheek. I should be pissed, livid at the action, but a dark grin pulls at my lips as my eyes remain fixed on her. I've never been more turned on.

"I'm not one of your fucking whores," she yells before walking away.



"You've outdone yourself Nikolai, the shipment reached my team ahead of schedule," Leonard grins, "it made for a very nice surprise when Kage's thugs thought they could steal from me."

I lean in my seat, swirling the tumbler in my hands. "Once we received intel that his men were targeting you – I thought you could use the extra, ammunition."

He nods firmly in gratitude before lifting to his feet.

I reach my hand out across the desk to shake his before Roman escorts him and his guard out of my office.

My father taught me that loyalty has to be earned. A man is nothing if his word cannot be honoured. Leonard Saffis has been a trusted associate over

the years, he has certainly proven his worth and in doing so, he has afforded my protection. A luxury that most could never acquire.

I sip my scotch as my eyes pan to the security feed of the foyer. “What the fuck?” I drop the glass to the table as my eyes are now fixed on the scene before me. Emelia in conversation with Leonard. Is she, is she fucking flirting? Why the fuck is she smiling at him like that? And why the fuck is he talking to her? I push my chair back and move to the foyer immediately.

“I would love to take you out for dinner, Emelia, if you don’t have any plans,” Leonard smiles at her.

“No.” I say, voice low and absolute, as I near them.

Leonard’s eyes widen as he turns to me. His face straightens as the realisation hits him.

“Don’t mind him,” Emelia rolls her eyes, “I’m available for dinner. You can pick me up at eight,” she smiles at him before turning to walk by me.

Defiance burns in her gaze as her eyes lock with mine for a long, heated moment. I’ve tried to keep my distance, fighting against the unbreakable pull towards her but how the fuck am I supposed to stay away when all I want to do is claim her right here and now.

The kiss of her lips, the softness of her body has been tattooed in mind. A delicious dream I get to revisit with every close of my eyes. And yet here she is, arranging a date with another man right fucking in front of me.

Emelia’s sweet, vanilla scent lingers in the air as she finally walks by me, making her way to the study.

I turn back to Leonard with a sharp exhale; he nods in understanding. He might be a trusted ally but if he even thinks about showing up here tonight,

he's a dead man. And he fucking knows it.



I finish my meeting early and arrive home at 19:59 to Emelia waiting on the staircase. She's dressed in a navy blue, satin cocktail dress with a slit running up towards the curve of her hip and black sandaled heels. Her long hair curled, draped along her exposed back. How silly you are Emelia to think I would ever let you walk out the door looking like that, let alone on the arm of another man.

I close the door behind me with a grin as she folds her arms.

"Expecting someone?" I ask, moving toward her.

"I am," she nods.

"He's not coming," I whisper through a smirk as I near her, looking up at her from the bottom of the staircase.

She moves down a step, then another until she's in front of me. "Not everyone's afraid of you, Nikolai," she grins. "I'm not."

I laugh; I can't help myself. I move up a step forcing her to take a step back. "That's because I haven't given you a reason to be, *milaya* [милая - sweetheart]."

She pauses, hands on her hips. "He will come," she says defiantly before shifting her dress then sitting on the staircase. Such a feisty little headache you are.

I sit beside her, pulling my gun onto my lap. Her bright, brown eyes are fixed on the cold, black steel while mine are glued to her. "Do you know why he won't come, Emelia?" I glide my fingers around the gun, lifting it before

aiming at the front door. “Because if he even tries to see you, there’ll be a bullet buried between his eyes before he even gets the chance to look at you again.”

Emelia swallows hard as her eyes are locked on mine. I drop the gun beside me, then reach toward her heel, fixing the loosened strap. I run my fingers along her bare legs, listening, watching as her breath begins to shallow and her lip’s part.

“There’s barely any fabric to this little dress, Emelia,” I rumble as my finger continue moving higher, over her knees, slowly along her thighs. “No man deserves to see you in this.”

Her gaze falls to my lips. “You don’t get to decide that, Nikolai.” She places her hand on mine, stopping me from moving towards her inner thighs.

I reach my hand behind her back, guiding her as I slowly pin her down. “Tell me that you don’t want me to kiss you Emelia,” I say, placing my leg in-between hers, keeping her parted.

“You’re an asshole,” she breathes.

I smirk, “that’s not a no.” My hand moves higher, caressing the soft smooth skin of her perfect thighs as I nuzzle my face in the crook of her neck. “I bet the further I go, the damper these panties are going to get...”

Her eyes widen falling to my lips as my fingers ghost along the curve of her pussy. My lips reach hers eagerly, I press my tongue into her sweet little mouth, starving to taste her. Emelia moans as I trace a line over her heated, lace underwear, right along her needy little slit. “Your body is betraying your defiance, *milaya*.”

My dick presses into her thigh. I need her to feel just how fucking hard, how fucking frustrated she makes me. Sweet little whimpers sing from her full, perfect lips into my mouth as I grind against her.

The sound of humming echoes through the corridor.

Fuck. Maria.

Emelia's eyes widen as she quickly moves from underneath me and straightens her dress before lifting to her feet. "I," she starts, lost for words as she stares at me.

Maria finally makes her way into the foyer with a smile as I stand up, eyes glued on Emelia. Cheeks flushed in the sweetest shade of pink as she swallows hard. She locks her eyes on mine; a small exhale leaves her lips before she turns and walks to her room. I'm so tempted to follow her, to bury my aching cock deep inside of her until she understands how fucking crazy she's making me. But for now, I won't rush her. I want her to come to me, wanting and willingly and when she does, I'm going to make her mine.

.



CHAPTER NINE



EMELIA

Booking a taxi in this town is a jarring experience.

After a thirty-minute wait, a light blue Toyota finally pulls into the courtyard. Lev looks at me curiously but says nothing as I make my way to the front door. “I’m just going into town,” I offer a smile. “I’ll be back later.”

Truth is, I need air.

Space.

Distance from *him*.

I can’t get him out of my head, the way he looks at me, the way his touch sets my skin on fire. The taste of him, the scent of him, the feel of him. The way his large, strong body wraps around me. Or how his facial hair rubs against my skin with delicious roughness. Nikolai makes me so angry yet burns through me until I’m nothing but heat on the edge of destruction. And God help me, I want to let him.

The town centre bustles with energy just twenty minutes from the estate. “Grazie [Thank you],” I smile at the driver as I close the door behind me.

The warm energy enraptures me, smiling faces, busy storefronts, young children with ice-cream smothered faces. In this slice of the world, everything feels calmer. Less demanding.

My baby blue, short chiffon skirt dances in the cool breeze. My sling bag falls over my white button up top as sandalled heels click along the weathered cobble walk. There’s a couple sitting on a park bench, under the shade of a tree, his head rests on her lap as she strokes his hair while reading a book.

On another bench a little girl sits as her mother ties her shoe. Cheeks red and eyes puffy from what I’m guessing was a scolding. There aren’t many stores in town, but just enough to find what you’re looking for. Restaurants, hair salons, a pharmacy, clothing boutiques, and jewellers line the bustling plaza.

My smile widens as my eyes landed on a bookstore; I move towards it instinctively. I pause as I begin to pass a bulletin board next to the store, a short older man wearing all black sticks a flyer to it.

His fingers shake unsteadily, but he pushes through. A thumb tack falls from his hand and lands at my feet. I bend then hand it back to him with a smile. My eyes lift to see the flyer ‘Church Bake Sale.’ I turn back to the man and notice his priest collar.

“You’re having a bake sale?” I ask.

He nods with a smile. “We are and we’re looking for volunteers if you’re interested.” He has a resonance in his tone, most likely from years of

preaching and counselling.

I nod. "I would be happy to."

He hands a flyer to me, flashing his teeth. "We would appreciate any help we can get."

"I'm not the most experienced baker but I have been told that I make kick-as-" I pause. "Uh, amazing brownies."

He chuckles. "Well, I look forward to trying those," he drops his voice to a whisper, "kick-ass brownies..." he pauses, waiting for my name.

"Emelia," I laugh, taking his hand.

His grip is gentle; but there's no mistaking the tremor.

"Father Vitaly," he smiles. "The proceeds are going towards renovating the playground behind the church. Children need a space to be children."

I nod in agreement. "I'll be there, father."

I slide the paper into my bag as he walks away.

I enter the bookstore with a giddy smile as the scent of aged paper, polished wood, and freshly brewed coffee greets me like an old friend. The bell above the door chimes softly behind me, announcing my arrival.

Golden afternoon light pours through the high arched windows, dust motes dancing in the beams like whispered stories waiting to be told. The shelves stretch, overflowing with well-loved spines and hidden gems, their titles etched in faded gold and curling script.

I run my fingers along the edge of a shelf, trailing the rough textures of leather bindings and paperbacks, each one holding entire worlds within them.

There's a calm here. A stillness that wraps around my shoulders and tells me I'm exactly where I need to be.

I could spend hours in a bookstore, but the sun is already beginning to dip, and I still need to book a cab back to the estate. But first, I'm not leaving without having some fresh bread, the smell envelopes me as soon as I make my way outside.

I turn the corner, allowing my nose to lead the way and bump straight into a broad, muscular chest. Then strong hands reach behind my back to keep me from falling.

A small breath escapes my lips as I look up to meet Nikolai's surprised eyes. His gaze drops to my chest, eyeing my cleavage peeking through my unfastened buttons. A smirk grazes his lips as he steadies me.

"Nikolai? I didn't expect to run into you," I manage.

His eyes scan the area around me. "That makes two of us. Why didn't you ask one of my men to bring you into town?" He asks.

My brows knit at his question. "I'm more than capable of getting around on my own."

My eyes drift to his hand. A bag from the jewellery store dangles between his grip. Who's he buying jewellery for? His gaze darkens as he notices that my eyes have dropped to the bag.

"How did you get here?" He presses.

"I took a cab," I say, with a shrug.

"A cab? You must have been waiting for a while," he grins.

"I-"

“Well, good luck getting back, Emelia.”

My mouth falls open as he begins to walk away.

“Wait,” I call after him. “You’re not going to offer me a ride back?”

He chuckles. “I wouldn’t want to insult you *milaya*, since you’re so capable of getting yourself around.”

A breath escapes my throat as he winks at me then walks away. He’s not seriously going to leave me here, is he?

And just like that, Nikolai’s Lamborghini rolls away, throwing me a grin in his mirror. What a fucking asshole!

I reach for my phone and book a cab. Ugh, one hour away. I book it anyway, because what choice do I have? It’s getting dark as I head to a small café in the centre of town, silver lining, I can bury my head in my book with some of this delicious fresh bread while I wait.

I stew in the backseat of the cab as we drive to the estate. Darkness has completely fallen.

I’m cold.

Annoyed.

Bristling with frustration.

My mouth falls open in anger as I see Nikolai’s car sitting in the courtyard. I’ve never seen him leave his car out, is he fucking taunting me?

I march towards his office, the anger in me is so loud it’s drowned out my need to be polite. That was a dick move!

The door is open when I enter, Roman stands next to Nikolai as he sits behind his desk, sipping a glass of whisky.

“Seriously?” I yell. “You just left me when you were coming back here?”

Nikolai leans back in his chair; a dark grin pulls at his lips.

Roman shakes his head with a chuckle as he begins to leave the room. “В этом есть огонь [*vieu etom chto-to goryashcheye* - There’s fire in this one].”

Nikolai’s smirk widens as he stares at me.

“You know, I learned some Russian today too,” I say, moving towards him.

“Oh yeah?” He chuckles, the sound low and provocative.

I nod and lean over his desk. “Иди нафиг [*Edie na khuy* - Fuck you].” I let the words roll off my tongue like a curse as my gaze remains fixed on him.

Nikolai’s eyes flicker with fire as the corners of his lips tilt. He pushes his chair back; the sudden movement startles me.

Fuck, what did I just do? I turn and begin to leave but he’s already behind me.

He slams the door shut just as I’m about to reach it. His hands grab at my waist then he spins me around to face him.

My back presses into the cold, hard wood as his large, strong arms cage me in.

Dark, dangerous eyes stare down at me. He’s so close I can practically taste the expensive whisky on his breath. “Are you trying to piss me off or turn me on?”

“You’re a fucking jerk, Nikolai.” I snap.

“Please give me a reason to teach that pretty little mouth of yours a lesson.” He growls.

“Get off me,” I push against him.

He holds me in place as he runs his thumb over my bottom lip, sending a tantalising shiver throughout my body.

His chest tattoo peeking through the open collar of his black shirt as his cologne threatens to pull me under his dark, enchanting spell.

His voice is a low, rough whisper against my ear. “Say it again, I dare you.”

I stare at him. I won’t let him win.

“Fuck you,” the words fall out of my mouth before I can think straight.

Nikolai lets out a low, dark chuckle. His hands are around my waist and in an instant, I’m spun around with my wrists held behind my back in the grip of his large hand. He moves forward; a gasp escapes my lips as I feel the large, hard bulge of his erection pressing into my ass.

I press my thighs together as his fingers begin to ghost around my cleavage, slipping through the buttons.

His warm breath caresses my neck as he lowers his lips to my ear. “Do you think I make idle threats, Emelia?” His voice rough and absolute. “What did I tell you about this little fucking attitude of yours?”

“You should fix your attitude first,” I snap as I look at him over my shoulder.

I gasp as his fingers push open a button, then another. His index finger tracing the shape of an ‘N’ on the top of my breast. He chuckles against my neck as his fingers trace down my body.

He tightens his grip around my wrists, “There’s only one way to fix my attitude, *milaya*,” he grins, before pushing his erection into the palm of my hand. I whimper as I feel the size of him through his pants. “But you’re not ready for that yet,” his warm breath causing my skin to tingle as he whispers against my hair.

His free hand crawls slowly to my ass, then my thigh. He presses himself against me as he lifts my skirt, completely exposing my underwear. He slides his index finger beneath the delicate fabric of my baby blue thong as his lips brush against my neck.

I should stop him. I should but why the fuck can’t I? I can barely even think straight. A moan rises from my throat as he rips my underwear off in one clean motion.

“What a pretty fucking sight this is,” he smirks as his eyes burn into my naked bottom. His large hand rubs the curve of my ass, gently, reverently. My breath hitches at his touch.

Feeling the air against my bare, exposed skin. Feeling Nikolai’s touch, I swallow hard as I fight the urge for my eyes to roll back.

Suddenly, a hard smack stings against my skin. I moan loudly at the sensation which is both painful and pleasurable.

A groan escapes his lips as he caresses the reddened spot. Then one more slap, harder this time. He squeezes the curve of my ass before rubbing the burning handprint he’s left on my skin.

Nikolai drops his lips to my ear. “Next time you mouth off at me Emelia, you’re going to get fucked baby,” he whispers.

My breath hitches at the word which doesn’t go unnoticed.

“Do you like it when I call you baby?” he croons against my ear.

“No,” I murmur.

His lips brush against my neck, “liar.” He chuckles as he releases my wrists.

I turn around, straightening my skirt as my cheeks burn red, pressing my thighs together. I refuse to give him the satisfaction of seeing his effect on me. But the look of fire and need in his eyes tells me that he already knows.

The corners of his lips pull into a dark smirk as his eyes hold me captive. He reaches his hand between my legs, with his index and middle finger, he slowly trails a path up my thigh making my entire body vibrate before he reaches my inner thigh, now wet from my arousal. He reaches higher, until his fingers are gliding through the warm, slickness of my pussy. My mouth falls open as he moves his fingers straight to his mouth and tastes me. He’s so close, I see the moment his pupils dilate as his fingers touch his tongue.

“You should leave now, Emelia, before I lose control of myself,” he rumbles, voice low and demanding as his eyes burn into me.

My shaky fingers grip the doorknob. I turn it, opening the door as much as he will allow before slipping through.

I try to catch my breath as I make my way down the hallway. I’m so fucking wet. So, fucking heated. It’s taking all my willpower not to turn around and go back.

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CHAPTER TEN



EMELIA

Nikolai's been quiet since our interaction in his office.

I don't know why I care. Maybe it's because I haven't been able to get him out of my head. The scent of him, the feel of him. The way he hardened against me. My traitorous body wants more. So much more.

I settle into the study, my eyes are drawn to the bookshelf, particularly a set of old journals arranged neatly behind protective glass. I wonder who they belong to.

I sit and let the quiet wrap around me as I dedicate a few hours to writing. Funny how the words seem to pour out of me here, as if the room itself is coaxing them free. Each sentence falls into place with surprising ease, the story unfurling more naturally than the others I've struggled with before. It feels less like I'm forcing it into existence, and more like I'm uncovering something that was always waiting to be found.

I hadn't noticed the hours ticking by. Nearly midnight. My head tilts as my fingers slow on the keyboard, songs in my ears lulling me to sleep as my eyes begin to close. Soft gentle fingers tap on my shoulder, jolting me awake.

"Emelia, would you like me to make you some coffee?" Maria asks sweetly.

I remove my headphones and look at the time. "No, thank you Maria," I smile. "I'm just about to head into bed."

I close my laptop and hold it under my arms as Maria, and I exit the study together.

"You're usually in bed this time," I say, rubbing the corner of my eye.

She nods. "I was worried you might fall asleep in there; your back would be sore in the morning."

"That's very kind of you, thank you for worrying about me and checking on me." I smile.

We walk through the hallway towards the foyer. "You mentioned that you lived with your aunt after your parents passed. She must be worried about you being so far away."

I shake my head. "My aunt was never really the nurturing type. I only hear from her once a year, on my birthday, if I'm lucky. A quick five-minute phone call then she's gone again."

Maria's brows furrow. "I'm so sorry to hear that, Emelia."

I pause and offer a smile. "That's okay. I had the best parents in the world, even if I only got to have them for eight years."

The front door swings open as we reach the threshold of the foyer. A leggy blonde in a red dress enters first. She scans the room and her eyes land

on Maria and me. She then turns as Nikolai enters behind her. His eyes find mine for just a moment then quickly back to her. I exhale sharply as I watch him lead her to his office.

Maria's hand caresses my back. "Goodnight Emelia," she offers a small smile.

"Goodnight Maria," I nod.

I swallow hard before walking up the stairs to my room.

I was falling asleep not fifteen minutes ago and now I'm struggling. I try to scroll through social media as I settle into bed but the thought of Nikolai and that woman in his office is driving me mad. I stare up at the ceiling as I fight back tears. Why does this bother me so much? He's an asshole. A single, devilishly attractive asshole who can sleep with whoever he wants.

Ugh, I can't stand this.

I lift from my bed and wrap the duvet around me as I open the balcony doors. I sit on the ground and inhale the fresh night air, finding a moment of reprieve in the quiet.

The stars are beautiful tonight. I lean my head against the open glass door as I dial James.

"My favourite girl," he answers.

"Glad to know I haven't lost my title yet," I smile.

"No-one could ever replace you babe," he laughs. "You, okay?"

"I am, just a little homesick," I murmur.

"That sucks, you know we miss you terribly," he says.

I nod, fighting back tears. "I miss you too," a sob escapes my lips.

“Em, what’s going on?” He demands.

I shake my head. “Nothing, just a long day.”

James sighs but he doesn’t push.

“Do you remember that time we went camping for your dad’s fiftieth birthday?” I smile.

James laughs. “I do; it was quite a trip. We all got food poisoning from that dicey meat my mother bought from that gas station.”

I laugh. “It was a harrowing ordeal for sure.”

“What made you think of that?” He asks.

I tug the duvet tightly around me and place the phone on speaker, setting it on the ground next to me as I look up at the sky. “It was my first time camping, and I was terrified of bears and other creatures tearing into our tents during the night,” I start.

“I remember, you absolutely refused to sleep,” he chuckles.

I nod. “Do you remember the story you told me to help me fall asleep?”

He laughs. “Of course I remember, it was some of my best work.”

I chuckle. “Could you tell it to me again?”

“Em are you sure you’re, okay?” He presses.

“I am, I would just like to hear it again, please,” I murmur.

James clears his throat then starts. “Far away, in the quiet stretch of the sky, there was a little star who thought it was all alone. Each night it shone as brightly as it could, hoping someone, somewhere, might see its light.

Loneliness weighed on the little star's heart, so it began a journey across the galaxy. It drifted past golden comets, through clouds of glowing dust, and beside planets painted with rings. Yet no matter how far it travelled, it could not find another star." He pauses.

"And then?" I smile.

"Then, one night, tired from its wandering, the star finally rested. It looked around with gentle eyes, really looked, and what it saw made its light tremble with joy. Across the heavens, near and far, other stars sparkled back at it, thousands upon thousands, each one shining in its own way. The little star laughed softly. It had never been alone. Not once. The stars had always been there, waiting for it to notice. And so, from that night on, the little star shone not in loneliness, but in harmony, part of a sky full of friends," he breathes softly.

I smile as my lids begin to close. "Just stay with me for five more minutes, please."

James chuckles. "Of course, go to sleep little star."

When I wake in the morning, I'm surprised to find myself in my bed again. I feel rested, cozy, a hell of a lot better than I did last night. Why don't remember leaving the balcony? I'm glad I did though, I would've woken up with a nasty cold today. I stretch my arms out, my hand finds the space beside me and, it's warm. Was I moving around in my sleep?



CHAPTER ELEVEN



NIKOLAI

I shouldn't have let Simone in.

Fucking Mallory sent her – saying that I've been unusually quiet. And when Simone asked to use the bathroom, I would've been a fucking asshole to say no. I just wish Emelia hadn't seen her.

After I kicked Simone out my feet lead me to her. I just wanted to check on her, I told myself. And I definitely shouldn't have slept next to her. But seeing her, sleeping on the balcony tugged at my fucking heart. A heart I thought had died long ago.

She felt so perfect curled into my arms, like she was made for me. But how could an angel belong to a monster? I couldn't stop myself from kissing the tears that had dried on her cheeks as I held her closer, allowing myself just a single moment to care about something. To feel something.

A moment, just for her.

“Nikolai,” Luka rushes into my office as I end a call.

“I’m sorry but this couldn’t wait. Upon our latest sweep of the grounds our new security system picked up several recording devices.”

“What the fuck are you talking about?” I press.

He walks over to me, tablet in hand and shows me the digital blueprint of the estate with several glowing dots, representing the devices. He hands me the tablet then walks over to the bookcase, feeling beneath the top shelf until he rips a device stuck underneath.

“How long has that been there?” I snap.

“I’ll need to take them apart to give you a conclusive answer, but these are top notch, expensive, almost impossible to detect. We only picked them up with our security upgrade but realistically, they could have been here since...”

“Since I moved in?” I press.

He nods.

“What the fuck? Get them out!” I yell.

“We’ve already removed them, there’s only one remaining, in Emelia’s room. It looks like it’s on the pedestal, beside her bed.”

My fists clench. “Are they recording audio or visual?”

“Audio only, from what we can tell.” He replies.

“Find out who placed these Luka, and when. I want a name,” I demand.

“You’ll have one within the hour,” he nods.

I storm out of my office, up to Emelia’s room. I open the door, the sound of water falling fills the room. She’s in the shower, with the bathroom door

open. I close the bedroom door behind me.

My eyes are greedy to see her body, so, I look.

My pulse begins to race as I watch her face tilted up towards the stream, letting the water fall down her perfect body. Her magnificent ass is staring back at me as she washes her hair and hums a song. I'm so fucking tempted to join her that my fingers are already gripping the buckle of my belt. I swallow hard then remember why I'm here.

I move to the pedestal then reach around the frame until I find the recording device stuck to the bottom. Mother fucker.

"What are you doing?" Emelia exclaims behind me.

I lift to my feet and drop the device to the floor before stomping on it.

She stares at the shattered pieces. "What is that?"

"A death wish," I bite.

My mouth dries as she stands in a white gown, her cleavage peeking through the loosened fabric as she adjusts herself.

"Someone was watching me?" Her brows furrow in horror.

"No," I reply, "but they were listening."

Her eyes fall onto the shattered device again. Clearly uncomfortable as she tightens the gown around her.

"You don't knock?" She stares at me.

I grin. "Why would I knock on my own doors?"

My body instantly reacts to her as I move forward. Hair soaking wet, cheeks flushed pink. Body hot, naked under thin cotton material.

“Maybe that behaviour passes with your, little night-time buddies, but not with me. You need to knock before just barging into a room, Nikolai. Especially when I’m naked.” She says, her tone firm.

“Night-time buddies?” I laugh. “Is that what we’re calling them?”

She crosses her arms. “I don’t care what you call them; I would just prefer not to see them.”

A dark grin sweeps across my face. “Are you jealous, Emelia?”

“No,” she scoffs. “Why would I be?”

“You tell me, *milaya*,” I press.

“I don’t think about you enough to dignify that with an answer,” she scrunches her nose.

I laugh, “that’s a lie.”

She shakes her head. “It’s not.”

I grab her waist and move her onto the bed before she can protest. I pin her under me as I lift her wrists above her head. The slit of her gown falling open, revealing more of her spectacular breasts.

“If I fucked you right now, you would tell me no?” I hover dangerously close to her lips.

She wiggles, trying to loosen from my grip. “Hell would freeze over before I ever let you touch me again.”

The heat between her legs is outing her as a fucking liar but I’ll play this little game.

I lean forward and press my lips against her neck. She gasps as I run my tongue along her skin before tugging on her earlobe. “There’s a fucking

blizzard coming baby.”

“You wish,” she rasps.

I settle between her, the feeling of her body against me is making my cock ache. “You’re going to be begging for it.”

I almost lose my fucking mind as she grins. She wraps her legs around me and pushes me over so she’s on top. I’m so fucking surprised by the action that I let her.

She stares down at me as she rolls her hips against me.

“Emelia, wha-”

“Is that why you’re hard right now, Nikolai? Because you think I’ll be begging for it?” Her voice low and teasing.

My hands reach for her thighs as she rubs herself against me.

A growl escapes my lips as her hips move in dangerously seductive circles. The fucking sight of her on top of me, the feel of her against me is making me fucking feral. I want to pull my cock out and fuck the fuck out of her right now.

She parts the slit of her gown and lets it fall down her shoulder, teasing more of her breasts. “All I have to do is drop this and you’ll be on your knees,” she smirks.

I sit up and pull her closer, my hands rounding her perfect ass.

“You want me to beg, Emelia?”

She nods as she bites her lip. “Put your hands behind your back.”

I squeeze at the curve of her ass before pulling back and doing as she tells me. Emelia’s eyes pour into mine as she pulls at the belt of her gown, letting

it fall open completely now.

“Fuuuuck,” a low growl bursts from my throat as I take in her delicious, naked body. Her large breasts sit, firm and full on her chest, nipples so fucking perky my mouth begins to salivate. I reach out my hand but she stops me. “No touching, hands behind your back,” she grins.

My head falls back as she begins to grind against me, my cock is fucking aching, straining against my pants. “Emelia, please,” I beg.

She runs her hands through her hair as she begins to grind wilder, bouncing her tits. “Please what?” She presses her lips against mine, pushing her tongue into my mouth as I fight against the urge to move my hands.

“Please let me touch you, baby,” I plead.

She leans back with a wide smirk, running her fingers over her lips, “where would you like to touch me Nikolai?” her voice sweet and sultry, dripping with sex and honey. Her fingers brush against her stiffened nipples, “here?” Then begins to trail down her stomach as she widens her legs, giving me the perfect view of her sweet little cunt, “or here?”

My head falls forward, pressing against her chest as I watch her fingers glide up her slit, before teasing at her clit. The scent of her is so fucking intoxicating, I can’t control myself any longer.

“I want to brand myself onto you Emelia, everywhere will be mine to touch.” My lips ghost her neck as I press my erection into her. “You want me to beg, *milaya*? Then I’m going to beg with my tongue buried inside this pretty pussy of yours.”

She doesn’t have a moment to react before I’m leaning her back and flipping her over. My arms wrapped around her thighs as I position her to sit

on my face.

“Ah! Nikolai!” Her exclaim a breathy moan as I lick up her smooth, glistening, pink slit. Fuck me, she tastes incredible. I find myself staring at the perfection in front of me, memorising the soft folds of her lips, the blooming bud of her swelling clit. My tongue trails every curve, every dip, peeking into her opening.

Emelia’s head falls onto my lap as her moans begin to grow louder, deeper. It’s the most beautiful sound I’ve ever heard. I lick towards her clit as it continues to swell into a beautiful rosebud. I suck on it hungrily as she spreads her legs wider. Giving more of herself to me.

“Nik-” she moans as she writhes on top of me.

I tease more of my tongue inside of her. “You’ve made me a greedy man, Emelia.”

Her hands find my erection, palming me through my pants. I grip her hips tighter as my tongue lashes her pussy. I want her to fucking smother me just like this. A moan of relief bursts my lips as she finally sets my cock free, tugging my pants mid-thigh.

“Oh my God,” she breathes, hand stroking up the length of my achingly hard cock before she wraps her perfect, full lips around me, knowing exactly what I fucking need.

I squeeze at her ass as I begin to thrust my hips, needing more of me inside of her mouth. “Look at what a good girl you are baby,” I grin. “Good girls, get rewarded.”

I spread her legs wider and wrap my lips around her clit as I suck on her. Her sweet juices dripping down her thighs is making my cock throb. Emelia’s

ferocity grows with every lick, every suck. My cock is suctioned so snugly in her pretty little mouth she's going to suck the cum right out of me.

"This pussy is all fucking mine," I growl against her as I push a finger inside of her, fingering her until all I can hear is the sound of her pussy wetting my digit with every thrust. "Do you understand?"

The sound of her moans curl into the air like steam rising.

"Tell me you understand, Emelia," I nip at the folds of her lips.

"I understand," she manages, breathless.

Her soft, sweet thighs wrap tightly around me as her body quivers. I feel her orgasm coming and I intend on making this one she never fucking forgets. I pull her in tighter, keeping my mouth around her cunt while my hands remain gripped around her thighs.

"Cum for me, please, baby," I rasp.

Emelia's back arches as her pussy spasms around my tongue. A broken moan fills the air as she's cuming right on my face. Right where I fucking want her to. Her legs tremble as I lick up every drop of her, finally allowing myself to cum right in her sweet little mouth. And she doesn't waste a fucking drop of me. "Fuck, *milaya*," I moan as her tongue cleans every bit. I flip her over again, until she's pinned underneath me, breathless and spent.

I move up her body, until my lips are ghosting against hers. "See how good your pussy tastes." My tongue slips past the seam of her lips as I kiss her, letting her taste herself. I run my fingers through her hair as I kiss her sweet, full lips. Lips I've been dreaming about since the minute I laid eyes on her.

I hold her gaze. "Get dressed, I want you to see something."

“See what?” She asks, confused.

“You want to know more about this world, well I’m about to show you just how fucking real it gets,” I whisper against her lips.



How the fuck does she manage to make blue jeans and a t-shirt look sexy? Emelia’s answering emails on her phone as I drive us to the shipping yard on the outskirts of town.

Viktor and a few of my other men had wrangled up the group responsible for placing the listening devices in my villa. The fucking contractors I hired last year before moving in.

Luka confirmed that Daniel Smith had no knowledge the team had been paid off otherwise his fate would be sealed too.

I roll up to the warehouse. Emelia looks at me curiously.

“Where are we?” She asks.

I lift from my seat and exit the car, walking around to the passenger door to open it for her, reaching my hand out. “We’re here to get answers.”

Her brows furrow but she says nothing.

She walks beside me as I lead us into the warehouse.

Four men are on their knees; hands tied behind their back, faces swollen, as Viktor and Roman are watching them with their guns already drawn. Although, they wouldn’t need it. My men could tear a body to shreds with just sheer fucking willpower.

Emelia freezes as she takes in the sight before us. I nod to Viktor who moves towards her and gently guides her to stand beside him. I wouldn’t

want to get blood on that pretty, white t-shirt of hers.

I pull my gun and hold it in my grip as I walk towards the four men, each one of them averting my eyes except the one on the far right. Big balls for a dead man. I'll save him for last.

I start with the man on the left. "Who paid you?" I ask.

He looks up at me, then drops his face to spit on my shoes. I cock my gun and aim it at his head before a word can escape his worthless mouth. Click.

Emelia gasps behind me, but I can't look. I need her to see the monster; I need her to see the real me.

I kill and I like it.

I like the power of taking life.

It's almost as good as the feeling of being between her thighs.

I tilt my gun under the second man's chin, forcing him to look up at me. "Who paid you?" He turns to the man on the far right who shoots him a cold look. Click. A bullet through his neck.

The third man at least attempts to show common sense. "I don't know who paid us. He handled everything," he gestures to the man next to him. "I had no idea who you were, Nikolai. They threatened my family if I didn't cooperate."

"Your family's fucking dead, rat." The last man sneers.

I exhale sharply, sucking at my teeth as I take him in. I look over to Roman and nod. He moves forward and lifts the man to his feet.

"If you're truthful then I will show you mercy," I start.

"Thank you, Nikol-"

I lift my finger. “Don’t thank me just yet.”

Roman moves him to the worktable, placing his hands on the flat surface.

“How many devices did you plant?” I demand.

He turns to me. “Please...”

“How many?” I snap.

“Three...” he murmurs, his eyes staring at the blade in Roman’s hand.

“Three fingers.” I instruct with a nod.

“No, no, wait!” The man’s scream tears from his throat but dies just as quickly, strangled by agony as Roman’s blade carves through skin and bone. The wet sound of steel meeting flesh hangs in the air. By the time Roman is done, the man is reduced to a shuddering, blubbering mess. Unmoved, Roman tears a strip of cloth and binds his hand, the bandage soaking crimson almost at once.

“He did you a kindness by taking from your left hand, and I have shown you mercy by sparing your life.” I lean towards him, voice low and unyielding. “You can fucking say thank you now.”

He swallows hard; his eyes remain fixed on his butchered hand. “Thank you, Nikolai,” he murmurs.

Roman gestures for one of the other men to lift him and take him to Dr. Richards. A man I pay a small fortune to stay on call for me.

“Offer him work, I want a close eye on him.” I whisper to Roman.

Then my attention turns to the last man. He laughs as I walk towards him.

“Is something funny?” I grin.

He nods. “You, you didn’t even know that we were listening to everything, all this time. You must feel very foolish.”

My grin widens as my knuckles crash into his jaw. Blood spills from his mouth, and he spits it at my feet.

“Go to hell Nikolai. I’ll never fucking tell you anything,” he sneers.

My phone vibrates in my pocket.

A text message from Luka.

Traced the source of the payments. It was someone working for KA.

My grip tightens around the phone. “You don’t need to tell me shit; I know who paid you.”

The man straightens as he stares at me, then his eyes drift to her.

“This must Emelia...” he grins. “You know you were very entertaining to listen to.”

I turn to her. Her eyes widen as she covers her chest with her arms, as if she needs to protect herself. She never needs to do that when I’m around.

“Those late nights, all alone in your bedroom. I heard you... all those wonderful little moans you make when you touch yourself.”

My fists clench as I turn back to him.

“You’re going to kill me anyway Nikolai, I might as well enjoy my last moments by burying myself in that pretty little head of hers.” He laughs as blood drips from his mouth.

Emelia turns away as she tries to calm herself. I move towards her and lift her chin to face me. “He’s trying to take something from you, but I won’t let

him.” I say to her. “Keep your eyes on me and watch what happens when someone tries to fuck with you.”

Tears flood her eyes, but she doesn’t let them fall. She nods and turns to face the man.

I move towards him, like a predator stalking his prey. My fist meets his jaw, again and again until I hear bone crack. I lift him by his shirt and toss him flush to the ground.

“Did you touch yourself listening to her?” I ask.

He laughs, spitting blood, eyes returning to her. “I’ve never cum so fucking hard. I just wish that bitch Simone had the balls to get the camera in there, then it would’ve been a real fucking show.”

Simone? Mallory’s in on this too? Good, it’s about time I end that fucking arrangement anyway.

Roman hands me the blade. He knows me so well.

I roll the handle in my hands before plunging it into his crotch.

He screams out in agony as I yank the knife, letting the blood flow freely. I then lean down and stab the blade into his ears several times. Ears that were never worthy of hearing her.

I stick the knife into his throat for good measure but he’s already dead.

I lift to my feet and turn to Emelia; tears have fallen onto her cheeks as she stares at me. I move towards her and wipe the tears before cupping her perfect face. “Are you okay?”

She nods before curling right into my arms.



CHAPTER TWELVE



EMELIA

I wrap up a chapter and close my laptop.

The quiet snap of the lid marking a small victory. A sip of cool water cuts through the fuzz of concentration, and I slip my headphones down to rest against my collarbone, faint music still spilling softly from them. Leaning back, I let my gaze drift out toward the garden.

The gardener kneels in the dirt, steady hands guiding each root into place, while Maria hovers nearby with her usual blend of precision and enthusiasm.

They're working on a fresh patch of earth, the beginnings of a new bed, and I find myself wondering what colours will rise there in the weeks ahead. Curious to see what she's chosen. Whether it will be bold reds and oranges, or the softer pastels she claims soothes the soul. For now, it's only soil and the promise of something blooming.

I lift to my feet and walk towards Nikolai's office. I haven't seen him all day. I knock on the door and push it open.

Empty. Hmm.

I walk back outside to the garden. "Maria, do you know when Nikolai will be home?" I ask.

She turns to me with a smile. "I'm not sure dear, I heard Roman saying that he was meeting Mallory."

I still. "Mallory? Is she from... the agency?"

Maria nods. "From what I've heard, yes."

He's out with another woman? No, no, that can't be.

My feet are moving before my brain can catch up. I sprint to my bedroom and fall onto the floor as I try to catch my breath. I lean against the bed as I bury my face between my knees. How fucking stupid was I to think that this was more than just a fun time for him? Nikolai's used to having beautiful women at his beck and call. Of course it didn't mean anything. Why did I allow myself to feel safe with him?

Tears fall down my cheeks as the anxiety demon begins to whisper in my ear.

You know what happens when you let people get too close Emelia... You know what happens when you love...

Death.

Rejection.

You put on a smile to fool the world but inside you're just a broken little girl with no-one to love her...

I need to get out. Out of this house.

I need a minute to fucking breath.

I reach for my phone and call Sam.

“Emmy, babe I was just thinking about you,” she sings as she answers.

“Sammy, I need you to remind me that this was a good decision.” I start.

“Why? What happened?” She asks, concern whispered in her tone.

I exhale sharply. “It’s Nikolai, he’s just, not what I thought...”

She laughs. “Well babe, what exactly did you expect?”

“I don’t know...”

Sam sighs. “Em, I don’t mean to be downer but, there is a long list of authors who would jump at the chance to headline for Orion.”

“I know, you’re right...”

“You’re only there for a few weeks, and from what James says, Nikolai is quite the hottie; life could be worse, honey.”

“That’s the problem...” I admit.

“Wait, you like him?” She laughs.

“I think I just need some space from this place,” I say, avoiding the question.

“Well then this is kismet,” she giggles.

“What is?”

“Dante Brion has been asking about you,” she starts. “He’s actually in Italy on holiday; he reached out to me to find out if you would be open to a date.”

My brows knit in confusion, “he just asked you to ask me out?”

“Hey, the man is doing what he can,” she laughs. “You liked him, remember the book fair last year? You couldn’t stop laughing at his lame jokes.”

“They weren’t lame,” I smile. “I guess, I wouldn’t want to be rude...”

Sam chuckles. “I’m setting up a dinner for you tonight. Wear something hot.”

I roll my eyes. “I’m just having dinner with him, that’s all.”

“Sure, but wax, just in case.” She teases.

“Oh my God, text me the address,” I laugh.

“Love you babe, chat soon and have fun!” She smiles.

“I love you too,” I smile

I stare at my wardrobe, a blue and white dress stares right back at me. Revealing enough to leave an impression but subtle enough that it’s the right kind of impression. Since you’re out having fun Nikolai, so will I.



The cool night air caresses my skin as I step onto the port. My dress is swaying with the breeze while I clutch a small purse against my hip. Dante approaches with a grin, his dark brown hair artfully tousled, his blue eyes burning into me as though nothing else exists.

Dante Brion is something of a legend in author circles—talented, charismatic, and devilishly handsome. He made a name for himself as a world traveller and avid adventurer. Climbing treacherous mountains and breaking bread with ancient tribes.

No doubt his DMs overflow with fans eager to throw themselves at his feet.

“Emelia, it’s been too long,” he smiles as he nears me.

He takes my hand and lifts it to his lips, gently kissing my knuckles.

“Dante,” I smile. “It’s lovely to see you again.”

“It would have been my pleasure to pick you up, but Samantha insisted that you be the one to give me your number,” he chuckles.

I laugh. “She’s just looking out for me.”

“I won’t bite,” he winks. He reaches his hand out and wraps it around mine as he leads me down the pier.

Bright lights guide our path as the sun sinks toward the horizon. The staff stand ready, waiting to welcome us aboard the grand yacht. ‘The Cassie’ written in large blue font on the side.

“Does Cassie know that we’re on her boat?” I stare at him.

Dante laughs. “Cassandra was my mother’s name. I bought it after she passed. She always wanted to travel the world, now she can.”

Oh. “It’s beautiful, Dante.”

The wait staff guide us towards a table setup on the deck, adorned with candles and rose petals. My phone buzzes in my purse and out of habit, I reach for it. A call from Nikolai. I guess his date with Mallory is over. I dismiss the call.

Then a text message.

Where are you???

My grip tightens around my phone but the urge to reply is too strong to fight.

I know you were with a girl from the agency today.

Mallory?

Hope you had a good fucking time Nikolai.

I prepare to turn my phone off when another notification comes through.

I'm coming to get you.

I quickly turn it off before shoving it into my purse. He made the decision to be with another woman tonight so I'm not going to allow him to ruin my dinner.

"Someone looking for you?" Dante asks as he hands me a glass of wine.

I shake my head. "Nothing that can't wait."

He smiles as he clinks his glass to mine. "I'm really glad you could make it, Emelia. I must say I was disappointed when Samantha called to cancel."

"What made you reach out to her?" I ask, curious.

"I thought I might scare you off if I reached out directly," he says. "I know you haven't had a pleasant experience dating a writer before."

I chuckle. "Wow, so everyone knows about that, huh?"

He nods, eyes softening. "Thomas is a fucking idiot for cheating on you."

I turn to face the water, setting my glass on the table as my fingers curl around the railing. "Lately I've been wondering if I'm the idiot. Seems like I keep falling for men who are wrong for me." I admit.

His hand curls my chin as he turns my gaze to him.

“You’re beautiful, kind, talented, charismatic. You literally turn heads whenever you walk into a room, Emelia.”

A breath catches in my throat.

“Anyone that lets you slip through their fingers is fucking certifiable.” His gaze holds me steady before his eyes drop to my lips.

The wait staff appear behind us, arranging a lavish seafood platter and setting it carefully on the table. Dante smiles as he pulls out a chair for me, sliding it in gently before taking the seat across from mine.

“What if I told you I was allergic to seafood?” I say.

He pauses. “Fuck, are you?”

“No,” I laugh.

He shakes his head with a laugh. “Well, if you were then it would be burgers and fries Emelia, because I didn’t have a plan B.”

I smile before tasting the lobster bisque. “This is delicious.”

He nods. “Chef Marco is the best.”

I glance around the yacht, my curiosity getting the better of me. “Can I ask you something?”

He grins. “Is it, how can I afford all of this?”

I laugh as he anticipated my exact question.

“My parents were loaded. My dad owned an investment firm which went public in the early 2000’s. My brother took over when he passed.”

“Wow,” I chuckle. “So, you’re a fraud.”

“Hey,” he laughs. “Before you judge me just know that I didn’t choose this life, it chose me.”

My head falls back with laughter. “Oh God, that’s such a trust-fund-kid thing to say.”

His mouth falls open.

“Have I offended you?” I tease.

“You have Emelia,” he places his hand over his heart mockingly.

I raise my hands in defeat. “I’m just calling it like I see it.” I lean forward, dropping my voice to a whisper. “Do the others know about this double life of yours?”

He laughs as he sips his wine. “They do not, and if you tell them Emelia, I’m going to have to throw you overboard.”

I grin. “You wouldn’t dare.”

He pushes his chair back with a smirk.

“Okay,” I laugh. “Your secret is safe with me.”

The rest of the night feels calm, easy. Chatting to Dante feels great. There’s undeniable chemistry between us and it’s something I would be open to exploring if my heart didn’t feel so wounded by Nikolai.

I can’t be okay with him still seeing other women. I’m not comfortable with that. Not at all. I don’t care if that makes me a prude. It kills me to think about what he’s been doing with Mallory. I do need to sort that out before I give Dante the wrong impression.

“I think Orion After Dark is going to be a real game changer. Everyone’s talking about it,” he smiles.

“Really, what are they saying?” I sip my wine.

“I can’t speak for everyone, but I am very keen to see what dark fantasies are in that head of yours,” he grins.

I laugh. “I think you’re giving me too much credit. I’m not reinventing the wheel. But to be honest, I’ve loved working on this new book. I love this freedom, writing for an audience who wants the darkness. It feels like a space that I can give more of myself to and not worry about being judged.”

Dante stares at me intently. “Gretchen wouldn’t have offered you this opportunity if you didn’t absolutely deserve it, Emelia.” He takes my hand. “You’re such a talented writer and an incredible storyteller.”

He leans in closer. His hand still brushing mine as his lips begin to near me. “You know Emelia, I have the best Wi-Fi on my yacht and a full staff compliment. Just say the word and we could travel the coast, exploring, writing, living,” he pauses as his thumb brushes my cheek. “Together.”

“Is that fucking so?” Nikolai’s voice emerges. Hurrying onto the deck with Viktor following behind, gun drawn, aimed at the crew. My pulse races as he stalks towards Dante.

“Who the fuck are you?” Dante yells, moving me behind him.

“Your worst fucking nightmare.” Nikolai doesn’t miss a beat lunging his fist into Dante’s face.

“Nik, stop!” I yell.

Dante falls to the ground, holding his jaw. I rush in front of Nikolai, putting myself between him and Dante. “Nikolai, stop! What are you doing?” I scream.

He pulls his gun, holding it at his side. His face washed with an unbridled fury I’ve never seen.

“Did he touch you, Emelia?” He rumbles.

“No, of course not!” I exclaim as I push against his chest.

“Держи её [Derzhi eyo - Hold her],” Nikolai nods to Viktor who obeys his command immediately.

His large arm wraps around my waist holding me back as Dante lifts to his feet, staring at Nik as he wipes the blood from his lip. Nik stares back at him, unmoved, cracking his knuckles as his grin spreads, lazy and wicked, like he’s been waiting for this moment all night.

Dante’s jaw tightens, “I don’t know who you are, but you need to get the fuck off my boat, immediately.”

Nikolai tilts his head, amused, rolling his shoulders before lunging forward. His fist slams into Dante’s chest with a sickening thud that I feel more than hear. Dante stumbles back into the table, glass and dishes shattering against the floor.

“Nik, stop!” I beg, but my voice dies in my throat.

Dante recovers fast. He surges forward with a snarl, grabbing for Nikolai, trying to drive him back, to take control. For a split second, I think he might actually manage it. He doesn’t. Nikolai barely gives any ground. He shifts, precise, controlled, and suddenly Dante’s the one who’s off balance. My stomach twists, this isn’t a fight... it’s a lesson.

Nikolai lands another blow, sharper this time, into Dante’s ribs. I hear the breath punch out of him as he doubles over, but Nik doesn’t stop until he’s on the ground. He moves on top of him, pinning him down with measured blows, placed exactly where it will hurt the most. He doesn’t stop until Dante coughs, trying to drag air back into his lungs.

He leans forward, “If you ever try to come near her again,” Nik says, low and even, “I will fucking kill you.”

He lifts to his feet turning his attention to me, but I’m too stunned to speak. I stare at Dante’s collapsed body on the ground and move to try and help him as soon as Viktor releases his grip.

Nikolai stops me, grabbing my waist.

“No, he needs help!” I protest.

“His crew can help him,” he grits out before tossing me over his shoulder, dragging me back to the car as I pound my fists into his back.

Tears flood my eyes as Dante’s still body fades out of sight the further we go down the pier. Viktor opens the door to the back seat of the black SUV, then Nikolai places me inside before climbing in after me. I burst into tears as I throw my fists against his chest.

“How could you do that?” I scream at him.

Viktor takes the driver’s seat, taking us back to the estate.

“What the fuck are *you* doing Emelia?” He grabs my wrist, “you’re out on a fucking date?”

“Dante’s good, you had no right to do that!”

“You brought him into this, Emelia,” he bites. “What the fuck did you think was going to happen?”

“I-”

“Did you really think that you could just disappear for the night with another man and I would allow it?” He growls, body hovering over me, pinning me into the corner of the backseat.

“You were the one who spent the day with Mallory! I know she’s from your little escort agency, Nikolai. How the fuck do you think that makes me feel?” I yell.

Nikolai stills as he stares at me; the car begins to pull into the driveway of the estate.

Tears are streaming down my cheeks as Viktor pulls in and parks in the courtyard before leaving us.

“I’m sorry that I thought this was more than it was. But you don’t get to attack people who actually care about me,” I turn to Nikolai with tear flooded eyes. I reach for the door and quickly leave the car before he can stop me.

Nikolai’s hand reaches around my arm as I’m moving to open the front door. He spins me around to face him.

“Mallory ran the agency; I met with her today because she’s been sending girls to spy on me. The agency and Mallory are no more,” he replies.

I stare at him as he begins to cup my face.

“How the fuck could you think that I would ever be with another woman, when I have you? Now that I’ve tasted you Emelia, you’re the only thing I want to taste. You’re the only fucking thing I need. I will be damned if I ever let another man take you from me, do you understand, *milaya*?” His voice a rough whisper before he runs his tongue along the length of my neck. “Next time, they won’t just get a warning. I will kill anyone who comes near you again.”

“Nik...” I murmur as I wrap my arms around his shoulders.

I need his lips.

I need his touch.

I need *him*.

He lifts me into his arms, lips crashing against mine as he carries me through the threshold and up the stairs towards his bedroom.

The room is vast and effortlessly opulent. Twice the size of mine, at least. Crisp white walls rise high above me, adorned with striking pieces of artwork. Bold, modern pieces framed in matte black. Wooden beams stretch across the ceiling, just like in my room.

Moonlight spills in from the glass doors that lead to his balcony. In the centre of the room stands a four-poster king sized bed, carved in dark wood and dressed in layers of crisp white linens.

He lowers me to the ground and unbuttons his shirt before tossing it aside. I drop my purse to the ground then unzip the back of my dress, letting it fall until I'm standing in just my underwear.

I sit on the edge of the bed as I watch him unbuckle and pull his pants down in an achingly slow motion as his gaze remains fixed on me.

I lick my lips as my eyes roam his semi-naked body. Raw, muscular, his tattooed chest and arms on full display for me now. My eyes drift to the dark wooden case with condoms on the nightstand. An unwelcomed reminder of the women he's brought up here.

I look up to Nikolai. He turns to the nightstand, lifting the case before tossing it into the bin.

"What are you doing?" I ask, confused.

He returns to me, dropping to his knees as he cups my face. "Look at me baby, this is different."

A shallow breath escapes my lips.

“I’ve never had sex without a condom,” he brushes my hair off my shoulder, letting it drape softly down my back. “I need to feel you Emelia, is that okay?” He asks, his eyes burning into me.

Slowly I nod, “I’m on the pill.”

Nikolai’s grin widens. “For now.”

“Wha-”

He wraps his arms around my waist as he settles on top of me. His large, muscular chest pressing against me. He unhooks my bra then tosses it aside as we’re locked in a deep, sensual kiss. I’ve never been kissed like this before, kissed with such an intense hunger and longing. His kisses awaken every aching need within me and God, I never want him to stop.

My back arches as he runs his hands along the curve of my back.

“Oh, fuck baby,” he growls as his large hands paw at my chest.

My head falls back as his tongue circles my nipples, teasing them between his lips. His large hand cups the curve of my breast as his mouth continues to devour me. He grazes my nipple between his teeth before his tongue coats me again, sucking and pulling until they’re stiffer than they’ve ever been.

The pads of his fingers caress my skin with tantalising smoothness. His strong arms wrap around me as he holds my chest to his lips. “I’ve been dreaming about these, my dick gets so fucking hard imagining being between these beautiful tits.”

My eyes roll back as his tongue expertly licks at the curve of my breasts. He moves down to my stomach, his perfect lips and dangerous tongue marking every inch of my skin until he’s between my thighs.

“Let’s get these fucking panties off.” I lift as he pulls my underwear down before quickly tossing it aside. “Mmm,” he moans as he slowly runs his fingers between my folds.

He leans down and grips my thighs firmly as he holds my legs open. The raw fucking intensity of him, makes me quake.

He places warm, wet kisses on my inner thighs then glides his tongue between my slit.

“Such a pretty pussy,” he moans. He pulls me lower as he licks and sucks my clit with rigorous enthusiasm.

He grins then lifts my hips into the air as his kisses become wilder.

“Oh my God, Nik,” I cry out.

He growls as he expertly works his mouth on me. I can already feel my orgasm being teased on the tip of Nik’s tongue as he eats my pussy like he’s starved for it.

“I’m going to cum,” I moan.

My head falls back as my hips arch into him, greedy for his mouth on me. Nik grins. He tightens his grip on my thighs and increases his suction on my clit. My back arches as my pussy spasms with pleasure as I orgasm. “I fucking love the taste of you,” he licks my wet slit with a devilish grin.

He holds my gaze as he lifts off the bed and stands in front of me. In an unhurried tug he pushes his underwear down and kicks it aside.

My mouth falls open as I take him in, cock in hand, stroking himself as he watches me. I lick my lips as I stare at the size of him. About 10 inches, I nearly choked sucking on it, but he tasted so good. Never before have I experienced a dick this thick, and so hard it makes me equally scared and

excited. “Do you see what you do to me, *milaya*?” His voice low and rough. “You have no idea how many nights I’ve thought of you, imagined just this.”

My lips fall open. “I’ve imagined it too,” I breathe.

I lift my arms above my head and spread my legs wider. He smirks as he moves back onto the bed, settling between me.

“I can’t fucking wait.” He teases the tip of his cock between my folds and around the entrance of my core.

With slow thrust he finally enters me. I cry out as he pushes every thick, hard, sexy inch of his big cock into me. I’ve never felt so fucking full.

“Oh fuck, you feel so goddamn incredible,” he lets out a rough breath.

I moan with pleasure as Nik begins to thrust in and out, easing himself into me as my body welcomes him.

“Do you like the way that feels baby?” His voice a low seductive growl as his hips rock. His hands on either side of my head as he stares down at me with a dark grin.

“Yes,” I murmur, breathless.

He leans down, his lips against my ear as he thrusts harder. “You’ve been fucking teasing it since the day you walked into my office.”

He kisses my neck, flattening his tongue then sucking on my skin. “This body is all mine.”

He pins my hands above my head as he increases his pace. “You take me so good, baby.”

He kisses my jaw, then my neck with fevered passion.

“You’re so perfect, every inch of you, so fucking beautiful, Emelia.”

The room starts to spin as I feel myself getting close again.

My pussy begins to spasm with another orgasm as Nik thrusts harder and faster. I feel every single vein of his cock as he pounds into me.

My head falls back as my moans grow louder.

“Look at me baby.” He cups my face and demands my gaze. “Look at me when I cum inside of you.”

I feel his cock throb; my mouth falls open as Nik orgasms, filling my pussy with his warm, silky cum. He buries every drop deep inside of me with a low, satisfied rumble.

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CHAPTER THIRTEEN



NIKOLAI

“We’ve ran all the devices through our new system.”

Luka nods. “We can confirm that they belong to Alexander Communications.”

I lean back in my chair, taking in the two men sitting in my office. Luka and Viktor. A shared look of concern etched on their faces. Katherine’s been spying. The question is, why?

Luka lifts to his feet and moves to the LED screen on the wall. One click of the remote and financial reporting for Alexander Communications is displayed for me in 4k.

“They’re on the verge of bankruptcy,” he starts, then clicks through to a series of excel sheets. “After Ronald Alexander’s passing, she got rid of AC’s board and replaced the executives with, younger and certainly less experienced, members.

I roll my eyes as Luka swipes through images of the board, male models practically.

He opens another sheet, “Katherine’s frivolous spending has put them in a hole. Not to mention, her people aren’t able to compete with the latest technology. Her IT head left immediately after she took control.”

My head tilts, “Ronald was very fond of him, he helped engineer a lot of their software. Do we know where he went?”

Luka grins with a nod. “We hired him.”

I chuckle, leaning back in my chair. Good.

“There’s more,” he exhales sharply. “Leechee AI and NeuraTel were collaborating on a project to essentially provide free internet to impoverished countries.”

My brows scrunch. “Spencer and Frederick were working together?”

He nods, “they were, and successfully too. They had already taken over as a preferred network in many first world cities too, until...”

“Frederick’s murder,” I finish.

Viktor exhales sharply, “who benefitted from his death the most?”

Fuck. “Katherine.” I sneer, all the pieces finally falling into place.

Luka agrees with a solemn nod. “We found communication between her and Frederick, she wanted a merger, he said no.”

That sick fucking bitch. “What about Spencer?”

Luka turns to the screen again, opening surveillance footage from Leeches AI headquarters. Katherine and Spencer sitting in the glass walled boardroom. Tension is high, even through a pixelated screen.

“I don’t think you understand what's happening here, Spencer,” Katherine starts. “You will partner with AC on this project.”

Spencer’s visibly anxious, “it’s not that simple Katherine.”

She stares at him, “then simplify it.”

“I can’t ju-”

“You will,” she snaps. “Don’t forget what happened when Frederick said no.”

The feed then cuts as the screen goes black.

“What the fuck?” I mumble as my fists clench.

Viktor turns to me. “Что нам делать [*chto nam delat* - What do we do]?”

I exhale sharply. “Only Suoh can know about this, get Maksim to meet with him and tell him in person, preferably away from his office and home while we run the sweep for listening devices.”

Viktor nods and reaches for his phone.

My eyes lift to Luka. “Make sure you run the sweep personally, Suoh’s the only member I trust right now. I don’t want anyone hearing anything they shouldn’t.”

Luka nods, “understood.”

What a fucking mess. Katherine’s more vindictive than I gave her credit for. I certainly won’t be making that mistake again. She’s going to be suspicious now that I’ve gone dark and had her little bugs removed from my home. I need to be strategic about this.

I reach for my phone and send her a message:

My team found listening devices around the estate. We suspect

they have been planted by Dmitri before I moved in. My men are available to do a sweep of all of the members grounds to be safe.

Bile rises to my throat as I send the message. Katherine thinks she's playing a clever little game. Making moves, shedding innocent blood.

For an entire year she had access to my life, private conversations. She has no fucking idea that I've just waged war against her, but soon, soon she will.

Her reply comes quickly.

Thank you for letting me know Nikolai.

My men are looking into it. Xoxo, K.



She thought she could disappear for the afternoon without me noticing. Without me feeling the absence of her presence. I tracked her to the chapel recreation hall, a bake sale to raise funds for the playground. I can't lie; Emelia's philanthropy pleases me.

The air is bustling with laughter and activity. Children running with sweets in hand as they play. I scan the room, at each of the tables adorned with baked treats.

Then I see her, my Emelia, smiling as she places chocolate covered brownies into a confectionery bag and hands it to a customer. Her hair is down, fallen to her back but tucked behind her ears, out of her face. The pretty baby blue button up shirt she wears clings to her breasts in a way that makes my breath still.

My eyes linger down to her blue jeans, fabric hugging that amazing ass of hers. So casual and yet still so intoxicating.

She's like a drug. And I'm already fucking addicted.

My eyes tear away from Emelia for a moment as I notice Joanne, the church secretary, I move towards her with a smile.

Her eyes widen as she takes me in, clearly astounded to see me.

"Nikolai, what a lovely surprise," she manages.

"This is quite a turn-out Joanne," I reply looking around the busy room.

"We're lucky, many people offered to volunteer this year. We're almost at our goal," she smiles.

"What is your goal?" I ask, curious.

"Five thousand," she nods.

I reach for my phone and transfer a sum of ten thousand to the church's account. Father Vitaly had been reluctant to take money from me directly in the past so I had to twist Joanne's arm to give me their details so I could help whenever the old man was too stubborn to ask for it.

Joanne's phone buzzes in her hand and she turns it over to read the notification.

"Nikolai, this is too much!" She exclaims.

"Anything for the children." I wink.

Emelia finally notices my presence. She smiles widely as I walk towards her table. She's helping customers, packing brownies into bags with a cheerful smile. I move behind the table and rest a hand on her back before

kissing her cheek. I pull away then help her pack treats for her wide-eyed customers.

She eyes me up and down as the last person leaves her table. “You ditched your suit for jeans and a t-shirt Nikolai? How commendable,” she laughs.

I chuckle. “Anything for the community, baby.”

I pick up one of her brownies and take a bite, deliciously fudgy chocolate coats my tongue.

“No freebies,” she laughs. “You need to pay for that.”

I smirk and move towards her. “I could pay you with a kiss.”

She bites her lip as she smiles at me. Neither of us notice the older woman now standing at the table.

“How beautiful love is when you’re young.” She smiles. “My Arthur and I had fifty wonderful years together.”

Emelia’s face softens as she listens to her.

“How long have you been married?” She asks staring at us.

“We-”

“A year,” I answer. “We still have forty-nine to go to catch up to you and Arthur.”

Emelia packs a brownie in a bag as they both laugh.

“Cherish your love, my dears. For most of us, it’s a once in a lifetime experience,” she smiles before moving back into the crowd.

She turns to me, brows furrowed. “Why would you lie to her?”

I shrug. “Because she needed us to.”

I lean in and place a soft, reverent kiss on her lips.

“What was that for?” She smiles.

“Can’t a man just kiss his fake wife?” I tease.

Emelia laughs and swats at my arm. She picks up the empty brownie cartons and hands them to me. “Could you throw these away please?”

I shake my head with a laugh. “Bossing me around already.”

I take the boxes from her hand with a grin and head to the corner of the room to throw them out. I turn and look around, feeling the energy of the room. I had hidden away from the community for almost as long as I had been here, and right now I don’t know why.

I sense him before I see him, and a smile pulls on my lips.

“I must be getting old, my eyes are telling me that the scowl that usually hinders your face has disappeared Nikolai,” Father Vitaly says as he moves towards me.

I roll my eyes with a chuckle. “It’s a beautiful day.”

He nods. “Indeed, and even more so with a very large donation that we’ve received. You wouldn’t know anything about that, would you?”

I turn to him with a smile and shake my head. “Perhaps someone generous has a sweet tooth. I hear the brownies are amazing.”

Vitaly laughs as his eyes find Emelia at her table, helping customers.

He squeezes his hands, disguising the bouts of pain with a smile.

“I can arrange for you to see a specialist,” I say, my eyes dropping to his hands.

He lets out a small chuckle. "I'm an old man Nikolai; my time will come when it's meant to." He places his hand on my shoulder. "Enjoy your youth my boy," he smiles, patting my shoulder then walks back into the crowd.

Multiple Myeloma, Stage II. He was diagnosed over ten years ago. Doctors gave him six years before it worsened, before so much as opening a jar would be excruciatingly painful. I've offered to help, many times, but Vitaly is a stubborn man. Even death is having a difficult time taking him.

Emelia rests her head against the leather seat as I drive us back to the estate. The window is cracked open, pulling in a cool breeze that kisses her long hair. She's so fucking beautiful, I can barely keep my focus on the road.

"You look tired baby," I say.

She nods with a lazy smile. "I was up until 02:00 baking twelve trays of brownies."

My brows furrow. "I didn't even hear you."

She laughs. "I could've been an intruder Nikolai, you're lucky my weapon of choice was a spatula."

I chuckle and lift her hand to my lips.

When my eyes return to the road I notice a car behind us. I recognise it from the church parking lot but not a car that belongs on this road, this road leads to my estate and nothing else so they couldn't be lost. They were following me. I keep my eyes on the mirror as I slowly pick up speed, then watching them meet my pace. Mother Fucker.

I reach my hand over Emelia and pull her seatbelt until it clicks into place.

"What are you doing?" She asks, confused.

“We’re being followed,” I reply firmly then turn to her. “I need you to stay calm, okay? This will be over soon.”

She doesn’t have a moment to ask before I dead break and reach my hand out to her to prevent her from moving forward. The car behind me skids and swerves, stopping just behind us.

“Are you okay?” I ask her, checking her for any sign of distress.

She nods then releases her seatbelt.

“Stay here.”

I reach for my gun then move out of the car to theirs.

A black Toyota. Tinted windows with no license plate. Fucking amateurs. The driver holds his head, blood trickling from his temple as he tries to steady his vision.

I slam the butt of the gun against the window breaking it and shoot a bullet into his head. The passenger door falls open, and another man falls to the ground, holding his head. Nose broken and bleeding from the impact. I drop to my knees and lift him by his collar before pummeling my fist into his face.

“Who the fuck sent you?” I yell.

He shakes his head as he coughs blood. I hit him again and again. “Who sent you?”

Blood seeps from his lips. “Dmitri.”

I scoff. “Bullshit, Dmitri’s men know how to tail. I won’t ask you again.”

He coughs blood. “Spencer...he wants to talk...”

A gasp pulls my attention back to my car. Emelia stands watching me with concern in her eyes. He uses the opportunity to reach for his fallen gun. His finger grazes the trigger, firing a shot towards my car, towards her. She flinches at the sound of the bullet striking my bumper.

I tear the gun from his hands and toss it aside. White hot fury courses through my veins. “You just sealed your fucking fate.” I grab his head and slam it into the asphalt, cracking his skull, over and over. I lift his neck and twist until I hear a crack. I wipe my bloodied hands on his shirt before lifting to my feet.

Emelia stares at me, lip quivering, shoulders tense as she watches me walk towards her. I reach for her, I know the bullet didn’t touch her, but I still need to make sure. She’s fucking trembling. “Are you okay?” I ask, my voice low.

Her lips part as she nods slowly.

I pull her into my arms. “I would never let anyone hurt you.” I press my lips against hers.

My tongue moves along the seam of her lips; I tighten my grip on her as she opens her lips for me and lets me explore her mouth. A growl escapes my throat as her hands run through my hair. She feels so fucking good in my arms.

I pull back and take her in, her pulse racing, her lips swollen as she stares at me. I’m in fucking awe of her. I just killed two men and still, she lets me wrap my bloodied hands around her and kiss the fuck out of her.

So, goddamn perfect.



CHAPTER FOURTEEN



NIKOLAI

I sigh as I end another meeting in my office.

I need a fucking holiday. I could take Emelia to Velora Isle. Suoh's offered a standing invitation for me to visit his private island, a secluded jewel in the Mediterranean. Hmm, imagining her lounging around in nothing but a bikini is enough to make me book the pilot right fucking now.

I reach for my phone and dial Luka.

"Nikolai," he answers.

"Can you log me into Emelia's social media accounts?" I ask, unashamed at my question.

"Yes, just give it a moment." He pauses. "Your laptop will be logged into all of her known accounts."

"Known accounts?" I ask, confused.

"She might have more under a different name," he explains.

I don't fucking like that.

“Okay, I’m in, thank you Luka.” I hang up the phone and scroll through Emelia’s profiles, looking through her pictures and videos, at her life before me. No pictures of any boyfriends, that pleases me.

I move to her DM’s and scroll through hundreds of messages. Most from wide-eyed fans but many, too many, from hungry, horny, disgusting men who dare to look at her.

‘I can give you something to write about honey’

‘Nice tits’

‘You would look so good bent over my lap’

‘Bet that ass is tight AF’

‘Fuck you would look good with my dick in your mouth’

‘I’d sell my soul to eat your ass’

My fists clench so hard, nail cuts into skin. It would be easy to track each of them down and teach them a lesson about manners. And fuck, I want to. I close my eyes and steady my breath, choosing to delete the messages instead of letting the monster out again.

Emelia probably wouldn’t approve of me killing her fans. They can sleep safe – for today.



I love late nights in the gym, just me and the bag. Swinging my fists into it is almost as satisfying as the real thing. My father was an artful fighter, he preferred his fists over guns, and it showed. Growing up as the eldest son of the great Aleksei Kirovsky demanded certain sacrifices, from me. This world made me what I am, dark, monstrous, broken. But it also gives me power,

wealth, accessibility. The weight of a great name rests on my shoulders, but even I sometimes struggle to carry it alone.

I walk out of the gym and make my way to my bedroom; I need a hot shower and to curl up in bed with my girl.

I stop as I hear footsteps and humming from the kitchen. It's after 23:00, the staff aren't usually awake. I follow the sound and lean against the doorway as I watch Emelia humming to herself as she flips a pancake with a sweet smile. She looks so fucking sexy in her little grey camisole and matching shorts.

"What are you doing?" I ask unable to hide my grin.

Emelia jerks at the sound of my voice. "Don't scare me like that," she laughs.

I smile as I move towards the kitchen island and take a seat. "As much as I love this view, why are you making pancakes at this time of the night?"

"Oh," she laughs. "I've been writing all day, and my brain is still really wired." She starts, flipping a pancake with practised ease.

"When I was a kid, my dad used to make me these whenever I had nightmares, or I just couldn't sleep. It was kind of our thing," her smile softening at the mention of her father.

I smile as I hold her gaze. I can't help staring at her, she's so fucking beautiful inside and out.

She moves around the counter and slowly walks towards me. "I've been speaking with your staff Nikolai, and they all have nothing but kind and lovely things to say about you," she smiles as she wraps her arms around my shoulders.

“I pay them well,” I grin as I tilt my head to kiss her cheek.

“No, it’s not that,” she laughs. “I can read people, the way they speak about you is with genuine affection. You treat them like family, you’re loyal and protective.”

My gaze drops. “If you knew all the things I’ve done Emelia... You wouldn’t think so highly of me.”

She places her hand on mine. “You do what you have to, I would never think any less of you for being who you are,” she replies.

My sweet, beautiful, lovely Emelia. What are you doing to me?

She turns to the fridge and pulls out a can of whipped cream and strawberries, staring at me with a cheeky grin. “I know it’s late, but you can’t let me eat this alone.” She says already propping the pancakes on a plate before delicately placing the sliced strawberries on top then finishing it off with a generous dollop of whipped cream.

She cuts a piece and holds it up on a fork as she looks at me.

“Are you too tough for a pancake?” She teases.

“No,” I laugh. She moves the fork to my mouth and watches with a giddy smile as I chew.

She picks up the fork and takes a bite, tilting her head as she moans in delight. She turns to me. “What do you think?”

My dick is getting hard.

“I think that if you keep moaning like that, I’m going to have to do something about it,” I say, holding her gaze.

She pauses as her eyes widen. I stand slowly, towering over her as her back begins to press against the counter. I lift my thumb to her lips and wipe

remnants of whipped cream before licking my finger.

I place my hands around her waist as she looks up at me, her pulse racing as my fingers brush the sliver of bare skin between her shorts and camisole. A beautiful whimper escapes her lips.

Her nipples stiffen under the delicate grey fabric. I lean forward; her eyes began to close as I near her lips.

I wrap my arms around her and lift her onto my hips as I push my tongue into her mouth. I sit back down on the stool with Emelia on my lap as we're locked in a passionate kiss.

Her hips jerk as my cock hardens against her. I pull her closer, letting her feel every inch of me. Every single inch that I am going to fucking destroy her sweet little pussy with.

I pull back and lean her against the counter. My hands are fucking twitching to touch her. I pull at the straps of her camisole and let them fall down her arms, a growl escapes my lips as her breasts are exposed to me. Her beautiful dusky rose nipples call out to my tongue like the night beckoning the moon. I grab her, and pinch her stiff nipples, rolling her between my fingers. I tilt her, arching her back, presenting her tits to my mouth then sucking on her like a man starved. Emelia's moans are making my cock rock fucking hard.

She reaches for me, palming my erection through my shorts. I grin then lift us both as I pull down the front, releasing my dick before sitting down again.

Everyone should be asleep. So, she can play, because I'm going to play too.

Emelia's breath hitches as she takes my cock into her hands and strokes me. I guide her backwards and tug her shorts until her beautiful pussy is open to me. I lift my fingers to my mouth, coating the tips of my index and middle finger before gliding them between her sweet, pretty slit. Emelia's head falls back as she moans.

Mmm she's wet already.

"You have no idea how badly I fucking ache to touch you," I growl, moving my lips to her neck. Tasting that sweet peach and vanilla scent on her skin.

Emelia's legs widen as she strokes me harder. I press a finger into her, teasing, testing. I watch as she matches her strokes with mine. I push another finger inside of her with a grin, watching her ride my hand. She's so needy for me, so eager to have me inside of her. I fucking love it.

I rub her swollen clit with my thumb as I bury my fingers inside of her. The scent of her pussy is making me lose my fucking mind. I want nothing more than to eat her until she's screaming my name but she's stroking my cock so good I'm trying not to cum.

"You're so wet for me baby." The sound of my fingers slamming in and out of her is pushing me to the fucking edge of oblivion.

"I'm going to cum," she moans.

I increase the pace and pressure of my thumb on her clit. My cock is throbbing with her hand wrapped around me. I spread her legs wider, fingering her harder until I hear the blissful scream tear from her throat.

Her pussy drips on my hand as she orgasms. I finally let go too and cum all over her hand and thighs. I pull her towards me and press my tongue into

her mouth as we ride a blissful orgasm together.

My fingers still buried in her wet cunt as she tries to catch her breath.

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CHAPTER FIFTEEN



EMELIA

Nik and I pull up to the hangar on the private air strip.

The hum of the engine fading into the echo of our arrival. He steps out first, circling the car with a smile tugging at his lips. He opens the door, extending his hand to me, helping me rise from my seat.

Staff are already lined up, efficient and silent, ready to usher us toward the sleek jet waiting behind them. My eyes widen and mouth falls open as we step onto the plane. I drink in the polished wood panelling, the leather seats, the kind of luxury few people ever get to experience.

“Nik,” I breathe, glancing at him with a mixture of awe and disbelief, “don’t let this get to your head, but just how rich are you?”

He chuckles, leaning in to steal a kiss, slow and deliberate. “Rich enough to do whatever the fuck I want baby.”

He guides me to one of the oversized leather seats. I take the one beside him, close enough that I can curl into his arms.

A flight attendant appears almost instantly, setting a chilled bottle of champagne into an ice bucket before pouring it into slender flutes. The golden bubbles catch the light as the cabin hums with life, preparing for take-off.

I turn toward him. “Are you going to tell me where you’re taking me?”

He grins, shaking his head as he leans closer. “It’s a surprise.”

The engines roar to life, the plane begins its slow roll down the runway, and for a moment, it feels like the rest of the world has already fallen away.

In an hour, we’re landing in Venice.

A sleek black car is waiting for us on the tarmac of the private airport. Nikolai looks like a God. Dressed in blue jeans, a crisp white shirt, sneakers and brown aviator glasses. He exudes power even when dressed for comfort.

He takes my hand with a grin as he leads me to the car. The driver nods as we near, holding the door open for us.

Nikolai curls his arm around my waist, settling in closely beside me before brushing the hair from my face.

“What is Roman going to be doing without you today?” A teasing smile curls at my lips.

He chuckles. “He’ll be fine. He needs to be spending more time with his wife anyway.”

He holds me as the car glides out of the sleek private terminal.

Within minutes, the view begins to shift. Hills dotted with olive groves and vineyards roll lazily in the distance, and ahead the skyline of Florence

risers.

As the car sweeps into the city, the streets narrow, and the architecture sharpens. Nikolai's phone rings, interrupting the comfortable quiet. He stares at the screen before answering.

"Dennis, this better be an emergency," his voice cold and controlled.

I rest my head against his chest as my mind wanders.

My imagination already in overdrive creating stories in this picturesque setting.

"That can wait. I'm away with my girlfriend today, if anything else comes up, speak to Roman or Maksim."

He ends the call then returns his phone to his pocket.

My head snaps to him. "You just called me your girlfriend."

His brows knit as he chuckles. "That's what you are baby."

My smile widens. I bite my lip and move onto his lap.

"Emelia," he grins, eyeing the quiet driver. Reminding me that we're not alone.

I run my hands around his shoulders then behind his neck. "I just want to kiss you." I press my lips against his, teasing my tongue against him before nipping his bottom lip.

His eyes darken as his hands squeeze my thighs. His lips whisper against my ear. "I'm going to do very bad things to you."

I run my hand over his chest as I lean in and kiss his neck.

"You know what I'm going to do?" I whisper to him. "I'm going to get on my knees and show you just how greedy I can be when your cock is in my

mouth.”

A breath escapes Nikolai’s throat as I lift his hand to my lips and slowly suck on his middle finger.

“Pull over,” he instructs the driver. His voice low and demanding.

“We’re arriving now at the St. Regis sir,” he replies politely as the car rolls to a stop. The driver exits the vehicle and begins to round the car to open our door.

Nik’s hand moves between us, then he cups my pussy roughly under my skirt, making me gasp. “You’re fucking lucky we’re here *milaya*, just wait until I get you upstairs.”

I lick my lips as I move from his lap, returning to the seat as the driver begins to open the door. Nikolai exits first, then holds out his hand for me.

I breathe in the city around us as the sun begins to dip beyond the horizon. Nikolai takes my hand and guides me through the hotel lobby. My heels click against the marble floor as the space begins to unfold. Ornate arches, gilded details, modern elegance woven seamlessly into old-world grandeur.

Light spills from crystal fixtures above, dancing over silk-upholstered chairs and glass walls that frame the Grand Canal like a living painting.

Nik’s hand stays firm at the small of my back as the concierge greets us with hushed reverence.

“Mr Kirovsky,” she greets with a nod and a smile. “The penthouse is ready for you.” She hands him a slim, matt black key card. “Would you like to be shown to your suite, sir?”

“No,” he says firmly. “Have you organised the wardrobe to be brought to us?”

She nods. “Yes sir, wardrobe should be arriving in the next twenty minutes.”

Nikolai guides me through the lobby to the elevator. He’s on me before the doors close. His hands are in my hair as he kisses me roughly, urgently. I moan into his mouth as his beard bristles against my skin, sending waves of electric pulses straight to my core.

I’m dropping to my knees as soon as the doors close behind us. Instantly, unclipping his belt and tugging at his zipper like a woman starved. I tug his underwear until his beautiful, thick, hard, dick juts out to greet me. Only six floors till we reach the penthouse.

“Baby-” he begins to protest but I don’t allow him another word before my lips are wrapped all around his cock. Nik leans against the wall as the elevator continues its ascent.

He eyes the changing floor numbers then stares down at me. “If these doors open Emelia, then I’m going to have to take out my gun.” He rasps. “I can’t have anyone else getting to see you like this.”

My eyes flick to the side. Floor 5. I move back and stand to my feet. With a teasing grin I remove my top and bra. The doors ding open as I pull my skirt down then toss them inside the floor of the penthouse as I walk inside backwards.

The penthouse opens like a secret unveiled. High ceilings and wide windows stretch toward the lagoon, the whole city spilling out beneath us in

golden evening light. A wraparound terrace beckons, the Grand Canal glittering just beyond its edge.

Inside, every surface whispers wealth. Silk drapes, marble floors, art chosen not for trend but for legacy.

My eyes remain glued on Nikolai's hungry gaze. He stalks toward me, pants undone, cock hard. A sight so fucking sexy I save it in the darkest corner of my mind, stored for later.

I drop to my knees, wearing only a black thong now. Offering him my complete submission.

He reaches me, cups my face then stares down at me with dark eyes. I run my hands up his thighs and then wrap my hand around his dick.

His head falls back as he moans. I stroke him slowly, tenderly from base to tip. I place soft, gentle, teasing little kisses all along the length of his dick then all around the tip.

My tongue flicks out and licks the tip before wrapping my lips around it. "Oh fuck..." he growls.

I smirk as I begin to suck, taking in more and more of him with every bob of my head. My fingers grip the base firmly as I moan, making his cock vibrate in my throat.

I twirl my tongue around his tip as I hold his gaze with a smirk before I suck on him greedily, going deeper and deeper until I feel him in my throat.

"I need to touch you," he moans. He tugs his dick from my mouth and lifts me up until my legs are wrapped around his waist. He pushes his tongue into my mouth as his hands squeeze my ass while he carries me to the kitchen counter. He swipes the welcome basket, letting it fall to the floor.

Nikolai sits me on the counter; strong fingers grip the thin fabric of my thong before pulling it down and tossing it aside. A smirk pulls at his lips as he turns my body around then guiding me to lay with my back on the counter. He pulls me lower, until my head dangles off the edge. His cock presses against my lips as his hips thrust into my open mouth.

“How did I get so fucking lucky to have the most perfect woman?” He drawls as his hands reach forward. His fingers brush between my wet slit. He parts my folds until he finds my swollen clit, teasing it with the tip of his finger.

“Look at what a perfect girlfriend you are, baby,” he smirks, licking his now coated fingers before returning them to my clit. "Sucking on my cock like a good fucking girl while you open your legs for me."

Tears are beginning to roll down the side of my face as his cock hits the back of my throat, but I suck harder, grip harder. Nikolai's hips continue to rock as he fucks my mouth.

He presses a finger inside of me, then another.

“Baby you make me lose my fucking mind,” he thrusts his fingers in and out of me.

I moan, making his cock vibrate again. His head falls back as I feel him getting close, his hands move up to my breasts, squeezing them, rubbing my wetness all over my nipples. He leans his head down to my breasts and sucks on me. Lapping up all the moisture he painted over them.

He returns his hand to my pussy and rubs at my clit vigorously, coaxing my orgasm until I'm moaning with release. “Fuck baby, I'm close,” he growls.

He pulls himself out of my mouth and flips me around, so my stomach is on the counter. He returns his dick to my mouth then brushes the hair from my face.

“Do you like having your mouth full like this baby?” He rasps.

“Yes,” I murmur, sucking on his tip.

Nik finally cums, filling my mouth, my throat with every hot silky drop of him. I hold his gaze as I swallow. I move forward, still gripping his cock then I lick his tip, getting the last drops of him.

He pulls me from the counter and holds me against him.

He moves down to kiss me. “You are so fucking perfect,” he whispers against my lips.

Nikolai winks at me as an expected knock sounds at the door. “Get dressed while I let them in baby.” He slaps my naked bottom playfully before moving towards the private elevator door. I reach for my clothes on the floor and quickly redress in the bedroom before returning.

The elevator doors slide open as hotel staff wheel in two rails. The first gleaming with silks and chiffons, a line of evening gowns swaying like whispered secrets, sequins catching the last light of day. The second stands opposite, crisp and commanding, a procession of suits pressed to perfection in dark fabrics.

The concierge smiles as the shoes and accessories are brought in. “Your wardrobe options for tonight.”

My fingers brush against the beautiful fabrics. I turn to Nik with a wide smile. I could really get used to this princess treatment.

My eyes fall on a beautiful, champagne coloured, off shoulder, floor length silk dress with a rouged, thigh-high slit. I lift it from the rail with a soft breath. It's gorgeous.



The double doors open, and the ballroom unfolds in a sweep of gold and crystal. High, coffered ceilings gleam with centuries-old paintings of angels and mythical figures watching silently from above. Crystal chandeliers cascade from the ceiling like frozen waterfalls, each prism catching candlelight and scattering it across polished marble floors.

The long banquet tables stretch the length of the hall, draped in ivory linen that pools against the floor. Musicians tune their strings from a corner alcove; the soft sigh of violins barely audible over the hum of conversation as guests trickle in.

My hand rests comfortably in his as we pass the threshold. Nikolai looks like a dream, black loafers, a sharp black suit and crisp white shirt opened at the collar. He wears a Richard Mille RM 43-01, over half a million dollars strapped to his wrist, carried with the same indifference as loose change. I can't even be upset that he's drawing the eyes of nearly every woman in here.

"Nikolai, it's so great to see you," a man's deep, arresting voice cuts through the crowd. My eyes lift as a tall, handsome older man approaches us. His physique is strong, his hair peppered grey, but his eyes are commanding and dark.

Nikolai wraps his arm around my waist as he reaches out his right hand to the man. "Xander, it's been some time," he smiles. "This is Emelia." His eyes fall to me as his smile softens.

I reach my hand forward. "It's a pleasure to meet you, Xander."

His brow raises as his lips pull into a grin. "You are exquisite, my dear," he says, lifting my hand to his lips before kissing my knuckles.

"How did you manage to convince him to leave that fortress of his, Emelia?" He smirks.

"It didn't take much convincing at all," I chuckle. "He surprised me with this trip."

Xander's eyes widen. "Романтик [*romantic* - A romantic]?" He laughs.

"Можешь меня винить [*mozes menya vinit* - Can you blame me]?" He smiles, eyes fixed on me.

Then another voice cuts through the room, softer, feminine. "Uncle, there you are." A young woman moves towards Xander then kisses his cheek. She wears a floor length maroon dress with a low neckline. Large chandelier earrings hang from her lobes, accentuating her long neck. Her dark hair is pinned into an updo as curled trestles fall down her face.

"Nikolai... this a surprise," she grins as she stares at him.

I don't like that look.

"Natasha," he nods.

She turns to me, eyeing me up and down. "And who's this?" she smiles, brow raised.

"Emelia, my girlfriend," Nik replies with a grin.

"Girlfriend?" Her brows knit. "I thought you didn't do girlfriends Nikolai?"

"He does with me." I stare at her.

Xander lets out a low chuckle. “I like her.”

“You look familiar, Emelia,” Natasha says as she scrunches her brows.

“I’m an author, and I have a significant social media presence,” I reply with a grin.

“You’re an author? Beautiful and industrious, you really hit the fucking jackpot Nikolai,” Xander says.

“I most certainly did,” he nods before kissing my temple.

Natasha stares at me intently. The kind of stare that comes with a warning.

“Your mother was quite the writer too, wasn’t she?” He adds. “Her head was always stuck in those little books of hers.”

Nikolai nods.

His mother was a writer? Why didn’t he tell me that?

Xander taps Nikolai’s shoulder. “Enjoy the party. I’ll find you later, there’s something we need to discuss.”

Nik nods his head in reply then Xander walks away into the crowd.

Natasha stays, still staring. “Are you staying at the hotel, Nikolai?”

He’s clearly annoyed by her questions, but he nods.

“This place reminds me so much of that chateau we stayed in last spring,” she smirks, “do you remember?”

Nik’s jaw ticks. “I don’t.”

She chuckles, tilting her head at him. “Perhaps I’ll refresh your memory then,” she winks, “I’ll see you later.”

I grab her wrist as she begins to leave. I've spent most of my adolescence being bullied. I'm seasoned in bitch.

I lean into her, meeting her surprised eyes. "No, you fucking won't." My voice soft enough to not to draw attention but my tone is firm and absolute. "Don't ever speak to him again."

She stares at Nik, as if expecting him to say something. I drop her wrist and move back to him. He stares down at me with dark eyes as he leads me to the centre of the ballroom.

His hands round my waist as he pulls me towards him and sways to the music.

"Emelia..." he starts.

"She was disrespectful." I murmur.

He nods. "She was."

"Did you sleep with her?" I ask, hating myself for needing to know.

"I did," he replies with a soft nod.

He exhales sharply. "I don't want you to think about that, no-one meant anything." He pauses as he lifts my chin, commanding my gaze. "It's you and me baby. We'll fuck out the memories of everyone before us, until it's just us."

My eyes drop to my feet. "You know my submission is done," I start. "It's been eight weeks..."

Nikolai chuckles. "If you think I'm letting you leave, you're sorely mistaken, Emelia."

My lips curl into a grin. "I can't just stay; I still have an apartment,

Nikolai.”

He exhales sharply, then lifts my fingers to his lips. “Eight more weeks then,” he murmurs, “just eight more while you work on your book then we can decide where we go from there... please.”

I stare at him, wrapping my arms around his neck as my eyes pour into his. “Okay,” I smile.

He cups my chin, stroking my cheek with his thumb before kissing me softly, reverently as his hand curls around the back of my neck.

I fall onto the couch as soon as we enter the penthouse. Nikolai chuckles as he drops to his knees in front of me and takes my heels off. My curiosity getting the better of me. “I didn’t know your mother was a writer.”

Nik’s brows knit at my comment as he pulls my heels off.

“Xander mentioned-”

“Oh,” he laughs. “He was talking about her journals; she kept them when she first married my father.”

He kisses my ankle then removes the other heel.

“Why only then?” I ask.

Nikolai looks up at me. “It’s not a pleasant story, Emelia.”

“I’d like to hear it anyway, if you’ll tell me,” I say wrapping my arms around his shoulders and kissing his lips.

He lifts to his feet and settles in behind me on the couch until I’m laying comfortably in his arms.

“My parents hated each other when they first met, it was an arranged marriage. My grandfather, Olaf grew tired of my father ‘whoring around’ he

forced him to take a wife. My mother was the daughter of a business associate; she was practically sold as a deal.”

I stare up him as his face falls at the thought.

“She was promised to another at the time. A man she had been engaged to, who she had begun to love. But a week after hands shook in agreement, Aleksei and Alina were married. She was practically forced down the aisle, crying as she said I do,” he murmurs as his eyes darken. “She was fierce though, my mother, after the ceremony she escaped through a bathroom window at the back of the church and ran off with the man she wanted to be with.”

My eyes widen. “Was Aleksei angry?”

Nikolai chuckles. “Angry is an understatement. He tracked them down. They were getting ready to escape, to build a life together...” he pauses, “my father made her watch as he brutally beat that man to an inch of his life then he forced a gun into her hand,” Nik says, lifting my hand into his, shaping our fingers into a gun, “and made her pull the trigger.”

“What did she do?” I ask, intrigued.

“The only thing she could do, she withheld herself from him.” He exhales sharply. “Then everything changed, he was shot... The bullet just missed his heart, but he had lost a lot of blood; no-one thought he would make it.” He pauses. “What surprised everyone was how she had begun to look after him, nursing his wound, reading to him, caring for him.”

My brows knit. “If she wanted out of the marriage, why would she...”

“Probably because she knew what would happen if he died. She was still young, fertile. She would just be married off again. At least she could tolerate

Aleksei. Men in this world can be very cruel; especially to their wives.”

“What happened after he recovered?” I ask, curious.

“I don’t know,” Nikolai chuckles. “The journals stopped there. But three children later, they must have figured it out.”

I smile, curling tighter into his arms.

“One thing I’ll never doubt, is that my parents absolutely loved each other. A kind of love that defies the rule of time. Even when death took them, they couldn’t be separated.”

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CHAPTER SIXTEEN



EMELIA

My feet are burning a hole in the floor of the study.

The unsent email to Gretchen glaring at me from the open screen of my laptop. You need to send it, Emelia. Deadline's up.

What if she hates it?

What if she loves it?

Ugh God, I'm driving myself crazy. I take a deep breath, letting the fresh air fill the entirety of my lungs before clicking send.

It's gone. Screw it. I think it's great and I'm going to choose to believe that she will too.

An email notification startles me.

From: Gretchen Jones

Hi Emelia

Hope you're doing well. The team will share feedback in the next few weeks. Take care, dear.

Gretchen Jones,

Orion CEO



I walk down the stairs, to the dining room at 18:20. I wear a floor-length cream chiffon dress with pink and green flowers. The neckline is more daring than I'm usually comfortable with, but I can't wait to see his face when I walk into the room wearing this. Voices drift from the dining room as I near. Shit, am I late?

"Oh my God!" A young woman exclaims as I enter the room. Ah, this must be Roman's sister.

She pushes her chair back abruptly and runs, throwing her arms tightly around me. "I can't believe you're really here!" She exclaims.

"Raquel, let her go," Roman rolls his eyes before motioning for her to move away.

I chuckle as I take her hand into mine, "that's okay, it's a pleasure to meet you, Raquel."

"Come sit next to me." She insists, already pulling me to the table.

Nikolai sits at the head; his eyes burning into me as Raquel sits me next to him with her seated to my right. I catch Nikolai's gaze as his eyes trail down to my chest. I move towards him. "You look beautiful baby," he grins.

I press a kiss to his lips. He grabs my wrist and holds me against him as he whispers in my ear. “I’m going to tear this fucking dress off you later so no-one else can see you in it.”

I grin as I slip into the seat beside him while taking in another new face around the table.

“I’m Yelena, Roman’s wife. It’s nice to meet you Emelia,” she smiles.

Yelena looks even more beautiful in person. Her hair is dark and thick with curls. Her bright, green eyes sparkle as she rubs her growing belly.

“It’s lovely to meet you and congratulations.” I smile back.

“My friends are going to die! They didn’t believe me when I told them I’m meeting you,” Raquel squeals as she types excitedly on her phone.

I turn to Nikolai. I feel the burn of his gaze against my skin. Our eyes lock for only a moment before his drops down to my chest again. I press my knees together as I begin to feel the heat rise from between my legs. This gorgeous man was inside of me just hours ago and yet I’m already craving and aching for his touch again.

Staff begin filing into the dining room, each one carrying a silver platter with dishes releasing a glorious aroma in the air. Then comes the main dish, a roasted leg of lamb with sprigs of fragrant fresh thyme. They place it on the long oak table as steam rises in elegant curls mingling with a subtle scent of garlic and rosemary. Alongside it are dishes with creamy mashed potatoes and charred honey glazed baby carrots and a Mediterranean medley of roasted vegetables.

Nikolai lifts my hand to his lips and kisses my fingers.

“Okay, I just have to ask, book four ended with Ryan taking the job in Switzerland but Lily still hasn’t decided if she’s going with him, is she?” Raquel asks as she scoops a forkful of mashed potatoes into her mouth.

I laugh, “To be honest, I don’t know yet.” I reply. “I usually just let the characters tell me where the story goes.”

“I’m going to die if she doesn’t go with him Emelia,” she pouts.

“You’ll survive,” Roman says flatly as he rolls his eyes.

“When are you releasing your next book, Emelia?” Yelena asks.

I look up at her. “I’m taking a break from Lily and Ryan for a bit while I work on my new book,” I admit, before biting into a delicious piece of carrot.

“Shut up! A new book? Oh my god, what is it about?” Raquel asks excitedly.

“Raquel, calm the fuck down and let Emelia enjoy her dinner in peace,” Nikolai says as he gave her a stern look.

“I’m trying but I can’t help it, you guys just don’t understand...” she replies as she rolls her eyes.

“Just between you and I, it’s going to be a dark romance set in a world of fantasy.” I say to her.

Her eyes widen.

“I’m still working on the details, but I promise, you will have one of the first copies as soon as it’s ready,” I wink at her.

“I literally love you!” She smiles as she wraps her arms around me. “Your characters are so dreamy, Ryan is literally my dream guy, I cried when his mother died.”

I nod my head. “Yeah, it was tough to write.”

“Is it true that your parents died when you were just eight years old?” she asks.

I pause, staring at my plate before giving her a soft nod. “We were in a car accident.”

“I’m sorry to hear that, Emelia,” Yelena offers a small, consoling smile. A smile I’ve seen on many different faces over the years.

“Jesus Raquel, what’s wrong with you?” Roman asks, scowling at her.

“I’m so sorry, Emelia,” her lips begin to curl as her eyes drop. I quickly take her hand, “that’s okay, it’s part of my story.”

After dinner the staff brings in a scrumptious crème brûlée.

“Would you mind if I video call my friends so they can say hi to you?” Raquel asks, sweetly.

“No,” Nikolai replies firmly.

I look to him, “It’s okay, I’m happy to say hi to them.”

“Yes!” Raquel exclaims then quickly calls them.

Eight little blocks of faces appear on her phone. Each one waves in delight as we greet them. Raquel thankfully doesn’t keep me on the line long, after the initial greeting and a handful of questions about Ryan and Lily, Nikolai forces her to hang up or take the call outside, she isn’t ready to say goodbye to her friends, so she takes her dessert and lounges outside on the pool deck.



I exhale slowly, walking out onto the first-floor terrace for a moment of quiet. I close my eyes as the cool night air kisses my skin. I lean against the terrace and look down at the sprawling lawn below and vineyards ahead.

My phone buzzes. A notification. A message. From Thomas. What the fuck could he possibly want?

Tom: Em, I need to see you.

Emelia: Leave me alone.

Emelia: In fact, delete my number.

Tom: Can you really be that cold to me after everything we've been through together?

My heart thuds in my chest as my anger begins to boil over.

Emelia: Do you mean everything you've put me through? Then yes, leave me alone Tom.

No reply. He is such an arrogant asshole. What did he expect that I would go running to him whenever he called?

Tom: I think that little award has gone to your head Em...

Tom: Don't forget who and what you are

Tom: Nothing

Tom: People only know your name because of me

Tom: Because of MY connections

I stare at the screen of my phone, my grip tightening as I read his messages.

Tom: You really should be nicer to me, Emelia...

Tom: You can start by putting in a good word for me with Gretchen. I think she'd love a closer look at my work if she got to see it for herself.

Emelia: Are you insane? Why would I ever do that?

Tom: Because if you don't, I'll share that little video I have of you...

No, no, no this can't be happening. I hold on to the terrace for support as tears flood my eyes.

Tom: I'm sure the world would love to see how their favourite author likes to get fucked.

Tom: I wonder what Gretchen would think

Emelia: You are a fucking monster!

Emelia: You took that video without my knowledge or consent!

Emelia: If you leak it, I will sue you for every single cent you have!

Tom: Try it darling...

Tom: You and I both know that once that video leaks, the damage to your reputation will already be done.

Tom: No-one will be able to look at you again

Tom: Your book deals, your fans, all gone

Emelia: Please don't do this

Tom: I'm not asking for much, you owe me this

Tom: I helped you, now you help me

Emelia: Tom, I don't have that type of relationship with Gretchen. You can't seriously ask this of me

Tom: I'll give you a week, if I haven't heard from Gretchen Jones herself before then, well, I won't have much of a choice...

Tom: Don't force my hand Em.

Tom: Sweet dreams, princess xxx

I stare at the messages through fallen tears, hoping that I've misread. But no, that sick son of a bitch is actually blackmailing me. I hold my head in my hands as I sob, if that video gets out my life will be ruined.

"Emelia?" Nikolai's voice shakes me from my trance. I wipe the tears from my cheeks before turning to him.

"What's wrong?" He asks, his face a mix concern and anger as he hurries toward me.

I shake my head. "I can't-"

He stares at me, his voiced low and demanding. "Tell me."

My hand grips my phone tightly, before I hand it to him.

Nikolai's jaw ticks as he reads through the messages.

"Who the fuck is this?" He breathes.

"Thomas Winchester, my ex-boyfriend," I murmur.

"What is the video?" He presses.

A tear falls down my cheek as I show him the video. "It was a party; I had too much to drink. I just wanted to go home but he insisted I sleep it off at his place." I start. My throat dries as I recall that awful night. "I was passed out on his bed while he-"

Fury sparks in his eyes as he watches Tom climb on top of me and grope my unconscious body before pulling my underwear down.

"He fucking raped you?" Nikolai roars.

“No-one knows,” I sob, “not even James or Sam. I was too ashamed....”
My knees buckle but he holds me against him. “If
that video gets out-”

“Shh,” he whispers against my hair as he holds me closer. “I’ll take care
of it.”

I look up to him. “What are you going to do?”

He cups my face, staring down at me with so much reverence it eases the
tension in my chest.

“You know what happens to people who try to fuck with you.”

“Nik, I-”

“Don’t you worry about it baby, I’ll handle this.”

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CHAPTER SEVENTEEN



NIKOLAI

“So, Spence has really turned?” Damian asks.

He bites into a fresh slice of mango as we sit on the veranda of the estate, having breakfast.

“An associate showed me proof.” I say, sipping my cappuccino, secretly studying his reaction.

Damian Willoughby is one of the few members of Nocturne that I can almost, call a friend. Born to a family with exorbitant wealth, Damian has wanted for nothing. He enjoys his wealth. Cars, property, women. He’s determined to enjoy every pleasure a man desires. Although unlike his younger siblings, Damian works just as hard as he plays. He’s a stone-cold businessman – no-one fucks with his money. *That* is why I like him. But, trust, that has yet to be earned.

“Katherine was asking about you,” he says with a grin as he sips his orange juice.

“What does she want?” I ask, annoyed.

“She heard that you have a guest,” he laughs. “I think she’s feeling a little jealous.”

I roll my eyes as I take another sip. “She’s fucking delusional.”

Then in my periphery, I see her. My body turns automatically as I watch her run onto the lawn, dressed in a black sports bra and matching leggings. Her hair tied up in a ponytail as a pair of lilac headphones rest on her head. Every inch of her body moves so fucking perfectly.

Damian turns as he sees me pause.

“Oh my God, is that her?” he asks, his eyes widening.

I stare at the back of his head as he waves her over with a wide smile. My fists clench. Stop fucking looking at her.

Emelia walks over with a bright smile, a bead of sweat dripping down her forehead as she tries to catch her breath. My body reacts instantly as she nears.

Her breasts moving with a teasing bounce with each step she takes. The sexy curve of her waist to her hips and those delicate wrists of hers just begging to be pinned down. I want to bury myself inside of her right here. My dick begins to harden at the thought.

I begin thinking about those beautiful legs of hers wrapping around my waist as she screams my name. Those big, firm breasts bouncing just for me as I pound into her with relentless passion. I need to feel her, lick her, fuck her. Brand every single sexy inch of her until I’m in her fucking DNA.

Damian’s voice pulls me from my thoughts.

He stands quickly as she nears us.

“You’re the author, right?” he grins, moving to take her hand.

Emelia hesitates; she looks to me then back to him. “Yes, I’m Emelia,” she smiles. “I would shake your hand, but I’m sweaty after my run,” she chuckles. The sound of her laugh is a melody I could play on repeat.

“Nonsense,” Damian shakes his head as he reaches for her hand and pulls it to his lips, holding it there for much longer than necessary.

Fuck, now I need to kill him.

“I’m Damian Willoughby, and it is an absolute pleasure to meet you, Emelia.”

“You too,” she replies politely with a raised brow.

Emelia smiles awkwardly as he finally drops her hand. Then, she looks to me.

“Have you ever been to the south of France? It’s incredible in the summer, I have a yacht there.” Damian brags.

“I can’t say that I have,” she shrugs her shoulders.

“Good morning, Nikolai,” she smiles as she moves towards me and sits on my lap. She places a sweet lingering kiss on my lips.

“Good morning, Emelia,” I grin as I squeeze her thigh.

“You should join us, for breakfast,” Damian offers.

“No, I couldn’t, besides, I need a shower, then a meeting with my publisher,” she smiles.

“Oh, that reminds me, Katherine’s having some gala event at her estate this weekend. Will you be joining us, Emelia?” Damian asks.

She looks to me, unsure how to answer.

“Emelia will be accompanying me,” I reply matter-of-factly.

Her brows knit but she says nothing as she lifts from my lap.

“It was nice to meet you Damian, I guess I’ll see you at the party,” she smiles.

Damian nods with a grin. “Indeed, you will.”

I stare at Damian as I watch his eyes glued to Emelia’s body as she walks away. I begin to calculate how quickly I can move across the table and wrap my hands around his neck before Viktor could try to stop me.

“She is fucking hot,” he breathes, finally turning back to me.

“Do you enjoy your life, Damian?” I warn before picking up my cappuccino again.

He nods with a chuckle before taking another sip of his juice. “Alright man, I get it.”



On the flight to South Africa, the cabin is dim, the hum of the engines steady, almost soothing. I slip in my earbuds and pull up the audiobook of one of Emelia’s novels, *First Love*.

I want to know everything about her. Her thoughts, her secrets, her desires. I want to trace every word she’s ever written and see where it came from. Maybe then I’ll understand her more deeply than anyone else ever could. Maybe then I’ll know how to give her everything she needs.

I press play. A soft female voice begins to narrate, her tone delicate, intimate, almost confessional:

“It hit her in silence, the kind of realisation that left her breathless. She loved him. Not the safe kind of love that could be tucked away neatly behind rules and reason, but the dangerous, reckless kind that made her heart ache and her soul feel alive. She wasn’t supposed to, every story of her life had warned her against him. He was the enemy, the shadow she had been raised to despise, the name she had been taught to curse. She was born to hate him... yet every time he looked at her, the hate crumbled. In its place, something sweeter bloomed, fragile but unstoppable.”

The narrator pauses, then continues, voice breaking with a tender edge:

“She would give it all up. The safety, the certainty, the world she thought she belonged to, just to be with him. Because love like this didn’t come twice. Love like this was worth the ruin.”

I sit back, the words curling into me like smoke.

Fuck, I owe Raquel an apology.

Viktor and I land in Cape Town, South Africa in just under twelve hours. Roman insisted on coming but, Yelena needs him at home to prepare for the birth of their son. I told him to stay. I know he would never ask himself. Too stubborn. Too proud. Too much like me.

I move through the airport as Viktor collects the car; Black SUV, dummy plate. Unhurried, I pass a row of glossy storefronts when something makes me pause. A shop of curiosities, strange trinkets and darker treasures glinting in the glass.

One piece in particular draws me in. A mask. Shaped like a devil, horned, jet black, the surface swallowing light. Menacing. I lift it, feeling the weight

settle against my palms. A grin tugs at my mouth. Oh, I'm going to have a lot of fun with this.

Soon, Viktor and I are hitting the road to the annual literary festival in Franschhoek. None other than Thomas fucking Winchester would be giving a romance writing 'masterclass'.

"His fans call him Mr. Romance," Viktor chuckles behind the wheel.

Fucking gross.

"They won't be calling him anything for much longer," I smirk. "Did we secure the boat?"

He nods. "Все улажено [*vsyo ustroeno* - All arranged]."

"Good," I grin, "now let's have some fun."

The literary festival is a bustling event, spilling through the oak-lined streets of Franschhoek. Tented bookstalls rise from the ground; tables are stacked high with glossy new releases and dog-eared treasures waiting for a second life.

The unmistakable scent of coffee lingers in the air from a café nearby as laughter and lively debates echo from panel discussions tucked inside large, canvas tents.

Authors sit on shaded verandas signing books and taking pictures with fans. Emelia would fucking love this.

Viktor leads the way forward as we enter a large white tent. I'm surprised at how many seats have been filled. I had no idea so many people would willingly line up for a public lobotomy.

Thomas's voice booms from the front of the room. He moves around a small stage with a cordless microphone while he answers questions from the

crowd.

My grin widens as I finally see him in person. The pathetic little cunt who thinks he can threaten my Emelia. I move to the front of the room, taking a seat in the second row. Eyes locked on him.

He's talking about his latest book. Particularly the main character, his soldier—the grieving husband who turns his wife's bucket list into his own mission. His voice is smooth, deliberate, almost too aware of the effect it has on his audience. Laughter and wistful sighs ripple through the crowd when he pauses.

“Will there be a part two? The book ended on such a cliffhanger.” A fan asks.

Thomas laughs. “It was intended. There will not be a book two, the story ends without knowing if he completed the last item on her list. I've given the ending to each of you to let your imagination take you to the ending you desire.”

Then another question from the crowd, “Mr Winchester, I just have to say, that I love you,” the woman squeals. “Are you single?”

Thomas smirks as he eyes the crowd knowingly.

“Let's just say, it's complicated,” he chuckles.

Another question. “Are you still dating Emelia Morelli?”

My face snaps to the questioner then back to Thomas. A sly grin washes over his stupid fucking face.

“No comment,” he laughs.

Murmurs of excitement echo around the space.

“Does that mean you’ll finally co-author a book together?” A woman to the far right asks. “There were rumours that you had one in development.”

Thomas nods. “We do. Emelia and I have been working on a very special project together,” he winks.

I let out a low, mocking laugh, drawing attention. Thomas’s gaze turns to me.

“That’s fucking rich,” I chuckle.

“Excuse me...? He stares at me.

“Does Emelia know about this special project of yours?” I grin.

His brow raises. “Of course,” he laughs. “Are you a fan?”

“Of hers? Of course, but you on the other hand, you couldn’t pay me to read your regurgitated pig shit.”

Gasps and murmurs echo from the crowd. Thomas’s grin vanishes as his eyes begin to darken.

“Please tell us then, what have you written?” he asks, mockingly.

“Nothing you would ever have the privilege of reading,” I uncross my legs and lean back. Watching him lose his shit is so fucking fun.

He steps forward, jaw ticking. He eyes the crowd, just over fifty fans with wide eyes locked on him, so he watches his tongue.

“You’re not a fan, okay, then why are you here?” he presses, jaw tight.

I lift to my feet with a smirk. “To see what a pathetic little man you are. And now I have.”

I nod at Viktor before we both make our way out of the tent. Thomas’s eyes burn into the back of my head. Don’t worry Tommy, I’ll see you soon.

Darkness has fallen as it reaches 21:00. Thomas is enjoying beers and conversation with a small crowd who seem to be hanging on his every word. He finally leaves the tent and makes his way to the restroom. Perfect.

“Pull the car around, this will be quick.” I say to Viktor. I exit the car and head towards the public bathroom. A crowd still lingers but it’s widdled significantly since the afternoon.

I push the bathroom door, opening it to Thomas’s eyes finding mine in the mirror as he pisses in the urinal.

“You,” he sneers as he shakes then zips his pants before making his way towards me.

My brow raises as I close the door behind me, “you’re not going to wash your hands?”

“What the fuck is your problem?” he yells.

My fists clench. “You are my problem; you’re a rabid dog who needs to be put down.”

He moves toward me. His fist lunging towards my face. I grab his arm and drive my knee into his stomach. He doubles over, holding himself as he groans. I stare down at him and grin, “save that spunk for later Tommy, we still have a little trip to take.” I drive my fist into his face, watching as he loses consciousness.

Viktor is already waiting as I haul Thomas’s body outside and into the car. He scans the area for movement then covers his unconscious figure under a blanket.

“Ты можешь поверить, что он не помыл руки [*te mozes poverit, chto on ne vymyl rookie* - Can you believe he didn’t wash his hands]?” My brows

scrunch.

Viktor laughs then slides into the driver's seat.

We're arriving in Gaansbaai in under two hours. Pity it's the fucking dead of night or I could've enjoyed the scenery.

Thomas is still unconscious as Viktor lifts him onto the fishing boat. I didn't hit him that hard, did I? Shit.

He begins to stir as we hit the open water. His brows knit as he wakes. Nostrils twitching as the fresh ocean air hits him. "What the fuck..." he murmurs.

"Finally, you're awake. I was beginning to think this would be a wasted trip," I stare at him, leaning against the railing as Viktor controls the wheel.

"Who the fuck are you? Why are you doing this?" he yells, trying to stand to his feet.

I pummel my fist into his face, forcing him back down.

"Your reckoning, Tommy," I glare at him. "You made a big fucking mistake trying to blackmail my girlfriend."

"Your gir-" he pauses. "This is about Emelia?"

I nod with a grin as I move around, stalking him.

"I didn't know she was with anyone," he murmurs.

"She's not just with me Thomas," I pause. "She belongs to me. And when someone tries to hurt her, I need to hurt them."

He stares at me. "I don't know what she told you-"

"I saw the messages... and the video," I sneer. "I should rip your fucking head off just for that alone."

“She’s a fucking liar, she wanted it! She was practically begging me to fuck her all night then she says no as soon as I get her alone? She’s a goddamn fucking tease,” he yells.

My fists are fucking itching to crush bone and draw blood.

“You never deserved her,” I exhale sharply. My face turns in disgust to think that this cunt had the nerve to even breathe the same air as her.

“Are you jealous?” he asks mockingly.

“Yes,” I admit. “I’m jealous of any man who got to have a part of her before me. If Emelia would just give me a list, I would knock each one of you fuckers out of existence.” I grin. “But the alternative works just fine, I plan to fuck you all out of her memory until I’m all she knows. Until I’m all she craves.”

“You’re fucking sick,” he sneers.

“Am I?” I raise a brow and crouch until we’re eye level. “Is that love?”

“Wha-”

“You’re ‘Mr Romance’ aren’t you? So, tell me, is that love Thomas?” I grin.

“No,” he sneers through gritted teeth.

I lift to my feet, rolling my eyes. “Well, how the fuck would you know? You’re a rapist.”

A low chuckle rises from his throat as he sneers at me. “She fucking loved every second of it.”

My eyes narrow on him.

“She was so deliciously wet for me...” he smirks. “She fucking wanted it, you should’ve heard the moans she made when she took my co-”

I unleash my fucking anger on him. My fists connect with his face, his chest, his stomach. Punching every organ until it hurts to breathe.

Viktor flashes the boat lights into the dark water, signalling that we’ve reached our stop.

I lift Thomas by his bloodied shirt. “No-one fucks with my Emelia and lives,” I snap before pushing him off the back of the boat.

I lean against the railing with a grin as I watch him try to swim in the dark water. Viktor focuses the searchlight on him before joining me on the deck. I pull my gun, aim it at him then pull the trigger. He screams as the bullet lodges into his shoulder, drawing blood.

“Do you know where we are Thomas?” I smirk.

He thrashes around, the pain in his shoulder making it difficult to keep himself afloat. Blood pools in the water around him.

“We’re in the shark capital of the fucking world,” I continue with a laugh.

Thomas’s face falls as a large dorsal fin appears in the distance.

“You really are popular Tommy, just look at all of your fans trying to get a piece of you,” I grin as another fin appears. Then another.

Viktor laughs then mockingly tosses a floatation device into the water. Frantically, he grabs onto it as his eyes widen at the three fins heading towards him. He tries to swim back to the boat, but Viktor shoots a round of bullets into the water.

“You shouldn’t be rude to your fans Thomas,” I shake my head disappointingly. “Tell me again how wet she was.”

“Fuck you!” he yells.

The sharks swarm him. The petrified look in his eyes is one I will absolutely cherish.

In moments, large, ferocious jaws are sinking into him as he screams into the night. His body is torn, ripped, gutted as the animals’ feast on him. At least in his final moments he’s providing some sustenance to the world.

His books can fucking burn.

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CHAPTER EIGHTEEN



EMELIA

I roll my shoulders sitting in the study.

Headphones on, fingers clicking on the keyboard to the rhythm. At this pace I'll be able to deliver a completed book sooner than I anticipated. Feedback from Gretchen and the team has been incredibly positive.

Orion After Dark has already been making noise in the industry. It's launch date is only eight months away but I'm already being heralded as the headline author. The marketing teams have already developed a strategy to promote my new book, *Grimm*. A dark romance about love in death. Before Nikolai, death was something I pushed to the back of my mind, locked away with that painful memory from when I was eight years old. But he lives it. Revels in it.

He is the fucking grim reaper. A sexy, irresistible force of chaos.

I stare at my phone, waiting for a message from Nikolai.

He was supposed to come home today but his days are often unpredictable. I suppose I should get used to that.

I send him a text.

I miss you.

My brows knit as I stare at the screen, perplexed. 'No network.' Then, the lights go out. In an instant, I'm surrounded by darkness. I lift to my feet; moonlight pours through the large arched windows, painting the walls with shadows. I leave the study and move down the hallway towards the foyer.

Everything is completely dark. "Lev?" I call out.

"Maria?"

No answer. In fact, I don't hear anything at all except my heart pounding in my chest. I check my phone again, still no service.

I move towards the kitchen, opening the patio doors and making my way outside to the adjoining guest houses on the property where Lev and Maria live.

The cool, wet grass brushes my bare feet as I walk across the lawn but that's the least of my concerns right now. I reach Maria's door first. Lights are off here too. I knock against the light oak wood.

"Maria? Are you home?" I ask.

I step back, looking at the windows, waiting for movement.

But nothing. She could just be out with Zora, that isn't unusual.

I walk to the adjacent door and knock. "Lev? Are you here?"

Again, I wait for a moment, but nothing. What the fuck is going on?

My head snaps back to the estate as I suddenly feel eyes on me. I don't like this at all. What if Lev and Maria are hurt behind these doors, or worse? And I'm walking away because I'm scared?

I jump as the howl of an animal echoes from the nearby woods. My eyes are wide; my entire body is vibrating as I remain on high alert. Nikolai has enemies, I don't even know how many. What if they have been watching him? Watching me? And now they know that I'm here alone...

The sound of glass breaking sends a jolt of terror through me. My heart races. Fuck. I run back to the patio doors and lock it behind me as I stare onto the lawn. My eyes squint as a single figure appears in the dark, I can barely make him out in his black hood. But he's tall, broad and wearing a black, horned, devil like mask while the knife in his hand glints under the moonlight. "Oh my God," my phone falls out of my hand as I step away from the patio doors.

He moves across the lawn, unhurried, eyes locked on me. I pick up my phone from the ground, ignoring the network as I try to call Nikolai. Praying that the call will go through. It doesn't.

My eyes return to the stranger; he's running towards the patio doors now. I scream at the menacing sight.

This is how I die.

This is how my story ends.

My eyes frantically search the kitchen. I lift the butcher's knife from the wooden block then run back into the hallway.

"Viktor?" I scream. "Is anyone here?"

The sound of the patio glass breaking makes me trip over my own feet and fall to the ground as my entire body trembles with fear.

My eyes widen as the dark figure emerges at the end of the hallway.

I scramble, hands reaching for the knife. I grab the handle tightly before lifting to my feet and running up the stairs.

Tears well in my eyes as I stare down the hallway. Where the fuck do I go? I rush to the sitting area and open the balcony doors. I climb over the stone terrace.

My feet manage to just about fit on the narrow brick path wrapping around the floor as I press my back against the wall, walking carefully. The figure emerges on the balcony, watching me, tapping the knife against the stone as a grin pulls at his lips.

I've never been more terrified, but I keep moving. I have to.

I cry out as my footing skews, nearly causing me to fall. I turn back to the balcony. The man has disappeared. I freeze in place.

The window behind me opens and large hands are yanking me back inside. "No!" I scream as I fall to the ground.

My knife falls but I don't wait to look for it, I run out of the room into the hallway and down the stairs to the foyer. I pull on the front door, yanking it as hard as I can but it's locked.

"No, no, no!"

Footsteps echo down the stairs. The man toys with the knife in his hands as his eyes remain glued to me.

"Stay the fuck away from me," I yell. I move towards the hallway. If I can just get to the patio doors, I can get outside and run.

My feet are moving. But so are his. He grabs the back of my shirt then releases quickly, causing me to fall.

I crawl backwards as I stare up at the dark, masked man stalking towards me. "What the fuck do you want?" I shout through fallen tears.

He pauses. His fingers find the zip of his black hood; he slowly pulls it down before tossing it aside. My eyes widen as I take him in. Masked with only a pair of jeans and sneakers. His bare, muscular, tattooed chest on full display now. I sit up and swallow hard.

"Nik?" I breathe.

He tilts the mask up as he grins at me. "You're supposed to run, *milaya*."

My pulse races. "What are you doing?"

He flips the knife in his hands. "I want to play a game Emelia," he moves towards me, dropping to his knees before his lips crash into mine. Kissing me roughly, hungrily.

He cups my face. "I want you to run, so I can chase."

"Where is everyone?" I ask, breathless.

"I gave them the night off," he smirks, "it's just you and me baby."

I stare at the knife still in his hands and lick my lips.

Heat begins to rise from between my thighs as he runs the knife up my leg, over my grey sweatpants before teasing the blade at the buttons of my white shirt, snapping them one by one until my white camisole is exposed. My stiffened nipples are visible through the delicate fabric as my heart races.

"I'll give you three rounds Emelia," he grins. "First two rounds, if I catch you, I get to take off an item of clothing."

He teases the knife against my breasts.

“What happens on the third round?” I ask.

His eyes darken. “I think you already know baby, round three, I’m going to fuck you right where I catch you.”

I lift my head up to him, “and what if you can’t catch me?”

He chuckles, the sound low and sexy. “I will.”

His hand moves up to straighten the mask, positioning it back on his face. “Start running Emelia.”

My body vibrates again, but this time it’s with excitement. I lift to my feet and run back upstairs. I make it to the guest bedroom and hide quietly in the cupboard.

I hear Nikolai climbing the stairs, every footstep slow and purposeful. “Emelia,” he calls out with a dark chuckle.

I cover my mouth with my hand.

He takes a deep breath as he walks down the hallway.

“Mmm that sexy scent of yours is leading me straight to you.”

He pauses then walks into the guest bedroom. My eyes widen as his shadow passes the cupboard and checks under the bed. Then his shadow disappears. I move forward, to try and see him through the slits of the door.

The doors open abruptly as he pulls me out and pins me to the floor. Strong, rough fingers caress my lips, then my neck with tender slowness.

“What should I remove first?” He grins.

He tugs at my camisole to briefly expose my breast then his hands move down to my stomach before reaching for the waistband of my pants and

pulling them down.

He tosses it aside then holds my wrists above my head as he stares down at me in the mask. His erection digging into me through my exposed white thong. His free hand slips between us, into my underwear as he runs his fingers between my wet slit.

“No touching,” I smirk, “you haven’t won yet.”

He grins then pulls his fingers from my thong up to his lips and tastes me. “I think you better start running Emelia before I change the rules of the game.”

I wiggle free from him and move out of the room. I run down the stairs and open the door to the wine cellar in the basement. I make it a few steps but with all the lights still out I can’t see anything down here. I think better of that idea and move back up the stairs to the foyer. I barely cross it when Nikolai’s arms have wrapped around my waist. He pulls the open shirt from my shoulders and tosses it aside.

My breath hitches as I stand before him in only my thong and camisole now.

“You’ve already lost two rounds baby,” he smirks. “Why don’t you just give me that pussy now and just maybe I’ll go easy on you.”

I bite my lip as I slowly move back, shaking my head. “If you want me Nikolai,” I rasp, “come and fucking get me.” I turn to run. I move as quickly as I can, past the kitchen, through the now broken patio door and out onto the lawn.

I pass the pool, pass the helipad and run as fast as my feet can go. I don’t turn around. I can’t. If I do, I’ll see how close he is. I keep moving, the soft

wet grass brushes against my skin with each step.

A laugh rings out of my throat as his hands round my waist and he's tackling me to the ground. He holds me underneath him as he removes his belt then uses it to bind my wrists above my head. He pulls at the leather with a grin, tightening the restraint.

"Nik," I breathe.

"Uh uh, you're getting fucked by the devil tonight baby," he smirks. "Watching you run in just your underwear has made me so fucking hard," he says as he slams his erection against me.

He retrieves the knife from his back pocket and teases the blade against my exposed stomach. He then moves the blade between my breasts and tears the fabric of my camisole before tossing the tattered fabric aside. He leans back, eyes darkened as he stares at me while he removes his pants and underwear, until all he's wearing is the mask.

His head dips against my chest as his tongue laps my breasts, sucking, tugging, teasing my nipples. His hand moves between my legs, beneath my thong until his fingers are buried inside of my pussy. With slow thrusts he's working his fingers into me. Filling me while his thumb rubs my clit. I moan loudly at the exhilarating sensation.

Nikolai moans then rips my underwear off. He leans forward, his lips brushing the shell of my ear. "My mouth is already fucking watering just thinking about how I'm going to eat your sweet little pussy."

My back arches as he moves down my body. He spreads my legs as he buries his face between me. He licks me roughly, eagerly as if it's his first time tasting a woman. His lips curl around my clit as he pulls and sucks then releases before pulling and sucking again.

He licks every single inch of my pussy until I'm a broken, wet, loud mess. He pushes his fingers into me as he tenderly sucks on my swollen clit.

I cum right as his tongue continues to deliciously attack me. He spreads me wider and licks me wildly, making me cry out in pleasure and sensitivity.

"Mmm," he growls, "there's nothing sweeter than you baby."

He moves up my body. He doesn't give me a chance to catch my breath before he's shoving his hard cock into me. His hand grips my ass as he thrusts.

"Let me see those beautiful tits bounce for me *milaya*," he smirks as he thrusts harder.

"Look at you, hands tied up while I take what's mine," he licks his lips.

"Nik," I moan loudly, so loud my throat dries. The pure fucking fulfilment I feel with him inside of me is making me feral.

He thrusts harder, pounding into me, denting the ground with our bodies. "Such a good, good girl taking every inch of my cock," he rasps as he thrusts harder.

He grabs my breasts as his hips rock. He slows his movements as he angles my hips. "I'm going to fuck you on every single inch of this land if it's the last thing I do."

I feel his cock begin to throb, my pussy spasms as I'm cuming again. He thrusts harder. Rougher. Deeper. Fucking me like it's our last day on Earth. My legs are barely functioning, but he keeps going. Keeps thrusting until he squeezes my breast and fills me with his hot silky cum. His eyes roll back as his hips twitch, giving me every drop.

Nik finally removes the mask, tossing it with a grin before pressing his lips against mine. His arms wrap around my waist as we both lay naked on the grass under the glistening moonlight trying to catch our breath.

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CHAPTER NINETEEN



EMELIA

Zora graciously decides to accompany me into town.

Joining my mission to find an evening dress for Katherine's gala. Her only request was that we leave first thing in the morning to be on time for when Cardello's bakery pull their famous chocolate croissants out of the oven.

I was more than happy to oblige.

"Buongiorno, sì per favore due croissant. [Good morning, yes please two croissants]." Zora smiles, handing the cashier a crisp €20.

"This place is beautiful," I murmur as I take in the collection of photographs hung proudly on the wall. Cardello's is a family business and by the looks of it, the keys to this quaint little place have been passed through many hands.

Zora and I sit at one of the café tables outside as we enjoy our coffee and croissants.

“This might just be the best croissant I’ve ever had,” I smile, taking another bite into the flaky, buttery pastry.

Zora laughs. “I told you it was worth it.”

“You were right,” I chuckle. “Thank you for coming with me today, I don’t know where I would’ve found an evening dress at such short notice.”

“There’s a great store here, I’m sure we’ll find something,” she shrugs with a wide smile.

“Do you have a lot of friends in town?” I ask, curious.

“Kind of,” she nods, “everyone knows everyone here.”

“I live in the city, we don’t even know our neighbours,” I shrug.

“That’s quite sad,” she pauses, her bright, brown eyes fixed on me.

“Would you and your mother return to Russia, once Nikolai finds Dmitri?” I ask, taking another bite.

“We would,” she nods. “My sister just had another baby, a little girl. We haven’t seen her since we left...”

I begin to ask why when I notice Zora’s eyes lifting and catching the gaze of a young man who walks toward us. She shifts in her seat nervously as her smile widens.

“Who’s that?”

Zora blushes. “Antonio, his family owns the butchery.”

I lean back, observing her. “You like him,” I laugh.

“Shhh don’t say that so loud,” she begs as her eyes dart between him and I.

“Good morning, Zora, lovely to see you,” Antonio smiles as he nears us.

“Good morning, Antonio,” she smiles back.

“Who’s your friend?” he asks with a grin.

“This is Emelia; she’s staying at the estate. She’s a writer.”

“You’re a writer?” he asks enthusiastically before grabbing a chair from the table beside us, then sitting. “Perhaps you could help Zora, she writes beautiful poetry, but she never lets anyone see her work.”

“Is that so?” I chuckle as I eye Zora.

She shakes her head at me. “It’s just a hobby”.

“The world deserves to see you Zor,” Antonio smiles as he holds her gaze. He places his hand on hers and stares at her endearingly.

“Emelia and I have to do some shopping this morning...”

Zora starts as she pulls her hand away.

“We do but you don’t have plans for lunch, right Zora?” I ask with a teasing grin. “It’s a beautiful day, perhaps you and Antonio could meet up later?”

They turn to each other as their cheeks redden. Both dropping their gazes to the ground. It’s awkwardly sweet.

“I would love to...” Antonio finally says. “If Zora is keen.”

She smiles softly as she nods at him.

“Great, then it’s a date,” I smile. “Pick her up at 12:30, and don’t be late Antonio,” I teasingly point my finger at him.

“I wouldn’t dare,” he replies with a chuckle. “I’ll see you later Zor,” he smiles as he lifts from the table and nods politely before leaving. She watches him walk away with a soft smile.

“I hope I didn’t overstep, I was just trying to help,” I start.

Her smile widens. “I can’t believe I have a date with Antonio!”



We walk through the town centre until we find a boutique store with a small selection of evening dresses. I manage to find a simple, elegant red silk dress. Ideally, I would have chosen a more neutral colour, but the lovely little store does not offer much of a selection. Red it is, I guess.

As we make our way back to the car my eye catches an envelope resting against the passenger-side window. My brows furrow as I near it. My name is written in large black ink on the front.

“Emelia maybe you shouldn’t,” Zora warns as I lift the envelope.

I scan the car park, eyes falling on everyone near us, but no-one stands out. I decide to open it. Inside is a plain white card with a handwritten note:

The next one goes in you.

An object moves in the envelope. A bullet. My pulse races as I try to steady my breath.

I turn to Zora, forcing a smile, not wanting to scare her. “We should head back.”



It really is a beautiful day. Warm with a gentle cooling breeze. Nikolai’s not home yet, so I decide to take a swim, trying to ease my mind after that unsettling note left for me this morning.

I walk out onto the pool deck in a pink bikini, feeling very Barbie-esq as I ease into the crystal-clear blue water. I make my way to the tray Lev has placed on the edge for me with a Piña colada and rest my bookbag beside it.

My phone rings, pulling me from my thoughts. A video call from Sam. I answer with a smile and prop the phone up against my glass.

“Emmy! Wow, Italy seems to be treating you very well babe,” she teases.

I smile. “It’s incredible here.”

“I can see that,” she laughs then playfully sticks her tongue out, “looks like Nikolai is taking good care of my baby girl.”

I chuckle and drop my voice to a whisper. “He’s so fucking gorgeous; I literally lose my mind around him Sammy.”

“Yes! I’m so glad you’re finally getting out there again.” She claps her hands.

“Have you heard from Dante since...?” I ask, tilting my head.

“Since your boyfriend beat the shit out of him?” Sam laughs. “Don’t worry, James managed to diffuse the situation.”

I exhale, relieved. “I’m really sorry about what happened, could you tell him if you see him again?”

She chuckles. “I will, although from what I’ve heard, he’s exploring the Amazon jungles for his new book, so I doubt I’ll hear from him anytime soon.”

“Oh, that reminds me,” she exclaims, “did you hear what happened to Thomas?”

My eyes widen. “What happened?”

“He just fucking disappeared,” she replies. “He was at a literary festival in South Africa then, he vanished.”

I swallow hard. This was Nikolai... and he did it because I asked.

“I will never understand what the fuck you saw in him.”

“I honestly don’t know either...” I reply as my mind drifts.

I snap back to reality when I hear a light splash behind me. I turn to see Nikolai in his sexy, bare chested glory walking towards me with a mischievous grin.

“Holy fucking shit, is that him?” Sam exclaims.

I turn back to her. “I’ve got to go; I’ll chat to you soon.”

“Wait-” she starts.

I end the call before she can get another word in.

“Fun chat with your friend?” He asks as he nears me, his voice low and seductive before pressing a kiss to my lips.

“Samantha is one of my best friends,” I nod. “She was just checking in on me.”

Nikolai moves forward; his hand gently curls my waist under the water while the other lifts my glass curiously before smelling the drink.

“Seriously?” he chuckles.

“Don’t judge me,” I laugh.

He puts the glass down with a smirk and tightens his grip on my waist.

“This is an interesting choice of swimwear, Emelia.”

“Do you like it?” I grin.

His smirk widens as his gaze lingers on my chest then returns to my eyes. “Is this for me?”

I shrug my shoulders with a laugh. “Mmhmm, I just know how much you like pink.”

Nik chuckles. “I like you in pink,” his hand slowly drops to my hip. “I like you more out of it.” He pulls at the string of my bikini, exposing my left hip. His hand rounds my hip before dropping lower to the curve of my ass.

“Did you find a dress for tonight, baby?” he asks, his voice low and rough.

I nod softly. “I did.”

He drops his gaze to my neck, then he slowly pushes my hair aside. He moves closer, with only an inch between us, he rubs the spot of sunscreen I missed. His large hands begin massaging the lotion into my skin, pressing into my tense shoulder. My eyes close and head tilts automatically at his touch. A soft moan escapes my mouth.

He leans his lips toward my ear. “Now what did I tell you about moaning like that Emelia...” He whispers.

I swallow as our eyes lock. I reach for his chest, running my fingers over the hot wet ridges of his muscles, tracing the shapes of his tattoos. His grip tightens around my hips, pulling me closer as my hands move lower, over his taut, hard stomach.

“I have to tell you something,” I start. “Something weird happened today.”

His brows furrow. “What happened?”

I exhale sharply then reach for my bookbag and pull out the envelope.

“Someone left this for me,” I say, handing it to him.

His jaw ticks as he stares at the note, then the bullet. He tosses it aside and pulls me to him, holding me close. “Someone’s trying to scare you,” he says, brushing his thumb against my cheek, “but I’m going to find them before they can even think of trying something like that again.”

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CHAPTER TWENTY



EMELIA

Anxiety swirls in the pit of my stomach.

Standing in the centre of my room, staring into the floor length mirror as I prepare for the gala. The dress fits my body perfectly. A floor-length, low neck, silk dress in Venetian red. The delicate fabric hugs my hips and waist before falling elegantly at my feet. James would absolutely approve.

I brush my hair into loose curls, then finish the look with a pair of gold, teardrop earrings. The gold shimmers in the light as I do my makeup. I spritz a gentle misting of my favourite perfume as I finish the look with a pair of strappy black heels before I finally make my way down the stairs towards the foyer.

Nikolai is already waiting for me. He looks excruciatingly gorgeous in his all-black suit. A loose strand of dark hair falls across his forehead as he watches me. We lock eyes as I make

my way down the last few steps. He walks forward with a devilish grin as he reaches his hand out and guides me down.

“Emelia,” he starts, his voice low and provocative. “You look... incredible, baby.”

His eyes roam my body unashamedly as he slowly walks around me, drinking in every inch of my body.

“You don’t look too bad yourself, Nikolai,” I bite my lip as I check him out too, his chest tattoo peeking through the open collar of his shirt. The rich, sexy scent of his cologne is already igniting a fire between my thighs. We would have so much more fun staying in.

Nik grins then heads toward the front door, opening it for me. Viktor stands ready at the car and holds the passenger door of the black Ferrari F80 as the SUV waits patiently behind.

“It’s okay Vik, it’ll just be Emelia and I tonight.” Nik says as he takes the key.

Viktor nods and takes a step back, closing the door behind me as Nikolai slides into the driver’s seat beside me.

The engine roars to life, my stomach flutters as we leave the gates. Watching as Nik accelerates down the long, dark road.

“You, okay baby?” He asks as he glances my way, resting his hand on my thigh.

I nod with a smile. “Just feeling a little anxious.”

He exhales sharply. “I need to warn you, about Katherine...” he starts. “She has a fixation, with me. And because of that, she might act, cold towards you.”

My brow raises, “did you...?”

“Fuck no,” he sneers. “But she’s the head of a very powerful organisation, which means I have to play nice,” he replies. “No matter how much I fucking hate it.” He takes my hand to his lips and kisses my knuckles. “But she won’t be an issue for long, I promise.”



Soon, Nikolai and I are arriving at Katherine’s estate. The car glides up the long gravel drive, tires crunching softly as the villa comes into view. Warm amber light spills from a row of antique lanterns, each one casting delicate halos across the manicured hedges and stone pathway. The villa itself rises like a dream—its honey-coloured walls aglow, tall cypress trees standing as solemn sentinels against the evening sky.

At the grand entrance, liveried servers wait in perfect formation, silver trays of champagne flutes glittering in the lantern light.

Guests step from sleek cars in silks and tuxedos, laughter and the murmur of conversation floating into the night. The air carries the faint scent of jasmine from the gardens mingled with the sharp chill of freshly uncorked bottles.

Nik exits the car first, his expression sharp and composed. The valet reaches for my door, but Nik stops him with a simple and firm, “No.” He then rounds the car with authority, tossing his key to the valet before he opens my door himself, and holds out his hand out to me. I place my hand in his with a smile.

He guides me through the entrance of the villa, then down a short hallway before we’re in the foyer. Whispers and intrigued looks follow us as we make

our way inside.

He leans into me, dropping his voice, “do you know what they see when they look at us, baby?”

I turn my gaze to him with a curious smile.

“Power,” he grins.

Nik’s hand remains firmly on my waist as he greets guests passing by.

“Nikolai, I’m surprised to see you here,” a tall, handsome man moves towards us with a raised brow as he reaches for Nik’s hand.

“I couldn’t exactly say no when Katherine is practically my neighbour now,” he complains. “Emelia, this is Zeek Siphokazi.”

I shake his hand with a smile as he gestures forward. “It’s a pleasure to meet you Zeek.”

“You as well Emelia,” he smiles before turning to Nikolai. “I trust your trip to Cape Town went well,” he grins.

Nikolai chuckles. “Very well, thank you again for letting me use the boat at such short notice.”

My brows scrunch.

Zeek smirks. “Let me know if you ever feel like fishing again Nikolai,” he pauses, leaning forward, “I would be very happy to join you.”

Nik nods with a knowing grin. Zeek turns to me, then smiles before disappearing into the crowd.

I turn to Nik with a raised brow. “Do I want to know?”

He chuckles, wrapping his arm around my waist. “Probably best if you don’t.”

“Nikolai!” Damian chuckles as he walks towards us with a glass of dark liquor in hand. “You came! And you brought the lovely Emelia with you,” he grins. “Sei assolutamente incantevole [you look ravishing].” He takes my hand to his lips.

“Just showing my face, so Katherine doesn’t make an issue of it,” Nik replies as he watches him slowly return my hand to me.

“Speak of the devil...” Damian starts as he turns to face a woman walking our way.

Katherine Alexander knows how to make an entrance. That is made very clear within the first five seconds in her presence. She’s older than I expected, early fifties, blonde hair styled into curls, draping her exposed shoulders. She wears a strapless cashmere dress in the shade of royal blue. Large diamond chandelier earrings hang from her lobes as she moves toward us with a grin.

She squeezes Damian’s arm then places her hand on Nikolai’s chest as she moves to kiss his cheek. “Nikolai, I’m so glad you came.” She smiles, her British accent thick.

I already hate how familiar she acts around him. She touches him as if she has a right to... She turns to me with a raised brow then back to Nik. “And who is this?”

“Emelia,” I reply firmly, “I can answer for myself.”

A smirk grows on Nikolai’s lips. “My girlfriend.”

Katherine does not hide her disdain at the word. Her jaw ticks as she stares at me. I don’t believe she’s just ‘fascinated’ with Nikolai; this woman

is downright obsessed.

“You’re the author,” she finally says, forcing a smile.

“I am,” I nod. “And you are?”

Laughter rings from her throat. “Katherine Alexander, this is my home,” she pauses, “well, one of them.”

She turns her attention back to Nik and runs her fingers over his chest as if to prove a point. “I need to speak to you Nikolai, you’ve been avoiding me,” she says, her voice low and seductive.

“I’ve been busy Katherine,” he glares at her as he removes her hand.

“It’s about Spencer, we’ve found him, and he had some very interesting things to say,” she says as she tilts her head. “We need to talk,” she pauses, looking to me then back to Nik.

“Privately.”

Nikolai’s glare intensifies.

“I’ll keep Emelia company,” Damian offers, trying to ease the tension. “I promise, she’s in good hands.”

Nik gives Damian a sharp, pointed look then turns to me. “I won’t be long.”

I nod solemnly and watch as Katherine wraps her hand around Nik’s arm as she guides him to a private room down the hallway. She turns around and glances at me with a dark grin before closing the door behind her.

“Champagne?” Damian smiles as he reaches for two glasses from the nearby waiter.

“Thank you,” I force a smile as he hands a glass to me.

I glance towards the door where Nikolai disappeared. I want to barge in there and rip Katherine away from him by her bleached hair.

“Who’s Spencer?” I ask, curious.

Damian chuckles. “Why do you ask?”

“Katherine mentioned him. Is he, one of you?” I press.

“He was,” he replies as he finishes his drink. “But word is, he’s working with Dmitri.”

“Nikolai’s explained to me how your, circle, works, so if Spencer is meeting with Dmitri does that mean he loses his membership?” I ask, unable to abate my curiosity.

“I suppose that would depend on Katherine’s mood,” he shrugs with a chuckle.

I scrunch my nose at his answer.

“Oh, before I forget, I have a gift for you,” Damian grins as he swiftly changes the subject.

“A gift?” I repeat, confused.

He pulls out a small green box from his pocket, handing it to me. Willoughby name embossed in gold on the front.

“Damian, I can’t accept this,” I shake my head. Hands raised as though he just offered me a severed head.

“It’s not romantic, I swear,” he laughs. “Nikolai and I are friends, and I hope you and I can be too.” He opens the box to reveal a beautiful gold chain with an emerald pendant. “This was mined in Zambia, it’s meant to bring good health and good fortune,” he smiles.

“I shouldn’t...” I start.

“I won’t take no for an answer Emelia,” he smirks. “It’s rude to turn down a gift.”

I shake my head with a chuckle as Damian places the box in my hand. “I have to mingle,” he winks before joining a conversation nearby.

I sigh as I look to the door again. Still closed. What the fuck is she doing in there with him? I swear to God if she tries something, I’m going to forget my manners and unleash years of pent-up aggression on her. Never before have I felt this close to anger. Not even through years of teasing and bullying. ‘Be the better person, Emelia’ no, fuck that, I’m tired of the disrespect. Nikolai is mine just as much as I am his. And if anyone tries to get between us then they deserve to feel my wrath.

I place the little box in my purse and walk through the clumps of party guests until I find myself on the terrace overlooking the view of rolling hills ahead. I breathe in the peace of the outside air as I take in the scenery.

I squint my eyes into the distance. Holy shit, my entire body burns as I realise that I can see Nikolai’s estate from here.

What a fucking psycho!

“All alone Emelia?” Katherine’s voice startles me as she walks with a martini in hand.

“Where’s Nikolai?” I ask, my tone even and sharp.

“Busy,” she replies with a grin as she lifts a glass to her lips.

She stares at me for a moment. Eyeing me up and down.

Using her silence as a weapon to try and intimidate me.

“How long have you two been an item?” She finally asks, the threat in her tone unmissable.

“Why?” I tilt my head with a frown. “Does it bother you?”

She laughs. “Not at all, darling. I like to keep a close eye on my members. Make sure they’re in, good hands.”

“He’s not interested in you Katherine,” I stare at her. “Using your position to corner him into private conversations with you is pathetic.”

She stalks towards me, her grin vanishing instantly.

“You better watch your mouth, Emelia; you have no fucking idea who I am or what I’m capable of.”

“I know exactly who you are,” I pause, moving toward her, “you chase after men who wouldn’t give you the time of day if they didn’t have to.”

She scowls, clenching her fist as she begins closing the gap between us. “Perhaps it’s time you return to your little fantasy world, while you still can.”

“Emelia, let’s go,” Nikolai says, his voice sharp as he steps out onto the terrace.

I turn to him, his eyes blazing and wild as he glares at Katherine.

She grins at me as I begin to walk away, towards the safety of Nikolai’s arms. “Have a good night, Emelia,” she says, lifting her glass, “I’m sure I’ll be seeing you soon.”

Nik holds my hand firmly as he briskly leads the way out of the party, toward the car. He doesn’t waste a moment taking off and driving us back to the estate.

“What did she say to you?” he asks, his expression serious as his eyes

remain fixed on the dark road.

“Nothing I wasn’t expecting,” I reply flatly.

He turns to me.

“I can handle the likes of Katherine Alexander,” I add.

Nik exhales sharply. “I’m sorry for putting you in that position.

I needed to show my face, to avoid questions...”

I straighten in my seat and turn to him. “Do you know that she has a view of your estate from her balcony?”

Nik’s brows furrow as he shakes his head. “I didn’t know that.”

“I don’t like her...” I confess, staring out of the window with a pout.

He rests his hand on my thigh, squeezing gently. “Don’t worry baby, I’m taking care of it.”



As we finally reach the estate, I rest my head against the cool leather seat, watching Nik as he pulls into the garage. He’s so fucking handsome. The kind of handsome that makes the world stop and stare in awe of him.

He kills the engine then turns to look at me.

“You look absolutely beautiful tonight baby,” he grins.

He lifts my hand to his lips, placing a warm, lingering, soft kiss on my fingers.

Gently, he pulls my hand closer as he places a kiss on my wrist, then down my forearm to my elbow. He inches higher with a grin as he kisses my bicep, then my shoulder.

His beard bristles against my skin with delicious roughness, heating my core and making my stomach flutter.

Nik licks his lips then moves closer; the warmth of his breath caresses my neck.

Then, his lips. Then, his tongue.

I breathe in his cologne. I've never smelled anything sexier. It's intense and commanding, hints of sandalwood and nutmeg pull me under his dark spell.

His hand slips behind my back, wrapping his arm around me before pulling me closer while he kisses and nibbles on my neck.

"That feels so good," I moan.

He cups my face as he presses his lips against my cheek, then my jaw. Soft, wet, warm kisses. His beard, rough and sexy continues to brush against my skin.

My breath hitches as he moves his lips up the slope of my neck again, breathing me in until his lips hover dangerously close to mine. We stare at each other for a long moment as he brushes his thumb over my lips. "You take my breath away, *milaya*."

Finally, his lips meet mine. He opens my mouth with his and caresses his tongue against me. His lips taste like expensive whisky. I moan as he bites my bottom lip with a wicked grin. "Come here, baby." In one fluid motion, he pulls me onto his lap. His hands round my ass as I straddle him.

"Oh my God," I moan as I feel his cock harden against me. I wrap my arms around his neck and kiss him, deeper, rougher. He squeezes my ass and rubs his erection against me.

“You make me so fucking hard,” he growls against my neck.

His tongue flicks against mine as he lifts the hem of my dress above my thighs and exposes the curve of my pussy underneath my black lace panties.

“So, fucking sexy,” his voice low and rough as he licks the slope of my neck as he begins pulling down the straps of my dress until my breasts are fully exposed to him. His large hands cup my breasts as he teases and sucks on my nipples.

“Nik... I need you,” I moan.

“I fucking love how you moan my name,” he growls.

My hand reaches for his belt, unfastening it as he lifts my dress. His fingers curl beneath my underwear then with one sharp rip, they’re destroyed.

I pull his zip and reach my hand into his pants, palming his erection as my eyes pour into him.

“I wanted to rip Katherine’s hair out when she touched you,” the words falling out of my mouth.

Nik’s grin darkens. “I would love to see that.” He moves forward, pressing his lips against me. “Were you feeling possessive baby?”

I nod. “Seeing women throw themselves at you make me feel...” I tug his underwear down, freeing his hard cock.

“Tell me,” he murmurs, his eyes dark with need.

I lift my hips, positioning his tip against my core before slowly sinking down, “violent.”

Nik’s head falls back as he enters me. His hands round my ass as I ride him, slowly, reverently. His eyes are ablaze, tearing into me, as mine are to

him. As if we're seeing into each other's souls. Fucking in the darkness of them.

His fingers rest at my thighs as he watches me, relinquishing all control. A grin pulls at my lips as I stare down at him, having Nikolai completely under my spell burns a fire inside of me. A fire I didn't know existed.

My head falls back as I sink lower.

"Oh yes," he growls. "Take all of it baby, it's yours."

My hips grind against him slowly, angling myself to increase the delicious tension against my clit. I wrap my arms around his shoulders as I ride him.

His thumb grazes my clit with every bounce.

"You are so fucking sexy," he moans.

I lean forward to kiss his lips as I bounce harder. I feel my orgasm coming, my legs tremble as my walls tighten.

I drop my head on Nik's shoulder as my body vibrates with release. I lean back and lift Nikolai's hand to my mouth, sucking his fingers as I continue to ride him.

He leans forward, eyes dark, his hand moves to grab the curve of my ass before he thrusts up into me. I cry out at the sensation. The fullness. He tightens his grip on my ass as he fucks me harder. He nips at the skin of my neck as he cums, filling me, drowning my pussy in every drop of him.

He cups my face, his eyes pouring into me as we steady our breath. "I love you, Emelia."

A soft gasp escapes me. I stare at him, unsure if I misheard.

He brushes his thumb against my lips as if he's reading my thoughts. "I love you," he says with a smile. "I've never said those words before, to anyone... But you are my heart baby," he presses a soft kiss against my lips. "You're my world, I am completely" kiss, "absolutely," kiss, "devoted to you, *milaya*."

I wrap my arms around his neck. "I love you too, Nikolai. My heart is yours. Only and always yours."

He presses his lips against mine, kissing me softly, sweetly. The kind of kiss that burns itself into memory. One of souls bonding for an eternity, filled with warmth, certainty, and the quiet promise of forever.

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CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE



NIKOLAI

I stand over Victoria's grave with a bouquet of lilies.

My heart feels lighter than it's ever been. Emelia is the centre of my world, she consumes my mind, my heart, my fucking soul. I am absolutely and unequivocally in love with her. A love I don't deserve but pursued anyway. Funny how the concept felt so fucking foreign to me just months ago. Then a beautiful creature stepped into my office and breathed life into me, she's changed my entire world. Now, everything is for *her*.

I stare down at the headstone; Victoria would joke that it would take a special woman to make me an honourable man.

She was right about that. Emelia is a rare jewel, and I plan on cherishing the fuck out of her.

"Nikolai..." Father Vitaly smiles as he walks through the cemetery, hands clasped in front of him. "It's good to see you, even better to see your good mood hasn't faded."

I nod with a smile before kneeling to place the flowers on the grave.

“I’ve been meaning to discuss something with you Nikolai,” he starts.
“As you know we’ve begun construction on the playground.”

I nod. “I’ve heard so.”

He pauses, staring at me intently. “Could I show you?” he asks.

Curiously, I nod.

Vitaly leads the way down the cobbled path. We walk beside the church to the playground, behind the recreation hall.

I still, staring at the large wall mural separating the playground and the chapel.

“As you know, Victoria donated some of her beautiful paintings to the church.” He pauses. “I bambini amano guardare i suoi Fiori durante la scuola domenicale [The children love looking at her flowers during Sunday school].”

A smile pulls at my lips as I take in the large mural of Victoria’s wildflowers. “Since the bake sale was such a success and with that anonymous donation,” he grins at me, “we were able to hire an artist to recreate her painting.”

I step forward.

Very little moves me.

But this is pulling at my fucking heart. “Victoria would have loved it,” I manage. “Thank you.”



I toss a towel over my shoulder as I make my way to the gym. I grin at the sound of light footsteps on the treadmill. It widens as soon as I see her.

Her back is to the door; she runs so gracefully. Hair bouncing, hips swaying. She wears a zipped up black long-sleeved top and charcoal leggings. She's a fucking wet dream.

I place my towel and water bottle on the bench which finally catches her attention. She slows the machine and removes her headphones. "I didn't hear you come in," she smiles.

She hops off the treadmill and takes a sip of her water. A single drop falls down her chest. My eyes follow the rivulet as it travels between her breasts.

Then *it* catches my eye. A gold necklace with an emerald pendant. Fucking Willoughby crest carved right in the centre of it.

"Why are you wearing that, Emelia?" I exhale sharply as my smile disappears.

She frowns, closing her water bottle then reaches for her neck.

"Oh, you mean this?" She asks, lifting the pendant. "It was mined in Zambia, isn't it beautiful?"

My blood fucking boils. I told Damian to stay away from her, now he's gifting her jewellery. He's fucking dead.

"Take it off." I demand.

She freezes as she stares at me. "What-"

"Take it off Emelia," my words bite the air, unable to mask the agitation in my voice as I stalk towards her.

She moves backwards as her eyes widen, her feet trip over the floormat. She falls, staring up at me.

“Why?” She shakes her head, confused.

I kneel over her. Her back presses flat into the mat as she looks up at me with wide eyes.

I stare down at her, cheeks flushed pink, chest rising and falling as her pulse races. She is so goddamn sexy.

I reach for her zipper and slowly pull it down, exposing the swell of her perfect breasts, then her stomach. I hold her wrists down firmly on either side of her as I demand her gaze. Her beautiful, honey brown eyes remain fixed on me.

I lick my lips before I lean down and kiss her bellybutton, her smooth skins smells of that peach bodywash she loves.

I run my tongue up her stomach then move slowly between her breasts, then up to her neck.

“Oh my God,” she moans, as she arches her back, pressing her chest into me.

I clench the necklace between my teeth and tug it roughly, breaking the clasp. I stare down at her, then spit the useless fucking chunk of gold on the ground.

“You don’t ever wear another man’s jewellery, do you understand?” I say, my voice low and rough as I tighten my grip on her wrists.

She nods softly and reverently in response.

I settle on top of her, letting her feel how fucking hard she’s making me. “You’re mine, Emelia.” I run my fingers up her arm, over her breasts before

wrapping my hand around her neck as I lean down and brush my lips against hers. “I think you need another reminder, *milaya*.”

I lick my lips before placing a kiss against her soft, sweet, sexy little mouth. Her legs widen, giving herself to me. Letting me feel the sensual heat begin to radiate from her pussy. Driving me fucking insane.

I place a hand behind her head, then kiss her again, deeper, rougher. “I can’t keep my fucking hands off you,” I growl against her ear before teasing the skin of her neck between my teeth.

I slide my hand over the curve of her breasts, tugging her stiffened rosy nipples between my fingers. My dick is rock fucking hard, begging to be let free. Begging to be inside of her.

She moans again. The sound is like fucking ecstasy.

“I need to fuck you baby,” I whisper against her skin as I grind against her.

I move lower and tuck my fingers beneath the waistband of her leggings before pulling it down to her knees, along with her underwear. My cock throbs as I breathe in the scent of her sweet, heated pussy.

Emelia’s mouth falls open with a soft breath as my fingers touch and part the folds of her bare, smooth cunt. I lean forward, holding her gaze as my mouth explores her pretty slit. I part her thighs wider and suck on her clit, my mind frenzied at how wet she is for me.

She cries out as I press my tongue into her, lapping up her delicious juices. A low growl escapes my lips as I feel her pussy begin to spasm with my tongue inside of her.

Emelia stares at me with need burning in her eyes. “Nik,

I'm going to cum."

I lick up her slit, wiggling my tongue between her as she trembles. God, I could eat her pussy all fucking day long if she would let me.

I reach for her breasts and squeeze as my face stays buried between her soft thighs. I tease her clit between my lips then twirl my tongue around it before sucking on her again.

Emelia moans loudly as she cums, tightening her thighs around my head as she writhes with pleasure. Her sweet nectar drips down her thighs making me lose my fucking mind. I move up her body, returning to her lips as I begin to pull down the front of my pants.

She cries out as I shove my cock inside of her. I fucking love it when she does that.

"You feel so fucking good baby," I moan as I thrust in and out of her. I tease her bottom lip between my teeth as her legs widen for me.

She gives me her pussy so willingly, so eager to take me and I love it. I grab her breasts and thrust harder, watching them bounce just for me, solely for my pleasure.

"Oh God Nik," she moans.

I reach for her wrists and pin them above her head to hold her down as I increase the pace; she's going to be sore tomorrow. I want her to miss me with every ache and twinge between her thighs.

Emelia moans louder as I pound her pussy. I press my lips against hers as I finally cum, pushing my tongue into her mouth as my cock throbs and spills deep inside of her.

I lick up her neck as her body trembles, her face flush as her pussy continues to spasm. I release her wrists and move lower to her breasts, flicking my tongue over her nipples as I slowly pull myself out of her.

We both still as we hear voices and footsteps down the hallway. Fuck. I exhale sharply as I pull up her leggings and underwear then zip her top. I lean back, pull my pants up and hold out my hand to her, as we lift to our feet.

Viktor enters the room. “Nikolai, we need to leave in thirty-minutes,” he says swiftly, before leaving again.

I adjust my pants as I look at Emelia, cheeks flush, lips swollen, trying to catch her breath.

I pull her towards me and wrap my arms around her waist. “I have a few meetings, out of town. I’ll be gone for a day or two,” I say before placing a kiss on her lips and lifting her onto my hips to hold her. “I’ll be back as soon as I can, I promise.”

She wraps her arms around my neck with a bright smile, “you better.”

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CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO



NIKOLAI

Roman and I have a meeting with Suoh Murata.

Suoh's a well respect, fellow member of Nocturne and long-time business associate. Our black SUV rolls to a stop outside the gate of his estate in Shirokane. Very little impresses me, but even I pause to marvel at the stunning architecture. Modern with timeless Japanese elegance.

I step out of the car, adjusting my cuff as my eyes sweep the grounds. Clean lines, silver finishes and stone pathways lead to a pristinely manicured garden. My father always said, the way a man looks after his home tells you everything you need to know about him.

The front door opens before we can knock.

“Welcome to Tokyo, Nikolai,” Suoh says smoothly as he greets me with a firm handshake.

He nods at Roman as he gestures for us to come inside.

“Your home is beautiful Suoh,” I say, crossing the threshold.

“My wife deserves the credit; she styled every inch of this place before her passing,” he replies with a soft smile.

“Thank you for inviting us into your home, we would have been happy to meet at your office but this, is a very kind gesture,” I nod.

A grin pulls at his lips. “We’ve known each other for almost a decade now, and I believe the trust has been sufficiently earned.”

I nod in agreement.

Suoh runs a tight ship. As do I. Our mutual interest in arms dealings might have made us enemies, but working together became far more beneficial.

Suoh’s family is Yakuza, a fact he’s tried to conceal from his business circles. To them, he is like me, an heir to their family’s vast empire. And like me, he rules his empire with power and fear. You don’t cross Suoh Murata and live to tell the tale.

“Papa,” a little boy runs into the room and hugs at Suoh’s legs.

“Watashi no musuko da yoi [there’s my boy],” he smiles down at him before picking him up. “This is my son, Kazuya,” he says proudly as he turns to me.

“It’s a pleasure to finally meet you Kazuya,” I say, smiling at the little boy. He looks identical to Suoh, jet black hair and striking brown eyes.

I gesture to Roman to open the package we brought with us. “I heard it was your birthday; I’ve brought you a gift,” I smile.

Kazuya’s eyes light up as Roman hands him a box wrapped neatly with a bright blue bow.

“Papa, open,” he says shaking the box excitedly.

“I’m so sorry, Suoh, he heard your voice, and I couldn’t stop him,” another voice appears. I turn to see a pretty, young woman with long auburn hair and piercing green eyes walk towards us with a bright smile. Suoh’s smile is even brighter as his gaze stays fixed on her.

“That’s okay,” he chuckles. “Nikolai, this is Callisa, Kaz’s nanny.”

I nod my head to her.

“I’ll take him,” she says as she wraps her hands around Kazuya’s waist and pulls him into her arms.

I study Suoh carefully as he watches her walk away.

Fucking the nanny? How interesting.

We sit in Suoh’s office as Roman presents the plans for the construction of the weapons armoury in Prague. Our shared project.

“I’m impressed Nikolai, I didn’t imagine the construction could be accomplished so, swiftly.” He says as he sips his whisky.

“My men are the best; there’s nothing they can’t accomplish,” I grin.

“I see so,” he lifts his eyebrows. “September is a good month.”

“We break ground in September with expected completion in early December.” I nod.

Suoh laughs. “You really are ten steps ahead aren’t you, Nikolai?”

“Always,” I smirk.

Suoh lifts the glass to his lips.

“I heard Damian’s in town,” I start. “Do you know where he is?”

He glances at his watch. “He asked for a boxing session with Kenji, they should be wrapping up within the hour.” His eyes lift to me. “You’re meeting with him?”

I grin. “I am now.”



Kenji’s gym is where legends are forged. Countless artful MMA fighters and hardened boxers have passed through these doors. The hallway walls are lined with autographed photos—men who bled and sweated across this mat, laying the foundation for the next generation.

I step onto the gym floor in sweatpants and a T-shirt; no need to ruin a suit. My eyes lock on the ring. Damian is inside, throwing limp punches into Kenji’s waiting hands. Kenji looks bored out of his fucking mind.

I stare at the sight with a grin. “Is that really the best you’ve got, Damian? My housekeeper throws tougher punches.”

His eyes snap to me. He shakes his head with a chuckle. “Nikolai, I didn’t know you were in town.” He continues throwing punches.

I move towards the ring, stepping through the ropes. “I’ll take over Kenji,” I say as I nod to him.

“What are you doing?” Damian asks, confused.

I fix my stare on him. “How the hell are you sweating when you’re barely moving?” I raise my palms; he just shakes his head and starts throwing

punches. Jesus—weak as hell.

“Endurance training,” he mutters with a shrug.

I stare at him, letting him punch.

“You and I are friends, right Damian?” I start.

He pauses, staring at me. “Of course.” He throws another punch.

“And friends are honest with each other, correct?” I press.

He nods, brow raised.

“Good,” I grin. “Then tell me why the fuck you’re giving my girlfriend jewellery?”

Damian freezes as his eyes lock onto mine. I drop my hands as my stare burns into him.

“Nikolai, it was just a small gift...” he murmurs, taking a step back.

I tilt my head. “Do you think I can’t give her gifts?”

He shakes his head. “No, fuck, I didn’t mean it like that. I was fucking wasted, it was stupid...”

I stalk toward him. “You crossed a line.”

He moves back, “Nikolai, I’m sorry, I won-”

I grab his arm, yanking him towards me then drive my fist into his stomach.

Damian falls to the floor, holding himself as he groans in pain.

“You know me Damian, you know better than to fuck with me,” I snap. “Don’t ever fucking give her gifts again.”

Damian moves to his knees as he continues to whimper.

I stare at him, then reach my hand down. His eyes grow wide as he stares at my open hand suspiciously. He relents, and takes it, allowing me to help him up.

“Let’s never have this conversation again, do you understand?” I growl, staring at him.

“I apologise,” he nods, “it won’t happen again.”



Roman and I return to the hotel. He presses the button for the penthouse as I check my phone. I open the feed to the security cameras at the estate until I find her. My Emelia, working in the study. God, she is so fucking beautiful. The way sunlight hits those big brown eyes of hers. The way her entire face lights up when she makes progress on another chapter. I’m counting down the minutes until I can return home.

Until I can hold her.

Breathe her in.

Listen to her talk my ears off about her characters.

Fuck, I miss her.

We’re greeted by the sounds of chatter and laughter as we arrive on the penthouse floor.

“Nikolai,” Maksim says as he raises a glass to me. Maksim Draganov is my official second in command. I trust him to lead my men while I stay in Tuscany as we hunt Dmitri. Next to Roman, I trust Maksim with my life.

He’s brought four of my men from Moscow with him. Igor, Raf, Sergei and Ulan.

“брат [bratt - Brother],” I smile as I walk towards him and pull him in for a hug.

Maksim pats my back then pulls away with a grin.

“Так много итальянского солнца, Николай. Я почти принял тебя за модель [tuck mnogo italiansky solntsa, nikolai. ya pohti prinala tebya za model - So much Italian sun Nikolai. I almost mistook you for a model].” He jokes as he squeezes my arm.

“Ваша жена не жаловалась [vasha zhen a ne zalovalas - Your wife hasn't complained].” I grin, making the men chuckle.

I pour myself a glass of whisky and sit on the couch.

“How was the meeting with Suoh?” Igor asks, staring at me intently.

“прошло очень хорошо [proshlo ochen khorosho - Went very well]. He’s approved the plans which means we can start construction as planned.” I reply smoothly.

“That’s great news!” Sergei smiles.

I nod my head then turn to Raf who’s unusually quiet. “Что у тебя на уме? [o cham te dumaes - What’s on your mind?]” I ask, curious.

Maksim clears his throat and shakes his head at me.

“What?” I press.

Raf looks to me and forces a smile. “We killed Andrei last week.”

I pause as I stare at him. Andrei was one of Dmitri’s men.

I inhale sharply as I let it sink in. Before Dmitri turned against me, we were close, best friends, brothers. His men and mine had bonded as brothers too.

“Я не начинал эту войну [ya ne nachinal etu voynu - I didn't start this war]...” I say.

“We know Nikolai, and we want vengeance for Victoria. It's just hard to kill the men we once called brothers...” he replies.

A knock at the door interrupts us. Roman raises a brow as he looks to me. I nod for him to answer.

“I understand that what I've asked of you is not easy, and I appreciate your loyalty,” I say as I hold Raf's gaze.

“Nikolai wasn't expecting you,” Roman says as he holds the door open.

“I know but this couldn't wait,” Katherine says as she walks in.

Christ, this woman is like a fucking curse.

“What the fuck are you doing here Katherine? How did you find me?” I raise my voice, lifting to my feet as I stare at her incredulously.

She walks in with her head of security, Nelson, holding a messenger bag.

“You weren't answering my calls Nikolai and I'm afraid this couldn't wait,” she says as she moves towards me.

“It's about Dmitri,” she adds, with a serious look. “It's best we discuss this in private.”

I clench my fists as I stare at her.

I turn and lead the way to the office where Katherine, Nelson, Maksim and Roman join me.

Katherine sits before I invite her to.

“What couldn’t wait?” I ask, as I sit and glare at her.

She nods to Nelson who opens the messenger bag and sets a file on my desk with a USB.

I open the folder as I stare at her. I pull out a set of photos, documents and bank transfers. I look through the photos. Images of Dmitri Baranov and James Fields, engaged in secret conversations. Another document, text messages between them, discussing where to meet. Then the bank transfers, large sums of money being paid from Dmitri to James in exchange for information on me.

“What the fuck is this?” I demand.

Roman moves behind me and lifts the images to take a closer look. “Is this James?” He asks as his brows knit.

Katherine nods. “My people took those images a few days ago Nikolai.”

I shake my head. “That’s not possible.”

“I’m afraid it is, he’s working for Dmitri... and Emelia-”

“Don’t you fucking dare!” I slam my fist on the desk.

“She can’t be trusted Nikolai, they’re setting you up,” she replies.

I stand. “Get the fuck out Katherine!”

She stares at me as she lifts to her feet. “I’m only trying to protect you, soon you’ll realise that I’m right.”

“Get. The. Fuck. Out.” I sneer through gritted teeth.

Nelson looks at me with anger flooding his eyes.

“You’re feeling brave? Do it,” I challenge him.

Katherine places her hand on his arm. “There’s no need for that.” She turns to me. “I’ll expect an apology, Nikolai. I’m only looking out for you,” she says before walking out with Nelson close behind her.

I turn to Roman who looks through the bank transfer documents. “Do you think these are real?” He asks.

“I wouldn’t trust anything Katherine says, have Luka look at these,” I instruct him.

I turn to Maksim. “Find James Fields, if these turn out to be legit, then I want answers. Do you understand?”

“I do.” He replies with a nod.

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CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE



EMELIA

Maria hums as she stirs her lavender tea.

The gentle rising curl of steam fogs her glasses which makes her giggle. I tilt my head as I watch her with a smile. The silver spoon taps lightly against the porcelain as she adds a generous dollop of honey. Her movements are slow, relaxed, as if time itself waits for her.

Maria is beautiful, the kind of beauty that can't fade with time. A beauty that settles in the soul. The fine lines around her eyes and lips tell a story of a life lived with laughter and joy. She radiates a beautiful, soft light that can't be dimmed. And I need to know more.

“Thank you for spending time with me today, Maria, I really appreciate you doing this.” I take a sip of my own tea as I smile at her. Earl Grey with a drop of lavender and vanilla.

“It’s my pleasure dear, although I’m not sure what help I can offer, my life isn’t as exciting as it once was,” she laughs.

I shrug with a chuckle. “I guess we could start with how you came to work for the Kirovsky’s? If that’s okay?”

The question makes Maria smile, her eyes drift toward the window as she stares into the flower garden, drenched in the afternoon sunlight. She grins, as if her mind quietly begins to replay those memories.

“I was so young back then, times were very different. Not as many options for women,” she starts.

“Is that why you took the job as a housekeeper?” I ask, curious.

“Yes and no, my aunt, Olena was the housekeeper for the family before me. They always paid her very well and when she needed help after Nikolai and Victoria were born, I was happy to step in,” she adds.

A grin pulls at the corners of my mouth as an image of a young Nik appears in my mind. “So, you’ve known Nikolai all his life?”

“I have,” she pauses. “I’ve seen all the heartbreak and all the pain, mostly at the hands of people who were supposed to love him.”

I nod solemnly.

“Some days were better than others,” she continues. “Nikolai is a really good man; he’s always been very kind to me and my family. He looks after us. He’s made sure that we’ve wanted for nothing.”

“What happened to Zora’s father, if you don’t mind me asking?”

Maria turns her gaze to the window again. I watch as her expression dims. Her mind becomes lost in thought.

“Ivan was the love of my life...” she starts, her voice hoarser.

“How did you meet?” I watch her intently as I sip my tea.

“He worked for Aleksei; he helped him with security and other matters that we won’t talk about.”

“I understand,” I nod.

“Ivan was magnificent. The most beautiful man I had ever seen. As soon as I met him, I knew,” she grins. “We married not long after, then we welcomed our daughter Zasha and then Zora. Zora was a surprise,” she chuckles. “We had been trying to give Zasha a sibling but after ten years we all but gave up. Then, Zora came. We were so happy...” she says, wiping a tear from her cheek.

“We don’t have to talk about it if it’s too upsetting,” I say, placing my hand on hers.

Maria shakes her head. “My Ivan deserves to be remembered. We were married for thirty-two years, every year on our anniversary he would bring me a bouquet of sunflowers, my favourite,” she smiles as her gaze drops to her cup, she pulls it to her lips for a sip before she continues.

“As the years passed by, Nikolai felt that it was in Ivan’s best interest to step away from security and take on a roll as a driver. Ivan protested at first, he was stubborn like that,” she chuckles. “But Nikolai could see how his body had begun deteriorating after so many years in this life. He did him a kindness and let him keep his pride.”

I inhale sharply as Maria continues, my eyes fixed on her.

“It was supposed to be a quick trip, collecting Victoria and Erik from a gallery show...”

I gasp. “Ivan was driving the car...?”

Maria nods. “He was killed with them... When Nikolai found them, Ivan was holding onto a bouquet of sunflowers... the last one I would ever receive from him.”

Tears well in my eyes. “Maria, I’m so sorry...”

She smiles through her own tears. “Oh darling, it’s okay. One day, my Ivan and I will be reunited and all the time we spent apart will be erased from our memory.”

I wipe the tears from my cheek. “Can I hug you?”

Maria nods with a small laugh. I embrace her with a tight hug, my tears falling on her shoulder. “Thank you for sharing that with me.”

Maria wipes her face with a tissue as she takes another sip of her tea to calm her nerves. “Life can be so beautiful and yet so cruel...”

I nod, wiping the tears from my cheeks.

“What made you decide to become a writer, Emelia?”

I chuckle at the question. “My parents were a big factor,” I settle back in my chair. “My father was a novelist, as you know, and my mother was a children’s book author.”

“That’s lovely,” she smiles.

“My mom would bring me along when she held readings at bookstores. She was really popular, there were always large groups of kids just sitting and

staring at her with wide little eyes as she read her stories,” I chuckle. “They loved her.”

“Sounds like this is what you were born to do,” she tilts her head with a warm smile.

I nod. “I think so, I’ve always loved writing and storytelling. The world can be such a dark place, I just wanted to create a safe space in a world of my own.”

“I think that’s beautiful,” she says, holding onto my hand.

“Your parents would be very proud of the woman you’ve become, Emelia.”

My throat dries. “Thank you.”

Maria lifts from her seat as she rinses her mug. I open my journal to make my notes when I glance at my phone. Several missed calls from Sam. I call her back immediately.

“Sammy? What’s going on?” I ask, confused.

She sniffles through her words. “It’s James, he was attacked. I’m with him at the hospital now. He has a broken nose and bruising on his ribs,” she manages before bursting into tears. “It’s bad, Em. He has a concussion. I don’t know what the fuck to do.”

“Oh my God,” I gasp, lifting to my feet. “What happened?”

“He says it was Nikolai’s men,” she pauses, “they would’ve killed him if a police car hadn’t been driving nearby.”

“No, no, no Sam that can’t be true... Why would Nikolai do that? He wouldn’t!” I protest.

“I don’t know,” she sobs, “he’s still out of it...”

I burst into tears as my knees buckle. “Oh my God.”

“You need to come home, please,” she begs. “James needs us.”

I nod my head as I wipe my tears, taking a deep breath to calm my nerves. “I’ll leave on the first flight out of here.”

Sam exhales. “Be safe, okay. And text me when you land so I can pick you up myself.”

I nod. “I will.”

Maria’s eyes drown in concern as she stares at me. “Are you okay Emelia?”

I nod as I call Nikolai. “I’ll be okay.”

I walk out of the kitchen to the study as the phone rings.

“Hi baby,” he answers, his voice soft and warm.

“Tell me it’s not true Nikolai...” I start, my voice trembling.

“What’s not true?” He asks, concerned.

“James is in the hospital. He said you sent your men after him...” I cry.

He pauses.

“Emelia...”

“Did you do this?” I press. “Please, please tell me that you didn’t...”

He pauses again as he exhales sharply. “They weren’t supposed to hurt him...”

Time slows as air leaves my lungs. “Nik, how could you do this?” I yell as tears fall.

“Emelia please, just let me explain-”

“No! There’s nothing to fucking explain! James is like my brother; he’s the most loyal person on the fucking planet!” I shout as tears flood my eyes. “You hurt me when you hurt him.”

“Baby, I’m sorr-”

I end the call before Nikolai can say anything else. I trusted him, he knows how much James means to me and he hurt him anyway. God you’re so fucking naïve Emelia! James warned you to stay away from him and now you’ve put his life in danger.

I turn my phone off as Nikolai continues to call and text.

I run up the stairs and quickly begin to pack my suitcase.

I need to leave.

I need to go home.

I need to see James.

Tears fall down my cheek as I picture him weak and helpless in a hospital bed. I reach for my laptop and book the first flight out of here. Five hours, that should be enough time to get the airport. I book the taxi service then drag my suitcase hastily down the stairs.

“Emelia, where are you going?” Lev asks, concerned as he rushes towards me.

“I’m leaving, Lev.” I reply abruptly as I pull open the front door.

“Nikolai won’t like this,” he says, voice riddled with caution.

“I don’t care what Nikolai likes,” I snap. “I’m going home.”

I drag my suitcase behind me as I walk down the long driveway, seeing an old grey Honda waiting for me behind the gate. The driver is an older

man, mid-fifties. He doesn't speak English but that's the least of my worries right now.

He packs my suitcase neatly in the trunk as I settle into the backseat. I can't give myself time to consider if it's a good decision or not. I need to be with James. I need to go home.

I allow my eyes one last look at the estate before we drive off.

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CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR



NIKOLAI

I drive my fist into the seat after Emelia ends the call.

She is so upset, so fucking hurt. That tremble in her voice makes my heart ache.

Roman and I sit on the private plane, waiting for take-off. “What the fuck has Maksim done?” I yell.

I receive a notification, an email.

From: Luka N

To: Nikolai K

Ran the documents KA shared. They’ve been doctored.

No credible link between JF and DB. FYI. Picked up surveillance of her men sniffing around the Prague site.

I fucking knew it! That hateful bitch!

I dial Maksim, I need answers right fucking now.

“Nikolai,” he answers after two rings.

“What the fuck happened to James Fields? You were supposed to talk to him, not put him in the fucking hospital!” I yell.

“I know Nikolai, I’m sorry, the men got carried away. James apparently gave them attitude when they were questioning him...” he starts.

“I don’t give a fuck how much attitude he gave, he was a trusted associate, and you were meant to question him only.”

“Nikolai, I-”

“Enough, I need to fucking fix this now.”

I end the call and turn to Roman. “Tell the pilot we need to change course. I need to see James Fields, immediately.” Roman nods before heading to the cockpit.

I run my hand over my face. What a fucking mess. Emelia is so angry with me. I need to make this right.



We arrive in town in just a few hours. Roman already has a car waiting for us at the airport. We would arrive at the hospital in under twenty minutes. Giving me time to think about what the fuck I’m going to say to James.

“Как скоро Марк сможет получить подарок [cack scor0 marck smozhet poluchit podarok dostavkoy - How soon could Mark have a gift delivered]?”

I ask Roman.

He smirks. “Зависит. О чем ты думаешь [zavisit. o cham te dumaes - Depends. What are you thinking]?”

I call Mark and place him on speaker. He answers in two rings.

“Nikolai, to what do I owe the pleasure?” His voice firm but polite.

“Mark, I need a gift for a friend. Something that can be delivered within the hour.”

“Uh,” he pauses, “what kind of a gift are we talking about Nikolai?”

I smirk. “The kind on four wheels.”

“Oh,” Mark chuckles, relieved. “That can definitely be arranged. What budget do we have to work with?”

I tilt my head. “Mid six figures.”

Roman chuckles.

“Hmm,” Mark breathes. “We just got in a beautiful cherry red SF90. Straight out of the box. Would that work?”

“That’s perfect,” I nod. “I’ll text you the delivery address. Thank you, Mark.”

“Always a pleasure, Nikolai.”

I turn to Roman as I end the call. “What?”

“Nothing,” he laughs as he shakes his head.



I fucking hate hospitals. That antiseptic smell makes my stomach turn. Death and decay linger within its walls, unwelcome and unyielding.

I walk toward the nursing staff sitting at the front desk, each of them eyeing Roman and I with wide eyes and wider smiles.

“Good afternoon, ladies,” I grin. “We’re looking for a friend of ours, James Fields. I believe he’s on this floor.”

The nurse in front of the computer screen leans forward with a shy smile. “He’s in room 503,” she sweetly replies.

I wink at her. “Thank you.”

Roman leads the way as I follow slowly behind. I glance into each of the rooms we pass.

Young.

Old.

Sick.

Some patients lay in beds with the warmth of their families around them while others lay in eerily quiet rooms, eyes fixed on the window, staring out into the world.

Roman opens the door to room 503. James’s eyes widen with fear as he sees us. There’s someone with him. A woman.

“Nikolai-” James starts as he straightens in the bed.

I lift my hand. “James, this was a complete misunderstanding. I’m here to personally apologise to you.”

His brows furrow as he stares at me.

“Your men almost fucking killed him,” the woman snaps through gritted teeth.

“Sam,” James shakes his head at her. “Don’t.”

I exhale sharply. “She’s right, this was unacceptable. A complete overreaction. This will never happen again; you have my word.”

“I appreciate you coming Nikolai,” James replies with a nod.

“Thank you.”

“Where is Emelia?” Sam presses, anger and concern etched on her face. I pause as I stare at her. I don’t like her fucking tone at all. How dare she ever insinuate that I could hurt my *milaya*.

“Emelia’s great,” I force a smile. “In fact, why don’t you two join us next weekend at the estate. Then you and I can hopefully resolve this matter, James,” I offer.

He nods. “That’s very kind of you Nikolai. Samantha and I would love to.”

“I-” she starts.

James shoots her a stern look.

I grin at her and move around the bed until I stand in front of her, taking her hand into mine. “You have every right to be upset; this will not happen again, I can assure you of that.” I turn to James. “As a token of my remorse I have left a gift for you, outside of your apartment.”

“That’s not necessary, Nikolai,” he says.

“It is, I hope that you will forgive this mistake and that we can move past this,” I smile. “I value your partnership, James.”

He nods. Samantha still looks unsure, but I don’t fucking care.

I walk towards the door before turning to them one last time. “I look forward to seeing you both soon.”



Maksim calls while we're on our way home. Thirty minutes until landing.

“Мужчины подтвердили, что Кэтрин отправила своих людей в Прагу [muzhchiny podtverdili, chto catrin otpravilla svoikh ludey vieu prago - The men have confirmed that Katherine sent her people to Prague].” He starts.

I clench my fist. “Что они хотели [chego oney khoteli - What did they want]?”

“Они задавали вопросы о строительстве и о том, кто его разрешил [oney zadavali voprosy o stroitelstve you o thome, kto ego razreshil. - They were asking questions about the construction and who authorised it],” he exhales sharply.

“Did they recognise the men?”

“Нельсон и двое других, которых мы уже раньше видели [nelson you yeshchyо dvoye, kotorykh my ransze videli - Nelson and two others we've seen around before],” he confirms.

“If any of her men ask any more question, take care of it,” I instruct.

He pauses. “Nikolai, are you sure?”

“Katherine's ego has grown out of control; it's beyond time that she gets reigned in.”

“I understand,” he replies.

“I'll take care of Nelson,” I add. “Meet with Suoh to let him know about these latest developments. I'll need his vote when the time comes.”

Maksim nods. “Я буду [ya boudou - I will].”

I tap my fingers absentmindedly on the arm rest as I ponder all the ways I can teach Katherine a lesson. Her father would turn in his grave to see what's become of Nocturne. A nearly two-hundred-year-old organisation build on immense power, turned into a shell of what it once was all for Katherine's fucking vanity.

I need to be strategic; I need the members to agree to vote her out. And that, will not be easy.

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CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE



EMELIA

The little grey Honda hobbles down the long road.

I stare at my phone, 3% battery. Shit.

“How much longer until we get to the airport?” I ask.

“One hour,” the driver replies with a smile.

Ugh, he said that thirty minutes ago.

I lean back and take a deep breath trying to calm my nerves. Sam had texted me to let me know that James is okay and awake, but I need to see him. I need to be with him. It’s my fucking fault that he’s been hurt.

I don’t have time to think about it when the car suddenly jerks forward, and smoke begins to rise from the engine.

“Merda [shit]!” The driver shouts. He hops out of the car and carefully lifts the hood as he tucks his hands protectively into his sleeve.

This can’t be happening. I’m in the middle of fucking nowhere with a stranger who barely speaks English. Good job Emelia. When they write your obituary, they’ll be sure to mention how fucking stupid you are.

I jump out of the car. “What’s going on?” I ask him.

“Il motore è rotto [the engine is busted],” he huffs as he quickly pulls his hand away from the burning metal.

“I don’t understand, sir. Can we get to the airport?” I press, desperate.

“Need to tow,” he says slowly.

Shit!

“How long will that take?” I ask. “My flight leaves in three hours.”

“Maybe one hour,” he replies.

Fuck, I know what that means. I glance down the stretch of road. Not a single car in sight. Nothing beside wide stretches of green grass and grazing wildlife.

“Is there anything nearby? I really need to charge my phone.” I wave it at him.

He nods his head. “Gas station,” he points down the road. “Twenty-minutes.”

I exhale sharply then nod. I move to the trunk and retrieve my luggage. “I’m just going to walk.”

He’s still fiddling with the engine as I make my way past him and down the road. What the fuck is my life right now.



I haven't made it thirty minutes into the walk when it starts to pour with heavy rain. Thankfully, I can see the gas station coming up ahead.

I walk faster, awkwardly pulling my suitcase as one of the back wheels has started to loosen. I finally reach the door of the gas station and pull on it. Locked. Shit. I bang on the door in frustration. "Hello? Is anyone here?" I yell. No answer.

Shit! Shit! Shit!

I look around the property, for any signs of life. But nothing. Not a single damn person. I notice a bus bench on the side of the road, it looks like it hasn't been used in years, but it's the only form of shelter in the rain.

I sit on the bench, praying for someone to pass. I open my bag and pull out the only hoody I packed. I slip it on over my clothes then sit on the bench and wait.

In about thirty minutes, I spot a car, the first I've seen all day. I wave it down as it drives on the other side of the road. It stops and turns around, slowly driving towards me.

The passenger window drops. Three young men sit in the car blasting music on the radio.

"Sei persa, bella signora [Are you lost, pretty lady]?"

"I'm sorry, I don't speak much Italian." I reply. "I need to get to the airport. Could you help me?"

The driver kills the engine with a widening grin. I take a step back, swallowing hard as the hairs on the back of my neck begin to rise.

“Oh, you’re lost?” he says, “we can help you.”

He smiles as he exits the car and stalks towards me, his two friends following closely.

“I’m... I think I’ll just wait...” I reply. My body trembles as they continue to walk towards me.

Rough hands quickly grab at my suitcase, forcefully ripping it from me. “No please, I don’t have any money,” I beg.

“That’s okay, we don’t want money...” the driver grabs his crotch as he winks.

“Please leave me alone,” I beg as I continue to back away. My heart thunders in my chest as tears begin to flood my eyes. I blink them away as I watch their every move.

The driver lunges forward, his fist cracking against my face with brutal force. I hit the ground hard, my arm scraping against the gravel, pain slicing through my skin. My lips are wet. My hand shoots up instinctively. Blood. The metallic taste spreads as I scramble back on my hands, pulse hammering, tears streaking my cheeks. The three men close in, their shadows stretching toward me like predators.

A blue truck suddenly appears down the road, driven by an older farmer. Stopping immediately, he lifts his hand out of the window, raises his gun, and fires a shot into the air.

“Come,” he yells, gesturing for me to get in.

I hop into the truck as the farmer holds the door open. The men run and yell after us, throwing stones, one striking the back window as we speed off.

“Non dovresti camminare da solo [You shouldn’t be walking alone],” he scolds as he turns to me.

I burst into tears. “They took my luggage; my passport, my laptop.”

He exhales sharply. “I can take you into town tomorrow,” he says.

“Can’t we go now?” I plead.

“The roads are flooded. It won’t be clear until morning,” he replies.

I shake my head as tears continue to fall down my cheeks.

“My wife makes a delicious, chicken soup,” his voice softer now. “We have a room which you may use tonight, and I can take you into town tomorrow.”

I nod, “thank you.”



We soon arrive at a small farmhouse. Its red wooden shutters creak softly as they sway in the wind. He exits the truck first and opens a bright yellow umbrella as he reaches for my door and helps me out. We walk quickly to the front door; my white sneakers are drenched in mud. I apologise as I wipe my shoes on the welcome mat, trying not to drag any of the sludge in with me.

An older woman walks towards us with a confused look on her face as we make our way inside.

“Era bloccata. Quei punk stavano causando problemi di nuovo, hanno preso i suoi effetti personali [She was stranded. Those punks were causing trouble again; they took her belongings].”

“Oh no, povero Tesoro [Oh no, poor dear],” she says as she walks towards me with a smile.

“La porto in città domani mattina [I’m taking her into town in the morning].” He replies.

“What is your name?” She asks, her voice soft and sweet.

“Emelia,” I reply with a nod.

“I am Angela, and this is my husband Roberto,” she smiles.

I nod. “Thank you for helping me.”

“Are you hungry?” She asks.

My stomach growls for me.

“I take that as a yes,” she chuckles.

“Our daughter’s old bedroom is yours for the night, Emelia. We can leave first thing in the morning,” Roberto says as he rounds the dining table and takes a seat. The house is small but inviting.

Warm.

Cozy.

And clearly lived in, though it’s obvious they don’t have much.

“What were you doing at the gas station?” He asks.

“The cab I was in broke down along the road. I was just trying to charge my phone. Speaking of... do you happen to have a charger?” I ask, knowing I might be pushing my luck.

Angela nods. “In our daughter’s room, you should find one there.”

“Will your daughter be joining us?” I ask, curious.

Roberto chuckles. “No, Selene married a few weeks ago. Finally, after twenty-five years, she’s out of our hair.”

Angela nudges him with a giggle. “He teases. He cried like a baby at her wedding.”

“She was my baby,” he says softly, squeezing Angela’s hand and pressing her fingers to his lips.

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CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX



NIKOLAI

“Are you sure you want to do this?” Roman asks.

I nod. “It has to be done.”

We need to make a stop before returning home. Luka confirmed that Katherine is away for the evening, entertaining her latest boy toy of the week. Fucking pathetic.

Nelson, and a few of his men, reside at the estate with her. It’s a quiet area, which is why I fucking chose it.

Luka hacks into the security system, turning the cameras off as we arrive. This will be a swift operation.

Just Roman and I.

Like the old days.

The large black gates open for us. A confused guard rushes towards the car as we pull up to the courtyard. I exit with a grin.

“Mr Kirovsky, we weren’t expecting you. Miss Alexander isn’t-”

Roman presses his gun against the man's head and pulls the trigger before he can finish his sentence.

“Нам нужно, чтобы Максим убрался [nam nuzno, chtoby maksym ubral vsyo - Do we need Maksim to clean up]? He asks.

I shake my head. “I want her to find them.”

I step over the body and up the stairs to the front door.

Classical music plays as we cross the threshold. How fucking obnoxious.

Two guards lift from the couch and quickly rush towards us. I raise my gun. Click. Click. One bullet to the head and another to the throat. I walk over to the guard who holds his hand to his throat as blood gushes out.

“Where is Nelson?”

Blood pours out of his mouth as he tries to speak.

“Nik,” Roman points to the ceiling, to the sound of footsteps moving across the room.

Roman walks first, up the stairs, leading the way towards the sound of moans coming from behind a door. He opens it quietly.

Nelson Kyle, long-time head of security for the Alexander's, is laying in Katherine's bed, wearing what I assume to be one of her silk, floral gowns while he jacks himself off.

“What the fuck is this?” I chuckle walking into the room.

“Nikolai!” Nelson exclaims as he tries to cover himself. “What the fuck are you doing here? How did you get in?”

Roman grins as he walks around the room and picks up Nelson's gun, emptying the clip as he drops the bullets onto the floor.

“It’s incredibly rude to have your business interfered with, wouldn’t you agree?” I raise a brow, my tone dripping with condescension.

“I don’t know what you-”

“You were the one who paid the contractors to bug my home, Nelson,” I reply coldly.

“I don’t know what you’re talking about,” he averts my gaze.

“You’re a terrible liar,” I grin.

“Nikolai we can talk about thi-”

“Why were you sniffing around in Prague?” I press, my voice low and firm.

“You know the rules, when members partner on projects it has to go through Katherine,” he insists.

I laugh. “Fuck Katherine.”

He pauses; his brows raised in confusion. “You break the rules, you’re out. You know that!”

I move forward. “Katherine crossed the line by invading my privacy. And not to mention, coming for Emelia’s friend. That calls for retribution.”

“If you lay a single hand on me-”

“Then what?” I grin.

“Katherine has very powerful friends, she can destroy even you,” he smirks.

“Is that so?” I laugh. “Katherine’s days are fucking numbered.”

Nelson stares at me. I see the wheels turning behind those dead fucking eyes of his. He tries to run. Stupid.

Roman drives his fist into his stomach, forcing him back onto the bed.

“Fuck you Nikolai,” he spits as he cradles his stomach in pain.

I grin as I point my gun to his head, “You’re not my type.” Click.

I exhale as I turn to the open balcony door. Curious, I walk onto the terrace and look into the distance. My jaw twitches as I see my house, clear as fucking day. A pair of military grade binoculars tucked away between her patio furniture.

“Psychotic bitch,” I whisper under my breath.

I turn to Roman. “Пойдем [Let’s go].”



I rub my forehead as we finally return home, bracing myself for a scolding from Emelia, knowing that I deserve every word. I can’t blame my men for roughing up James, we don’t ask questions politely, that’s not how we operate. I should have given clearer instruction; the blame falls on my shoulders.

Lev opens the door. “Good evening, Nikolai,” he says politely.

“Evening Lev, where’s Emelia?” I ask.

He hesitates. “Miss Morelli has left,” he replies.

I stare at him. “What are you talking about?”

“She packed her bag and decided to leave earlier today. I tried to stop her, but she wouldn’t hear it,” he explains.

WHAT THE FUCK!

I rush up the stairs, clearing two steps at a time. I run down the hallway to my bedroom. The quiet stills me. I move towards the walk-in closet. My heart sinks as I take in the empty racks. Her perfume still lingers in the air, but she's gone.

My Emelia is gone.

The pain in my chest begins to swell as dark thoughts start to take over. The thought of never seeing her again, never holding her again, never kissing her again.

The thought of her hating me...

I love her, I love her with every-fucking-thing inside of me. I can't lose her. I won't!

I need to get her back.

I need her to never fucking leave me again.

I hurry to my office and turn on the security feed. I rewind to earlier in the day. I watch as Emelia hastily enters a beat-up, shitty Honda before it quickly takes off.

I dial Luka immediately as Roman joins me.

"Nikolai," he answers.

"I need you to find Emelia, she got into a taxi around 14:36. I need to know where she is right now," I demand.

"Logging into the security system now," he confirms. Then a

moment passes. "I ran the license plate of the car, and it looks like it was booked into a local mechanic about two and half hours after she was picked up."

“Check the flight logs,” I command.

“Already on it, there’s no record of her taking a flight today,” he confirms. Thank God.

I turn to Roman. “где, черт возьми, она? [gde, chirt vozmi, ona - Where the fuck is she]?”

“I found something,” Luka starts. “Camera feed from a gas station.”

He plays a video. I watch Emelia, tired, wet, desperately knocking on the door of the abandoned gas station, then sitting on the bus bench as the rain falls.

“I know where that is,” Roman starts.

“Keep watching,” Luka adds.

We soon see a car with three men pass her then turn around and stop beside her. I clench my fists as I watch them walk towards her, the look of fear on her face makes my chest heave. My fingernails poke into my skin, cutting into flesh as I watch them rip her suitcase from her then one steps forward and throws a punch at her, causing her to fall to the ground.

Air finally fills my lungs when an older man in a truck stops. She quickly gets in, then drives off with him.

“I need the address of the man in the truck Luka,” I manage as I exhale sharply.

“Already on it and sending to your phone now.”

“Those three men, I need their addresses too,” I command.

“Understood.”

I move quickly down the hallway and grab my keys. I dart off with Roman driving separately, closely, behind me.

The roads are rough, littered with debris from the rain and strong winds. I bang my hand against the steering wheel as I think about Emelia being hurt. Desperate for help. I will never forgive myself if anything happens to her.

I race towards the farmer's address. Roman pulls up behind me.

“Позвольте мне разобраться с этим [dai mne se ethym spravitsya - Let me handle this],” he insists stepping in front of me. He recognises the look in my eyes. The look that doesn't wait to ask questions.

Roman knocks on the door as I take a deep breath to calm myself down. I don't want to knock! I don't want to be polite! I want Emelia! I want her to come back to me, where she fucking belongs!

Finally, an older man answers the door. “Posso aiutarti [Can I help you]?” He asks.

“We believe you've taken in a friend of ours,” Roman replies. “We'd like to bring her home.”

The old man scans at us cautiously. “Perhaps you should come back in the morning,” he says.

I fucking lose it. I push by him and make my way through the house looking for her. I walk up the stairs and open the doors until I reach one on the far end, I feel her before I open it.

My shoulders relax as soon as I see Emelia laying in the little bed, safe,

asleep.

I rush towards her and fall to my knees beside her.

“Emelia, I’m so fucking sorry baby,” I start, my voice hoarse.

I run my hand over her cheek and through her hair.

Her eyes flutter open at my touch. She jerks back as soon as she sees me.

“What are you doing here?” She asks, a tremble in her voice. I fucking hate that. “I’m here to bring you home.”

She shakes her head. “I’m not going anywhere with you! You almost had James killed, Nikolai!”

“It was fucking Katherine,” I explain, “she tried to set James up.

She told me that he was fucking working with Dmitri.”

She stares at me incredulously. “And you just believed that?”

“She had proof Emelia,” I beg. “I had to look into it.”

“You didn’t even give him a chance to defend himself before your men attacked him!” She yells.

I drop my head. “I know baby, and I’m so sorry.” I exhale sharply, “I’m going to make this right. Let’s go home.”

She shakes her head again. “Fuck you. I’m not going anywhere with you!”

I stare at her as my anger begins to boil. “You’re not fucking staying here, Emelia.”

“I’m not going back with you, Nikolai. I’m getting on the first fucking flight out of here.” She shouts as she lifts to her knees.

“I’m going home!”

I exhale sharply before standing to my feet and stare down at her. “Your home, is with me.”

I reach for her, tossing her over my shoulder as she protests. Her fists pound into my back as she yells for me to let her go. After this stunt, she’s never leaving my fucking sight again.

I carry her down the stairs. The man and his wife stare at us with deep concern etched on their tired faces.

“Please don’t hurt her,” the woman begs as she starts to move forward. Her husband holds her arm to keep her back.

“She will not be harmed, I assure you this is just a lovers quarrel,” Roman smiles.

“Oh, fuck off Roman,” Emelia snaps.

I nod at him before carrying her out to the car.

I open the door and place her on the passenger seat. I yank the seatbelt over her and strap her in tightly as she glares at me. I don’t give a fuck that she’s angry. She can shout and struggle all she wants. She doesn’t belong in this fucking place. She belongs with me, and I’ll be fucking damned if I let her leave again.

I slam the door shut before sliding behind the wheel.

Emelia stares out the window into the open door of the living room, watching as Roman hands the old couple an envelope.

“Are you going to hurt them too?” She asks, a tremble in her voice again.

“Of course not,” I turn to her, “that couple just became very wealthy thanks to you.”

She stares at me as her brows knit. I start the car then quickly take off.

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CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN



EMELIA

I lift my knees to my chest as I stare out of the window.

Nik pulls the car into the garage with a sharp exhale. He kills the engine then stares at me intently. I pull away as he reaches for me.

“We need to go inside,” he says flatly.

“No.”

“Emelia...” he glares at me, his tone harsher.

I turn to him. “I said, no!”

His jaw twitches as he takes a deep breath. He then pushes open the driver door and slams it closed behind him. The force makes me jump. I don’t want to be under the same roof as him. I will sleep in the car if I have to.

He opens the passenger door and lifts me out forcefully.

“Put me down!” I yell.

“You need to fucking listen when I speak to you Emelia, then I won’t have to do this,” he yells back.

We get caught in the downpour as he carries me to the front door. He finally puts me down and holds my wrist tightly as he guides me upstairs to his bedroom. He pulls me into the bathroom then begins to fill the bathtub with hot water.

“Get in,” he commands. His voice low and rough.

What the fuck?

“No!” I snap.

“Emelia, get in the tub,” he says, moving towards me.

My anger boils over. I push at his chest as hard as I can; he barely moves. “You can’t treat people like this Nikolai!” I shout.

He catches my wrists and moves closer, his face inches from mine. “Get in the fucking tub before you get sick,” he yells.

I yank my wrists free and glower at him.

I reach for the waistband of my pants, pulling it down then tossing it at him. Then my t-shirt. Then bra, then panties.

Throwing each piece of clothing at him until I stand naked. My entire body is heated with anger and frustration. He stares at me. His chest rising and falling.

“Why do you care to do this Nikolai? Does it amuse you to hurt me?” I manage, fighting back tears.

“Emelia...” his voice softens.

“I thought you loved me... How fucking stupid am I? Because how could you when you hurt the closest person to me...” a tear falls down my cheek.

He moves forward, carefully at first, until he’s right in front of me. In an instant, he falls to his knees and drops his head, holding his hands out to my hips but not touching me.

“I’m so sorry,” he says, his voice lower, softer. “I’m so fucking sorry.” He lifts his head slowly, brows furrowed as he stares at me. His eyes filling with hurt and remorse. “Please forgive me. I need you to forgive me.”

“Nik, I...”

“Baby, I swear, I will do everything in my power to make this right. Please, please forgive me Emelia...”

I move my hand through his hair. His eyes close at my touch. He finally places his hands on my hips and pulls me closer, pressing his cheek against my stomach as he wraps his arms around me. He holds me for a long moment before finally lifting to his feet. He wraps his arms around me.

“When I found out that you had left, my entire world crumbled around me. You’re burned so deeply within me that not even an eternity could erase you.” His voice low and soft.

I stare at him as he brushes my hair from my shoulders, letting it fall down my back.

“I love you, Emelia. I fucking love you.” He places a soft gentle kiss against my lips as he wraps his arm around my waist and holds me tightly against him. “You are everything, my life, my world, my only fucking reason for breathing. I am yours, only yours, forever.”

My breathing steadies being in his arms, I look up at him as he brushes his thumb over my lips before kissing me again, softly, reverently.

“Marry me...”

My eyes snap up at him.

“I refuse to live with the thought of a life without you, I would chase you to the ends of the fucking earth. I would travel through the depths of heaven and hell to make sure our souls remain tied together for eternity,” he breathes. “Marry me, Emelia.”

“I-”

He takes my hands into his. “Say yes, *milaya*.”

Tears flood my eyes as I stare at him. My throat dries.

“Yes,” I whisper. “Yes, I’ll marry you.” I curl into his arms as he presses his lips against mine. I love Nikolai more than I’ve ever thought I could love anything or anyone. He’s my heart, my soul, the axis on which my entire world spins upon.

He deepens the kiss as he holds me tightly against him, as if he’s afraid to let me go. “It’s us, forever baby,” he whispers against my lips.

I nod, reverently. “It’s us.”

Nik guides me into the bathtub, helping me settle into the water. I rest my shoulders against the marble as he gets on his knees beside me. He stares at the marks on my arm from when I was attacked. His eyes meet mine, but he says nothing.

He doesn’t have to.

He squeezes the sponge and runs it over the bruise.

“Does it hurt?” He asks, his voice soft and gentle.

I shake my head. “Only when I touch it.”

He exhales sharply then examines the swelling on my cheek.

He pulls my hand up to his lips and kisses my fingers. “Rest for a bit baby.”

He lifts to his feet then pauses as he reaches the doorway.

“James is fine. I stopped by the hospital before coming home.”

I turn to him.

“I’ve invited him and your friend Samantha to stay with us next weekend,” he says.

“Nik...”

“Don’t ever fucking leave me like that again, Emelia,” he grits out before finally leaving.



CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT



NIKOLAI

I wrap her tightly in my arms as she finally falls asleep.

The scent of her soft, sweet shampoo, wafting delicately under my nose. My anger is fucking stewing. I shouldn't have given those three men another night to live but I can't leave her. She needs me here.

"Nik," she whispers in her sleep.

"I'm here," I whisper, kissing her forehead. "I've got you. I've always got you."

She exhales softly. "I love you."

"I love you too, baby."

I hold her closer, breathing her in as we both fall asleep.



Waking up next to Emelia is the most incredible fucking feeling. Her skin is soft, smooth and smells of rich vanilla and peaches; I bury my face in her neck and breathe in the delicious scent of her. Her eyes flutter open as she snuggles her naked body closer to me.

“Good morning baby,” I whisper, moving her hair from her face.

“Good morning,” she smiles, still half asleep. She nuzzles her face against my chest as I wrap my arms around her. My dick begins to harden as she runs her fingers over my chest.

She tilts her face up to me, and leans in, pressing her lips against mine. I cup her jaw as I kiss her pillowy lips, then her cheek, then her neck.

Emelia moans softly as I nip her earlobe. I run my fingers along the curve of her back, slowly, then over the curve of her perfect ass.

“You are so fucking gorgeous,” I whisper against her skin.

She arches her body, pressing her breasts into me as she kisses my neck. “Nik, I need you,” she moans.

I tilt her chin up to me and press a deep, lingering kiss to her lips as I lift the duvet and settle on top of her. She stares up at me with those beautiful, wide, glittering eyes. I can’t believe she’s going to be my wife.

I lift her fingers to my lips and kiss each one. I reach for the nightstand, to the small, square, black box sitting there. She stares at me with a soft smile as I open it, unveiling a five carat, flawless pear-cut diamond, framed by smaller brilliant diamonds, set on an intricately intertwined band of rich 18k gold. A

masterpiece of craftsmanship and rarity. A ring that once belonged to my mother. A ring that I can now place on my Emelia's hand.

"This is for you, *milaya*," I say, slipping the ring on her finger. A perfect fit. "It was my mother's ring. Besides her journals, it's the only thing I have of hers, one of the only things I hold dear," I kiss her lips, "it's the only ring that deserves to sit on your perfect hand."

Her mouth falls open as her eyes begin to glisten, staring at the ring. "I love it," she smiles then wraps her arms around my neck and presses her lips against mine. "I love you; I love you so fucking much."

I chuckle against her lips. "I love you so fucking much baby."

I reach my hand between her legs, grinning as she begins to open up for me. I rub and touch her delicate folds as I press kisses to her neck. Her head falls back with a throaty moan as she opens her legs wider. I press a finger inside of her, then another. Taking my time, thrusting in and out.

Emelia reaches her hand down and fondles my cock. Fuck, she could make me cum just like this.

I move down her body and run my tongue all over her perfect tits. I tease her nipple between my teeth as I pull my fingers out of her. I move back up to her lips then her neck, cupping her face as I steady my cock between her, Teasing my tip at her entrance.

Slowly, I sink into her. I tuck my left arm behind her back and reach for her left hand with my right. I kiss her ring as I thrust into her, lovingly, devotedly as I pledge my entire fucking life to her, to making her happy.

"You make me feel like I'm floating," she says softly. "I feel so safe and loved with you Nik," she caresses my cheek as our eyes pour into each other.

As we're joined in the most intimate way possible. "I would follow you through every passage of time, until time itself no longer exists. I am yours Nikolai, only yours, forever."

My throat dries as I lean forward and kiss her, slowly thrusting myself in and out of her. Before Emelia, I fucked. I loved it. Not once had I ever experienced or cared to experience the act of making love. It's funny how one person can fix your entire world view. When my beautiful angel of a fiancé opens herself up for me, we become connected as one, physically and spiritually. Bodies and souls.

Her head falls back as her pussy begins to spasm. She's so wet. So warm. So perfect. I push myself into her for a final thrust before I fill her. She moans against my lips as my cock throbs inside of her.

"You are my everything," I whisper against her lips. "I would burn this entire fucking world down if you ever asked me to."

Emelia smiles softly as she wraps her arms around me.



We pull up to the little townhouse in the somewhat quiet cul-de-sac just outside of town. Children play in the road, riding their bikes and kicking a soccer ball. I smile at the sight; such innocence deserves to be preserved.

Roman, Viktor and I step out of the SUV. The sound of the ice cream truck fills the air as the kids yell and squeal in excitement.

I turn to Viktor. "Купите их всех для детей [kupite ikh vse dlya detey - Buy them all for the children]. Tell him to play the music louder."

He nods then proceeds to hand a stack of cash to the man in the truck. He smiles and nods then begins handing out ice-cream to the overjoyed children. I grin as I watch their faces, so joyful, so innocent. I would love to be a father. I'm hoping Emelia will toss those fucking birth control pills soon.

Roman knocks on the door of the townhouse. A young man, early twenties, in a black shirt with the words 'Fuck You' on the front, answers. He freezes as he opens the door. I recognise him immediately, the driver from the gas station video. Roman pushes forward and lifts him by his neck as we enter the house. His friends sit in the living room, deep into their little video game. Not a fucking care in the world. Blue shirt and green shirt.

"Lasciami andare [Let me go]!" He yells. His screams finally draw his friend's attention.

"Che diavolo è questo [What the fuck is this]?" Blue shirt yells as he throws the controller and tries to make his way out of the room. Viktor is faster. He forces him back onto the couch and Roman pushes black shirt between them.

I sit on the coffee table in front of them, holding my gun.

"Найди её вещи [naidi eyo veshchi - Find her things]." I instruct Viktor. He soon rummages through the house looking for Emelia's suitcase.

I turn to the three of them. Confusion etched on their stupid fucking faces. "Dove si trova [Where is it]?"

They turn to each other.

"Non sappiamo cosa vuoi [We don't know what you want]." Green shirt replies.

“Bullshit,” I chuckle. “La valigia [The suitcase]. Where is it?” I exhale sharply as I rest my gun on my thigh.

Viktor's voice cuts through the tension. “Я это нашёл [Ya nashel eto - I found it].” He lifts Emelia’s cream suitcase and places it in the centre of the room. He crouches down as he opens it, checking for her passport and laptop.

Only the passport is there.

“Dove è il laptop [Where’s the laptop]?” I press.

Black shirt’s eyes dart to the desk in the corner of the room. I lift and move towards it.

“Ha una password, non l'abbiamo toccata [It has a password, we didn’t touch it].” Blue shirt adds, his tone desperate. “Promessa [Promise].”

I hand the laptop to Roman who packs it neatly into the suitcase then I return to the three assholes on the stained couch.

“Hai rubato questo [You stole this].” I start. “Word is, you’ve been stealing and terrorising people in the town. Four girls have gone missing after run-ins with you.”

“Chi ha detto questo [Who said that]?” Green shirt asks.

“They’re fucking liars,” black shirt yells.

I sit back down on the coffee table and stare at them, a snarl in my tone. “If that farmer hadn’t stopped you, you would have raped her...”

Green shirt leans forward. “Stavamo solo scherzando [We were just messing around].”

I lift my gun and smack it across his jaw. “I like to mess around too,” I grin.

I nod to my men. In an instant Roman and Viktor are hauling the three fuckers into the back of the SUV with their hands tied securely behind their back. The tune of the ice-cream truck down the street blasting so loudly, their cries for help are in vain.

Darkness has completely fallen as we pull into the clearing of the forest. I step out of the car, eyeing the van waiting for us. Zeek Siphokazi smirks as he takes us in. “I must say, I was pleasantly surprised to receive your call Nikolai.”

I chuckle as I move towards him and shake his hand. “I know you like hunting Zeek,” I tilt my head with a knowing grin, “I thought you’d enjoy this.”

My reasons for extending the invitation to Zeek are twofold. One, I need to see what kind of man he is. A man cannot hide his true self when he has the power of taking a life in his hands. Two, if, as I suspect, we are cut from the same cloth then I’ll need his vote to get Katherine out.

Zeek chuckles and nods to his man who stands near the van. He pulls the door open and yanks two men forward, to the ground. “I hope you don’t mind,” he turns to me, “I brought a few more people to the party.”

I chuckle at the sight. Two bloody, bruised, furious men, wrestling against their restraints. White shirt and brown shirt.

“What are their crimes?” I ask curiously.

“They hurt Mee-” he pauses, “someone I care about.”

Hmm, Meena? I know Zeek likes her, it's very fucking obvious by the way he would practically stare at her during Nocturne meetings.

“Okay,” I nod.

Roman moves forward, handing us each a powerful compound bow and a set of twenty steel-tipped arrows. Strong enough to penetrate through muscle. The five men are lifted to their feet, their restraints and gags removed.

“Welcome gentleman,” I grin. “Each one of you has committed a crime that you are now going to atone for,” I pause, settling the bow on my shoulder. “If you can make it through the forest, to the riverbank, then you’re free to go.”

The men stare at each other. “We just have to make it to the river?” Blue shirt asks.

Zeek nods, stepping forward. “That’s right,” he chuckles.

Roman turns to the men, his voice dropping to a low, rough whisper. “Time to run.”

Black shirt moves first. His feet lift quickly as he runs into the dark of the forest. The others follow behind. Running. I turn to Zeek and hold my finger up. “Give them a head start, let them think they can outrun us, it’ll make their demise even sweeter.”

After a beat, I drop my finger with a grin, “now, let’s have some fun.”

Zeek throws the bow over his shoulder and moves off quickly with a wide smile.

I chuckle as I veer to the left, moving quickly until green shirt is in my line of sight. I nock the arrow in the bow, aiming it at his thigh then release. He falls to the ground, holding the area still impaled with my arrow. I move towards him and shoot another arrow into his chest then another into his stomach.

Green shirt coughs blood as I stare down at him. I nock another arrow. My eyes lift as I hear Zeek impale brown shirt with an arrow through the eye. I chuckle.

Sick fuck.

I release the arrow, shooting green shirt in his neck.

One down.

Two to go.

I stalk blue shirt next. He's heavier than green shirt but his feet move faster. I already know that his body is surging with adrenaline. He's running as if his life depends on it. Because it does. But blue shirt was marked for death the minute he and his buddies set their sights on my Emelia.

I hear him, panting, pausing against a tree as sweat drips from his forehead. He retches then throws up. I nearly turn my head at the sight. Fucking gross.

"You really should change your diet," I shake my head at him mockingly.

"I didn't touch her," he begs, breathless.

"Only because you didn't get a chance to," I nock my arrow. "The river's that way, blue shirt." My eyes motion behind him.

A bloodcurdling scream rings out. Zeek must have caught white shirt.

Blue shirt's eyes widen. He straightens and runs, well, if you can call it running. I release the arrow into his back.

He falls to his knees. I nock another arrow, aim and release another into his back, then again. Three more times then one last arrow through the back of his head. His body falls forward with a lifeless thud.

My eyes finally lock onto black shirt. He's managed to near the riverbank. Good. I move quickly, keeping him in my sight. He's running now. He knows I'm coming. And he knows what's coming.

I move faster. I nock an arrow and shoot it into his leg as his feet hit the water. Stopping him.

Black shirt falls to his knees. I toss the bow and arrows as I near him. I don't need it.

"Tutto questo per una puttana [All this for some bitch]?" He shouts, holding his leg.

My fists clench. I run to him and lift him by the neck before pummeling my fist into his jaw, dropping him to the ground. "She's my fucking wife!" I snarl.

I kneel over him. My fists pound into him with fierce roughness, as if he were just the leather bag in my gym. Fist against muscle, bruising skin, cracking bone until blood seeps from his lips.

"Hai osato mettere le tue mani sporche e infette su di lei [You dared to put your filthy fucking hands on her]," I sneer.

His hands and arms are flailing weakly as he tries to protect himself. I reach for my knife and flick it open. A Cold Steel Rajah III. I stare at the metal timepiece, one of the few gifts from my father. My eyes flicker with fire at the engraving:

Месть - наша сила.

Vengeance is our strength.

I press my hand against black shirt's throat to hold him down as I impale the knife into his left ear then drag it across his face, through his eyes until I

reach his right ear.

He screams and wails, the sound filling me with tremendous joy. This filthy fucker and his friends would have raped and killed my Emelia. Several young women in the town had been reported missing, all after altercations with their crew. Families left desperate without answers, at least now, they can have justice.

I slip the knife to his neck and draw blood in one clean cut. “I’ve just done the world a great favour,” I say, wiping the blood from the knife on him. I stare down, watching him claw at his neck as life begins to drain. I watch until his useless fucking body ceases twitching.

“Wow,” Zeek chuckles as he claps his hands. “I didn’t know you were so, passionate, Nikolai. I’m impressed.”

I return the blade to my pocket and walk towards Zeek. “I can be, especially when it’s deserved.”

We begin the walk back to the clearing. Passing the dead men along the way. “Should we?” Zeek gestures to the bodies.

I chuckle. “Don’t worry, my men will take care of it.”

His brow lifts with a grin, “of course.”

I tilt my head to him. “Are you fond of Katherine?”

He pauses and turns to me. “Are you?”

Hmm, he’s still sussing me out too.

I shake my head. “I want her gone.”

His lips curl into a grin. “As do I. She’s been meddling in my business interests, costing me deals.”

I stare at him. “She murdered Frederick.”

Zeek’s eyes widen as he pauses. “She wouldn’t...”

I nod. “She did, I’ve confirmed it. Her company was in a hole, she tried to force Frederick into a merger, he said no.”

He exhales sharply, then begins walking again. “I knew she was fucking crazy but I didn’t expect-”

“There’s more,” I start, “she had listening devices placed in my home, and, the other members.”

“What the fuck?” Zeek yells.

“I’ve already had them removed from my home and Suoh’s. My men can assist you with a sweep and removal too,” I offer as we near the clearing.

He nods. “I will take you up on that, I appreciate you trusting me with this Nikolai.”

Zeek reaches out his hand. I reach forward and shake firmly. “I trust that I can count on your vote then, when the time comes?”

He nods. “Of course. Whatever you need.”



CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE



NIKOLAI

Roman and I run a few errands.

Mostly business meetings but we make a stop in town. I want to get something special for Emelia.

An older man and younger woman stand on either side of the jewellery store as we enter. Both dressed in all black. The woman rushes forward first.

“Buon pomeriggio, posso aiutarla [Good afternoon, may I help you]?”
She smiles politely.

I nod. “Sto cercando qualcosa di...speciale [I’m looking for something...special].”

The man's eyes light up. "Ha un particolare tipo di pietra preziosa in mente, signore [Do you have a particular gemstone in mind, sir]?"

I shake my head. "Non particolarmente [Not particularly]."

"Se è per un'amica, non puoi sbagliare con i diamanti [If it's for a lady friend, then you can't go wrong with diamonds]." The woman adds with a grin as she gestures toward their diamond display.

I stare at every piece, nothing stands out. Emelia deserves the best, something custom, but for now, this will have to do.

I tap on the glass. "The diamond earrings and the tennis bracelet."

The old man nods, moving quickly to unlock the case. The woman lifts the black velvet tray with the earrings, handing them to me with care as they glint beneath the lighting. I move them in the light as I examine each one of them, brilliant, expensive, beautiful. I watch how the light fractures through the cut, absolutely flawless.

"Quanti carati sono questi [How many carats are these]?" I ask, although I already have a guess.

"Six. Each." The man smiles.

I nod. "I'll take it." He hands me the gold tennis bracelet next. Slim, elegant, timeless. "Potresti incidere qualcosa qui per me [Could you engrave something on here for me]?" I ask as my thumb brushes the inside of the clasp.

"Sì [Yes]," she nods. "Cosa vorresti mettere sul braccialetto, signore [What would you like to put on the bracelet, sir]?"

I grin as I think about the inscription. "Put... My Emelia."

The man nods with a smile. “Posso farlo per te ora mentre paghi, signore [I can do that for you now, while you pay, sir].” He lifts the bracelet and disappears to the back room.

The quiet drive back to the estate is interrupted when Katherine calls. I stare at my phone screen, an incoming video call. She’s been very quiet after the bloody surprise I left for her.

“Katherine,” I answer, flatly.

“Nikolai, have I called at a bad time?” She asks with a pout, resting the phone on her desk as she leans back in her chair. She wears a black silk robe with her blonde hair fallen onto her shoulders.

“I’m on my way to a meeting, what do you need?” I reply coolly.

“I’m sure you’ve heard that my home was broken into,” she murmurs as she begins to cry. “My Nelson was gunned down...”

I catch Roman’s gaze in the rearview mirror. “I had no idea, I’m sorry to hear that, Katherine.”

She wipes her tears. “I’ve increased security, round the clock. And attack dogs.”

I nod. “That’s probably for the best.”

“I wanted to tell you how sorry I am about that mix-up with James Fields,” she starts. “We received bad information, I hope nothing has been done that can’t be undone.”

I shake my head. “Water under the bridge.”

Fucking bitch. What game is she playing at? She has to know that it was me who killed her precious Nelson. Even though she could never prove it.

She straightens in her seat. “We have a new member joining Nocturne. I’m calling a meeting soon to introduce them.”

“Who is it?” I ask, curious.

She grins. “I wouldn’t want to spoil the surprise, Nikolai.”

I take a deep breath. Jesus this woman is pushing my buttons.

“Fine, I have to go Katherine,” I reply before ending the call.

Roman stares at me in the mirror.

My brows furrow. “Что за черт она задумала [chto, chert vozmi, ona zatevaet - What the fuck is she playing at]?”

I shoot Luka a text:

Setup surveillance on KA. Something’s going down.

I want to know what she’s planning.



I stand in the doorway, arms folded as I watch Emelia’s eyes widen at the rows of clothes I had ordered for her. All arranged perfectly in the walk-in closet, next to mine.

Evening wear, casual wear, shoes, bags, jewellery, and especially more of those little skirts she loves to tease me with.

“Nik,” she chuckles, rolling her eyes.

I move forward and wrap my arms around her, her back presses against my chest. “Don’t complain when I spoil you,” I press my lips against her temple, “get used to it baby.”

She bites her lip as she throws me a look over her shoulder. “I have money too, you know.”

I laugh. “You are so fucking cute.”

She swats at my arm playfully.

“Go check behind the coats,” my brows flick in that direction.

She throws me a curious look then moves towards the rail, parting it to reveal her suitcase.

She gasps. “How did you get this?”

“Good Samaritan dropped it off,” I lie.

She eyes me suspiciously but doesn’t press further. She squeals in delight as she unzips the case and holds her laptop.

“You have no idea how happy I am to have this back,” she hugs it. “I backup all my work but this laptop is so special to me.” She pauses as she lifts her clothes. “My passport’s missing, it’s not in here.”

“We’ll find it,” I lie again. It’s tucked away in my safe.

She walks towards me with a bright smile. She wraps her arms around my neck and lifts on her toes as she kisses me. “Thank you.”

I wrap my arms around her waist and lift her onto my hips as we remain locked in a deep, unhurried kiss.



CHAPTER THIRTY



EMELIA

“Tell me Viktor,” I start, walking in the town centre.

Desperately looking for an electronic store that sells cell phones made in this century. “How long have you worked for Nikolai?”

Viktor chuckles. “Almost ten years now.”

“So, you saw everything that happened with Dmitri?” I press.

He nods. “Dmitri is a traitor to the brotherhood; he deserves no mercy.”

I eye our surroundings, fidgeting with my engagement ring.

“Do you think he would ever, come after me...?”

“You’re safe, I can promise you that,” he insists, tapping the gun discreetly hidden on his hip.

Two young women walk by and eye Viktor as they cover their mouths and giggle.

I lean towards him, “I think they like you.”

He shakes his head. “Not my type.”

I frown, curious. “What is your type?”

“Not women,” he replies coolly.

“Oh-”

“Here’s a store,” he says gesturing to a shop ahead.



I’m relieved to finally have a phone again. Nikolai told James that I was safe and happy, but I know him. He wouldn’t believe it until he hears it from me.

My eyes remain glued to the screen as I watch my contacts sync on the device. I exhale impatiently as I stare at the wheel spinning over and over and over.

“Finally!” I beam.

I walk out onto the veranda and sit on the patio furniture as I start the videocall.

“Emelia!” James exclaims as he answers. “What the fuck? Do you know how worried I’ve been?” He gives me a sharp look then turns the phone to Sam, who’s with him. “How worried we’ve been,” she adds as she crosses her arms.

“I’m so sorry, it’s a long story but I’m good. Great, actually.” I smile brightly.

James sits the phone down on the coffee table facing him and Sam on the couch in his apartment. I notice new luggage in the corner of the room.

“Is that for your trip to me?” I ask with a smile, trying to lighten the mood.

James rolls his eyes as a smile grows on his lips. "It was time for an upgrade."

Sam laughs. "That new car has really gone to your head. He's such a snob now Em."

I tilt my head. "You bought a new car?"

They both stare at me in surprise.

"You didn't know?" James asks, confused.

I shake my head. "How would I know?"

Sam smirks. "It was a gift from your boyfriend."

I pause at the word. Boyfriend.

"A red fucking Ferrari, Emelia. You should see this thing, it's..." Sam mimics a chef's kiss.

"He's uh, not my boyfriend..."

James stares at me. "What do you mean?"

I lift my hand to the screen to show them the ring. "We're engaged."

"What the fuck Emelia!" Sam's eyes widen. "You're engaged?"

I nod with a smile. "It just happened."

"I mean, it's sudden..." she pauses

"I know, and you both know that I wouldn't jump into anything I wasn't sure about," I smile. "I'm madly in love with him, he's everything."

She holds her hand to her heart. "I'm so happy for you babe, you deserve all the love and happiness in the world."

I turn to James who's unusually quiet. "Are you okay with this?"

He exhales and relaxes as he leans against Sam. "I'm happy for you, Emmy."

"But," he continues. "I will only give my blessing after we get to see you in person, and I can make sure that you're safe there."

I laugh. "Do you know how many guns there are in this house?"

Sam giggles. "Guns that you don't know how to use."

I roll my eyes. "Nikolai wouldn't let anything happen to me."

James nods with a soft smile. "That I can trust."

"I miss you guys, and I can't wait to see you this weekend. I have so many fun things planned for us!" I clasp my hands together with a wide smile.

"We can't wait!" Sam squeals as she shimmies her shoulders.

"I should go; I have a chapter to finish if I'm going to stay on track," I say as I lift from the chair.

"Bye babe, we'll let you know once we're boarding," James winks at me.

I blow a kiss to them. "Travel safe, I'll see you soon!"



I wake to a cool breeze. I reach for the cell phone, charging on the pedestal beside me and check the time, 01:23. Nikolai's not here. I put the phone back and turn.

My body jolts forward when I notice that the balcony door is open. Did we forget to close that? I rub my eyes then look again. I gasp as a man

dressed in black appears, staring at me as he holds a large knife in his hands. The steel of the blade glinting in the moonlight.

“Nik!” I scream.

The man runs towards me and covers my mouth with his hands as he pins me down under his weight.

“She wants me to leave a mess.” His voice a low and maniacal whisper as he teases the knife against the skin of my neck. “I’m

going to fucking gut you bitch-” His body jerks as two gunshots fire into the room. One into his shoulder and the other into his chest. The intruder falls back onto the floor, knife still in hand.

Nikolai moves furiously towards him, he tosses the gun then drives his fist into his jaw, forcing him onto the ground. I fall to the floor as I try to catch my breath. My entire body trembling with fear. Frozen as I watch Nikolai become possessed with rage and beat the man’s face to a bloody pulp. He wraps his hands around the man’s neck and twists with a sickening snap.

Another man climbs the terrace, pulling himself up by a rope with one hand as the other points a gun at Nik.

I don’t think, I reach for the discarded gun, aim and shoot. A bullet hits the side of his neck, forcing him to lose his grip and fall to the hard rock of the courtyard below. My ears are ringing as the gun falls from my shaking hands.

Tears roll down my cheek as air finally fills my lungs again. “Nik,” I manage.

He turns and rushes to me, crouching to lift me up. “Are you okay?”

I nod as I hold onto him.

“You shot him,” he says, surprised.

My breath hitches, “he had a gun, I couldn’t let him hurt you.”

Shots ring out in the courtyard.

“Fuck,” he yells. “Come on, we need to get to the safe room.” He’s already guiding me into the walk-in closet. He closes the door behind us and opens the security panel on the side of the door; a thick slate of reinforced steel suddenly appears and barricades the door. I drop to the carpeted ground and lean against the large jewellery stand in the centre of the room.

I killed someone.

I fucking killed someone.

More gunshots ring out. Nik grabs a tablet and sits next to me, pulling me into his arms as I shiver uncontrollably. Breathe Emelia.

One.

Inhale.

Two.

Hold it.

Three.

Exhale.

He cups my face. “I would never let anything happen to you, baby.”

I curl into him. “Maria... are they-”

“They’re fine,” he nods. He opens the security feed on the tablet, showing Maria, Zora and Lev safe but anxious in a secure room downstairs. “We have

protocols for this, they're protected." He opens the telecom system then speaks. "Вы все в порядке [vy vse vieu poryadke - Are you all okay]?"

They nod. "Мы в порядке [my vieu poryadke - We're fine]." Lev answers.

"This will be over soon, hang tight," Nikolai replies.

He scans the camera feed as Viktor and a group of other men open fire against the intruders. "Who are they?" I ask, gesturing to the men with Viktor.

"They work for me, they stay close, out of sight, ready for surprises like this," he confirms.

He watches as Viktor shoots and punches his way through the group. Nik exhales sharply.

"You want to help them?" I ask, looking up at him. "I'll be okay,"

I lie.

He tightens his grip and puts the tablet down. "No baby, this is where I should be." He lifts my jaw and presses a kiss against my lips. "I will always protect you."

I wrap my arms around him and rest my head against his chest.

"That man... He said that 'she' sent them. Is this Katherine?"

Nik's face darkens. "She's fucking dead, I promise you."

He brushes my hair from my neck and kisses me. Slowly easing the tension from my body. He gently moves the strap of my blue chemise nightgown then kisses my shoulder.

My head falls back as a soft moan escapes my lips. He wraps his hand behind my neck as he pulls my lips to his.

“You’re not shaking anymore,” he murmurs as he brushes the hair from my face.

I stare at him. I’ve never felt safer. Never felt more protected than when I’m in his arms.

“Nikolai?” A voice echoes from behind the door. Viktor. “We’re all clear.”

“Okay,” he replies coolly.

He lifts to his feet then reaches his hand to me, lifting me up. Nik pulls me closer then kisses my forehead.

“I have to check on the men, but I’ll be back soon.”

I nod. “I’m going to take a shower.”

He smirks. “Wait for me in there.”

He moves across the room to grab a t-shirt before entering the code on the security panel and leaving the room.

The closet is the size of a bachelor apartment. Shelves, drawers and backlit displays line the walls. Nik’s clothes and shoes are meticulously arranged towards the left. Everything smells of him.

I turn to the right. Looking at my clothes hanging there. It dawns on me that I’ll need to pack my apartment and bring the rest of my wardrobe and belongings here. I wonder if I could bribe Sam and James with pizza and margaritas to help me. They wouldn’t say no, but an incentive wouldn’t hurt.

I inhale sharply then turn and cross into the ensuite bathroom. It’s a cathedral of luxury. A rainfall shower made of brushed black steel and glass stands in one corner, surrounded by warm stone tile. A deep, freestanding

bath, large enough for two, sits beneath a wide window. The countertops are white marble adorned with gold fixtures. Every single detail whispers wealth.

I let the water run in the shower as I pull off my chemise and toss it into the laundry hamper. The warm water caresses my skin and eases the tension in my muscles almost instantly.

I lather the shampoo into my hair. A drop of dried blood drips to the floor. I swallow hard as I remember the man's knife against my neck. Katherine wants me dead. I can't believe that she's this obsessed with Nikolai that she would try to kill me. There must be more to this.

The events of the night replay in my mind as I scrub my body. The whisper of the man's voice in my ear, the look of hatred in his eyes as he held me down. The way the other man held his gun pointed towards Nik. My body shudders as I recall the power of the gun in my hands.

Fight.

Flight.

Freeze.

I've always wondered which state my body would default to. I'm glad that it's fight. I've never raised a hand to another person; it's not in my nature. Even when they deserved it. But the thought of anyone hurting Nikolai brings out a rage in me that I didn't know existed.

I tilt my head towards the stream and close my eyes. A smile pulls on my lips as I hear Nik toss his clothes in the hamper then join me.

His hands wrap around my waist as his lips drop down to tenderly kiss along my shoulder then the curve of my neck.

"Is everyone okay?" I ask, placing my hand on his.

“Our men are fine, the others, are not.” He replies with a grin.

He wraps his arms around my chest and pulls me flush against him. “You killed a man for me tonight, Emelia.”

I tilt my head and welcome his tongue against my earlobe. “I would do it again.”

Nik chuckles, low and sexy in my ear then turns me to face him. He gently tilts my chin up to him as he grins at me. I reach for his semi hard erection and begin stroking. Nik drops his head to my lips and presses his tongue into my mouth. I stroke firmly and slowly; I love the feeling of his cock in my hands.

He moans as his hands reach for my ass. He squeezes my cheeks apart then lifts me onto his hips in a swift motion. He holds me against the cool, marbled tile as his tongue explores my mouth, and his hand explores my pussy. He strokes my clit in gentle, soothing circles as I moan ragged breathes into his mouth.

“I can’t wait for you to be my wife,” he growls against my lips as he presses two fingers into me.

“Nik,” my head falls back as he thrusts into me.

“Mmm, you’re so wet Emelia,” he rumbles as he slowly removes his fingers and steadies the head of his shaft at my core.

I wrap my arms around his neck and run my fingers along his broad shoulders. I marvel at the strength of him as my fingers run over the muscles of his arms then back up to his chest. I trace the ridge between his pecks, then draw my fingers over the pattern of the rose tattoo with Russian text on his

shoulder. I'm so entranced in my admiration of him that I don't notice him staring at me with a soft grin.

I smile at him and press my lips against him, pushing my tongue into his mouth as I run my hands through his hair.

He holds my thighs firmly then pushes himself into me.

"Oh my God," I tilt back slightly as I tighten my grip around his waist.

He smirks as he pumps harder and leans me back further.

I bite my bottom lip as he fucks me harder. He runs his fingers over my lips; I push my tongue out to lick him. He then runs his hand down my chest, squeezing my breasts.

"This body Emelia, you make me lose my fucking mind," his voice low and rough as he continues to thrust. Harder, faster.

I moan loudly as my needy pussy begins to spasm with release.

My head lolls back as my arms drop, exhausted, spent, satisfied. My lids are heavy as he slows his thrusts with a dark grin. "Are you tired baby?" His voice soft and melodic.

I moan in response as he pushes in and out of me. His thumb brushes my lip as he teases my mouth open and hovers close. "I just need a little more, will you give me more?"

My eyes lift to him; I lick my lips as I nod. I tighten my grip around his neck as his cock throbs inside of me.

He grins as he pushes harder.

Deeper.

Wilder.

He widens my legs and moans as he fills me with every drop of his hot, silky cum.

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CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE



NIKOLAI

I feel rested.

My mind is quiet for what feels like the first time in years. Emelia lays in my arms, still sleeping. I brush her thick, dark hair from her face and admire her. The heavens couldn't create a more perfect woman for me. Breathtakingly beautiful inside and out. Smart, fierce, kind. And now, she's finally mine. She's going to be my wife.

She stirs gently and moves herself closer to me. I kiss her forehead and hold her closer, wrapping my arms around her deliciously delicate body. I fucking love her so much, it scares me.

I need to be strategic about getting rid of Katherine. She needs to bleed for this. I thought I had time, but after last night's stunt it's clear. She needs to be put down. There are still

a lot of moving parts that need to fit into place before I can take action.

If I kill her, the others will take issue with that, and I'll lose my membership. That can't happen. If I lobby for her to be replaced, then I'll need a majority vote. Suoh, Zeek, Damian and Meena would side with me. I just need two more votes. Once her title has been removed, then I'll come for her business. And once she has absolutely, fucking nothing, then I will take her life.

Spencer Lee has been trying to setup a meeting with me for months, since I've uncovered his secret meetings with Dmitri. I don't know if I trust myself not to act when I see him but perhaps, I could make this work in my favour. We have a mutual enemy now.

Then there's the other issue, Hector Collins, Head of Nocturne Operations, the actual workforce behind the organisation and Katherine's right-hand man. I exhale sharply.

Hector's a good man, he wouldn't betray Katherine without a good reason, but I need to have him on my side if I'm going to get rid of her. Step one, remove her title. I need to be patient if this plan is going to work, she can't know that I know she sent those men. I want her to think she has the upper hand. Even as head, there are still rules. She cannot act against a member without a vote and yet she's decided to wage fucking war against me.

You can believe that you've won this round Katherine, because when the time comes, you won't fucking see me coming.



The air thrums with quiet opulence. Inside the glass walled pavilion, spotlights shimmer down on a curated lineup of mechanical masterpieces. Supercars, bespoke vintage restorations, and one-of-a-kind concepts, each polished to perfection.

It's not open to the public. This is an invitation only event. A playground for billionaires and legacy collectors, where the scent of fine leather and engine oil mingles with notes of expensive cologne and aged scotch.

Security is subtle, but ironclad. So is the discretion. No name tags. No press. Just whispers of who might be here, a Saudi prince.

A tech titan from Silicon Valley. An F1 champion with a taste for the rare and ruthless. And parked at the centre of it all, the crown jewels. Custom-built Valhallas, reimagined Bugatti's and Ferraris.

This isn't just a trade show. It's a statement. A kingdom built from carbon and chrome.

The air is thick with the low murmur of power as I step into the pavilion. Old money, new tech, unspoken deals. I scan the space then give a subtle nod to Roman. He doesn't need instruction. He knows the drill. Fading into the background, slipping behind a curtain of display banners. Near but unseen.

Then I see him. Spencer Lee. He's leaning in close to another man, laughing, gesturing toward one of the demo models as they discuss torque and traction.

A smirk pulls at my lips. My stride is slow, steady, the kind that makes people step aside without even realizing why.

My eyes lock on him like a predator sizing its prey. And then... he sees me. His expression falters quickly. Smile frozen as the colour drains from his

face. Too late Spencer.

He straightens, looking around at security posted nearby. He tries to hide the shift in posture, but I see it, that flicker of fear. That flash of recognition.

“Spencer,” I say, voice low, steady.

He swallows. “I didn’t think you’d be here, Nikolai.”

I grin. “Clearly.”

He looks around nervously, making sure to be seen by the large security nearby. I tilt my head to him. “You wanted to talk, Spencer, so let’s talk.”

His eyes widen. “Here?”

“Why not,” I shrug. “Would you prefer some place more, private?”

He stares at me as he swallows again. “No, this is fine.”

I lean forward and run my hand across the carbon fibre hood of the latest BMW prototype beside him, “you’ve been a hard man to track, are you hiding from someone?”

He clears his throat. “Not exactly.”

“Really?” I raise a brow. “I would be very worried if I were you, we all saw what Katherine did to Frederick.”

His eyes widen. “You know...?”

I nod. “I do, I know that Alexander Communications was at risk of closing its doors until that surprising partnership with Leechee.”

His eyes drop. “I couldn’t say no...”

“I know,” I pause. “What I didn’t know was that she was capable of murder and spying, but I’ve learned quite a lot this last year Spencer.”

His eyes lift to me. “She asked me to lay low until she gave word for me to return when the new member joins.”

My brows furrow. “Who is it?”

He shrugs, “I don’t know. But I know that they’re the one who killed Frederick.”

I exhale sharply as the graphic scene re-enters my mind.

Frederick, his wife, his child, his fucking dog. All butchered.

What kind of a psycho would be joining our ranks?

“You killed my men,” he says, staring at me.

“They fired a shot at my fiancé,” I say, meeting his stare.

“They wouldn’t-“

“They did, and they paid for that,” I sneer, leaning against the car. “Now tell me Spencer, why the fuck were you meeting with Dmitri?”

Spencer exhales sharply. “It’s complicated...”

“It is not. Dmitri is a fucking traitor.”

Spencer shakes his head. “Nikolai, he wants to meet with you.”

I fold my arms and stare at him. “He will meet with the barrel of my fucking gun.”

Spencer moves forward. “He asked me to arrange a meeting with you, that’s why I met with him.”

I grit my teeth. “Have you forgotten what he’s done, Spencer?”

“I have not, but there’s a lot that you don’t know, Nikolai, things that Dmitri needs to tell you himself. I can arrange a meeting-”

“No.” I move forward, rage seething. “Dmitri will not have a chance to speak before my bullet is buried in his skull. Do you understand?”

Spencer tenses as he spots Roman nearby. His mouth falls open as he turns back to me, the accusation cresting on the tip of his tongue.

“Do you really think I would kill you here?” I move forward, shoulders brushing. The skin on his neck prickles as my voice drops to a whisper. “I want Katherine gone. I’m sure you wouldn’t disagree with that, correct?”

He nods at me.

“Good.” I pause as I begin to walk away. “When the time comes Spencer, I trust that you will vote the right way.”



My phone rings as we make our way back to the estate. Katherine. I place her on speaker as Roman shoots me a pointed look in the mirror.

“Katherine,” I answer, my tone even but not unfriendly.

“Nikolai, how are you?” Her voice drips with snark which is pissing me the fuck off.

“I’m fine.” I reply flatly.

Her tone changes as she feigns concern. “I heard that Dmitri’s men attacked you at your estate, that’s very unfortunate, I hope no-one was hurt,” she pauses, “I did warn you that he would come for us Nikolai.”

I stare at the phone. I’m tempted to tell Roman to drive the car to her so I can throttle her fucking neck.

“My men handled it.”

“That’s good news,” her tone warm again. “Our new member joins next week. I’ve called a meeting. I think you’ll be very interested to meet him.”

My brows knit. “Is it someone I know?”

She chuckles. “He’s a fascinating storyteller. Apparently, he knows you and Dmitri very well.”

Who the fuck is she talking about? I turn to Roman who shakes his head in confusion.

“I look forward to seeing you Nikolai, and please send my regards to Emelia,” she grins before ending the call.

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CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO



EMELIA

I gasp in delight as I stare out the window.

Perched on the staircase overlooking the courtyard as I watch the large black iron gates hum open as Roman's black SUV pulls along the driveway, unhurried.

I rush to the bottom of the stairs and race to open the door before Lev. He laughs as I smile at him. My body is vibrating with happiness as I cross the threshold, watching Roman pull the car in front of the door.

Viktor walks behind me, grin on his face and tablet in hand. "Do you have thick files on them too?" I tease.

He nods with a chuckle. "You know I do. And I was especially interested in the criminal record. Arson and loitering, hmm, quite interesting friends you have Emelia."

What???

“Who has a criminal record?” I press, and why didn’t know about it?

Viktor grins, refusing to answer.

My attention turns to the sound of the car door opening, Sam steps out first and I practically run her over as I wrap my arms around her.

“I’ve missed you so much!” I exclaim as tears well in my eyes.

She laughs and hugs me tighter. “I’ve missed you more!”

“I don’t get a hug?” James pouts as he walks around the car to me.

I run to him and jump up into his arms, wrapping myself around him. Tears flowing freely now. “I’ve missed you,” I cry.

He strokes my back and sets me down, tears falling on his cheeks, “I’ve missed you too Emmy.” He leans back, studying me carefully then pulls me into a tighter hug. “I just realised, this is the longest we’ve ever been away from each other.”

I squeeze him tighter. “You guys should just move here,” I laugh.

Sam chuckles as she stares at Viktor waiting at the door. “If the men look like that then I’m sold,” she grins as she waves at him.

“Come on,” I laugh. “You guys had a long flight; you must be starving.”



Sitting on the veranda with martinis in hand, Sam and James are enjoying Maria’s smoked salmon and roasted vegetables. “This place is beautiful,” James breathes as he takes in the view.

I nod, “I’ve never felt as calm as I do here.”

“I’m sure your fiancé has a lot to do with that,” Sam winks.

“Where is Nikolai?” James presses.

“He’s been away on business, but he should be home today,” I sigh.

“Look at her, like a lovesick little puppy,” Sam laughs.

I playfully toss a baby carrot her way. “Don’t be mean, I miss him.”

“You better be talking about me or I’ll need a name and address, *milaya*,” Nik’s voice cuts through the conversation as he walks towards us with a wide grin. I don’t think, just move.

I push my chair back and rush towards him, into his arms. He lifts me to his hips and kisses me roughly with a moan. “I missed you too,” he whispers.

He lowers me to my feet and takes my hand, walking us towards the table. He pulls my chair then sits me down before greeting James and Sam.

“Your home is beautiful Nikolai,” James remarks as his eyes drink in the lush scenery of the estate.

“Thank you, and thank you for joining us this weekend,” Nik smiles, “I have an international conference call so I won’t be able to join you at the club this evening but, tomorrow we’re having a party for the birth of Roman and Yelena’s son then Sunday, we’ll have lunch on the yacht.”

My brows furrow. “You have a yacht?”

Nik laughs. “I do, bought it immediately after that writer foolishly invited you on his.” He leans down, his lips brushing the shell of my ear. “Mine’s bigger.”

I chuckle as he pulls my hand onto his thigh and covers me with his own.



I walk down the staircase in my black silk dress. Low neckline, hem falling mid-thigh with a slit that just about shies away from revealing my underwear.

I look towards Nikolai's office door, it's closed. Damn it, I really wanted to see his face when he saw me in this.

Sam whistles as I make my way down the final steps. She looks gorgeous in a champagne-coloured dress, all her curves on display. James looks equally as handsome in a charcoal suit and open collared white shirt. Tonight, I will get my besties laid, it's the least I could do for making them worry about me these last few weeks.

Viktor eyes me up and down as he opens the car door for us, I know he's wondering if Nikolai approved this outfit, but he doesn't say anything. He simply closes the door behind us before sliding into the driver's seat and taking off.

"Where is this place you're taking us to Emelia? I wouldn't think a small town like this has a club," Sam asks as she applies her mauve lipstick.

"Zora, Maria's daughter, told me about it, it's supposed to be super fancy, between this town and the next. She says it's really popular," I answer.

"She didn't tell you that Nikolai owns the club?" Viktor chuckles.

My eyes widen at him, "she did not."

James and Sam both burst into laughter.

"Nikolai probably asked her to tell you about it," she leans closer and cups my chin. "He can't have his precious Emelia going to dark, dangerous places."

James erupts in a thunderous laugh. “Do you remember how she ran out of that club in Amsterdam?”

Sam chuckles. “Yes! Like a bat out of hell!”

My cheeks redden as I swat James’s leg. “I didn’t know that they were going to get naked, I was just surprised that’s all.”

“What was the name of this club?” Viktor asks.

“The Jewel,” Sam replies with a giggle.

Viktor nods. “I know it, and that is not a place for you Emelia.”

I straighten in my seat. “You’ve been there? Has Nikolai?”

Viktor shakes his head. “Nikolai wouldn’t step foot in a place like that unless he had money invested in it.”



The club buzzes with life. The floor is thumping with dance music. My smile widens as I take in how busy it is. A handsome man walks towards us. “You must be Emelia; we have the VIP area ready for you.” I turn to James; his eyes are already glued to the man. I grab Sam’s hand with a laugh as we walk towards the area overlooking the dance floor.

“My name is Art, if you need anything just shout. We have champagne and shots ready for you, but a waitress will be by to get any other drinks you’ll like.”

Sam giggles. “Thank you, Art,” she turns to James, “was there something you wanted from him?” She teases.

His smirk widens as he slaps her bottom. “We’re good for now, thank you Art.”

We down three rounds of shots and a glass of champagne, the burn of alcohol chasing away the last flickers of restraint. My inhibitions have taken a holiday for the night, packed their bags and vanished without warning. The room is spinning in the best way possible, full of flashing lights and the thrum of bass that pulses through my chest like a second heartbeat.

With a wild grin, I grab Sam's hand and loop my arm through James's, dragging them both onto the crowded dance floor. The music is loud and addictive, the kind of songs you don't just hear, you feel. My body moves instinctively, hips swaying, arms in the air, eyes are burning my skin, but I don't care.

I feel untouchable.

Limitless.

Art, the host, eyes James from across the room, a smirk playing at the corners of his mouth, equal parts challenge and invitation. The moment their gazes lock, it's like the air between them shifts. James doesn't hesitate, he leans in close to say something in Sam's ear, and then he's gone.

When James reaches him, Art wastes no time, sliding an arm around his waist.

"Damn," Sam mutters, raising her eyebrows. "That man doesn't play."

I laugh, shaking my head as the music swells around us. "Neither does James."

A beautiful woman in a deep red dress eyes Sam from across the bar, her gaze bold and unflinching. Sam notices her too, biting her lip with a soft laugh, already halfway curious.

I shoot the woman an encouraging look and a wink, silently giving her the green light. In an instant, she's gliding through the crowd like it's parting just for her, and Sam, never one to shy away from a thrill, meets her halfway before disappearing into the thick of the crowd.

I toss my head back, close my eyes, and let the music move me when suddenly, I feel eyes on me. *His* eyes.

I glance up at the security cameras mounted around the room. Is Nikolai watching me right now? A grin curves across my lips at the thought, then a devilish idea sparks to life. That's when I notice him, a handsome enough man leaning against the bar, staring at me. I raise my hand and curl my finger, beckoning him over. He comes immediately.

He places his hands on my waist like he has a right to. I glance up at the nearest security camera and wink, deliberately. My body begins to move, hips swaying, rhythm pulsing. The man presses closer, smirking, trying to draw me in but I don't let him.

This isn't for him.

This is for *him*.

I drop to the floor, slowly, sensually, letting his fingers trace the arch of my back as I roll and rise again. Then, without warning, the lights go out. Just for a second.

When they flash back on, the man is gone. And in his place stands Viktor. Cold. Still.

"Nikolai doesn't like that Emelia," he says, voice low and even.

"So, he *is* watching me?" I ask.

Viktor doesn't confirm it. He doesn't need to. Because I know. I feel it. Nikolai is watching so I'll give him something to watch then.

Defiance burns through me as I march toward the bar, heels clicking, head high. When I reach it, I kick off my shoes without hesitation and hop onto a stool, then up onto the bar itself. I raise my arms above my head and begin to dance. Bold, unbothered, tipsy and utterly unrepentant.

My short black dress rides higher with each sway of my hips, the slit parting dangerously as my hand slides along my thigh, teasing the edge just enough to earn a chorus of whistles and cheers from the crowd below. Sam appears at the bar, wide-eyed and grinning.

"Oh, hell yes!" she laughs, pulling cash from her bra and tossing the bills at me with a theatrical wink. "Show them how it's done!"

I laugh, wild and breathless, and roll my hips with the beat, tossing my hair back as if I own the entire damn room. I arch my back and grind to the beat, letting the music drown out everything else. Everything but the way he must be watching me. Drinking me in. Seething with it.

James rushes forward, breathless and flushed, clearly fresh from his heavy makeout session with Art.

"What are you doing?" He scolds, skidding to a stop at the edge of the bar. "Do you want Nikolai to kill every man in here for looking at you?"

I throw my head back with a laugh, the sound sultry and soaked in champagne. Bending low toward him, I let my fingers trail under his chin, eyes glittering with mischief.

"No... but I would very much like to see him try."

My eyes lift as the crowd begins to part. A grin pulls at the corners of my lips as I watch Nikolai stalking dangerously towards me.

Dark suit.

Hair tousled.

Eyes burning with unbridled anger.

I reach onto the bar, unphased, lifting a bottle of vodka. Locking eyes with him, I twist the cap then flick it before lifting the bottle to my open mouth. I bite my lip as he reaches me. He's fucking pissed.

I lower to my knees, until I'm face to face with him then push my tongue into the seam of his mouth. His eyes darken as he reaches for me. "If you wanted my attention, you fucking have it," his voice low and rough as he yanks me down in one swift, unexpected motion, throwing me over his shoulder like I weigh nothing.

He's already marching us through the club, to the office upstairs; eyes set like stone. Once we enter the office, he sets me down and locks the door behind us. I lean against the cool hard wood as he walks toward the desk then turns to me, his face burning with rage as he stares at me. His eyes drop to my outfit, fists clenching as he fully takes me in.

"Are you mad?" I ask, my voice dripping with honey.

"Murderous," he growls as his eyes flicker with fury.

Nik leans against the desk as he unbuttons his black shirt, his face cold and lethal as he doesn't dare tear his eyes from me. My breath hitches as he tosses his shirt onto the couch. He unbuckles his belt, allowing it to whistle as it slowly pulls through the loops.

"Get on your knees," he commands.

I pause, my pulse racing. I've never seen Nikolai this angry, at least not with me.

I comply. Dropping to my knees as I hold his terrifying gaze.

"Crawl to me," he says. His voice low and rough.

"No, I-

"Crawl Emelia. Don't fucking make me tell you again." He snaps the leather of his belt against the desk, the sound equally terrifying and thrilling.

I swallow hard. My hands find the cool, rough, carpet as I begin to crawl towards Nikolai. My defiance waning the closer I inch toward him. I look up at him as he places the belt on the desk and begins to open a bottle of whisky before lifting it to his lips.

"Open your mouth," he says, before taking a sip.

Entranced, I stare up at him and part my lips. He smirks, staring down at me as he lowers himself. I gasp as he grabs my face, rougher than he ever has before. He tugs at my chin to open my mouth wider, then he dribbles the liquor from his mouth to mine before brushing his thumb along my bottom lip.

"You want to dress like a whore and dance like a whore, then I'm going to treat you like one." He leans closer. "My fucking whore."

He kisses me roughly as he wraps his hand behind my neck and holds me towards him. I moan into his mouth as our tongues collide, drowning in the scent of finely aged whisky. He pulls back and smirks at me before standing to his feet, unzipping his pants and pulling his erect cock out.

"You know what to do," he says.

I lift to my knees as I wrap my hand around his cock; I lick at his tip and close my eyes as I run my tongue along the length of him. I love the way he tastes. I suck, greedily. Feeding my insatiable appetite for him.

“Mmm that’s my good little whore, suck my cock, I know you fucking love it.” He growls.

I take him in deeper, Niks hips are rocking gently as he pushes more of himself into me. I flick my tongue against his tip then moan as I guide him towards my throat.

“Oh, fuck baby,” his eyes roll back as he thrusts into my mouth.

I reach down between my legs, parting my underwear then rubbing my clit. I’m already so fucking wet.

“Uh uh, *milaya*,” he lifts me to my feet and removes my hand. He pulls my fingers to his lips then sucks my wetness from them. “You only get pleasure when I give it to you, you still have a lesson to learn, baby.”

I lean in to kiss him, but he spins me around, pressing himself against my back, forcing me to face the monitor with the video feed from the club. He replays my dance with the man as he holds me in his tightening grip.

Nikolai lifts the slit of my dress and rubs my pussy through the thin lace fabric of my underwear. My head falls back against his chest as my eyes close, relishing his touch.

“Do you want to know what I did when I saw this, Emelia?” He whispers, his warm breath caressing my neck.

I nod. “Yes.”

“I drove down here and put a bullet in his head but not before chopping off those filthy fucking hands he dared to touch you with.” His tone is cold

and unyielding as the tip of his middle finger grazes my clit.

“That man probably had loved ones, friends, family, ambitions. And his only crime, was touching you. Do you understand that your actions have consequences, Emelia?”

I don’t answer. I can’t. My mind is racing with frustration, regret, shame and pleasure.

Nik wraps his free hand around my throat and tightens his grip. “Tell me you understand, Emelia.”

“I understand.” I moan, breathless.

I can’t think of anything else besides my need, my need for him to fill me. His fingers ghost my clit and tease my core, I push my hips towards him, but he grins and continues his tease. He pulls my dress from my body then grabs my waist as he rips my underwear.

He takes a seat in the chair behind the desk, lifting his gun before slowly tapping it on the dark, hard wood in front of him, motioning me to sit. I move immediately. Lifting myself onto the desk. Right where he wants me.

He widens my legs and runs the cold, steel barrel of his gun against my thighs. I should be terrified, I should, but I’m the furthest thing from it. His touch is exhilarating, addictive. All rational thought becomes abandoned the minute Nikolai looks at me.

He opens my legs as he stares between me with a widening grin.

“I need to make sure my little whore is nice and wet before I play,” he growls, leaning his face between my legs.

A broken moan escapes my lips as he slowly licks up my slit, and sucks on my clit. “Mmm perfect.”

He licks the barrel of his gun and rubs it between my folds. The cold, hard steel making me wetter, hotter.

“Is it loaded?” I ask, breathless.

Nikolai grins and nods. He rubs the barrel at my entrance, slowly pushing it into me.

I moan as he pushes further, until the tip of his gun is inside of me. I spread my legs wider for him as I rest my hands on the desk. He pushes in and pulls out with devilish precision. He then licks the barrel again before rubbing it against my clit.

I tremble at the new sensation.

He rubs harder at my swollen clit, the pressure too much and somehow, not enough. I feel an intense pressure as if I'm about to burst. I cry out as my pussy spasms, my body shivers with intensity as I start squirting all over his gun and hands.

“Oh, fuck baby,” he growls then places his gun on the desk as he licks me, lapping me up, soothing me with his tongue. My thighs are flooded. I’ve never squirted before, I didn’t know I could. Nikolai’s tongue is gentle as he caresses my pussy. The first time he’s been gentle all night.

He pushes back, standing to his feet then pulls me from the desk and turns me around. He grabs my breasts and pinches my nipples. “When I saw those men watching you on the bar, leering at what’s mine, I nearly burned the fucking place down.”

“Nik, I-”

“I thought about all the ways I could punish you Emelia,” he growls, “but truthfully, the thought of giving you pain does not bring me any pleasure.”

I exhale slowly as Nikolai's hands curl my waist. He leans forward, his lips brushing the shell of my ear. "But that doesn't mean I'm not going to spank the fuck out of you."

I'm pushed down before I can reply. One hand binding my wrists behind my back, bending me across the desk while the other rubs at my ass cheeks. Then a hard smack.

I jolt forward at the pain as a loud moan leaves my lips.

Another smack, harder this time.

I feel my skin burning, even though Nikolai rubs the area he just reddened. One more smack.

Nikolai lets out a groan, taking in his handy work on my bottom. I feel it, the print of his large hand buzzing on my skin. "What a pretty fucking sight," he moans, running his hands over the marks and spreading me with his thumbs.

I bite my lip as I feel his cock greeting my entrance. "Tell me you're my whore," he commands.

"I'm your whore Nikolai," I moan, breathless.

He shoves his cock into me and pounds roughly. The feeling both painful and exquisite as he continues to drive himself in and out of me. "Don't you ever fucking forget who you belong to," he pushes me down further, slamming his cock into me now, "my ring is on your finger, the taste of my cock is on your lips," he thrusts harder, rubbing my clit, "my cum drips between your delicious thighs."

My pussy tightens, spasming around his thick cock, I grip his arms as I orgasm.

“Mmm, that’s my good girl, now keep those sexy fucking legs open for me while I cum inside of your perfect little cunt,” he growls.

He pushes harder and harder then finally I feel the throb inside of me as he fills me with his hot cum. My legs shake but he holds me up against him as he trails kisses along my shoulder and neck.

Slowly he pulls himself out of me as he continues to kiss my shoulders as he holds me against him. He releases his grip then moves around the desk to pick up my dress then from the floor. Nik dresses me, then dresses himself.

He cups my face then kisses me, sweetly, reverently. “I love you, baby.”

“I love you too,” I murmur.

He wraps his arm around my waist as we exit through the back of the club before quickly peeling away in his car.

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CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE



NIKOLAI

I hold my hand out as Emelia lifts from the seat.

She takes it with a bright smile as she stands to her feet. She looks breathtaking in a baby-blue sundress, corseted at her breasts, hugging her waist then falling delicately down to her knees. My smile widens as I notice that she's wearing the diamond earrings and tennis bracelet I've gifted her. She's utter fucking perfection.

She holds a large gift box in her hands, first editions of her mother's famous children's books, expertly wrapped.

James helps Samantha lift from the backseat as we stand in the courtyard of Roman's home.

Emelia's eyes widen as she takes in the large villa.

"This is beautiful," she smiles.

I take her hand and lead us through the front door. Everyone's arrived already and mingling in the backyard while Roman and Maksim stand near the bar engaged in a light, hearty conversation as they sip on dark liquor. We begin to cross the sunken living room when a familiar face moves towards me.

"Nikolai, you look very well nephew," Aunt Alma, Roman's mother, smiles as she wraps her arms around me.

"And you look even more beautiful than the last time I saw you," I grin as I kiss her cheek.

"Ты лжёшь, но я все равно приму комплимент [te vres, no ya vsyo ravno primou compliment - You lie but I'll take the compliment either way]," she laughs.

Her attention then turns to Emelia and her eyes widen.

"This must be Emelia," she smiles. "Она совершенно прекрасна, Николай [ona sovershenno prekrasna, nikolai - She's absolutely beautiful Nikolai]."

Emelia tilts her head at me.

"She says that you're beautiful," I grin.

"Oh," she laughs. "That's quite a compliment coming from you."

"You humour me darling," she smiles as she takes her hand, admiring the engagement ring. "We should really start teaching you some Russian," she drops her voice to a whisper, "then Nikolai won't be able to keep anything from you."

Emelia laughs. "I've asked Maria to start teaching me. Меня зовут Эмилия Морелли [menya zovut emilia morelli - My name is Emelia

Morelli].”

I chuckle and wrap my arm around her waist. “Ненадолго [nedolgo - Not for long].”

Aunt Alma smiles warmly. “Alina would have absolutely loved you,” she pauses, “come, you must meet my grandson.”

She leads us outside, where the men raise their glasses in greeting as we step over the threshold.

James and Samantha drift ahead, quickly falling into conversation with Yelena and her sister.

I guide Emelia forward, toward Maksim.

“Nikolai.” He nods with a smile as we approach. “And this must be Emelia. It’s a pleasure to finally meet you. I’m Maksim.”

Emelia returns his smile, her expression bright. “It’s lovely to meet you, Maksim.”

“He’s going to be arranging the move for you, he’ll have all your things moved into the villa and clear your apartment for you.”

She turns to me. “I was thinking that I should do it. It’s the end of a chapter,” she smiles, “feels like something I need to do myself.”

I brush her hair from her face. “I don’t know how I feel about you being eight hours away from me.”

“She won’t be alone,” Maksim offers. “We can still have everything moved, as you need Emelia.”

She turns to him. “I appreciate it, thank you.”

My arm is still wrapped around Emelia's waist when a familiar voice echoes behind me. "Давненько не виделись, брат [davno ne videlis, bratt - Long time, brother]."

A grin pulls at my lips as I turn to see Dominik, my little brother, walking towards us. A cocky smirk plastered on his face as he walks without a care in the fucking world. His dark hair moves effortlessly in the light breeze, his green eyes locked on me. It's been just over a year since I've seen Dom. The day we buried Victoria.

While I focused on hunting her killer, he tried blocking it out. Spending his time in the beds of many women and men, sometimes both. At thirty, he parties.

Drinks.

Drugs.

Fucks.

And he can, he has more money than he knows what to do with. He's never been particularly interested in business, but I forced him into a property and business portfolio when he turned twenty-one. Even without my money or our parents, he would still be filthy fucking rich.

He opens his arms as he nears me. "No hug?" He grins.

He doesn't wait for me to answer before wrapping his arms around my shoulders. "You never were one for affection were you brother," his gaze falls to Emelia, "although from what I've heard, that has changed."

He releases his grip and moves to Emelia who chuckles as he hugs her. "My future sister-in-law," he smiles as he takes her in.

"You and I are going to get to know each other very well."

She chuckles, eyes glittering. “I can’t wait.”

Maksim and Roman chuckle. “Don’t believe everything he says Emelia,” Roman starts. “Especially if he tries to tell you about how he beat up that gang of bikers,” he laughs.

Maksim playfully taps his shoulder as he joins him in a laugh.

“I could have handled that on my own,” he rolls his eyes.

I grin. “Is that why you called me?”

Dom shakes his head. “Don’t listen to them Emelia. Their memories aren’t what it used to be.”

He pauses then lifts her left hand as he looks at the engagement ring.

“It looks beautiful on you,” he smiles.

She nods as he gently releases her hand.

“Em, did you know Yelena’s sister is an archaeologist?”

James smiles as he walks towards her.

Then, I see it, the moment Dominik’s eyes meet James’s.

It’s instant.

“James, this is Dominik, Nik’s brother,” she says with a smile.

Dom reaches out first. James’s bright eyes remain locked in his gaze as his hand begins to lift. Emelia notices it too. The sudden tension.

“It’s a pleasure to meet you James,” Dom grins as he grips his hand.

James nods. “You as well Dominik. I wasn’t aware that Nikolai had a brother.”

Dom chuckles. “That doesn’t surprise me,” he shoots me a look. “He keeps his younger, more attractive brother hidden from the world.”

I roll my eyes and wrap my arms around Emelia. Her eyes are glued to the interaction between Dom and James.

James is a good man. Dominik, although my brother, is not. I won't interfere, at least for now.



I arrive in London. Dark clouds begin to roll in as I move towards the town car waiting for me on the tarmac.

The car slips away from Heathrow airport, trading the tangle of motorways for stretches of winding country roads. The car crunches up the drive, rounding the fountain before rolling to a stop in front of the large double doors at the entrance.

The driver opens my door with a nod. I exit and straighten my jacket as I exhale sharply. The sky has completely greyed. If I were a superstitious man, I'd call it an omen. But I'm not. In this world, luck is nothing more than a fantasy for the hopeful.

I reach for my gun as I near the two security guards standing near the door.

"Mr Kirovsky," the one greets as he holds out the silver tray. I place my gun down with a nod. The second guard opens the door for me to enter. My mood is tense. More tense than I've felt in a long time. Perhaps because it's the first time, I'll be seeing Katherine since I butchered her men in her home. Or since she sent hers to attack my Emelia.

My fists clench at the thought as I walk down the hallway to the large room up ahead. I need to watch my words carefully today. All I want to do is

bury my chamber into Katherine's skull. I want to watch every drop of blood pour from her lifeless body.

I cross the threshold into the banqueting room. The members are seated around a long rectangular, solid mahogany table polished to a mirror finish. Eyes are focused on Katherine as she sits at the head.

"Nikolai," she smiles as I walk in.

I nod then take the empty seat beside Suoh.

"Thank you all for joining, we have important issues to discuss today," she starts. "First, Nikolai informed me that Dmitri has been spying on him. He found listening devices planted around his estate months ago."

Eyes turn to me. Brows are raised.

"As you know, Hector and the team have run a courtesy sweep of your homes, and we can confirm that no-one else has been affected." She continues.

Suoh and Zeek's eyes are both fixed on me, a knowing look on their faces. My team ran sweeps on their homes after Katherine's team pretended to. She was listening. To all of us.

"We do however have intel, that has helped us narrow the search," she turns to me, "we've found Dmitri."

What the fuck?

"Where?" I snap.

She grins. "Portugal, there was a shootout with my men but, we can confirm that he took at least one bullet."

"You should have told me the minute you had eyes on him Katherine," I yell.

She exhales sharply. “I’m afraid, the events unfolded too quickly for that Nikolai,” she pauses, “which brings me to why I’ve gathered us all here today.”

The door clicks open as footsteps enter behind me. A chilling air brushes against the back of my head, but I don’t look. Footsteps near then round the table, walking towards Katherine. She beams as she stares at the man walking towards her.

“I would like to introduce our new member,” she grins.

The man turns, facing everyone.

What. The. Fuck.

“Aleksandr Woznyuk,” she continues as she claps her hands together.

He steps forward, eyes of interest and confusion on him.

“Thank you, Katherine, for welcoming me, it has been a pleasure getting to know you,” he lifts her hand to his lips before gently dropping it. “And I look forward to getting to know you all.”

His eyes fall to me, burning with intensity. Katherine gestures for him to take a seat, which he does, opposite me.

“I trust that you will all welcome Aleksandr as you have been welcomed,” Katherine smirks. “Nikolai, I believe you know each other.”

I stare at Aleksandr as he sinks in the chair. “We do not.”

He grins. “You still don’t remember me?”

I lean back, taking him in. What fucking game is he playing?

I shake my head.

He chuckles as he stares at me. “Don’t worry,” he pauses, “Я обновлю вашу память [ya osveju tvoyu pamyat - I’ll refresh your memory].”

I exhale sharply. Threatening me so blatantly calls for violence. I think it’s time I look into Aleksandr, since he enjoys playing these futile little games, I’ll play one too.

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CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR



NIKOLAI

Emelia sits on the bathroom sink in a white, silk gown.

Legs dangling on either side of me as I stand with a towel around my waist, body still wet from the shower as I shave.

“Gretchen loved the book! I can’t wait to show you the cover mock-ups, it’s so good,” she smiles, lifting her shoulders animatedly.

“I can’t wait to see it,” I chuckle. I fucking love her like this.

So much passion and drive. I could listen to her talk about her books all damn day long.

She reaches beside her and pulls a small pill box forward. Her fucking birth control.

My brows raise. I reach for her thigh. “What if I asked you to stop taking those?”

She chuckles. “What if I told you, I need a wedding first?”

“Okay,” I squeeze her thigh then return my gaze to the mirror as I finish up my shave. “Get dressed and we’ll go to the chapel. I’m sure Vitaly wouldn’t mind squeezing in a wedding today.”

A laugh rings from her throat. “No, I need more than an hour to plan Nikolai.”

She drops her gaze as a smile sweeps her face. “I do like the idea of Vitaly marrying us, and the chapel would be perfect.” Her eyes pour into mine as I meet her gaze.

I lean my head down and kiss her. “Just give me a date baby.”

I drop the razor and give her my full attention. I pull at the belt of the gown, letting it fall open. Emelia takes a deep, slow breath as I run my hands along her naked stomach. “I can’t wait to start a family with you,” I murmur.

She wraps her arms around my neck, letting her gown fall open completely as she presses her perfect, soft, pillowy lips against me. I push my tongue into her mouth as I reach up and cup her breasts. I lean back and flick her nipples with my thumb. “Where would you like our honeymoon to be, *milaya*?”

She reaches for my towel and lets it fall to the ground.

She shoots me a cheeky grin as she wraps her warm, soft fingers around my hardening cock. “Somewhere warm, where we can be barely dressed or maybe somewhere cold where we need to have our bodies close together for warmth.”

“Either. Both,” I press my lips against her neck. “You choose.

We can spend the next year of our life just travelling the fucking world.”

I reach between her thighs and run my thumb along the slit of her pussy. Slowly. Purposefully, watching a soft breath escape her lips as she leans back. Giving herself to me.

My other hand cups her large, full, fantastic breasts. “How much bigger do think these will get when you’re pregnant?” I wink at her while circling her rosy nipples.

“I don’t know,” she laughs.

“I can’t wait to find out,” I smirk as I push a finger inside of her.

Her eyes close as I open her lips with mine and kiss her. She wraps her arms around my neck as she moans into my mouth.

I withdraw my finger, rubbing her nectar on my cock as I position myself between her.

Emelia licks her full lips as she grins at me. “Take me to the bed.”

I lift her, letting her wrap her legs around my waist as I carry her to the bedroom. I move to lay her on the bed when she stops me.

“Lay down, Mr Kirovsky,” she grins, already guiding me onto the bed. I chuckle as I do what she wants. My head rests on the pillow as I watch her, moving around the bed until she’s at the end. Her beautiful eyes glitter with mischief as she drops the gown and crawls to me.

“Mmm,” I moan. “What a beautiful sight this is.”

She moves between my legs then runs her tongue along the length of my aching hard cock. I lick my lips as my head falls back.

She wraps her lips around my tip then begins to suck, gently, slowly then picking up the pace as she takes me in deeper. She brushes her thick long hair over her shoulder as she fixes her gaze on me.

She sucks harder, running her perfect little tongue on all the spots I need her to. Then she tugs my fucking balls. “Fuck,”

I exclaim. Nearly painting the inside of her throat with my cum. My dick vibrates in her throat as she chuckles. “My baby is being very naughty,” I say, fighting the urge to flip her over and teach her a lesson.

My dick juts out of her mouth as she giggles before positioning herself on top of me. She teases my cock between the slit of her pussy. Rubbing against me. Rocking her hips in dangerously sexy circles. Stimulating her needy little clit with my hard, aching tip. Making me lose my fucking mind.

“Emelia, if you don’t put my dick inside of you right fucking now, I swear to God...”

She laughs, continuing her slow torture. “Say please,” she grins.

I lean forward, gripping her nipple between my lips as I squeeze her ass. “Please,” I beg.

Emelia bites her lip then pushes me back down. She lifts her hips, then slowly sinks onto me.

“Fuck,” my head falls back in satisfaction, finally feeling the delicious stretch of her pussy as she opens up for me.

Her hips move in a sensual rhythm as she rides me. She spreads her legs wider, giving me the perfect view of her pretty little cunt taking every inch of my cock.

“Oh my God,” she moans, rolling her hips faster now.

I lick the tip of my fingers then reach between her thighs, rubbing her perfectly swollen clit.

“Yes,” she cries out. “Touch my pussy just like that.”

“Such a naughty girl today,” I grin, increasing the pace of my fingers.

Emelia’s hips begin to slow. I lean forward grabbing her hips then flip her onto her back.

I press my lips against hers as I thrust into her. She wants to ride me and tease me with this delicious body of hers then she’s going to get fucked, hard.

I rub her clit, coating my fingers with her then placing them in her mouth, letting her suck while I pound into her.

She moans loudly as give her every single inch of me. “Naughty girls get fucked hard baby,” I grin.

Her pussy spasms as she begins to cum. I’m tempted to get my fucking gun again and make her squirt but there’s no time for that now. I run my tongue along the slope of her neck as my cock throbs. “Who do you belong to baby?”

She replies with a breathless moan, “you.”

My cock twitches, then a thick, wonderful, hot release of cum fills her.

I bury my head in her neck as she runs her hands through my hair.



I sit in my office, shooting off a text to Luka.

Send me everything you can find on Aleksandr Woznyuk.

Luka replies quickly.

Understood. I’m looking into it.

I barely rest my phone on my desk when Viktor frantically rushes into my office. “Nikolai, it’s the chapel. It’s on fire.”

I lift to my feet immediately and rush to the garage. In moments I'm peeling out of the estate gates.

Clouds of smoke bellow in the distance, wafting in the air against the dark night sky. Viktor drives behind me. I stop the car abruptly as we reach the burning building. The front doors are completely engulfed in flames. Impossible to enter.

I shout to Viktor as he pulls up behind me. "Use the hose until the fire department arrives." I rush around the building to the back of the chapel. I kick the locked door down and enter.

The air is hot, nearly unbreathable. "Vitaly?" I yell.

I move through the rectory, smoke fogging my vision.

I nearly trip as my feet meet resistance. My eyes drop to the ground. A sharp breath escapes my throat as I see Joanne's lifeless body laying on the floor. I crouch and lift her wrist. No pulse. Her face is bruised and bloodied. She was murdered.

My eyes lift as I hear noise ahead, I follow it. A low groan fills the air as I reach the nave. Smoke nearly engulfs the entire space. I keep moving forward until I find the source of the groans.

I still as I see Father Vitaly's body laid on the altar. In his sleepwear. Bloodied and torn now. I move towards him and drop to my knees beside him.

There's blood everywhere, bruising everywhere. This was a brutal attack. His eyes flicker open, blinking away the blood dripping from his head as his eyes find mine.

"Nikolai..." he manages. His voice low and shaky.

“I’m getting you out of here,” I say, reaching my hands beneath him.

He coughs, turning his head as blood drips from his lips. His hand wraps around my arm as his eyes lock onto mine. “It’s my time, my boy,” he rasps.

“No.” I attempt to lift him, but he cries out in pain at the movement.

“Nikolai,” he says, staring at me, “you need to go.”

I shake my head. “I’m not leaving you,” I say, looking around the room for something, anything to help.

His shaky fingers reach toward the gun on my hip.

“Please,” he whispers.

My eyes widen. “No.”

He coughs blood again. “Nikolai, please...” His eyes pour into me.

Pleading.

Asking what he knows he cannot.

He’s in pain and he needs me to end it.

“I can’t...” my voice low and uneven.

“Please...” he begs as his shaky hands reach for me again.

I swallow hard as my throat dries. My eyes close for a moment, forcing back the tears threatening to fall. I’ve never felt guilt taking a life.

They all deserved it.

Vitaly, does not.

He served his community with love and kindness for over fifty years. He was the kind of man that I could never dream to be. And here he was, asking me to put him out of his misery.

The fire continues to rage around us. I can hear the fire engine outside as the men try to tame the blaze.

I stare at him and take his hand into mine. "Thank you, for everything..." I manage.

His lips curl into a small smile as I reach for my gun. I take a deep breath as I point it towards his temple. He begins to pray through staggered breaths.

"Our Father, who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy name.
Thy kingdom come,
thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our trespasses,
as we forgive those who trespass against us.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil. Amen."

I pull the trigger. A tear falls down my cheek as I stare at Vitaly's lifeless body. I place his hands on his chest before lifting to my feet. My anger is loud. I throw a fist into the wooden podium, crushing and stomping it until it's no more than a pile of debris. I'm a sinner. I was born one. But this sin, this will haunt me. Vitaly and Joanne's blood are on my hands. Good, kind people who had the misfortune of meeting me.

My head turns to the entrance doors as the fire fighters are attempting to breakthrough.

Then I see it.

The message.

Spraypainted red on the white walls:

Now you'll never forget me.

A cold chill runs through me. Fucking Aleksandr.

I move through the chapel, back to the rectory and out the back door. I round the chapel to find Viktor. My phone buzzes as I reach him. A message from Luka.

Took a lot of digging, but I found him.

Vladimir Woznyuk

He was his older brother

He was brought into the Krovavy Krug.

You killed him Nikolai.

I reply quickly.

Send me everything you find.

“There’s traces of gasoline around the chapel, this was arson,”

Viktor says.

I stare at the flames. “This was a message,” I pause, “stay and let me know once the fire has been put out.”

He nods in reply.

I move towards the car and drive back to the estate. My fingers grip the wheel tightly as I drive quickly, recklessly. But I don’t care, I just need her. I need to not feel this fucking sick anymore.

I push through the front doors to find Emelia already waiting for me on the staircase. “Roman told me...” she starts.

I move to the centre of the foyer; eyes locked on her as I fall to my knees. She rushes toward me.

“I couldn’t save them...” I choke out.

She wraps herself around me, holding my head to her chest as she strokes my hair. “It’s okay, it’ll be okay,” she whispers.

I hold onto her tighter, my anchor in this dark fucking world.

“Vitaly’s gone,” I murmur as tears finally fall down my cheeks.

A sob escapes her throat as she tightens her grip on me. “Do you know who...?”

I nod against her chest. I’m going to make Aleksandr regret the day he was ever fucking born. I am going to hunt him and rip the soul out of his worthless fucking body before I gut every single limb.

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CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE



EMELIA

I wrap my arms around James's shoulders.

A hug filled with sadness as we say goodbye at the airport. "I'm so sorry we didn't get to do everything we planned," I murmur.

"That's okay, babe, we understand," Sam says with a smile. "Besides, now we've got a reason to come back. Nikolai promised us a yacht trip," she winks.

Leaning back, I take James's hands, curiosity tugging at me. "So... what did you two end up doing yesterday?"

He chuckles. "Dominik invited us to a party. Would've been rude to say no, Em."

Sam bursts out laughing. "Yeah right, he was practically glued to his hip."

Oh. My. God.

A grin spreads across my face. "I knew you liked him."

James shrugs with a cheeky grin. "He's... interesting."

Sam shoots me a knowing smile.

“I love you guys so much,” I say, pulling them both into a hug. “I hope I show you that enough.”

“We love you too, babe,” James replies warmly.

“It’s the three amigos, forever,” Sam adds, tightening her grip.

“I’ll see you soon though. I’ll need your help packing up my apartment,” I remind them.

“Yes boss,” Sam chuckles.

Tears begin to well. Then the boarding call crackles over the intercom. My heart sinks as I wave goodbye and watch them disappear toward the terminal.

Viktor waits for me at the SUV. We’re halfway to the estate when Nik calls him.

“Nikolai,” he answers, putting the call on speaker.

“Is Emelia home yet?” He asks.

“We’re nearly there,” he replies, shooting me a look.

Nik pauses, “meet me at the chapel after you’ve dropped her. Roman and Maksim are already on their way.”

Viktor nods. “I’ll be there soon.”

“Am I on speaker?” He asks.

Viktor chuckles, “you would kill me if I drove Emelia with a phone in my hand.”

I lean forward with a grin.

“I love you baby,” Nikolai coos.

I smile. "I love you too."

I lean back in the seat after Nik ends the call, taking in the view of the clear open road ahead.

The little town has been in mourning since Father Vitaly's death. He was a pillar of the community. At his funeral I learned about all the lives he's changed. Too many to all speak, otherwise we would have been there for hours. He lived for his community, and his legacy would live on, Nikolai would make sure of that. He personally took on the costs for the reconstruction of the chapel and the cost to relocate the new priest, Father Ferguson.

"What's going to happen now? With Aleksandr?"

He exhales sharply. "He needs to be put down."

I nod in understanding. "And Katherine?"

He shoots me a look. "She's being dealt with."

His words are cut short by the screech of tires, a sound so sharp it drowns out everything else. I suck in a breath just as another car barrels straight toward us. There's no time to react.

Impact slams us into chaos, metal twisting, glass shattering, bodies thrown against steel and plastic.

Shards slice into my arm and shoulder. My head smashes against the side panel, a burst of pain and the warm trickle of blood. Dazed, I blink through the haze, turning toward Viktor in the driver's seat. Blood streams from his nose and forehead, but his eyes are sharp. He's already reaching for his gun, assessing the wreck.

Our car lies upside down on the side of the road, metal groaning as several pairs of legs rush toward us.

Guns drawn.

Aimed at us.

Viktor's phone has landed beside my head. I grab it with trembling fingers and dial Nikolai.

"Viktor," he answers coolly.

"Nik, someone hit us. There are men, I don't know how many, guns-" The words tumble out of me in a rush.

"I'm coming." His voice shifts, strained, and I hear the pounding of his footsteps, the crunch of gravel under his feet as he runs.

"There's six of them..." Viktor grits out, blood on his lips, his eyes locking with mine. And I know. They're going to kill us. Nikolai won't make it in time.

"You keep fucking shooting until I get there, Viktor!"

Nikolai roars into the phone, the growl of his engine exploding in the background.

The men close in, shadows against the broken glass.

"Nik," I sob.

"Baby..." His voice cracks, hoarse and tight with fear.

A gunshot tears into the car, and I drop the phone.

My door is wrenched open, Viktor shoves me back and fires, the bullet slamming into a man's skull. Another round cracks through the car, striking

Viktor's shoulder. I scream as his body jolts, but he keeps shooting, relentless, until the gun clicks empty.

Then another shot hits his arm.

Another to his torso.

Another to his chest.

"Viktor," I scream as the gun falls from his hands. I wrap my arms around him as if I could somehow stop the bleeding, as if I could will this nightmare to end. "I'm so sorry, Viktor," I cry.

A man rushes forward and yanks me out of the car.

"Emelia, keep fighting!" Nikolai screams through the speaker.

"I'm coming."

I kick and push against the man holding me against my will but he's twice my size. In moments I'm forced into the

back of an SUV with a man staring, seated in the space beside me.

"Finally, we meet, Emelia," he smirks.



CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX



NIKOLAI

My knuckles are white.

Gripping the wheel as I rush towards the stationery SUV in the distance.

I can't think.

Can't fucking breathe.

I'm just driving with reckless abandonment. My eyes briefly flick to the mirror, only now noticing Roman's car following behind me. I stop the car abruptly and run out with my gun drawn.

"Emelia!" I shout out. Desperate.

I rush towards the car, dropping to my knees. Then I see him.

Viktor.

Bloodied.

Lifeless.

My heart stills as I take in the sight. Knowing that he died protecting her. Loyal and devoted, right until the end.

Roman and Maksim rush up and yank the driver's door open before pulling him out. Roman attempts CPR, pushing his palms into his chest in rapid succession but it's useless.

A tear falls down his cheek as his movements begin to slow. I reach into the vehicle finding Emelia's purse as her phone rings. My lips tighten as I lift it and stare at the screen. A video call from an unknown number.

I click answer. White hot fury courses through my veins at the sight before me.

"Nikolai," Aleksandr grins, "did you like the gift I left at the chapel?"

My blood is fucking boiling.

"No?" He laughs. He then turns the camera to Emelia, seated beside him. Wrists bound in front of her, struggling against the restraints.

I finally find my words. "Baby, you fight, you keep fighting. I'm coming for you."

Aleksandr laughs, the sound maddening as I rush towards the car. I study the screen, trying to eye the surroundings, finding something familiar. My eyes lift to Maksim who's staring at me. I lift my finger to the shape of an 'L' – he understands. Maksim dials Luka and tells him to trace the call.

"This is between us Aleksandr, let her go." I demand.

He lifts a knife to the screen, the long, thick, silver blade glints against the setting sunlight. My face goes white as he teases the blade against her neck.

"You really are quite a beauty; no wonder Katherine is so incensed with the mere presence of you."

Emelia jerks away. “Stay the fuck away from me.” She lifts her leg and kicks her heel into his shin making him cry out.

“Fucking bitch,” he bites out, then slaps her across the face.

My nails are digging into my flesh, drawing blood as my fists curl. “I’m going to fucking kill you!” I bark.

He pulls her forward by her cardigan and licks the blood on her lip as she yells for him to stop. I nearly crush the phone in my hands.

My vision is blurring.

All I’m seeing is fucking red.

RED. RED. RED.

He turns to me. “I’m going to have so much fun with her.”

He then turns back to Emelia with a sinister grin as he cups her face roughly. “I can’t wait to get a taste of the cunt that’s brought the great Nikolai fucking Kirovsky to his knees.”

My breath stills as he ends the call and the screen goes black.

My heart pounds in my ears until it rings. I see Maksim running towards me, mouthing something. But I can’t hear him. I can barely see him between the flashes of Aleksandr’s filthy hands on her. His tongue on her. The fear in her eyes.

My gaze lifts as Maksim’s a few feet away now.

“We know where he’s going!” He yells as sound finally returns to me. “They’re heading for the port.”

I rush forward towards my car. A few of the other men along with Roman begin to arrive and carefully load Viktor’s body into the SUV.

Maksim accompanies me as I start the car. He's barely closed the door before my foot slams on the accelerator.

I'm coming baby, just hold on.

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CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN



EMELIA

“He’s going to fucking kill you!” I yell.

As hard as I can, I kick and push against Aleksandr’s hold.

His hands wrap around my throat, forcing me against the window of the car as his eyes burn into me.

“He can try, but by then I would have broken every last part of you...” he drawls as he tightens his grip. Constricting my airflow now.

“За нами следят [nas presleduyut - We’re being followed].” The driver shoots over his shoulder.

Aleksandr’s head snaps back to the road. “How the fu-”

In the blink of an eye, an SUV jackknifes into us.

Forcing us into a shipping yard.

The driver loses control and crashes into the brick wall of a warehouse. I'm tossed to the floor, landing between the seats on impact.

The sounds of yelling and gunfire ring out all around us.

My eyes lift to Aleksandr as his face contorts in fury taking in the scene. I use the momentary distraction to kick my heel into his stomach then reach for the door to escape. But I'm not fast enough.

He yanks me back in by my leg with such a force that I'm pulled under him as he hovers over me with a scowl so fierce it's tearing into my soul.

"Such a little fighter," he bites out as he thrusts his groin against me. He quickly retrieves the knife, before I know what's happening, the sharp, jagged, silver edge is impaled into my thigh, cutting through the fabric of my jeans.

Through skin.

Through muscle.

I scream in agony as the pain rushes through me.

"Hold that for me, Emelia, I'll be right back," he grins.

My hands are shaking as I watch Aleksandr pull his gun then join the fight.

"Nik," I cry out, peering through the back window, looking for him. But I don't see him. And I don't recognise any of these men. I turn my attention back to the knife and use my palms to pull it free from my thigh. My legs tremble as pain shoots through me. Blood gushes down my leg, darkening my jeans. I swallow hard as I begin to feel light-headed. I turn the blade of the knife towards the fabric of the restraint around my wrists. I raise my knees

and hold the blade firmly between them as I move my wrists up and down over the serrated edge. The restraints finally loosen and fall.

I peer out the window. I jerk as a bullet is shot at Aleksandr, hitting his shoulder. The shooter runs towards him, but Aleksandr's men are closing in too.

In moments they're ushering him to a nearby car before speeding off. I move across the console to get to the driver's seat.

My eyes flick to the movement in the mirror. The shooter is moving towards my door. I fight the weight of my eyelids as they threaten to close.

I apply pressure to my thigh with my left hand as I start the ignition with my right. The door swings open and a tall man with haunting blue eyes is staring at me. My body leans to the side, too weak to fight anymore.

He presses a hand over mine on my thigh and shouts to a man behind him. "Её ударили ножом [eyo udarili nozhom – she's been stabbed]."

The man then lifts me from the seat into his arms.

"Nikolai's coming," another voice appears behind him.

He exhales sharply. "We can't wait; she's losing blood. Send them instructions to meet us at the safehouse."

My vision blurs as he begins to carry me to another vehicle, setting me down on the backseat before he sits behind the wheel.

"Who are you?" I manage, my voice low and shaky.

His lips thin as he stares at me in the rearview mirror, then the answer rolls off his tongue. "Dmitri."



My head lulls against something soft. My eyes blink open as a man sits on a chair beside me, stitching the wound on my thigh. I feel a sharp sting as he pulls the final stitch. His fingers are bloodied as the strand of cotton pulls through my skin before being tied off.

My eyes roam around the space lazily, still groggy from whatever they had given me. I'm laying on a couch in what appears to be the living room of a cabin. My gaze drifts to the man walking into the room. I inhale sharply. "Dmitri."

He stares at me. Then the man. "Leave us," he commands.

The man nods in reply, he picks up the bloodied discarded tissues with the white and green first aid kit then leaves the room.

"Don't come near me," I spit out, lifting a finger to him as I sit up. The hairs on the back of my neck are raised as our eyes are locked.

"I'm not going to hurt you, Emelia," he says, his voice low but firm.

"Bullshit, you killed Nik's sister!" I hiss.

Dmitri's eyes narrow as he moves towards me. He watches me carefully before pulling a chair in front of me and sitting. His eyes drop to his feet solemnly and I shift my position uncomfortably.

"Victoria was like a sister to me... I would never hurt her," he murmurs.

I stare at him. "Really? Because Nikolai has proof it was you... I don't know what game-

"He saw what she wanted to see," his eyes lift to me.

My brows knit. "Who? Victoria?"

“Katherine,” he exhales sharply.

“What do you mean?” I press.

He lifts to his feet; the action startles me then, he offers me his hand. “Let me show you.”

I stare at his large, outstretched fingers warily and shake my head, “I don’t trust you.”

“That’s fair,” he drops his hand, “but I can show you what really happened that day, if you care to know the truth, Emelia.”

My eyes flick outside, to the window, to the men moving into positions with their guns drawn.

“If I wanted you dead, I wouldn’t have saved you from Aleksandr,” he says, eyes fixed on me.

I swallow hard.

He’s right.

Why did he save me?

Slowly I lift to my feet and cautiously follow Dmitri.



CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT



NIKOLAI

My fingers wrap around the steering wheel.

My foot presses heavily on the accelerator as the cabin edges into view. I'm trying to keep it fucking together but he has her.

HE FUCKING HAS HER.

"Luka says Aleksandr, and his men just boarded a flight, they're heading to London."

My grip tightens. Knuckles white. "I want eyes on him at all times."

Maksim nods in reply.

My eyes flick to the mirror. Several cars behind me.

My men.

All armed and ready to finally reign down fucking war and fury on Dmitri.

His men are ready too. My eyes narrow on them dotted around the cabin, weapons drawn and aimed at us.

I stop and kill the engine as we reach the clearing. I'm out of the car before Maksim can stop me.

"Where the fuck is she?" I yell as I move towards the steps leading to the front door.

My head snaps to the creak of the door opening. Emelia's gaze is focused on me as Dmitri walks her outside with his gun pressed to her side. My eyes drop to her thigh, jeans bloodied with a cloth tied around her.

My eyes then flick back to Dmitri. "You're fucking dead."

Emelia turns to him, a pained look on her face before looking back to me. "Dmitri saved me from Aleksandr," she starts.

"Emelia-

"You need to let him talk to you Nikolai, please," she pleads.

I stare at her, shaking my head. "He needs to pay for what he did to Victoria."

"I didn't kill Victoria..." he says, words biting the air.

My fingers fucking twitch. I move forward. Closer and closer until I reach the steps.

Dmitri's men look to him for instruction. He gives them a simple nod in reply.

"Let her go," I bark, "это между нами, трус [eto mezhdu nami, trus – this is between us, coward]."

“If I let her go, then you’ll kill me before we even have a chance to speak, Nikolai,” he guides Emelia back then gestures to the door with a nod. “You first.”

I exhale sharply. Moving up the stairs as my eyes remain glued to her. I brush my fingers against hers as I pass her. “It’s going to be okay, baby.”

I stare at the gun at her side then my eyes lift to Dmitri.

I swear to God today’s the day he fucking dies.

I enter the cabin with him and Emelia following behind.

Soon, I step into what looks like an office. Wooden panels line the walls, and at the centre stands a desk with an open laptop, a video paused on its screen.

I recognise it immediately. A video I’ve watched a hundred times over. The surveillance footage from when Victoria was murdered.

My head snaps to Dmitri. “Is this a fucking joke?”

“Press play Nikolai,” he insists.

My fists clench, my feet move forward. Eyes locked on him.

“Nik,” Emelia breathes. “Please, watch the video.”

Tears well in her eyes as she stares at me. I exhale slowly then turn to the laptop and press play.

I’ve memorised every frame of the video by now. Ivan is at the wheel; Victoria and Erik sit in the back. Ivan turns right, steering into the tunnel. As the car nears its mouth, another vehicle cuts them off while a second closes in from behind.

Doors fly open. Three men spill out, guns raised. A fourth steps forward, levels his weapon and fires the first shot. Then the barrage begins, bullets raining into the car.

No matter how many times I watch, it never gets easier.

And then it happens, the shooter turns toward the camera.

My stomach drops, my world tilts. Every time before, it was Dmitri's face staring back at me. But this time... this time it isn't. The man in the video... is Aleksandr.

"What the fuck is this?" I bite out.

"The truth Nikolai, Katherine hired Aleksandr, that's how he managed to secure a position in Nocturne," he replies solemnly, eyes fixed on me.

"No, no! It was you! I fucking saw it!"

"She manipulated you Nikolai, she's been at it longer than you realise," he pauses. "She's been weaving her web of lies since the day she took over as head."

I shake my head. It's not possible.

"Did you verify the video with Luka?" He presses, already knowing the answer. "No, because you didn't have a reason not to trust her."

"You wanted to hurt me..." I murmur.

"You know deep down that I wouldn't do this," he presses.

"Really? Because I recall you telling me that you would be coming for me and everyone I love!" I shout.

"I was fucking pissed Nikolai, it was a stupid fucking thing to say but I can't take it back and I certainly didn't fucking mean it," he yells. "Katherine

told me that you were leading the charge to have me removed as a member and when I came to you, you didn't fucking deny it."

"Because why the fuck would I need to Dmitri?" I shout. "You were my brother, how could you ever think that I would betray you?"

"She made me fucking believe it, she lied and manipulated her way into getting everything she fucking wants," he replies.

"How do I know this isn't manipulation?" I bite out.

"... it wasn't about Victoria... it was about Erik. He was the target," he says. "Katherine sent her men, after him. Victoria was just collateral damage to her."

"What the fuck are you talking about?" I press.

"When Frederik and Erik started NeuraTel, Erik took the role as a silent partner so he would be free to travel with Victoria while his brother retained control of the business," he replies.

"I know that Katherine killed Frederik," I exhale sharply.

"Did you also know that Frederik was handing over the reins of the company to Erik? He was set to take over as CEO just a week before his death." Dmitri stares at me.

"Victoria would have told me-"

"She was going to, she planned to tell you that they were moving to Hamburg," he replies, staring at the screen. "She didn't get the chance to..."

I shake my head, staring at the screen. Erik trying to shield Victoria from the bullets.

“She was like a sister to me too Nikolai, I could have never hurt her,” he murmurs. “I had to mourn her death and deal with you hating me for it.”

A tear falls down my cheek as I turn back to the laptop.

To Aleksandr’s face. How could I have been such a fucking fool? All this time, it was fucking Katherine.

Emelia moves towards me; Dmitri’s gun dropped at his side now. Tears well in her eyes as she stares up at me, wrapping her arms around me. I pull her closer, holding her tightly to me as I kiss her head. I’m never letting her out of my fucking sight again.

I cup her face and press my lips against hers in a possessive kiss as she curls into me.

“I’m so sorry *milaya*,” I murmur against her lips.

“Viktor... is he?” she stares up at me, hopeful.

I close my eyes with a slow exhale before shaking my head.

“He’s gone.”

Emelia’s lip curls as she breaks into a sob. I pull her closer, holding her tightly against my chest. She turns her face to Dmitri who offers a small smile. “Dmitri and his men saved me,” she murmurs then looks up to me.

“We’ve had eyes on Aleksandr since everything happened last year. When he took her, we knew we had to intervene,” he nods.

I wipe the tears from her cheek and press several kisses to her lips.

I drop my hand from her waist and move towards Dmitri. His stance rigid and hesitant as I near him.

I still, trying to find my words.

“I cannot thank you enough for saving her,” I pause, stretching out my hand. “I won’t ask for your forgiveness-”

“There’s no need to,” he interrupts. “I understand why you came after me. The only person who deserves blame, is Katherine, she tried to turn us against each other, and she succeeded, for a while.” Dmitri takes my hand then pulls me into a hug. “Ты не можешь разорвать кровную связь [te ne mozes razorvat krovnyuyu svyaz – You cannot break the bond of blood].”

I nod in agreement. “We need to speak to the men.”

I reach for Emelia, pulling her close as the three of us step back into the clearing.

The air is thick with tension, both sides locked in a silent standoff, guns still raised. All eyes follow as Dmitri and I move to the centre, shoulder to shoulder.

“We’ve been fighting a war built on a lie,” I begin, my voice carrying across the space. “Brother against brother, all because of the ambitions of a ruthless woman.”

Dmitri inclines his head. “No longer. We are brothers, all of us. And we will not allow anyone to divide us again.”

“Katherine and Aleksandr will be hunted down and made to pay for the ruin they’ve caused,” I say, sweeping my gaze across the gathered men. “But tonight, we celebrate. Tonight, we stand as one, a force so strong, so powerful, that our enemies will tremble at the sight of us. Tomorrow night, we meet at the estate to begin repairing what others tried to destroy.”

I turn to Dmitri. He steps forward, pulls me into a firm embrace, and taps my shoulder, a gesture of solidarity, of brotherhood restored.

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CHAPTER THIRTY-NINE



EMELIA

I reach my arm out for him as my eyes flutter open.

My hand glides across the cool, white, silk sheet of our bed, searching for his warmth but not finding it. My gaze moves to the sound of water falling from the bathroom. I turn and lift my phone, checking the time. Just after midnight. I grin as the water turns off.

Sitting up, I remove my nightgown and toss it aside. I lift from the duvet and sit on my knees.

Naked.

Waiting.

The scent of his bodywash lingers in the air. Fresh and clean

but unmistakably masculine. Notes of cedarwood and dark amber curl around me, warm and grounding, softened by a faint trace of citrus that lingers like sunlight. The kind of scent that

makes me want to be close, to breathe him in again and again, until it's imprinted on me completely.

Nik's eyes are on his phone as he leaves the bathroom in just a white towel around his waist. *My* eyes are fixed on that muscular chest, painted with tattoos that I just love to spend time tracing with my fingers.

His black hair damp, glistening in the light of the bathroom as he crosses the threshold into our room.

He's the most incredible man I've ever laid my eyes on.

And I am his, forever his.

"Did you have fun with Dmitri?" I grin, voice low and teasing as his eyes finally lift to me.

He smirks as he takes me in then tosses his phone onto the couch before dropping his towel to the floor. He moves towards me with fire in his eyes.

"I did," he grins. "We had a lot to catch up on."

He reaches me. He runs his fingers across my cheek, regarding my face with sweet reverence as I stare up at him. My eyes close at his touch. Firm, commanding and yet divinely comforting.

"How many men did you kill tonight?" I ask, eyes slowly lifting back up to him.

His face darkens as a grin pulls at his lips. "Four."

"Was Aleksandr one of them?" I ask.

He shakes his head as he moves his hand to my neck. "Not yet, I have plans for him."

He joins me on the bed, then presses firm, hot kisses to my cheeks and along the slope of my neck.

“He’s going to wish for death, but I will not grant it.

Not until I have broken every part of him. I want to watch the life slowly drain from his eyes for ever even thinking of coming near you.” He pushes my hair back then returns his lips to my neck.

Nikolai’s facial hair rubs against my skin with that delicious roughness I’m addicted to. “As for Katherine,” he murmurs, still kissing my skin, “she’s gone into hiding now that her lies are being exposed and she’s been exiled from Nocturne. But I have men already hunting her down.” He grins then cups my face. “What do you think would be an adequate death for her, *milaya?*”

My lips curl into a grin. “I shouldn’t say.”

He chuckles then presses a kiss to my lips. “Tell me.”

I lick my lips as my eyes pour into him. “She’s taken so many innocent lives, Victoria, Erik, Ivan, Frederick and his family,” she pauses, “she even tried to turn you against James, putting his life in danger, and then turning you against Dmitri. She deserves the worst kind of death,” I murmur. “She needs to burn.”

Nikolai’s eyes darken as he wraps his arms around me and guides me down onto the bed, settling on top of me. “I would be more than happy to let you do the honours, baby,” he smirks, kissing my hand. His lips then return to mine as he pushes his tongue into my mouth, stealing my breath with a passionate, pulse flickering kiss.

The tip of his cock greets my core as he grinds against me before slowly thrusting inside of me.

I love the way Nikolai loves me. He kisses me as if he can't stand not to, fucks me as if it gives him life. He looks at me as if I'm the most precious thing in the world. As if I would shatter into a million pieces without the ferocity of his protection and possessiveness. His love, loyalty and devotion have no bounds. He would burn the world for me, and I love him so fucking much that I would bend my knees on the ashes and ruin to thank him for it.

He's everything that I dreamed a man could be. He's my dark fairytale. A twisted love story written just for us. And everyone knows, villains fuck better.

He buries his face in my neck as he thrusts in and out of me. My eyes roll back as I moan. He fills me so perfectly, hitting every needy spot.

My walls begin to tighten as my pussy spasms with delicious release. His large hand grips my hips as he thrusts harder.

"I love you baby," he whispers, trailing kisses against my neck.

"I love you," I breathe, wrapping my arms around his shoulders as I widen my legs, ready, eager for him to fill me.

He holds my eyes captive under his dark enchantment as his cock throbs, pumping every single drop of cum into me as if he can outfuck my birth control.

To his credit, he's certainly been trying. Perhaps I should tell him that I finally tossed that out the minute we arrived back home.



It's the strangest feeling, returning to the place I once called home. James is waiting at the airport as Dmitri, Maksim, and I move together through the private hangar.

Nik insisted they accompany me since he had to leave urgently, to meet with Suoh in Prague, setting a trap for Katherine there. He's mentioned a weapons armoury, but I have no idea what significance it has or why she seems determined to get her perfectly manicured hands on it.

Aleksandr is also still free and still trying to hurt Nikolai. We won't be safe until he and Katherine are found and made to pay for what they've done.

"Look at you, walking around with your muscle," James teases as he nears me. I wrap my arms around him and squeeze him into a tight hug. "Shut up, I know you missed me."

He chuckles against my hair. "Of course I missed you," he pauses then leans back as his fingers cup my chin. "I don't know how I'm going to get used to being so far from you."

"Dominik is in Moscow," Maksim grins.

My head snaps to James. "Is there something you need to tell me?"

He rolls his eyes with a laugh, wrapping his arm around my waist, leading the way outside, avoiding my question.

Standing in my two-bedroom apartment again after nearly eight months feels, strange. *I feel strange.*

Like I don't belong here anymore. Perhaps I never have.

I belong to him. With him.

I smile as I move to my old bedroom. A beautiful bouquet of red roses is waiting for me on my bed with a note.

Missing you already baby...

Forever yours, Nik

Soon I'll be Mrs Emelia Kirovsky. God, if only that awkward fourteen-year-old me could see how far we've come. I finally have the love that I desperately craved all my life.

I have a man who worships the ground I walk on. Nikolai loves every single part of me with a ferocity that I didn't know could be possible. His love clings to me like a whisper, lingering in the air wherever I go. No matter the distance, he is always with me.

"One pepperoni, cheese, barbeque chicken and," James pauses, leaning against the kitchen island as he scrunches his nose, "ham and pineapple?"

I laugh, turning to Maksim who rolls his eyes. "Don't knock it until you've tried it, pretty boy."

"Pretty boy?" He chuckles, "I quite like that," he shoots me a wink.

Dmitri grabs the box with pepperoni and sits on the floor beside me as I finish taping another box. My cozy apartment is becoming a lot cozier by the minute as brown craft boxes fill the space.

Maksim lifts to his feet as a knock sounds at the door. He grabs a slice of ham and pineapple pizza, shooting a wide grin at James before opening the door.

"Right on time," he says, greeting the movers with a nod.

"Everything goes into the truck besides the boxes in the guest room," he directs them through the living room then down the hall.

Dmitri's gaze moves to a photo album, tucked into a pedestal beside the couch. Curiously, he opens it and flicks through images of my life before.

The only time pictures meant anything to me.

“Are these your parents?” He asks, eyes lifting to me with a small smile as he points to an image of my mom and dad standing behind me on my third birthday, smiling and laughing as I blow out my birthday candles.

“I heard that you lost them young, I’m sorry Emelia,” he tilts his head with a sympathetic smile.

I lift my knees to my chest and cradle my legs, eyes glued on the photos. “It still shocks me how one person could cause so much ruin,” I murmur. “Three lives were taken that day and all he received was a fourteen-year sentence...”

“Does Nikolai know this?” He asks, curiously.

My brows knit, returning my gaze to him, “no, why?”

Dmitri exhales softly with a smile. “Seems like something he would be very on keen on correcting for you.”

I shake my head with a soft exhale.

Dmitri’s eyes lift to James with a grin. “I watched your interview with Sergei Volodin.”

James chuckles. “Friend of yours?”

“Abso-fucking-lutely not,” Dmitri scoffs. “His administration is solely responsible for displacing thousands of people.”

James nods. “It’s appalling.”

“It is,” he starts. “You should’ve killed him when you had the chance.”

James laughs. “Unfortunately, as tempted as I was, I can only use my words as my weapon. From what I’ve heard, it’s unlikely that he will be

receiving another term.”

“And when he’s been stripped of that fancy security detail of his, I suppose there’s nothing stopping someone of, seeking reparations,” Dmitri grins.

I laugh. “I can see why you and Nik are friends.”

Dmitri rises to his feet, moving to the fridge to grab a bottle of water when there’s another knock on the front door.

“There she is!” I exclaim, as the door opens to Sam standing in the hallway with a bright smile.

“Looks like someone finally got away from her very important meeting to grace us with her presence,” James teases.

My head tilts as I notice Dmitri leaning against the doorframe with his arms crossed, blocking her.

“Is this your new bodyguard, Emelia?” She chuckles as she grins at him with a flicker of fire in her eyes. She tries to sidestep but his hand snaps forward.

“I didn’t get your name,” he smirks.

She stares up at him. “What makes you think you deserve it?”

He chuckles. “By the way you’re undressing me with your eyes, it’s only polite, don’t you think?”

“Oh please,” she scoffs with a laugh.

“Sam, quit flirting and get your ass over here,” James rolls his eyes.

Dmitri grins at her as he lifts his hand, finally giving her passage.

“Sam,” he drawls, as if to feel her name on his tongue.

“You look like trouble,” he eyes her up and down.

She moves by him, close enough to drop her voice to a near whisper. “I am.”

The movers have done a great job of stripping the apartment of everything. I hadn’t noticed how white and clinical these walls are now that they’re bare. Soon, this will be the home of a new inhabitant. The start of their story as my chapter comes to an end. The five of us lay on sleeping bags in the middle of the living room as it nears midnight. Yes, we could have just booked a hotel, but this is my last night here. It feels wrong to just leave as if my time here meant nothing.

“Full house,” Sam laughs as she stares at Dmitri sitting on the floor across from her as they play poker. “Pay up, tough guy,” she teases.

He laughs. “You’ve taken all my cash, Samantha, I’ll just have to find another way to pay you.” His eyes drop to her lips then slowly return to her eyes.

“Get a room,” James tosses, laying beside me as his eyes remain fixed on his phone. “Actually, it’s super echoey in here without

furniture, so if you’re going to have sex, do it in a different apartment.”

Sam’s brow lifts as she holds Dmitri’s stare, clearly tempted by the idea.

The lights go out before she has a chance to reply.

“They weren’t supposed to turn the power off until tomorrow,” I complain.

Dmitri’s brows knit as he quickly lifts to his feet and moves to the window. He stares into the courtyard at the other units in the complex.

“Everyone’s dark.”

His eyes widen as he stares at men running through the courtyard, dressed in all black. Guns drawn.

“They’re coming,” he barks at Maksim. He doesn’t hesitate. He grabs his phone and shoots a text to their men.

“What the fuck?” I exclaim, staring into the courtyard at roughly ten men racing towards the staircase. I don’t need Maksim or Dmitri to confirm it. They’re coming for me.

Blonde hair glints in the moonlight as Katherine makes her way through the courtyard. Her eyes lift to mine, staring down at her from the fifth floor. My fists curl at the sight of her.

“Take Emelia and Samantha to the roof and barricade the door,” Maksim instructs James then hands him a gun.

“Do you know how to use that?” Sam asks, concerned.

James nods. “Point and shoot.”

“There’s a fire escape ladder to the left of the bathroom window,” I shoot to Dmitri as I reach for my phone and text Nikolai.

Katherine’s here.

I’ll call you when it’s over.

I love you.

A bullet crashes through the window barely missing Sam. Glass falls on her as she yells out. Dmitri hands me a gun, I take it with a nod before grabbing Sam’s arm.

We exit the apartment and race up the stairs to the rooftop on the twelfth floor with James following closely behind.

“Emelia,” Sam murmurs, voice shaky as her body trembles against me.

“It’s going to be okay, I promise Sammy,” I say, trying to reassure her. Bullets shoot up through the staircase as Katherine’s men race to catch up with us. My phone vibrates with a reply from Nik.

Luka has eyes on you.

Just stay on the rooftop and shoot anyone who comes near you.

I love you.

It’ll be over soon.

As we near the twelfth floor, my eyes focus on James.

He’s already shot four bullets, only four left in the cylinder. I yank open the doors to the roof and let them enter first. Sam and James’s eyes snap back as they notice that I’ve stopped following them.

“Emelia, come on!” James yells.

I shake my head, “you’ll be safer without me.”

James rushes towards the door. “I love you,” I say, “barricade this until the rest of our men get here.” I pull the door shut before James can reach me.

I use the butt to break the deadbolt’s latch, and seal them up there. My ears twitch as the roar of footsteps are nearing me. I turn and rush to the end of the hallway. I lift the windowpane, reach to the right, and snag the emergency ladder. A man finally appears down the hall, staring at the closed access door to the rooftop.

“Hey, asshole!” I yell, and he looks up.

I clamber out the window onto the ladder and start down the side of the building.

He curses into his comms. “She’s coming down the east wall.”

If they’re chasing me, Sam and James will be okay, they have to be. I rush down the stairs, watching Maksim and our other men collide in a violent clash with Katherine’s. I scan the area, anxiously, frantically, until I spot blonde tuft in the building foyer.

“Emelia!” Dmitri shouts as he fights off two men.

“I’m going after her!” I yell back, gun already in hand as I move towards the glass doors.

A bullet brushes past me, into the foyer, lodging itself in the man’s skull as he protects her. My head snaps back to Dmitri, still aiming.

“Make the bitch suffer,” he nods to me.

My eyes meet Katherine’s widened gaze. In moments she’s lifting the gun that had fallen and shoots a bullet towards me. Missing me but barely.

She races through the foyer down the stairs into the laundry room as she yells to her men on the comms. “Fucking kill them!”

I rush after her as she’s reaching the end of the stairs, moving faster. Until I have my arms around her and we’re tumbling on the ground.

Katherine slaps her hand across my face, causing me to fall back. She uses the movement to pin me under her weight as her fingers wrap around my throat. “You’ve ruined everything you bitch!” She yells.

I kick up my knee, into her stomach then throw a punch at her face.

“I didn’t ruin anything you fucking psycho!” I yell back.

I reach for the fallen gun and smash the butt across her face, causing her lip to split. I hit her again and again until she becomes disoriented.

My eyes lift to the maintenance worktable at the edge of the room. I grin as I move towards it and pick up the duct tape.

“Not so powerful are you now, Katherine?”

“Go to hell,” she spits.

I drop to my knees and restrain her wrists behind her back as she struggles, weakly, against me.

“You killed Nik’s sister, Maria’s husband,” I start. “You tried to manipulate Nikolai into killing my best fucking friend.” I wrap another layer of tape around her wrists, for good measure.

I can hear men fighting in the foyer above us. But they will not stop me from doing this. She’s going to die. I aim the gun at her as she fights against the restraint.

I reach into my pocket, for my phone and video call Nikolai. He deserves to see this.

He answers almost immediately, distress clear on his face. “I’m okay,” I start, trying to ease his nerves.

“You were supposed to stay on the rooftop Emelia,” he scolds.

I rest the phone on top of the washing machine, “I want to do this for you, for Victoria.” I move out of the way so he can see Katherine, bloody, restrained and on her knees.

“Emelia...” his eyes widen as he takes in the scene. “Baby, can she hear me?”

I nod with a grin. “She can, right Katherine?”

“You do this, and you will incite the wrath of very powerful people,

Nikolai,” she sneers. “Not even the Kirovsky name will protect you.”

“YOU MURDERED MY FUCKING SISTER!” He shouts, his tone drowning in unbridled rage.

“You think *she* will kill me for you?” She laughs. “She’s a meek, little mouse who lives in a fantasy world.”

I stare at her as a grin pulls at my lips. “I would do anything for him.” I lift the gun, aiming it at her leg and shoot.

Katherine shrieks as the bullet lodges into her skin.

“The next one goes in you... Isn’t that what you wrote in your little note?” I press.

She cries out in pain.

“You need to suffer for what you’ve done,” I move back to the maintenance table and lift an unopened bottle of turpentine. I chuckle as I turn the bottle to the screen.

“The universe certainly has a sense of humour,” Nik throws his head back with a laugh, “that’s quite extreme baby, are you sure you-”

“I can do it,” I cut him off with a grin.

My eyes flick back to Katherine as I remove the cap of the bottle. I pour the contents onto her head, watching her yelp and scream as I douse her with the dirty mineral. I turn to the sound of footsteps rushing down the stairs. Dmitri and Maksim.

“We’re all clear,” Maksim says, eyes widening at the sight.

“James and Sam are still locked on the roof,” I remind them.

He nods. "I'll get them." He moves back up the stairs, leaving just Dmitri, myself and Nik with *her*.

"Katherine, Katherine, Katherine..." Dmitri chuckles as he crosses his arms, staring at her. "Been a while."

She sneers at him. "Fuck off Dmitri."

"I had no idea what a conniving cunt you are," he grins.

I empty the bottle on her and step back, reaching for the box of matches. I turn to Dmitri, "would you like to do the honours?"

"I couldn't take that from you," he smirks. "She's all yours."

His eyes flick to Nikolai on the screen. "Напомни мне никогда не злить твою жену [napomni mne nikogda ne zlit tvoyu zhenu - Remind me never to piss off your wife]."

I strike the match, watching the terror spark in her eyes.

"Don't do this Emelia, I can make you a very wealthy woman if you just let me go!"

Nikolai laughs. "She's already a very wealthy woman; you have nothing to offer Katherine. Now shut the fuck up and burn."

I drop the match, for a second, it's only a scatter of orange light. Then a blue flame opens, and the room fills with heat and the pine-sweet sting of burning turpentine.

Katherine screams as the fire ravages her body. Dmitri keeps his gun pointed at her; she's not taking the building with her. He shoots a bullet into her chest as she tries to get to her feet.

My eyes are glued to her. The way the flames are eating into her flesh. I gag at the smell. “Fuck,” I yell before rushing to the basin and throwing up.

Dmitri laughs. “It gets easier to stomach, Emelia.”

Is he fucking joking? I’m never doing this again.

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CHAPTER FORTY



NIKOLAI

I lean back on the green velvet office chair.

Hector Collin's eyes are glued on the window, staring out at the view from the thirty-eighth floor of his office. Eyes fixed on the greying London skyline. He turns to me, eyes softening as he nods.

"I can assure you that we had no idea of Katherine's involvement in Victoria or Frederick's murder. And we certainly did not support it," he starts, voice tight.

"Good, then you will agree that we had no choice, Hector? She tried to kidnap and kill my fiancé," I say, the words rolling bluntly out of my mouth.

He nods again. "We understand." He then returns to his chair at the desk, opposite me. "Our team completed a very thorough investigation, and we confirmed that Katherine hired Aleksandr to murder Erik in exchange for membership."

“And...?” I press.

“And, since his actions are against our bylaws, Aleksandr’s membership has been revoked.”

“Good,” I grin. “Don’t bother letting him know - he won’t be alive long enough for you to pass on the news.”

“Nikolai, you know I can’t-”

“You don’t give me permission to take care of my business, Hector,” I bite out, cutting him off. “What about Dmitri?”

“What do you mean?” His brows knit.

“He was ousted unfairly, surely the right thing to do would be to reinstate his membership,” I state.

He exhales sharply. “That’s not up to me; the members will need to vote.”

“How many votes do we need?” I press.

“Five,” he replies.

I nod. “Done, call a meeting and you will have your vote.”

Hector turns to his laptop screen and shoots off an email. “You will have your meeting in a fortnight; you will all also need to vote on a new head.”

I lift from my seat and move towards the window, taking in the view.

“When my father was a member, the rules were different,” I begin. “The head was always an impartial party, not a member.”

Hector nods. “That was the case. The Hawthorne’s operated as head for many years, until the Alexanders joined.”

“What happened to them?” I press.

Hector leans back in his chair, studying me. “What are you asking me, Nikolai?”

I turn to face him. “I think it’s clear what I’m asking, restore the organisation to them.”

He shakes his head. “It’s not that simple.”

“Why not?” I shrug. “At least meet with them Hector, no-one would have to lose their jobs, you would just be under, new management.”

“I don’t know-”

“Just start the conversation with them,” I interrupt him, “the Hawthorne’s ran the organisation with integrity, it’s only fair to give them this opportunity.”

I move towards the door. “If you’ll excuse me, I have some very pressing business to attend to.” I grin at Hector before leaving the office. Now that I’ve gotten that little issue out of the way, it’s time to have some fun. I’m coming for you, Aleksandr.



The private hanger hums as the small jet roars to life. The clock approaches 02:00 as three cars begin entering through the steel gates. I knew Aleksandr would turn to Vince Murdock. He didn’t have any other allies now that Katherine was fucking ash. But poor Aleksandr over estimated his importance. Once I showed Vince ‘proof’ that Aleksandr was responsible for killing his business associates, he was more than happy to hand him over on a silver fucking platter to me.

The cars stop in tandem as he and his men exit the vehicles, ready to board the plane and get as far away as he can.

I step out onto the tarmac, straightening my jacket. “I’m afraid your flight has been cancelled, Aleksandr.”

My men are on them before they can even think about reaching for their guns. I move towards him as Maksim holds him steady, restraining him. “Did you feel like a big fucking man putting your hands on her?”

“Would you like to know how she screamed when I pushed my blade inside of her?” He smirks.

“You’re going to beg for death by the time I’m done with you,” I bite out before swinging my fist into his jaw.

He says nothing, he stares at Maksim as steel handcuffs are placed on his wrists before Dr Richards moves behind him and injects a sleeping agent into his neck.

I breathe in the scent of home. Moscow. How much I’ve fucking missed being here. As much as I’ve come to love the villa in Italy, it was always meant to be temporary. This is where Emelia and I will live as husband and wife. It’s where our children will grow up. Where they will claim their right to the Kirovsky empire.

The tires crunch against the gravel as we pull up to the building. I step out slowly, taking in the overgrown weeds and scattered debris that have claimed the property. It’s been nearly fifteen years since I last walked through these doors, the place where men are forged into the brotherhood, where legends are made. But these walls remember the fallen. They echo with the ghosts of those who never walked out of the ring.

Roman drags Aleksandr through the threshold as he begins to stir, finally waking from the sedative.

“Where the fuck am I?” He grits out.

“This is where your vendetta was birthed, Aleksandr,” I stare at him with a grin. Studying him, watching as he finally realises.

His head snaps to me.

“Welcome to the Krovavy Krug,” I pause, “this is a great honour for you, one that you do not deserve.”

He spits at my feet. “Пошёл ты, Николай [poshyol te, nikolai – Fuck you, Nikolai].”

I move towards him, “you’re going to die in the same place I killed your brother.”

The rest of the lights flicker on, revealing the entirety of the space. A boxing ring, fenced behind a cage. The only way out is to kill your opponent; to kill for your place in the brotherhood.

I lift him to his feet and make him watch as three men are brought into the centre of the ring. “You recognise them, don’t you?”

“Ты, чертов ублюдок [te, chertov ublyudok – You fucking bastard]!” He yells.

A grin pulls at my lips as he realises, I have the only remaining Woznyuk men in my fucking hands.

Fire flickers in my eyes as it begins to dawn on him.

“Your brother chose to enter that ring, and he lost, fairly.” I begin. “Your family, your cousin, your uncle, your brother, they are all here because of

you.”

His head snaps to me. “You think that you are God Nikolai, but you will learn that you are not invincible. Do you think I’m the only one who wants you dead?”

I chuckle as I move closer to him, dropping my voice to a low growl. “Let them fucking come.”

Dmitri, Roman, Maksim and I stand outside the cage as the first fighter is brought in. Aleksandr’s middle brother.

“I’ll take this one,” Dmitri grins, already stepping into the ring.

He removes his shirt and tosses it aside. Cocky bastard.

Raf moves to the centre of the ring, to referee. “Твой противник должен умереть, прежде чем тебе разрешат обрести свободу [tvoyn protivnik dolzhen umeret, prezde cham tebe razreshat obreste svobodu - Your opponent must die before you're allowed your freedom].”

Dmitri winks at the fighter. “Try to stay away from the face, there’s a beautiful lady I’m trying to impress.”

The men chuckle. Dmitri’s thrown boxing tape which he quickly wraps around his knuckles.

Raf moves back lifting his finger. “Начать [nachat – Begin].”

Dmitri doesn’t waste a moment; he’s on him in a flash. Pounding his fists into face then his chest. The man spits blood then drops to the floor. Dmitri pounces on him, the force so strong my eyes widen in surprise. He grips his throat as he squeezes the life out of him. “You’re not putting up much of a fight.” He complains.

The man tries to twist and hit against Dmitri's hold but he's a fucking beast. No man has ever fought against him and won. A grin pulls at his lips as he watches the light drift from the man's eyes.

Raf nods. "Виктор [victor – Victor]."

Next, Maksim takes the cousin. A stocky man but again, my men are made of fucking steel and determination. It's not long before Maksim has him in a chokehold. He grins at us before snapping the man's neck.

"Sick," Dmitri chuckles. "Я скучал по тебе, Максим [ya skuchal po tebe, maksym - I've missed you Maksim]."

Raf nods. "Виктор [victor – Victor]."

Roman removes his shirt as he enters the ring. The uncle is brought in, scowling as he's ushered into the centre. "Я не буду с тобой драться [ya ne boudou se tobou dratsya – I will not fight you]." He sneers.

"Вы предпочитаете умереть трусом [vy predpocitaete umeret trusom - You prefer to die as a coward]?" Roman bites out.

Raf lifts his finger, "Начать [nachat – Begin]."

The man turns his back to Roman. Roman's eyes flicker, he moves forward anyway and thrusts a powerful kick into his back. "Do you think I won't kill you unless you fight?" He throws his fist into the man's jaw. "Your family came after mine and now you are going to be fucking exterminated."

Roman lifts him by his shirt as he pummels his fist into his face and chest. Holding him against the cage, lifting him in the air by his throat. His feet dangling, his hands clawing against Roman's arm. "So high and mighty, you are," he grins as he tightens his grip, squeezing until a blood vessel pops, making blood run from his nose. Roman squeezes tighter, until the man stops

moving. He lets his body fall to the ground then wipes the blood on his pants, unphased.

Raf nods, “Виктор [victor – Victor].”

I remove my shirt as it’s finally my turn to step into the ring. Wearing just a navy sweatpants and sneakers now. I want to be comfortable for this so I can take my time.

Aleksandr is brought into the ring, his eyes locked on me as I wrap tape around my knuckles. He does the same, removing his shirt before wrapping his knuckles.

Raf moves back and lifts his finger for the final round. “Начать [*nachat* – Begin].”

I move forward first, eyes locked on him. I drop my hands to my side. “I’ll let you have the first shot Aleksandr,” I grin, then move my hands behind my back.

His eyes narrow as he moves towards me, cautiously. He doesn’t hesitate, he throws a punch into my jaw. My head shoots back at him. “Just what I fucking thought – weak.” I kick his stomach, sending him into the side of the cage. I move towards him and drop to my knees until we’re eye level. “I spank her harder than that.”

I grab him by his throat and force him into the centre of the ring. “Let me hear you beg, Aleksandr,” I grin.

“You will never hear me beg,” he spits.

“Fine by me.” I unleash my fucking anger on him. My fists connect with his face, his chest, his stomach. Punching every organ until he coughs blood.

I lift him by his throat and thrust my fist into his jaw until he spits teeth. I kept hitting, punching harder until he stops moving.

Until air stops filling his worthless fucking lungs.

Raf nods, hand stretched out to me. “Виктор [victor – Victor].”

I let his body fall to the ground with a thud, lifeless. Useless.

“гнить в аду [Gni v adu - Rot in hell].” I spit.



I lean against the doorway of the walk-in closet, watching Emelia tuck her photo-album into the safe. My eyes flick to her rows of shoes. She has no idea that I had Luka install trackers on every single fucking pair she owns. I’m not losing her ever again. And if she runs, I will gladly chase to bring her back to me.

“I can feel you staring,” she giggles.

I grin and move towards her, wrapping my arms around her waist and pressing kisses against her cheek and neck as I breathe her in.

“Is it over?” she asks, her hand caressing my arm.

“Yes, he’s gone, baby. Aleksandr and all the fucking Woznyuk men are all gone.”

She breathes a sigh of relief.

“I will not give any mercy to anyone who tries to hurt you Emelia,” I murmur against her skin.

She exhales softly. “I’ve been so sick with worry,” she pauses. “My stomach has been in knots.”

I turn her around and brush the hair from her face, “We can have Dr Richards give you something, *milaya*,” I kiss her cheek, “I can’t stand the thought of you being unwell.”

She reaches her hand around my neck and presses a kiss to my lips. “I don’t think there’s anything he can give me for this.”

My brows knit as I watch her reach behind her back and pull something from the pocket of her jeans.

“I should have told you that I threw out my birth control,” she starts lifting the positive pregnancy test between us. “I didn’t think it would happen so soon.”

I still. My eyes remain glued on the two pink lines. “You’re pregnant?” I breathe.

She nods with a soft smile. “I took like five of these just to make sure.”

Fireworks explode in my fucking chest. I pull her towards me lifting and spinning her in the air as I kiss the fuck out of her full, perfect lips.

“I’m so fucking happy, baby,” I exclaim.

“This means we’ll have to move up the wedding,” she laughs, curling into me.

“This weekend,” I say matter-of-factly, “I’m not spending another week without you as my wife.”

She looks up at me with those beautiful, bright, doe eyes.

I run my thumb across her chin as I drink her in. “I’m so fucking happy baby; you make me so happy.”

She licks her lips and curls into me tighter. “Soon we’ll be a family

three.”

“For now,” I grin, lifting her onto my hips as I move her towards the bedroom. “Our child will need siblings, Emelia.”

Laughter rings from her throat in a beautiful melody as I carry her to our bed. As they say, practice makes perfect.

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CHAPTER FORTY-ONE



EMELIA

The oceanside hotel couldn't be more perfect.

I smile as guests are ushered to their seats on the lawn, which offers a flawless view of the sun dipping below the horizon and casting golden shadows across the intimate setting for our wedding.

As I stare down to the beachfront a thought jumps into my head. It's been a long time since the anxiety demon has haunted me. If he did, Nikolai would kick the shit out of him.

A gasp behind me breaks my thoughts. I turn to James and Sam watching me with glistening eyes. My eyes drop to my dress. Nikolai told me to spend whatever I wanted, and I did.

The dress is a romantic, modern ballgown in soft ivory.

The fitted, corset-style bodice is semi-sheer with an illusion sweetheart neckline: delicate lace appliqué climbs over my breasts, creating the effect of lace floating. The waist is nipped,

then gives way to a full, layered tulle skirt that's both voluminous and airy. It's everything I've ever wanted: ethereal, feminine, and quietly glamorous.

"Emelia... you look..." Sam trails as she forces back tears.

"Beautiful," James smiles.

I move towards them with my arms open. "I can't cry, I just had my makeup done."

Sam laughs then takes my hand. "I'm so happy for you Emmy, you deserve the world, and I know that Nikolai would move heaven and Earth to make you happy."

James nods. "If someone had told me a year ago that I would be walking you down the aisle to marry Nikolai Kirovsky, I would have them committed," he laughs. "But seeing the two of you together, you were made for each other Emmy... I couldn't wish for a better man for you."

I smile, reaching for their hands. "I love you both so much, I'm so grateful for you."

Sam exhales slowly then kisses my cheek. "I'll see you down there, babe." She winks at me then moves out of the room to take her place as my maid of honour.

James's lips curl into a smile as he extends his arm to me. "Shall we?"

I nod and wrap my arm around him as we make our way out of the bridal suite, through the hallway before we reach the sprawling, green lawns.

Then, I see *him*. Waiting for me at the end of the aisle as a soft breath escapes his lips. He looks excruciatingly handsome. Dressed in an all-black suit, and black tie. Those forest green eyes of his are staring into me, holding

me captive as they love to do. I melt as he smiles at me. The most beautiful smile in the world. A smile that's reserved just for me.

Our eyes are locked as instruments begin to play *Turning Page* by *Sleeping at Last*, as I walk down the aisle. James caresses my arm and leans in, to whisper. "Are you ready?"

I smile at him, eyes glistening. "Yes."

With every step I take, memories of Nikolai and I flood my mind. The absolute love and security he's given me is more than I could have ever dreamed possible. He leaves no room for doubt in my mind, he's always all in with me.

I giggle as I see the Fields family, sitting near the front. Wide smiles of support as they watch me walk down the aisle. I'm unable to stop a happy tear from falling. I turn to James, grateful. My side would be practically empty, but he and Sam made sure it wasn't. They invited our group of friends, all their partners, even Gretchen and some of the team at Orion. Maria, Zora and Lev also sit on my side with soft, sweet smiles.

My eyes return to Nikolai, then to the seats on the right of the aisle. Familiar faces I've seen before, but many that I haven't. Equally wide smiles look back at me.

Sam stands waiting in a beautiful pastel-blue coloured dress with a bouquet of flowers. Next to Nikolai stands his best man, Dmitri, looking very handsome in his all-black suit.

James wraps his hand over my arm as we near the end of the aisle. He turns me to him, holding my hands while he mouths. I love you.

"I love you too," I whisper.

Nikolai moves forward and James places my hand in his. He looks at me with an intensity that makes my pulse spike.

Suddenly, no-one else is around. It's just Nik and I moving towards the altar as Father Ferguson waits with a kind smile.

His hands cover mine with gentle protectiveness as his eyes drink me in. I've never experienced a man look at me the way that he does, he loves me loudly, proudly.

"Dear friends and family, welcome." Father Ferguson begins. "Today we come to join Emelia and Nikolai in holy matrimony, a promise of love, a covenant of faithfulness, a choice to walk forward together, hand in hand." He pauses.

"Marriage is a gift. It asks us to be both brave and gentle: brave enough to show our true selves, and gentle enough to listen to another's hopes and fears. Emelia and Nikolai have chosen to make those promises before us. Let us bless them with our presence, our prayers, and our joy."

Nik rubs his thumb across my fingers as we stare into each other.

"There is a passage I find fitting for today, from the letter that teaches us what love is. Listen, and let it settle on your hearts. From one Corinthians chapter thirteen, verse four to eight: Love is patient, love is kind. It does not envy, it does not boast, it is not proud. It always protects, always trusts, always hopes, always perseveres. Love never ends."

The priest smiles at us. "Those words remind us that marriage is not a feeling that comes and goes; it is a way of living. You are each other's companions on this road. You will have seasons of bright sun and times of storm. Promise now to hold to this simple truth: to be patient, to be kind, to

protect and to trust. Let your love be a home for one another. Now, I will ask you each the questions that bind this promise.”

My smile widens as Nik flashes me a grin.

“Nikolai, will you have Emelia to be your wife, to live together in the covenant of marriage? Will you love her, comfort her, honour and keep her, in sickness and in health, and, forsaking all others, be faithful to her as long as you both shall live?”

“I will,” he smiles.

Father Ferguson turns to me. “Emelia, will you have Nikolai to be your husband, to live together in the covenant of marriage? Will you love him, comfort him, honour and keep him, in sickness and in health, and, forsaking all others, be faithful to him as long as you both shall live?”

“I will,” I breathe.

“Please repeat after me,” he says. “I, Nikolai, take you, Emelia, to be my wife. I promise to love you, to honour you, and to be faithful to you, for all the days of my life.” Nikolai echoes every single word with love and devotion.

Then it’s my turn. “I, Emelia, take you, Nikolai, to be my husband. I promise to love you, to honour you, and to be faithful to you, for all the days of my life.”

Father Ferguson turns to Dmitri. “May I have the rings?” He nods and moves forward, handing the rings to us. I hold Nikolai’s ring in my hand. A band that exudes power and control, quiet platinum court.

“Repeat after me,” he starts, looking to Nikolai. “With this ring, I thee wed. I wear it as a sign of my love and faithfulness.” Nikolai repeats the

words then slips the beautiful pear-shaped diamond ring onto my finger. Where it belongs. The priest then turns to me. “Repeat after me, with this ring, I thee wed. I wear it as a sign of my love and faithfulness.”

I smile as I push the band onto his hand. My eyes lift to meet his and the world is suddenly so still, so perfect.

“O God of love, bless these rings. May they be a constant reminder of the mutual love, respect and fidelity that Nikolai and Emelia pledge to one another this day. Amen.”

Father Ferguson clasps his hands with a wide grin. “You have declared your consent before God and have sealed that consent by giving and receiving rings. By the power vested in me, and with the blessing of God and these witnesses, I now pronounce you husband and wife.” He pauses. “Nikolai, you may kiss your bride.”

Applause and cheers roar from the guests as Nik wraps his arms around me and crashes his lips into me.

Finally, he is mine.

And I am his.

Forever and for always, *his*.

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EPILOGUE

NIKOLAI

One year later...

A grin pulls at my lips as I watch Emelia press her face into the neck of our beautiful baby boy, making him giggle with uninhibited glee.

Lexan Kirovsky, a strong name for the prince that he is. Emelia and I both wanted to honour our fathers, so we settled on a blend of their names Aleksei and Jonathan. We chose the middle name of Viktor, for the man who gave his life for her.

Motherhood suits her so fucking well. She's adapted beautifully. It's the greatest honour to get to experience life with her. I don't know what the fuck I've done to deserve her, but I know that with every breath I'm going to keep trying to be a better man, for her. For them.

The last year has been a world wind; travelling, living, loving. Emelia's book, Grimm, became a global success. Her fanbase grew tenfold as her publisher marketed her to a wider audience. The success put her on multiple best-seller lists. I had to put my foot down when Gretchen tried to talk her into a second book tour at seven months pregnant. Fuck that, my baby needed to be pampered and off her feet. Her fans could wait.

I lean against the bar as Yelena brings her son, Ruslan Volkov, nearly two years old now to sit beside Emelia and Lexan.

Roman moves towards me, drink in hand as we watch our sons stare at each other.

"History has a funny way of repeating itself," he nudges my shoulder with a chuckle.

"Indeed, cousin," I grin. "У них будет друг друга. Точно так же, как их отцы [a nich budet drug druga. točno tuck ze, cack ikh ottsy - They will have each other. Just like their fathers]."

He nods with a knowing smile in agreement. Our sons will become men together, just as we have.

"Are you and Yelena all set for the move?" I ask.

He nods. "We leave the day after tomorrow. She's going to miss this little town. Honestly, I will too."

I chuckle. "Emelia as well, she's made this place a home."

My eyes lift to Samantha and Dmitri lost in flirtatious conversation with each other. I have no idea why they've insisted on secrecy. We all fucking know. I've never seen Dmitri happier than when he's with her.

Footsteps echo from down the hallway, then Dominik and James enter the living room with several gift bags. Emelia rolls her eyes as she shoots me a look then turns back to them.

“Did we not tell you to stop buying shit? We have an entire room filled with gifts already,” I shake my head.

“You will not stop us from spoiling our nephew, brother,” Dominik grins as he sets the bags down.

I never thought I would see the day when my baby brother would settle down, but James has brought out a side of Dom that I didn’t know existed. He’s calmed his storms and made a real man out of him. An honourable man.

It’s been four months since they tied the knot, an intimate ceremony in Ireland. No fucking idea why, but apparently the coastal town held a special memory for them. Emelia couldn’t be fucking happier. She’s always considered James to be her brother, and now, he is. Officially.

The night has quietened after everyone’s left. Excitement lingering in the air as we all prepare for our move back home. Maria, Zora and Lev have left already, preparing the Kirovsky estate for our arrival.

I check on Lexan, tucked in, fast asleep in the nursery. “Спокойной ночи, мой принц [spokoynoy nochi, moi printz -

Goodnight my prince].”

I pull the door slowly then move through the hallway to find my wife.

I lean against the doorway as I stare at Emelia, standing on the balcony breathing in the crisp night air. Her long hair tumbling down her back. A lilac dress clinging to that perfect body of hers, giving me flashbacks to the day I first laid my eyes on her.

I move forward and wrap my arms around her waist.

“I love you so much, baby,” I whisper against the shell of her ear.

She reaches her hand up and caresses my hair. “I love you too.”

I rest my chin on her shoulder and steady her against me. “The movers will be here tomorrow to begin packing.” I start. “The estate is already completely furnished but Victoria’s paintings and my mother’s journals are coming with us.

Unless there’s something else, you’d like to bring as well.”

She shakes her head. “I have everything I could ever need with you and baby Lex,” she smiles.

She turns to face me, staying in my hold as she leans against the terrace. She runs her fingers along my chest. “What will our life be like there? I’ve never been to Moscow.”

I grin. “Well Emelia,” I take her hand and kiss her fingers, “the Kirovsky’s are highly regarded. You’ll be treated like royalty.”

Laughter rings from her throat, pleasantly amused. “Is that so?”

I nod, confidently. “You’re the queen of a great empire, *milaya*.”

Her eyes darken. She licks her lips then leans up to press soft, warm kisses against my neck. “Then I should bow to my king,” she grins before dropping to her knees.

Her fingers make quick work of undoing my belt, then the button and zip of my pants. Her eyes glitter as she stares up at me, palming my growing erection. She tugs on my underwear until my dick eagerly juts out to greet her.

The sound of Emelia slurping on my cock is like a fucking lullaby from the heavens. Her perfect, plump lips move up and down as she sucks. Her bright eyes soft, pouring into me as I brush her hair back.

“You’re fucking insatiable baby,” I grin, savouring the feel of her mouth.

Her tongue shoots out and trails a path along my length as she moans. God, my control is slipping, fast.

I reach for her and lift her to her feet. I wrap my arms around her waist and hold her closely to me as our lips collide in a passionate, heated kiss. She always tastes so fucking sweet. I lift her, letting her wrap her legs around me as I carry her into the bedroom.

Gently I drop her onto the bed. “I have a surprise for you,” I start, removing my shirt then tossing it aside.

Her eyes widen as she takes in the fresh ink tattooed across my heart, just for her.

“Nik,” she smiles, biting her bottom lip as she touches her name on my skin. “I love it.”

I cup her face and press my lips into her. “You are my everything, baby.” I reach for her dress lifting it along the sides of her waist as she raises her arms.

I toss it aside then get my pants off. Emelia lays on the bed watching me as she slowly begins removing her underwear until she’s fully bare for me. I climb on top of her greedily. My mouth magnetised to those fantastic breasts of hers.

“They’re really sensitive, your son seems to be greedier than you,” she laughs.

I kiss and lick her nipples, only sucking at the curve of her breasts. “How does that feel baby?” I coo against her skin.

“Really good,” she moans.

I reach my hand between her thighs as I soothe her nipples with my tongue. Slowly I run my fingers between her folds before teasing her clit with the pad of my middle finger.

I press a finger into her as I kiss her neck, breathing in that gorgeous vanilla scented perfume of hers.

My dick is rock fucking hard, ready to be buried inside of her. But my baby needs to be taken care of first.

I drop to my knees on the side of the bed, burying my face between her thighs. My fucking nirvana.

I hold her open as I lick and suck. Her needy little clit swells under my attention. I need more, need her to fucking smother me with this perfect cunt of hers. I wrap my arms around her thighs and lift, until I’m standing with her legs around my shoulders.

I move towards the wall, giving her balance as I take what’s mine. Emelia holds my shoulder to steady herself as her right hand snaps up to her mouth, stifling her moans.

My fucking moans.

“Don’t you fucking dare,” I growl against her. “I want to hear you.”

“Nik,” she cries out.

“Lex is fast asleep baby, give it to me. Let your husband hear how much you love his tongue,” I nip at the flesh of her folds, making her moan.

“You are my queen, Emelia, and I will bury my face in this perfect little pussy of yours every single day for the rest of our lives to pledge my love and loyalty to you baby.”

Her eyes roll back as she gives herself to me. She’s so fucking wet for me, ready for me to fuck the fuck out of her.

I move her back to the bed, setting her down before climbing on top of her. I shove my cock into her as I pin her hands above her head.

“Tell me who you belong to baby,” I growl.

“You,” she moans, “I belong to you.”

“You will always belong to me, in this life and all the fucking rest, you will always be mine.”

I press my lips against hers as I thrust into her, satisfying my cock's insatiable need for her. “I’m cuming,” she moans as her pussy tightens around me. “Just like that,” she murmurs.

“Mmm, you like opening your legs and letting me fuck you like this, Emelia?” I grin.

“God, yes,” she cries out.

I thrust harder.

Wilder.

I press my hands on either side of her head as I stare down at her. Hips rocking as I fuck her roughly. Just how she fucking likes it.

“Your body makes me lose my fucking mind, I want to touch, kiss, suck, fuck, all day long,” I steal a kiss from her lips.

My cock throbs, I slow my movements, savouring the feeling of her tight, wet, velvety cunt.

I press my lips to her hand, kissing her ring, our promise of love, devotion, forever as I give her every single drop of me. Our eyes pour into each other as I cup her face, soaking in her radiance. I'm in utter fucking awe of her.

With a single look she quiets my demons. She breathes light into the darkest corners of my mind. She is love in abundance, my undeserved salvation. Her body is my altar, mine alone to worship. I kneel faithfully and devotedly at her feet because she is the only thing I'll ever bow to.

My wife.

My heart.

My Emelia.



The end.

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Megan Williams is a spicy romance author from South Africa, known for crafting stories filled with dark, brooding men and the kind of yearning that lingers long after the last page.

When she isn't bringing her characters to life, she's most likely buried in a book, reading as voraciously as she writes.

Inspiration often finds her in unexpected places, whether it's the lyrics of a song, a quiet moment outdoors, or a fleeting daydream. And if you catch her staring off into the distance, don't be fooled, another scintillatingly delicious story is already on its way.

It's just for research...

I'm a guest in the home of nefarious Russian mafia boss,
Nikolai Kirovsky while I work on my romance novel.

Eight weeks then I'll be gone again.

I've only ever flirted with danger from the safety of my
keyboard, but here, in his world, the villains are very real
and very dangerous...

Why the f*ck I agreed to this arrangement needs to be
studied - a temporary lapse into psychosis.

Then I saw her...

The woman with a face of an angel but breathes fire.

*She tells me that hell will freeze over before
I rouch her... she has no idea that there's a
f*cking blizzard coming.*



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